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Now and then: traces of the present in medievalist fantasy fiction

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Now and Then:

Traces of the
Present in
Medievalist
Fantasy Fiction

Narelle Campbell

Abstract

This thesis examines two medievalist fantasy series by authors from former British settler cultures – *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* (1995-2003) by Australian writer Garth Nix, and *The Fionavar Tapestry* (1985-1986) by Canadian author Guy Gavriel Kay. I argue that although these texts are firmly situated in the realm of the imaginary, they are far from being culturally irrelevant. They are inescapably contemporary cultural products, strongly informed by the moments and places of their production, and revelatory of present aspirations and anxieties. I discuss the British and, more broadly, Western inflections at the centre of medievalist genre fantasy and examine how these impact on representations of ethnicity, gender and class within my chosen texts. This entails a consideration of how colonial legacies continue to inform the ways in which postcolonial settler cultures construct their own identities and view other cultures. I argue that the medieval temporal and spatial settings utilised by Nix and Kay create a privileged space, imbued with a sense of greater power, authority and authenticity than the present. Moreover, I argue that the power available to imaginings of the Middle Ages is appropriated by the authors as these fantasy texts engage discursively with debates of contemporary ideological significance.

Completed at the University of Wollongong.

I certify that this thesis is my own work except for where I have given full documented references to the work of others, and that the material contained in this thesis has not been submitted for formal assessment in any formal course.

Narelle Campbell

26 March 2013.

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Introduction:

Popularity and Pertinence

Medievalist fantasy novels discursively engage with contemporary issues of cultural and political significance. These include the areas of national identity, class, ethnicity and gender. Despite being commonly set in an imagined past, fantasy stories are contemporary products that say much more about the moments and contexts of their creation than they do of historical times. Although genre fantasy has been proportionately under-represented in scholarship, I assert that its extreme popularity in Western societies attests to its affective appeal and cultural relevance. This makes it a pertinent area for greater critical attention. This chapter will introduce *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* by Australian author Garth Nix, and *The Fionavar Tapestry* by Canadian author Guy Gavriel Kay. It will address the quintessential 'Britishness' that I contend underlies much of popular medievalist fantasy, and consider possible post-colonial and cultural implications of fantasy produced in former British settler cultures.

The 2010 Booklover's Best Top 101 List compiled by Australian bookseller Dymocks is but one source that immediately demonstrates the appeal of genre fantasy. With Stephanie Meyer's *Twilight Saga* in the number one position, J.K. Rowling's *Harry Potter Books* in second position, and J.R.R. Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* in position number five, both the commercial value and wide readership of fantasy are evident. The remainder of the list also contains a liberal smattering of books that qualify, if not always as genre fantasy, at least as fantastic. There are novels such as: Audrey Niffenegger's *The Time Traveller's Wife* (4)¹ where the protagonist has a gene that causes spontaneous time travel; Tim Winton's *Cloudstreet* (19) with its hauntings and visions; Paulo Coelho's *The Alchemist* (50) focusing on an exotic dream-inspired quest; Donna Tartt's *The Secret History* (94) with its mix of classical myth and mystery; and Jasper Fforde's *The Eyre Affair* (36) with its (literally) novel-hopping book detectives. Science fiction such as Douglas Adams's *Hitchhikers Guide to the Galaxy* (31) and Frank Herbert's *Dune* (80) sit alongside more conventional fantasy such as Tolkien's *The Hobbit* (23), C.S. Lewis's *The Chronicles of Narnia* (87) and Kristin Cashore's *Graceling* (92). There are fond satires of the genre such as William Goldman's *The Princess Bride* (70) and Gregory Maguire's *Wicked* (72), time-slips in Diana Gabaldon's *Cross Stitch* (26) and a number of books with 'Vampire' in the title. This survey confirms the popularity of fantasy seen in the Australian Broadcasting Corporation's (ABC) 2004 poll which sought to discover Australia's "favourite books" (My Favourite Book, online). With more than 15000 respondents the result included numerous fantasy novels. Moreover, the vote was won by J.R.R. Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings*.

¹ These numbers indicate the titles' position in the *2010 Booklover's Best Top 101 List*.

More recently, 12 July 2011, the ABC's national television programme *First Tuesday Book Club* (FTBC) hosted a discussion of the fantasy genre. The panel, mediated by Jennifer Byrne, consisted of four bestselling authors, each of whom has works published both within and outside the fantasy genre. Panellists were: Australian writer Emily Rodda (Jennifer Rowe), best known for her children's fantasy; British-born Australian writer, Fiona McIntosh, who writes in the genres of crime, fantasy and historical fiction; Australian Matthew Reilly, known for his action thrillers, many of which include overt fantasy elements; and American author Lev Grossman, who is also a book critic for *Time Magazine*.

Pointing to the clear commercial dominance of fantasy fiction, Grossman challenged a comment made by McIntosh which marked a distinction between 'fantasy' and 'mainstream' readers. "What mainstreamers are you talking about?" Grossman questioned, "We're the mainstream" (FTBC 10:08). McIntosh responded with qualified agreement, providing an example of how the distinction between fantasy and mainstream literature is situated more in reader perception than in actual practice:

I'm talking in front of 500 people and say, 'Do you read? Does anybody here read fantasy?' And they sort of get that lemon sour look on their face, and yet if I say, 'Have you read *The Time Traveller's Wife*?' and hands go up, and, 'Oh, it's the best book I've ever read,' and you think, 'OK, so, you're not reading fantasy, then'.
(10:12)

This exchange encapsulates the paradox that surrounds the fantasy genre. Despite the fact that within Western culture fantasy dominates in bestseller lists and in 'favourite' polls, somehow it remains discursively pigeonholed as

sub-literature, being perceived as lacking in aesthetic value and in its engagement with reality.

The issue was reprised later in the *First Tuesday Book Club* discussion as Byrne spoke of fantasy's "inability, to date, to really cross into the mainstream" (19:53). The panellists' responses drew attention to the constructed and abstract nature of this perceived difference between 'fantasy' and 'mainstream' literatures. Reilly asserted that, rather than being informed by consumers' purchasing and reading practices, the perception is reinforced by artificial book store categorisations (20:00). Rodda pertinently noted that *The Lord of the Rings* was voted the most popular book of all time, prompting Grossman to reiterate his earlier assertion: "we are the mainstream. Literary fiction, that's a subculture, that's a niche" (20:29).

The disparity between impression and actuality is amusingly illustrated in a 2007 interview, published in *The Age*, with fantasy author Terry Pratchett, a multiple bestselling novelist who has sold over 65 million books worldwide. Pratchett speaks of attending a book signing event in a large bookstore at a time when his latest novel had held the number one position in national book sales for several weeks. Noticing his novel was shelved in the SciFi/Fantasy section of the basement and not with the display of the Top 10 bestsellers, Pratchett asked the store manager why this was the case. The reply came; "Well, Terry, you're not exactly bestseller material" (Hughes 26).

The above examples are indicative of the disjunction between the vast readership of fantasy and the seemingly intractable perception that this

genre exists only as a sub-literature. They also provide some insight into why fantasy is under-represented in literary criticism. Further insights into genre fantasy's under-representation might be found in discourses that label fantasy as nostalgic escapism, essentially conservative, derivative, or juvenile.

Such assumptions are clearly discernible in debates surrounding the literary merit of J.K. Rowling's *Harry Potter* books. A.S. Byatt, in a 2003 opinion piece for *The New York Times*, categorises many of J.K. Rowling's adult readers as "childish", saying they are "simply reverting to the child they were when they read the Billy Bunter books, or invested Enid Blyton's pasteboard kids with their own childish desires and hopes" (Byatt 13). This echoes the views of Anthony Holden, a Whitbread Prize judge in the year 2000, a year that saw Seamus Heaney's translation of the medieval poem *Beowulf* narrowly defeat Rowling's *The Prisoner of Azkaban* for the award. Holden asserts: "If *Harry Potter* had won the Whitbread book of the year it would have been sending out a signal to the world that Britain is a country that just can't grow up" (Lyll 9). He also expresses the view that *Harry Potter* is "derivative" and "traditional" (Lyll 9). Ironically, the epic *Beowulf* that won the prize is undeniably traditional, possessing the imprimatur of British culture. It is unsurprising, then, that another of the Whitbread judges, Richard Harris, places Holden's criticism within discourses of 'high' and 'low' art that implicitly cast popularity as antithetical to excellence. Harris argues that this negative reaction to Rowling's texts "exemplifies the gap between the arbiters of literary taste and the appetite of the public for books" (Lyll 9).

Debates that conflate an appreciation of fantasy with immaturity are not limited to Rowling's *Harry Potter* novels. In the *First Tuesday Book Club* discussion, Fiona McIntosh commented on the manner in which fantasy is widely bracketed as juvenile. She recalled "being in primary school, and the teachers really despairing because I wouldn't grow up. That was their accusation – that I needed to read more grown-up fiction. I think that sort of pervades how fantasy is seen today" (FTBC 3:31). Lev Grossman drew attention to the high/low culture debates with the observation: "my parents are English professors, so fantasy was quite disapproved of in our household" (5:20), and Jennifer Byrne noted that 'escapist' was a "commonly used term of abuse" (6:32). Matthew Reilly's response indicates something of the power dynamics that accompany negatively dismissive discourses on fantasy literature:

I'm a young guy, but I have vast amounts of experience of disapproval of escapist fiction, and it's amazing how some people try to sort of elevate their own level of power. And what we find in the book world is you get people who say there's high literature, and then they say there's escapism, and, oh, my God, that escapism sells millions of copies, and let's be honest, the biggest-selling books and stories of all time – *The Lord Of The Rings*, *Harry Potter*, *Star Wars* ... (FTBC 6:53)

This suggests that there has been remarkably little change in broader perceptions of fantasy literature since fantasy critic Brian Attebery observed in *Strategies of Fantasy*, almost two decades before the abovementioned discussion, that:

we have book reviewers and teachers of literature who boast of being unable to read fantasy. They cannot say why: whether it is content or form they object to, magic or reconciliation. They expect all romance to be escapist, all fairy tale to be arch and pretentious and those expectations govern their response. (Attebery, xi)

The strength of negative discourses can even pervade the perceptions of consumers of fantasy. Grossman speaks of the largely uninterrogated assumptions attached to the genre that he sums up as “a really common sense that fantasy isn't respectable” (FTBC 8:15). An example of such a ‘common sense’ can be found in a recent *Sydney Morning Herald* review for the HBO television drama, *Game of Thrones*. The article announces in the lead paragraph that “Fantasy has grown up at last” (Birmingham 6). Despite the reviewer’s overt admiration of the sophistication of *Game of Thrones*, fantasy as a collective phenomenon is still tacitly assumed to be juvenile.

Criticisms that indiscriminately relegate fantasy to the category of sub-literature are not confined to cultural debates within the media. They are also present in academic critiques. Umberto Eco’s “Dreaming of the Middle Ages”, for example, evocatively refers to genre fantasy as “an avalanche of pseudo-medieval pulp in paperbacks” (Eco 62) and “escapism à la Tolkien” (Eco 65). Rosemary Jackson’s influential *Fantasy: The Literature of Subversion* is even harsher in its criticism as she characterises Tolkienesque fantasy as “backwards”, “chauvinistic”, and “totalitarian” in vision (Jackson 156). A continued prejudice in favour of realism is discernible, for example, in the recently defunct Excellence in Research for Australia (ERA) rankings for journal titles. The listing for 2010 shows no journal with a specific focus on fantasy fiction, speculative fiction or science fiction classed above the rank of C, the lowest possible classification for peer-reviewed academic journals.

It is within this comparatively under-represented area of critical discussion that I wish to situate this thesis. My discussion will point to examples of areas

of this engagement, with a focus on postcolonial cultural identity, ethnicity, class and gender. Indeed, as John Stephens notes in *Language and Ideology in Children's Literature (LI)* (1992) fantasies, though not set in a 'real' world, still comment "on contemporary social practice" albeit by "indirections, parallels, figures, even allegory" (Stephens *LI* 256).

Rather than partaking in a wide-ranging survey of fantasy literature, my thesis will involve an in-depth examination of two medievalist fantasy series Garth Nix's *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and Guy Gavriel Kay's *The Fionavar Tapestry*. Both these series have been recognised and awarded within fantasy and broader literary communities.² They have also proven their longevity in the market place, having been the subject of multiple editions and reprints. These series are not intended to be seen as representative of genre fantasy as a whole. Despite charges that much of contemporary fantasy is confined and imitative, authors and texts of genre are members of a 'broad church'. It is a fluid genre. As Tzvetan Todorov claims, the evolution of literary genre is not confined to a fixed taxonomy but "operates with an altogether different rhythm: every work modifies the sum of possible works, each new example alters the species" (Todorov 6). My selection, however, was influenced by the fact that Nix's and Kay's series are situated much closer to the generic centre of the fantasy literature than to its boundaries, making them apt choices for an exemplary consideration of genre fantasy novels.

² Kay's accolades include a World Fantasy Award, two Aurora Awards from the Canadian Science Fiction and Fantasy Association, and being placed thirteen in the All-Time Best Fantasy Author list (Guy Gavriel Kay - Award Biography). Nix's include nine Aurealis Awards for Australian Science fiction and Fantasy, a Ditmar Award (Garth Nix – Award Biography) and a top 10 listing in the Young Adult section of the American Library Association (Teen's Top Ten).

The Old Kingdom Chronicles (also known as *The Abhorsen Trilogy*) is comprised of *Sabriel* (*Sab*) (1995), *Lirael* (*Lir*) (2001) and *Abhorsen* (*Abh*) (2003). This series is set in a secondary world where Ancelstierre, a country that resembles a pre-First World War, industrialised England, sits at the southern border of the medieval, magical, Old Kingdom. The novels follow the quests of Sabriel, Touchstone, Lirael and Sameth as they seek to save the Old Kingdom and, by extension, Ancelstierre from the destruction threatened by supernaturally powerful, evil and, largely, Dead enemies. *The Fionavar Tapestry* is comprised of *The Summer Tree* (*ST*) (1984), *The Wandering Fire* (*WF*) (1986) and *The Darkest Road* (*DR*) (1986). This tells the stories of five young Canadians, Kimberly Ford, Jennifer Lowell, Dave Martyniuk, Paul Schafer and Kevin Laine, who are mystically transported into the medieval, magical world of Fionavar, a world that is the 'prime creation' and a model for all other worlds. Here they take up their places in a war against a great evil Power, Rakoth Maugrim, who threatens to destroy not only Fionavar, but all possible worlds. Though both series can be seen as sites of Manichean battles of good against evil, providing the stories with a moral imperative, they also offer the opportunity to discuss the values attached to representations of class, gender, ethnicity and identity.

Both these series aptly fit within the categories of 'heroic' or 'sword and sorcery' fantasy popularised by Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings*. In *Strategies of Fantasy* Brian Attebery usefully appropriates the concept of 'fuzzy sets', with fixed centres but imprecise outer-limits, to describe the genre. He argues that genres are "defined not by boundaries but by a centre" (Attebery 12). Asserting that resemblance is a better marker of fantasy than firm taxonomical limitations, he suggests that *The Lord of the Rings* provides the

“mental template” for readers of popular fantasy in English (Attebery 14). Focal generic markers of fantasy, then, include aspects such as: internally coherent secondary worlds where things that contravene this world’s limits of reality are possible; ‘sword and sorcery’ motifs like kings and queens, witches, wizards, prophecy and destiny, supernatural villains, quests; and northern, medieval settings. Though these characteristics of fantasy can ostensibly appear detached from reality, they can be used as effective vehicles for contemporary ideological discussions.

Another oft-used quality inherited from Tolkien’s centrality is the aura of a medievaesque ‘Britishness’.³ Indeed, *The Lord of the Rings*, which is famously J.R.R. Tolkien’s attempt to create a “mythology for England” (Chance 1), draws heavily from both Celtic and Anglo-Saxon mythologies. This characteristic is a central consideration in my thesis. It was influential in my selection of the works of Nix and Kay. These authors are from former British settler cultures, Nix from Australia and Kay from Canada, which allows me to examine textural inflections of national identity, postcolonial anxieties, and the affective pull of cultural heritage.

The medievalism at the core of fantasy demonstrates an attachment, not necessarily to an historical past, but to idealised or imagined pre-modern places and times which frequently exhibit a certain quality of Britishness. To return briefly to books in the favourites’ lists mentioned at the beginning of this chapter, an impression of Britishness is present not only in the works of the British fantasts listed. Australian writer Traci Harding’s Australian heroine

³ Though Britain did not exist as a united political entity in the Middle Ages, I will be using it as a useful inclusive term for the areas and historic cultures that now comprise Britain.

in *The Ancient Future* (1996) which is not drawn back in time to an antipodean past, but to sixth-century Wales. The *Deltora Quest* (2000-2005) by fellow Australian author, Emily Rodda, does not have an Australian setting, but is situated in a pseudo-medieval 'past'. American Marion Zimmer-Bradley returns to an imagined Arthurian Britain in *The Mists of Avalon* (1979), while her compatriots, Raymond E. Feist, Christopher Paolini and Kristin Cashore invent new secondary, medievalist worlds for their fantasies in *Magician* (1982), *Eragon* (2002) and *Graceling* (2008). Diana Gabaldon, also American, chooses early eighteenth-century Scotland as the period and location for the time-slip in *Cross Stitch* (1991).

If, as Attebery argues, Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* is the central template for contemporary fantasy in English, it is unsurprising that medievaesque, 'sword and sorcery', heroic pasts feature in fantasy fiction. Though fantasy writing continues to evolve and expand in settings, locations, styles, temporalities and subject matter, there remains a strong interest in and demand for fantasy which is situated close to the Tolkien model. Indeed, appropriating J.R.R. Tolkien's metaphorical comparison of fairy-stories to "attics and lumber-rooms" (Tolkien 39), Terry Pratchett wryly (and perhaps a little too cynically) observed that "Most modern fantasy just rearranges the furniture in Tolkien's attic" (Pratchett 591).

Medievalism that employs various combinations of fantasy, nostalgic longing, and a sense of national identity, however, does not begin with Tolkien. It has long been evident within English literature. The existence of an actual Middle Ages seems not to foreclose on the invention of a disparate array of 'Middle Ages' by modern and medieval writers alike. Indeed, marvellous, idealised,

and nostalgic constructions of the Middle Ages can be found even in medieval texts. Geoffrey Chaucer's "The Wife of Bath's Tale" provides an example of looking back with romantic longing to "th'olde dayes of the Kyng Arthour, / Of which that Britons speken greet honour, / [when] All was this land fulfild of fayerye." (Chaucer lns 857-861). Similarly, *Sir Gawain and the Green Knight* looks back to "Arthurus day" (2522) when Bolde bredden perinne, baret þat lofden/ In mony turned tyme tene þat wroȝten (21-22).⁴ Sir Thomas Malory idealises an imagined past, when "olde love" was true. Unlike "love nowadayes: sone hote sone colde", in "Kynge Arthurs dayes" "men and women coude love togydirs seven yeys, and no lycoures listis was betwyxte them, and than was love trouthe and faythefulnes (Malory 60).

Medievalism is present in Early-Modern literature, such as Spencer's didactic epic *The Faerie Queene* and, to varying degrees, in a number of Shakespeare's plays from *King Lear* to *A Midsummer Night's Dream*. There is evidence of the continued appeal of the Middle Ages in Gothicism, and nineteenth-century medievalism is seen in movements like romanticism and pre-Raphaelitism. Medievalist genre fantasy, therefore, continues literary tradition in its various and romanticised constructions of the medieval past. Grounded in longstanding literary practice, as evidenced by the works of the abovementioned medieval writers, genre fantasy utilises the 'empty' spaces created by temporal distance and overlays them with imagined histories and fantastic possibilities. The medieval past, therefore, is an adaptable resource for fiction.

⁴ "the old days of Arthur" (Borroff 2522), when the "Bold Boys bred" in Britain "did in their day many a deed most dire" (Borroff 21-22).

Medievalism often indulges in imaginative constructions of the Middle Ages. *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and *The Fionavar* tapestry participate in forms of popular medievalism. The Old Kingdom presents as a medieval-esque Kingdom, complete with kings, queens, castles, knights and horses. It is pre-industrial, and like a great deal of nineteenth-century medievalism, values artisanship and disdains mass production. It employs medieval literary motifs such as knightly service, destiny, caste and magic, quite literally taking up the imagery of 'Bell, book and battleaxe' (Wilkins BB&B 1). The novels also engage in a Gothic medievalism, evoking horror through the threat of the (un)Dead. *The Fionavar Tapestry* is also overtly medievalist, most obviously in its depiction of the High Kingdom of Brennín with its grand palace, kings, court and mages. Other Kingdoms in *Fionavar* are also medievalist; the Dwarf Kingdom represents an older cruder Middle Ages than that depicted by Brennín; Cathal represents a medieval Other in evoking the Saracen; the *lios alfar* evoke Nordic elves; and the Giant *Paraiko* recall characters from Welsh legend. Medievalism is clearly apparent in the way in which Kay draws from Celtic and Norse mythologies, even borrowing the characters of Arthur, Guinevere, Lancelot and Taliesin from Arthurian legend.

Pertinently, rather than exerting a fixed positive identity of its own, the Middle Ages are often defined by what they are not; they are not modern, not classical, not progressive. The Middle Ages can be rendered as a gap in enlightened culture's evolution. The 'Middle Ages' very naming defines this period less by any substance of its own, than by its position between the classical and the modern. When combined with the sheer temporal and geographical vastness of the Middle Ages, this can leave, within the popular imagination, spaces of perceived 'emptiness' or, at least, mere outlines of the

past; spaces and outlines over which modernity and post-modernity can conjecture and write.

My choice to study the works of an Australian fantasy author and a Canadian fantasy author has been motivated by questions of cultural heritage, attachment, and identity. I am interested in the implications of a literary nostalgia that suggests a yearning for a 'home' in place both temporally and spatially removed from geographic, national experience.

The recent addition of a database on Australian Popular Medievalism to the Auslit on-line resource on Australian literature provides evidence of this attachment. Compiled by researchers Kim Wilkins, Drew Whitehead and Oliver Chadwick, the database highlights the influence of medievalism on Australian popular fiction. In "Bell, Book and Battleaxe" (BB&B) (2010) Wilkins observes that medievalism is most notable in the genres of fantasy, historical, and romance fiction (9). She comments that more than 250 popular Australian novels for adult audiences were published between 1995 and 2010, featuring a European Middle Ages "either as an actual setting or as a source for adapting images and ideas" (6). This demonstrates the significance of medievalism within the Australian popular imagination, prompting Wilkins to ask "why the Middle Ages are important, how they are represented, and what those representations might tell us not just about individual authors but about contemporary Australia" (6).

Pertinently, Wilkins identifies 160 of these books as "fantasy fiction in its strictest sense, that is, epic high fantasy in the style of Tolkien's *Lord of the*

Rings" (10). Moreover, as this number only includes adult fiction, it does not reflect the full extent of fantastic medievalism in Australian literature. Australian children's and young adult fantasy are significantly represented in both the local and global marketplaces. Indeed, bestselling children's author Emily Rodda alone has produced four fantasy series, collectively comprising thirty five novels, and Garth Nix's individual young adult catalogue includes three highly successful children's/young adult fantasy series consisting of twenty novels.

Wikipedia too, with its amateur status, collaborative methodology and policy of consensus, reflects wide popular interest in the fantasy genre. This is seen in the high number of entries about fantasy authors. Though not subject to academic peer review, the site is useful resource for the viewing of societal trends. Significantly, Wikipedia's listing of fantasy authors reveals a strong association between genre fantasy and writers from Britain and former British settler cultures such as Australia, Canada, and the United States of America, with more entries for authors from these countries than from other Western nations. ("Category: Fantasy writers by nationality" online).

Part of the phenomenon of fantasy's popularity in Britain and in former British settler cultures likely arises from a history of continuity and identification with the Middle Ages. In 1979 a seminal paper by Hans Robert Jauss, "The Alterity and Modernity of Medieval Literature", shifted the direction of debate on medieval studies by asserting the 'otherness' of the Middle Ages and of the medieval audience. In response to Jauss' focus on alterity, English academic J.A. Burrow argued that he felt less alienated from the Middle Ages than his colleagues on the continent seemed to feel. Medieval studies

in England, he contended, demonstrated a greater literary and cultural continuity with early modern writers such as “Spencer, Herbert (and some would add Shakespeare)” drawing strongly upon their medieval predecessors (385). Where, according to Burrow, Jauss expresses a regret that “the study of the literature of the European Middle Ages ... has lost its place in the educational canon” (385-6), Burrow’s experience in English universities (in the late 1970s) was that “medieval literature still plays a significant part in the ordinary curriculum of undergraduates reading English” (386). Burrow argued that the British experience is of a more accessible Middle Ages. As an educational model, this British interest in the Middle Ages was also exported to British settler cultures.

Leslie Workman, in “Medievalism and Romanticism” (1994), makes an even stronger claim for the connection between Englishness and medievalism, arguing that in the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries medievalism was “so much a natural part of English life” (10) that the word ‘survival’ rather than ‘revival’ might be more appropriate to a consideration of the phenomenon of British medievalism. He, too, focuses on the significance of literature and education in sustaining a cultural connection with the medieval. In *Imagined Communities*, Benedict Anderson similarly emphasises the role literature plays in the construction of cultural affiliation and identification. Anderson speaks of the importance of print-capitalism and the rise of the text in meaningfully combining notions of “fraternity, power and time” (36). He argues print commodities paved a way “for rapidly growing numbers of people to think about themselves, and relate themselves to others, in profoundly new ways” (36). This “created the possibility of a new form of imagined community” (46). Rosemary Marangoly George sums this up in

The Politics of Home: Postcolonial Relocations and Twentieth-Century Fiction by saying “all texts that are read in a society are intertwined with the imagining of that community” (108). Where Anderson speaks of the place texts occupy in national imaginings, this thesis is also concerned with the role stories play in maintaining and confirming broader cultural identity, in constructing the idea of a shared heritage, character and ideals.

Certainly, Australia and Canada are tied to Britain through membership in the Commonwealth and through constitutional monarchy (although the Canada Act (1982) made the Queen’s role in Canada a solely symbolic one). Canada’s identity is also influenced by its history of French colonisation alongside British colonisation. Still, despite geographic distance and, in practice, political independence, the impact of British heritage remains. Those of us who are descended from former settler communities cannot look back more than a few centuries without having to turn to Britain or Europe for a cultural past. Though story tellers have the alternative of utilising the pre-settlement past and historical space of their current countries as the context for historical imaginings, this can be problematic. As will be discussed in relation to the inclusion of a Native American culture in Kay’s *The Fionavar Tapestry*, the use of Aboriginal motifs can entail an ethically fraught appropriation from, or overriding of, the cultural and spiritual property of Aboriginal populations. It might also be seen as a retrospective literary colonisation, discursively reinforcing the physical occupation of these lands.

An ancestral heritage provides a form of continuity within diasporic communities. The popularity of medievalist genre fantasy in nations that are spatially, and largely politically, removed from Britain demonstrates a sense

of cultural if not physical belonging. It speaks to the cultural imaginings of our communities where the unspoiled northern landscapes and the romantic medieval models of castles, crowns and kings expose an affective attachment to an imagined homeland and to cultural roots.

Rosemary Marangoly George considers ideas of belonging in postcolonial and twentieth-century realist fiction. Her work begins with a prologue entitled “All fiction is homesickness” (1) and ends with an epilogue stating “All homesickness is fiction” (199). George argues that global English language novels “re-present the ideologies of ‘home’” (1). She argues that the notion of ‘home’ is inherently marked by ambivalence – that ‘home’ is not fixed in meaning; it is a “place that is flexible, that manifests itself in various forms” (9). Although unfixed, the idea of home and of ‘home country’ still carries cultural power. It is built around a “pattern of select inclusions and exclusions. Home is a way of establishing difference” (2). George asserts that home, “along with gender/sexuality, race, and class, acts as an ideological determinant of the subject” (2). A sense belonging to a home relies on:

a learned (or taught) sense of kinship that is extended to those who are perceived as sharing the same blood, race, class, gender, or religion. Membership is maintained by bonds of love, fear, power, desire and control. Homes are manifest on geographical, psychological and material levels. They are places that are recognized as such by those within and those without. (George 9)

Clearly, geographical space is only one of the myriad determinants that construct the belonging and identity incorporated in ‘home’. George argues that for colonial writers, any reference to a ‘home-country’ reflects this tension, as it implies that somehow the writer is not speaking from home (2).

Such a tension is suggested by the allure that imaginings of medieval Britain hold for the writers of genre fantasy in settler cultures. Moreover, it speaks to the strength of notions of cultural heritage, while hinting at post-colonial concerns about contemporary belonging and identity.

Considerations of cultural lineage, literary heritage, and ideas of home and loss all coalesce in an examination of medievalist fantasy emerging from postcolonial countries such as Australia and Canada. Moreover, the popular dominance of the genre evidences the affective resonance and reach of such literature. This gives fantasy a point of access to discourses of contemporary cultural significance. The flexibility of the Middle Ages, too, enables modern writers to attach an historical heritage to contemporary ideas and representation, naturalising and giving greater cultural weight to the ideologies their texts express. This can be turned to many purposes. In “The Idea of the Middle Ages Outside Europe” (2009), Kathleen Davis and Nadia Altschul emphasise that the medieval is “an idea rather than an internally unified entity” (1). They argue that the period of the “Middle Ages” has never been “a stagnant, inactive, or merely inherited category in the former colonies, and that it continues to be an operative and volatile domain” (21). Rather than primarily seeking resemblance and inheritance, this thesis considers the flexible utility of the medieval in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and *The Fionavar Tapestry* and how the Middle Ages might be co-opted in the service of contemporary ideologies.

Chapter 1 will situate this thesis in the critical areas of fantasy and medievalism studies. It firstly reviews fantasy criticism over the twentieth and early twenty-first centuries, highlighting theoretical and historical

perspectives that will constructively inform the discussions of my selected texts. It also discusses works which, though not centrally concerned with the fantasy genre, have strongly influenced the manner in which fantasy has been critically approached, or sometimes ignored. Together these works provide a foundation and context for my discussion of genre fantasy. Secondly, it focuses on the semiotic plasticity and utility of the Middle Ages as a setting for contemporary storytelling, and considers the cultural power of imaginings of the medieval. This section also discusses the anxieties attached to the authentic/inauthentic dichotomy inherent in medievalism studies.

Fantasy and medievalism studies do not represent the only areas of critical interest in my discussion. This thesis also intersects theoretically with scholarship on matters including postcolonialism, Orientalism, gender politics and national identity. Critical considerations of such subjects are situated within relevant sections of the thesis.

Chapter 2 begins my discussion of Garth Nix's *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*. It focuses on the cultural significance of the contrast between North and South that is central within the series. It argues that the novels utilise the affective weight of a medieval 'Northernness' and 'pastness' in a discursive challenge to pure scientific rationalism and unfettered industrial progress. Chapter 3 argues that *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* reflect their Australian origin and participate in contemporary debates on national identity and class. Chapter 4 considers how the novels respond more immediately to Australia's political and cultural context at the time of their production. It does so through an examination of the refugee crisis depicted in *Lirael* and *Abhorsen*. This

entails a discussion of Australia's own refugee crisis and the cultural and political re-emergence of a conservative Anglo-centricity. Chapter 5 closes my consideration of *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* with an examination of how the series represents its heroes and heroines. It asserts that Nix utilises the power of medievalist representation to subvert traditional gender paradigms and challenge entrenched expectations of gender behaviour.

My discussion of Guy Gavriel Kay's *The Fionavar Tapestry* begins in Chapter 6. I introduce the various lands and races in Fionavar, and contend that the High Kingdom of Brenninn represents the West, enlightenment and patriarchy. Informed by postcolonial theory, particularly Edward Said's *Orientalism*, I examine the relations between the Western High Kingdom and Cathal, a domain with clear Eastern, Saracen markers, arguing that the West is strongly privileged within the novels. Chapter 7 extends this study to the Dalrei, a tribal culture that closely resembles that of the North American 'Indian'. It considers the Canadian inflection this adds to the series and discusses how the portrayal of the Dalrei intersects with issues at the forefront of Canadian politics at the time of Kay's writing. I particularly focus on Western paternalism and the issue of land ownership, arguing that Western authority is inconspicuously naturalised. The latter section of this chapter looks at the novels' Dwarfish kingdom, arguing that *The Fionavar Tapestry* yet again represents this different culture as essentially inferior to that of the High Kingdom. In this case, however, as the Dwarves evoke a more rudimentary, working-class Western society, this hierarchy is justified by class rather than ethnicity.

Chapter 8 focuses on gender archetypes, arguing that although the novels include strong women characters, their portrayals are constrained by entrenched constructions of appropriate masculine and feminine roles. Chapter 9 combines the earlier themes of ethnicity and gender through a case study of the romance between Brennin's Prince Diarmuid and Cathal's Princess Sharra. I consider the gender and power dynamics evident in Diarmuid's seduction of Sharra and claim that these can be read as metonymic of the relationship between East and West.

Fantasy and medievalism criticism provide a foundation throughout my thesis. They inform and underlie this consideration of *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and *The Fionavar Tapestry's* discursive intervention in contemporary debates on identity, ethnicity, class and gender. I argue their appeal to the past both utilises and feeds the considerable affective and cultural power available to contemporary imaginings of the medieval.

Chapter 1

Fantasy and Medievalism

This chapter contextualises the coming analysis through a survey of scholarship related to genre fantasy. Such a survey offers insight into the historical underrepresentation of genre fantasy within literary criticism, and supports my venture into this developing area of critical interest. My review of literature also considers the cultural implications of medievalist representation, and the power attached to re-imaginings of the Middle Ages.

This review of scholarly literature discusses criticism from the 1920s to the present. It includes scholarship on fantasy and on related areas such as of folktale, mythology and romance. The movement across times and between disciplines means that the terminology is not consistent across the different works considered. Added to this is the ‘fuzziness’ associated with many of these terms. As noted in Chapter one, in his discussion of fantasy Brian Attebery appropriated the concept of ‘fuzzy sets’ from George Lakoff and Mark Johnson⁵ to describe what constitutes popular fantasy. He argues that the set of ‘popular fantasy’ has a fixed centre and fuzzy boundaries. This image can also be applied to the question of what constitutes myth, or

⁵ See Lakoff, George, and Mark Johnson. *Metaphors We Live By* (1980).

romance, or fairytale and folktale, or even to subsets of fantasy such as medievalist fantasy, high fantasy, and genre fantasy. There are established, uncontroversial makers that hold the centres, but the boundaries of these concepts are not similarly fixed. Moreover, these sets have large sections that overlap or even reside inside related sets.

Before moving to the literature review proper, therefore, I will consider some of the terms applied to fantasy literatures. The definitions given here attempt to capture aspects at the centre of these concepts, but I would like to reiterate that these terms do not have firm outer-limits and that they frequently intersect with other terms. I will begin with 'fantasy' which, at a basic literary level, can be used as a descriptor for any work that is not realist in nature, making it "a most extraordinarily porous term" (Clute 337). Where realism seeks to represent experience as it is ordinarily perceived, fantasy goes beyond that which would conventionally be considered possible. Although this broad definition of fantasy can encompass a range of literatures including, but by no means limited to allegory, fairytale, folklore, science fiction, surrealism and horror (Clute 337), its general usage within this thesis is narrower. It is applied to the popular genre of literature described by Attebery, as bearing a familial resemblance to the structure and atmosphere to J.R.R. Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings*, the work he asserts is the "mental template" for readers of popular fantasy in English (Attebery 14).

Attebery argues that resemblance becomes a better marker of fantasy than firm taxonomical limitations. He considers three fundamental aspects of contemporary fantasy's resemblance to *The Lord of the Rings*. These relate to content, structure and reader response: content within fantasy involves the

impossible – a violation of that which the author “believes to be natural law” (14); structurally fantasy is comic in that it begins with a problem and ends with resolution (15); and responsively, fantasy is evocative of a particular joy or wonder (16). This definition underscores significant central markers of genre fantasy, whilst leaving the outer limits unfixed.

Much of the fantasy that comfortably fits within Attebery’s schema also fits into subcategories, and these subcategories themselves intersect. John Clute and John Grant’s *The Encyclopedia of Fantasy*, for example, identify categories such as ‘High Fantasy’, ‘Sword and Sorcery’ fantasy, ‘Heroic Fantasy’, and ‘Genre Fantasy’. High fantasy is “set in otherworlds, specifically secondary worlds”, and deal with matters “affecting the destiny of those worlds” (Clute 466). Sword and sorcery fantasy as “a subgenre featuring muscular heroes in violent conflict with a variety of villains, chiefly wizards, witches, evil spirits and other creatures whose powers are – unlike the hero’s – supernatural in origin” (Clute, Langford & Kaveney 915); it is easy to see how this might overlap with high fantasy if the conflict is of great import and set in a secondary world. Indeed, Clute comments on the extent of intersection between certain subsets of fantasy when he defines Heroic Fantasy with the observation that there “may be a useful distinction between [heroic fantasy] and sword and sorcery, but no one has yet made it” (464). He goes on to argue the term is redundant “because a central thread in any analysis of [Sword and Sorcery] is the understanding that it is a kind of Genre Fantasy which features a hero” (464) (though Clute’s explanation appears to assume ‘heroism’ is inherently ‘muscular’ and embedded in matters of high destiny). Such an explanation places these subcategories under the broader subcategory of Genre Fantasy.

'Genre' as a modifying adjunct to 'fantasy' is often used in a pejorative manner. John Grant argues that it is "almost always High Fantasy, Heroic Fantasy or Sword and Sorcery, and the main distinguishing characteristic is that, on being confronted by an unread [genre fantasy] book, one recognises it; one has been there before, and the territory into which the book takes one is familiar" (396). Although this opens the genre to the charge of being "imitative dross" (Grant 396), my discussion of literature in this chapter will show that I do not use the term in a negative manner. If, as Attebery argues, fantasy is defined by a resemblance to a fixed central template (14), one cannot be surprised at familiarity, but combinations of the expected and the unexpected can work together to allow the genre to offer continual surprises.

Often the terms I use in my consideration of fantasy are driven by the secondary material I am discussing. Vladimir Propp, for example, discusses Folktales, stories originating in oral tradition, set in this world, which often reflect aspects of cultural identity (Ashley 359-360). Propp's focus upon the *Wondertale*, a subset of folktale that deals with marvellous happenings, intersects strongly with the classification of fantasy fiction. Similarly, there is the category of Romance, and I primarily employ the term to conform to Northrop Frye's use of 'romance' in his discussion of "The Mythos of Summer" (Frye 187-206). Frye's usage heavily overlaps with conceptions of fantasy, particularly in its medievalist form. Brian Attebery's entry on Romance in *The Encyclopedia of Fantasy* (EoF) is another that speaks of the scope of such a term: "Like the term Fantasy 'romance' refers to a bewildering number of forms of literary expression" (820). A medieval term first applied to any text translated from Latin into vernacular languages, it

was soon applied to tales of chivalry and courtly love (Attebery EoF 820). Many medieval romances were based on traditional legendary or historical figures but the stories were embellished, often by the addition of supernatural occurrences and features such as quests and knightly heroes (EoF 820). The term 'romance' was retrospectively applied to classical Greek prose narratives of improbable adventures with supernatural elements and happy resolutions (EoF 820), and was later applied to medievalist fiction and poetry such as that by Sir Walter Scott, William Morris and Lord Alfred Tennyson; to gothic novels such as that of Anne Radcliffe and Horace Walpole; and to love stories such as those by the Brontë sisters (EoF 821). Typically, my usage of 'romance' coincides with the medieval and medievalist understandings of the term; heroic, chivalric and courtly narratives often embellished with non-realist or supernatural occurrences. Alternatively, I use the term 'genre romance' when speaking of the popular love stories predominantly written by and marketed to women.

'Fairy-story' is another term that has a particular inflection based in its context. When used in relation to a discussion of Tolkien this resides at the centre of the genre now known as fantasy. Tolkien uses it in his now famous essay, *On Fairy Stories*, setting out his thoughts on the nature this type of literature. Tolkien's fairy-story is, therefore, synonymous with related terms like 'Tolkienesque fantasy' or 'high fantasy'. If I discuss stories in the ilk of *Cinderella* and *Sleeping Beauty* I refer to them as fairy-tale.

Often the modifying terms I attach to 'fantasy' are used to highlight particular characteristics. 'Medievalist fantasy', for example, is used to draw attention to the settings and tropes that demonstrate the legacy of the Middle Ages,

and 'popular fantasy' is used to underscore the genre's wide marketability and appeal. These terms, however, still reside under the broader banner of genre fantasy. When speaking of literatures that might defy consensus reality but do not sit toward the centre of fantasy, I speak of 'fantastic' elements rather than referring to it as 'fantasy' literature.

Significantly, much of the theoretical work that has influenced scholarly criticism of popular fantasy fiction is only tangentially connected the genre. The historically privileged place of realism within literary scholarship, and concomitant lack of an accepted apposite theoretical framework for the fantasy genre, has mean that critics of fantasy have often turned to literature on fairy tale and folklore. Russian folklorist and formalist Vladimir Propp's 1928 *Morphology of the Folktale* exerted an influence on theorists including Claude Lévi-Strauss and Tzvetan Todorov. The intersection between folklore and fantasy is obvious, particularly given that the focus in Propp's study is the *Wondertale* – folktales with supernatural or magical elements. Certainly, the *Wondertale* and genre fantasy share many motifs: castles, curses, kingdoms, kings and queens, princes and princesses, witches, rituals, weddings. Also, both genre fantasy and the *Wondertale* sit outside consensus reality.

Although folklore, like genre fantasy, can superficially appear detached and escapist, the opening page of Propp's *Theory and History of Folklore* (THF) makes the astute observation that an understanding of folklore cannot be divorced from ideology. He notes that "Folklore is an ideological discipline. Its methods and aims are determined by and reflect the outlook of the age" (3). I will argue that the same can be said of fantasy fiction. As a formalist,

however, Propp's central concern is form of narrative – structure, patterns, plot components, devices and conventions. His work focuses on these aspects above the cultural purpose served by the form. His complex taxonomy for the folktale centres on the progress of a fairy tale's narrative through sequentially linear 'functions' (character actions) that comprise the 'generic units' of a story. An accidental by-product of such a taxonomy was a scholarly concentration on structural aspects at the expense of aesthetics. Propp's schema also opened fantasy to charges of being derivative, imitative and unvarying.

The recognition of narrative patterns within storytelling, however, should not imply that all texts are essentially the same. This is noted in Alan Dundes' introduction to the 1968 edition of Propp's *Morphology of the Folktale* (MF) as he comments on the wide applicability of Propp's taxonomy to many literary forms extending from novels and plays to comic strips, film and television (Dundes XIV-XV). Indeed, Propp himself recognises that a story rises above its structure. He speaks of the "two-fold quality of a tale: its amazing multiformity, picturesqueness, and color, and on the other hand, its no less striking uniformity, its repetition" (MF 20).

Propp, however, comments on the wider spectrum of possibility allowed outside the constraints of realist fiction:

The folktale is deliberate and poetic fiction. It never passes itself off as reality. What makes the folktale attractive if the representation of reality is not its purpose? First of all, its unusual narrative. The lack of correspondence with reality, fiction as such, offers special delight. [...] this is why people find them so fascinating. (THF 19)

Fantasy, like the *Wondertale*, can offer this enjoyment. A consideration of fascination and delight can shift the focus from a story's form to its reception.

Northrop Frye's "Archetypal Criticism: Theory of Myths", published in his 1957 text, *Anatomy of Criticism: Four Essays*, though not directly concerned with the genre fantasy, has also proved seminal in fantasy criticism. His category "The Mythos of Summer: Romance" (Frye 187-206) can be aptly applied to fantasy as well as romance literature, influencing the criticism of fantasy scholars including Katherine Hume and Brian Attebery. The fantasy genre fits very closely within Frye's conception of romance. Indeed, given the non-realist nature of his 'romance', the terms 'romance' and 'fantasy' can largely be viewed as interchangeable in my discussion of Frye's critical framework, with the exception that fantasy often engages with myth in a more direct way than Frye's romance. Frye observes that modernism's appreciation of irony and objectivity worked to relegate the romantic to an "old-fashioned" past (62). This contributed to the binary that sets the real above the unreal.

It is significant, then, that Frye questions the dichotomy between modern "realist" literature and romantic literature, complete with its fantastic elements. He stresses that both forms of literature are fictional in their representation. "Realism", he argues, is not achieved through the recreation of something's likeness, but rather by adherence to certain artistic conventions which imply likeness; "realism is an art of implicit simile", which the reader can interpret as contextually plausible (136). Romantic literature on the other hand, is no more fictional, but simply more overt in its fictional status. Through introducing fantastic elements, this literature gives up its

“external analogy to ‘life’” (Frye 135); it steps outside the stylistic conventions that imply a wider contextual plausibility. I will argue, however, that despite fantasy giving up its ‘external analogy to ‘life’”, the familiarity of traditional motifs and patterns are able to create an alternative sense of plausibility. Fantasy texts evoke a ‘reality’ that exists according to different artistic conventions than those that are upheld in realist texts. Furthermore, I will argue that this plausibility brings with it discursive power.

Romance, Frye contends, occupies a place between myth and realism. According to Frye’s analysis, “undisplaced myth [is] generally concerned with gods or demons, [taking] the form of two contrasting worlds of total metaphorical identification, one desirable and the other undesirable” (139). Alternatively, romance, although indulging in fantasy, has “the tendency to suggest implicit mythical patterns in a world more closely associated with human experience” (Frye 139-140). This tendency draws attention to the ambiguous position occupied by romance or fantasy. Fantasy approaches the real without fully taking hold of the conventions that maintain the façade of realist plausibility, and it approaches myth without attaining that sense of elevation and the divine attached to classical myth. Genre fantasy, then, does not quite fit into considerations of myth and archetypal meaning, and is similarly at the edge of considerations of the power of realist representation. This ambiguity, conversely, also allows fantasy access to conventions of both myth and realism, enabling it to utilise, appropriate, and combine a broader range of archetypes, conventions, forms and motifs in creative ways.

Frye also observes that socially, romance has “a curiously paradoxical role” (186). Romance, he argues, is utilised by ruling and intellectual classes as a

channel for the projection of dominant ideals, whilst it simultaneously demonstrates a “genuinely ‘proletarian’ element [...] which is never satisfied with its various incarnations” (186). This broadness in utility is indicative of the ambivalence and the malleability and even cultural power available to the fantasy genre. It is not insignificant that it can be utilised to reinforce hegemonic power, or to subvert, or even to present an outright challenge to dominant authority. Something of the cultural potency of fantastic storytelling can be found in Frye’s recognition of the perennial nature of romance. He observes that, despite marked changes in society, romance “will turn up again, as hungry as ever, looking for new hopes and desires to feed on” (186). Indeed, this thesis will discuss the hopes, fears and desires reflected in Nix’s *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and Kay’s *The Fionavar Tapestry*.

Myth is often regarded as high literature and romance as popular culture, but Frye argues the difference between the two resides, rather, in “the hero’s power of action: in the myth proper he is divine, in the romance proper he is human” (188). Still, Frye observes, most “cultures regard certain stories with more reverence than others, either because they are thought to be historically true or because they have come to bear a heavier weight of conceptual meaning” (188). I suggest that Frye’s observation offers insight into readers’ affective responses to genre fantasy. Though divinity may increase distinction, it might also remove the story and characters from human experience, disrupting reader identification and empathy. The humanity of a hero more easily invites an empathetic and affective relationship between readers and a text’s protagonists. Moreover, given the parallel themes and motifs within myth and romance, the human element within tales does not necessarily strip romance of significance. As will be

particularly discussed in my consideration of Guy Gavriel Kay's *The Fionavar Tapestry*, the genre of fantasy extends beyond pure romance, in that it is able to appropriate from both popular tales and myth. This allows the genre to blend the cultural weight of mythology with the humanity of romance.

Another theoretical approach that has heavily influenced the scholarship on fantasy is Tzvetan Todorov's *The Fantastic*, first published in English in 1973. In this influential work Todorov offers another structural framework for the consideration of fantastic literature. Although writing in a critical climate that privileged originality, Todorov recognises the importance of genre. His framework differs from prevailing approaches, in that it endorses an examination of both sameness and *difference*. He argues that even within genre fiction "the work of art is essentially unique, valuable because of what is original about it that distinguishes it from all other works, and not because of what in it may resemble them" (5).

Rather than allowing literature to be constrained by precise categories, Todorov's work draws attention to flexibility both within and between genres. He argues that, regardless of the number of texts examined in any analysis, "we are never justified in extrapolating universal laws from them" (4). Addressing Propp's use of biological taxonomies as analogies for literary classification, Todorov asserts there is a substantial difference between art and science. As noted in Chapter 1, he contends that art's "evolution operates with an altogether different rhythm: every work modifies the sum of possible works, each new example alters the species" (Todorov 6). This observation is significant for a consideration of fantasy, as it both recognises and demonstrates a capacity for movement and flexibility within a genre.

Building upon structuralist theorists that came before, Todorov offers a new criterion for the genre he calls 'the fantastic'. He situates it in that unfamiliar place that resides between reality and dream, truth and illusion. In doing so he explains the "fantastic is that hesitation experienced by a person who knows only the laws of nature, confronting an apparent supernatural event" (25). It exists only in that moment of uncertainty which hangs between the real and the imaginary. Its precarious position is evident in that once "we choose one answer or the other we leave the fantastic to a neighbouring genre, the uncanny or the marvellous" (Todorov 25). Todorov argues that the fantastic "lasts only as long as a certain hesitation common to reader and character, who must decide whether or not what they perceive deviates from 'reality' as it exists in the common opinion" (41). If the event can be explained by the laws of nature the story defaults to the 'uncanny', if it cannot be explained by existing laws of nature it defaults to the 'marvellous'.

Clearly, according to Todorov's categorisation, conventional genre fantasy falls outside his class of 'the fantastic'. Although that moment of 'hesitation' may not be completely absent from fantasy texts, it does not occupy a position of centrality in the genre. Rather than sitting easily within Todorov's 'fantastic', genre fantasy more aptly fits alongside the associated, but separate class of 'the marvellous'. Todorov's marvellous encompasses fairy tale where impossible "events provoke no surprise" (54). He also identifies: the hyperbolic marvellous, that draws on exaggeration and larger-than-life imagery; the exotic marvellous, where foreign settings account for transgressions of reality; the instrumental marvellous, where magic items and gadgets such as flying carpets and magic apples provide the marvellous

aspects of the story; and the scientific marvellous, where the “supernatural is explained in a rational manner, but according to laws which contemporary science does not acknowledge” (54-58).

The acceptance of magic and of phenomena that transgress rules of natural possibility place most of what is generally classified as genre fantasy outside Todorov’s ‘fantastic’. Genre fantasy typically causes no hesitation, or quickly defaults to the marvellous. It invites readers to commit themselves to worlds of possibilities, unrestrained by the laws of science and reality as we understand them – to willingly open themselves to delights of magic, romance and adventure. Scholarly interest in Todorov’s taxonomy, however, has largely centred upon his conception of the fantastic. Clyde Northrup argues, in his 2004 *The Qualities of a Tolkienian Fairy-Story*, that the influence of Todorov’s ‘fantastic’ was such that it became a foundation or a touchstone for critics in their own examinations of the fantastic, leading to the critical “exclusion of a whole category of fantasy literature” (815).

Rosemary Jackson’s influential 1981 work, *Fantasy: the Literature of Subversion* seems to bear out Northrup’s claim. Leaning strongly toward a Todorovian fantastic, Jackson primarily considers non-realist works that fit more comfortably within Todorov’s frame, but adds a strongly psychoanalytical perspective to her readings. Jackson argues that the added psychological focus is significant, as she identifies fantasy as a “literature of desire, which seeks that which is experienced as absence and loss” (3). Literary fantasies, Jackson contends, express unconscious drives. Without a consideration of the psychological, she asserts, Todorov’s fantastic “fails to consider the social and political implications of literary forms. [...] it does not

move outward to again relate the forms of literary texts to their cultural formation" (6). Though such a statement would appear to provide a frame through which the hopes and desires expressed in genre fantasy might be profitably considered, Jackson expresses a strong disdain for fantasy that sits within the generic 'secondary world' mode:

This book aims to locate such a transcendentalist approach as part of a nostalgic, humanist vision, of the same kind as those romance fictions produced by Lewis, Tolkien, T.H. White, and other modern fabulists, all of whom look back to a lost moral and social hierarchy, which their fantasies attempt to recapture and revivify. (Jackson 2)

Jackson's discussion of texts, therefore, though ranging from gothic fiction to works by Franz Kafka and Thomas Pynchon, largely repudiates popular fantasy, negatively labelling it as both nostalgic and reactionary. She asserts that the popularity of Tolkien indicates the:

strength of romance tradition supporting a ruling ideology. Tolkien is nostalgic for a pre-industrial, indeed pre-Norman conquest, feudal order. He makes a naïve equation of industry with evil, referring with disgust to the 'materialism of a Robot Age', and looking backwards to a medieval paradise. (Jackson 155)

Using Tolkien as almost a metonym for popular fantasy, Jackson moves on to characterise the genre as "backwards", "chauvinistic", and "totalitarian" in vision (156). It might be argued that Jackson's criticism also reflects a 'naïve equation' of medievalist romance with intransigent conservatism, not allowing for the different ways medievalist fantasy can be harnessed in support of varying ideological perspectives. Her assessment suggests a modern disdain of the medieval.

Such a summary treatment of Tolkien provides some support for Northrup's contention that, in an attempt "to define fantasy literature within a Todorovian framework, [critics] fail to account for, or even recognize, Tolkien's contribution to the study of fantasy literature in his lecture 'On Fairy-Stories,' or the critical framework that he delineates" (Northrup 816). Still, despite this concern being borne out in the work of critics such as Jackson, Tolkien's impact on both writers within the fantasy genre and fantasy criticism is evident. Scholarship is not monolithic and more recent scholarship (including Northrup's own) has proven that, although genre fantasy may have been comparatively underrepresented and even undervalued within literary criticism, it is not absent. A quick survey of scholarship that embraces the analysis of fantasy as a critically valuable pursuit will be considered after the following discussion of J.R.R. Tolkien's "On Fairy Stories".

Originally delivered in 1938 as an Andrew Lang Lecture at the University of ST Andrews, "On Fairy-Stories" discusses fantasy literature. Tolkien declares his own emotional investment in the genre in his opening statement, saying "I have been a lover of fairy-stories since I learned to read" (11). He, perhaps a little disingenuously, also signals that his interest is that of an enthusiast rather than a critic (11). In his address Tolkien speaks of 'Faërie' as though it were a real place, "a perilous land", and himself as "hardly more than a wandering explorer in the land, full of wonder, but not of information" (11). Even so, one might suspect this scholarly humility to be a little disingenuous, or possibly a manner of distancing himself from the more structuralist approaches to myth and fable prevalent at this time.⁶

⁶ Tolkien notes that it is dangerous for a traveller in Faërie to "ask too many questions, lest the gates should be shut and the keys lost" (Tolkien 11).

Despite the genre's dependence on the strange and alien, Tolkien's examination highlights the human focus of fantasy fiction. He argues the stories are not primarily concerned with 'fairies', but rather with "the *adventures* of men in the Perilous Realm or upon its shadowy marshes" (17). He argues it is only 'natural' that fairy stories are more about men than elves, as "elves are not primarily concerned with us, nor we with them. Our fates are sundered, and our paths seldom meet. Even upon the borders of Faërie we encounter them only at some chance crossing of the ways" (17). Clearly, Tolkien paints 'Faërie' as 'Other'. This is significant to a consideration of how fantasy fiction positions humanity in a place of key importance, and to the way in which constructions of Faërie might operate as a mirror or contrast to contemporary identity. The import of human desire in fantasy fiction is also evident, as Tolkien claims at "least part of the magic [elves] wield for the good or evil of man is power to play on the desires of his body and his heart" (16). Rather than situating fantasy as detached from contemporary human concerns, it is made central.

As Tolkien moves on to definitions of a fairy story, the essence of desire and emotional response come even more to the fore. A fairy story, according to Tolkien, is not simply "one which touches on or uses Faërie, whatever its main purpose may be: satire, adventure, morality, fantasy" (17); it taps into "a particular mood and power" (17). This mood and magic, even in a satirical tale, must "be taken seriously and not be explained away" (18). Indeed, it is an acceptance of the reality of magic, within the web of the story, which distinguishes much of fantasy from associated genres. Tolkien argues, a fairy story "cannot tolerate any frame or machinery suggesting that the whole story in which [marvels] occur is a figment or illusion" (21).

Tolkien, significantly, differentiates his approach from more structuralist methodologies which he argues are too narrow in view for a consideration of the genre, as structuralism forgets the nature of the story as a whole (24). Indeed, Tolkien argues that similar or recurring motifs do not equate to the *stories* being the same, saying “[i]t is ‘precisely the colouring, atmosphere, the unclassifiable individual details of a story, and above all the general purport that informs with life the undissected bones of the plot, that really count’” (24). Tolkien sees value in antiquity of tales, but adds that independent invention, inheritance, and diffusion have all “played their part in producing the intricate web of story” (26). As intertextuality and familiarity play a large part within genre fantasy, Tolkien suggests an analogy between story making and a cauldron of soup. He argues that history and myth are among the ingredients mixed within the cauldron, and asserts that fantasy is dynamic and continually developing; “the Cauldron of the Story has always been boiling and to it have continually been added new bits” (32).

Although Tolkien sees fantasy as apolitical, asserting that its pure form is “artistic in desire and purpose” (54), I argue the manner in which the story is remixed, and the elements that modern writers add, make fantasy novels contemporary and relevant cultural documents. Even without the transformation of imaginative remixing, certain political and ideological inferences still accompany the repetition of myths and stories. In *Retelling Stories, Framing Culture* John Stephens and Robyn McCallum argue that retold stories are implicated in the construction, preservation and perpetuation of ideologies. They state that “literary and cultural formations represented in retold stories are often apparent bearers of clear attitudes to

such things as power (political, social and personal), hierarchy, gender, class and race" (21). Although appropriations from older literatures can prove apt vehicles for the transference of deep-rooted hierarchical ideologies, retellings can also be the site of challenges. Indeed, Stephens and McCallum assert that "retold stories have the potential to disclose how old stories suppress the invisible, the untold and the unspoken" (22).

Tolkien's focus, however, is not on ideological assumptions, but upon his intertextual soup as a resource for reinvention. He labels the act of writing fantasy 'sub-creation', saying that the fantasy writer:

makes a Secondary World which your mind can enter. Inside it what he relates is 'true': it accords with the laws of that world. You therefore believe it while you are, as it were, inside. The moment disbelief arises the spell is broken; the magic, or art has failed. You are then out in the Primary World again, looking at the little abortive Secondary World from the outside. (Tolkien 40-41)

This perspective positions Tolkien awkwardly against postmodern emphasis on irony and of self-aware intertextuality which advertise literature's constructed nature. The intertextuality that genre fantasy indulges in is typically of a different kind. Aspects such as repeated motifs and references to historical events and personages can provide a sense of plausibility. In spite of the unreality attached to the genre, the familiarity created by intertextuality is able to facilitate an uncynical acceptance of the credibility of a story as presented. It can make a 'belief' in magic appear normal and reasonable within the frame of the secondary world.

Tolkien's intertextuality, therefore, might be perceived as lacking the irony foregrounded in many modernist and postmodern texts. Tolkien scholar Michael Drout argues that the perception that Tolkienian fantasy lack irony is a mistaken one, asserting that fantasy's irony is merely different in form:

it is a kind of scholarly irony, enjoyable, but different from the morality-focused irony more common in Modernist texts. Part of the pleasure of the texts comes from recognizing how authors have pieced together incomplete materials, how they have filled lacunae and how they have remained true to their conceits while transforming their sources. (Drout 13)

Still, Tolkien's framework appears somewhat out of step with certain modern and postmodern expectations. There is also a sense of critical dissidence as Tolkien identifies "Fantasy, Recovery, Escape, and Consolidation" as fantasy literature's key values (Tolkien 48). Tolkienesque fantasy, therefore, express the pursuit of a certain wholeness and coherence. Its creation seeks not to expose or deconstruct, but to construct and mend.

While this critical dissidence may place fantasy outside the central concerns of much contemporary literary criticism, its manner of dealing with hopes and anxieties makes it deserving of critical attention. Fantasy creates a literary space in which impossible longings can be realised. Through "the imaginative satisfaction of ancient desires" (67), Tolkien argues these stories give consolidation to desires whether frivolous, such as wishing to fly, or more profound "such as the desire to converse with other living things" (66) or the desire to escape death (67).

A crucial aspect of Tolkien's thesis is his notion of the *Eucatastrophe* or the "sudden joyous 'turn'" in the story (68). This 'turn' stands opposite to dramatic tragedy. Fantasy's consolation does not deny the existence of sorrow and failure, Tolkien argues; "it denies (in the face of much evidence, if you will) universal defeat [. . .] giving a glimpse of Joy, Joy beyond the walls of the world, poignant as grief" (68). This encapsulates much of the mood to which a great deal of fantasy aspires, and demonstrates the importance of ambience above verisimilitude in representation. Tolkien's lecture is unashamed in its defence of engagement and enjoyment; neither is it ashamed of paradoxically granting a greater sense of substance and 'reality' to fantasy. It speaks clearly to the affective appeal of such literature, demonstrating not a disconnection with the present, but something of this literature's power to appropriate from the sense of authenticity and substance with which the past is often endowed, and to access seams of delight and desire within its readership.

Although genre fantasy does not hold a central place in the works of theorists such as Todorov and Jackson, it is given substantial consideration in the work of later theorists, who express varying judgements on fantasy's literary value. Published in 1984, Kathryn Hume's *Fantasy and Mimesis* considers fantasy within the context of literature as a whole, as "not a separate or indeed a separable strain" (xii). Rather than being constrained by narrow classification, Hume's working definition of fantasy literature is as "inclusive and flexible as possible" (20). For Hume fantasy includes any text that involves a "deliberate departure from the limits of what is usually accepted as real or normal" (xii). This widening of definition shifts discourse away from structural debates which, intentionally or otherwise, worked to limit the scope

of scholarly conversation about fantasy fiction. Hume's blurring of boundaries between different forms of non-realist literature can also be seen as a step toward the weakening of discernible hierarchies that have historically worked against the study of the popular forms of fantasy.

To consider fantasy within literature, Hume posits four basic approaches to reality – “illusion, vision, revision and dissolution” (55). She argues that, depending on the approach, fantasy can “attempt to disturb the reader's own assumptions, or reaffirm those assumptions and comfort the reader” (55). According to her schema, the literature of illusion uses escape and comfort; the literatures of vision and revision try to expose a new reality or to revise reality; and the literature of dissolution attempts to dismantle comfortable beliefs and undermine notions of reality. Although these approaches demonstrate something of the multifaceted nature of fantasy and the complexities attached to the form, divisions and hierarchies are reasserted within Hume's discussion of these approaches. Most aptly situated in the category of ‘illusion’ – escapist literature – genre fantasy is implicitly situated lower than literatures that challenge or disturb.

Hume argues that authors of illusory texts, being disillusioned and disempowered by reality, offer “to disengage us from its grey unpleasantness and to enfold us in comforting illusions”, holding out to the reader “roses without thorns and pleasures without payment” (55). Hume expresses a form of qualified agreement with Lewis's and Tolkien's arguments that escape can be positive, saying “one can feel that the illusions of escape literature offer possible benefits” (68). She argues that despite fantasy adventures' tendency to trashiness, they can provide a psychological

reassurance of individual worth and “encourage a belief in the possibility of meaningful action” (68). Hume considers illusory fantasy, however, as indicative of a “*retreat from society*” (60), and a “*refuge in day dreams*” (64). The psychological benefit she speaks of is undercut by an implicitly patronising appreciation of the literature’s appeal to those unable to deal with the realities of their own lacklustre existences. Its readers, Hume asserts, “would like to think of themselves as crippled heroes, forced to operate in a materialistic universe which has lost its myths and monsters” (66). Identifying with the heroes of the inner-circle, as opposed to the unexceptional everyman, readers can “glory vicariously in competence and the accompanying self-confidence” (67).

Although written as a defence of fantasy fiction, this seems a confrontingly pejorative and generalising statement, particularly given the extent of the genre’s readership. It sidesteps issues such as the polysemic nature of texts and the nuances of reader reception. In Hume’s schema a genre fantasy reader is commonly one who “otherwise feels alienated and disenfranchised and finds one’s daily actions meaningless” (67). In a noteworthy instance of ‘damning with faint praise’, Hume allows that this literature is at least meaningful for “people who cannot believe in themselves”, saying it is of psychological value in building the feelings of worth for those who might otherwise “have trouble engaging themselves with life in any fashion” (68). Consequently, although considering fantasy worthy of critical attention Hume still participates in a negative discourse regarding both the texts and readers of genre fantasy. Escape literature, Hume asserts, “rarely challenges us to think”, offering “blind, passive enjoyment” (81). Through my discussion of the works of Guy Gavriel Kay and Garth Nix, however, I will assert that the

genre is far from simply 'escapist' as it intersects with significant issues of contemporary cultural relevance.

Published in the same year as *Fantasy and Mimesis*, Ann Swinfen's *In Defence of Fantasy* asserts the cultural significance of genre fantasy, showing that scholarship on fantasy literature does not speak with a single voice. Taking Tolkien's *On Fairy Stories* as a starting point for her analysis, Swinfen examines English and American fantasy written after 1945. What most separates Swinfen's view of genre fantasy from Hume's is her insistence that it is very much a product of, and engaged with, the real world.

Swinfen approaches the breach between realist and fantastic representation by observing that "there is always some common ground between the primary world and a secondary world" (76). Similarities in physical nature – in matters such as heat, cold, dark and light, compass settings, the changing of seasons, and the celestial sky – work, she asserts, to make a secondary world comprehensible and logical to the reader (77). Such a correspondence to the primary world becomes even more important as, Swinfen argues, it reveals a contemporary social relevance and an "underlying seriousness of purpose" (95). Within secondary worlds she observes that many of the issues are "social ones, paralleling those of the primary world" (96). These include questions concerning social values, social structures, the balance between communal support and individual freedom and the moral values attached to the misuse of wealth, power and knowledge.

Swinfen's text demonstrates a shift from a focus on structure, literary influence and aesthetic form within fantasy criticism, to a consideration of how fantasy texts might participate in social, ideological and philosophical discourses. She discusses the multivalent nature of the form and its "considerable use of allegory and symbolism" (100). Swinfen argues that not only do fantasy texts construct a moral and intellectual framework for a novel's action (100), they demonstrate an attempt to "communicate to the reader a vision of some kind to transcendental reality" that extends over both the secondary and primary worlds (121). The layers of meaning and symbolism within fantasy allow novels that superficially appear unrelated to the real world to comment upon real world issues. Swinfen matches a concern for social and political issues with the authors' awareness of their and their readers' common knowledge and experiences of contemporary history. She further argues that, consciously or otherwise, "the facts of a shared contemporary social scene [will] colour the thinking of many writers of fantasy, and not just those with a clear social or political message" (191). This corresponds with my own approach to Garth Nix's *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and Guy Gavriel Kay's *The Fionavar Tapestry* as I argue they interact with issues in national debates in Australia and Canada at the time of their production, for example, refugee policy in Nix's writing and Native title in Kay's.

Although the miraculous in genre fantasy may obscure fantasy's participation in contemporary discussions, Swinfen's central thesis is that:

fantasy, just as much as the realist novel, is about reality – about the human condition. All serious fantasy is deeply rooted in the human experience and is relevant to human living. [...] fantasy provides the writer with greater scope to construct his own scheme of morality, his

own time structure, his own political and social order. But at no time does this apparent freedom permit the author to escape from contemporary reality. (Swinfen 231)

Swinfen's *In Defence of Fantasy*, therefore, recognises fantasy's engagement with issues of cultural, social and ideological significance. Rather than situating fantasy as 'escapist', or as only marginally and tangentially concerned with contemporary reality, Swinfen highlights the potential of fantasy as a tool for social criticism.

Brian Attebery's 1992 *Strategies of Fantasy* similarly defends fantasy literature in its generic form. Writing almost a decade after Swinfen and Hume, Attebery's work is illustrative of genre fantasy movement toward critical respectability. Attebery challenges the clear distinctions and hierarchies often attached to categories of the fantastic, asserting "an overriding kinship among fantastic texts" (ix).

Alongside Attebery's appropriation of the concept 'fuzzy sets', discussed earlier, one of Attebery's observations I wish to highlight is that contemporary critical theories lend themselves to a better appreciation of fantasy. According to Attebery, because of their metafictional and inventive emphases, postmodern approaches are more apt for readings of fantasy, being able to "illuminate both recent and older works" (37). Along with an awareness that fantasy stories exist only within the artifice of narrative, he points out that Tolkienian fantasies, like postmodern works, are often metafictional. They make reference not only "to the narrative past, especially to myths and its near relatives, legend and fairy tale" (41), but to other fantasy stories and also to tales within tales. Attebery notes such devices

can be playful as well as fantastic (40), observing that they “comment on the story telling process” (41).

Fiction, Attebery reminds us, is not a mirror of reality. Rather, it relies on agreement between the author and the reader and the acceptance of narrative conventions (51). A shared heightened awareness of the literary frames, however, does not equate to a sameness of emphasis or approach. Where postmodernism characteristically exposes literary frames, shattering the illusory reality, Tolkienesque fantasy utilises its awareness of narrative construction and convention to sustain plausibility within an imagined magical world. It is “interested in sustaining illusion, not violating it” (Attebery 42). Still, Attebery notes “the form of fantasy implies a degree of self-reflexiveness and authorial manipulation of reality” (46). This, perhaps paradoxically, works most effectively when it assumes an ingenuous sincerity in its “perfectly impossible narrative” (46). Although acknowledging differences in intent and approaches between postmodernist and fantasy literature, he draws attention to similarities such as a playfulness in construction. Both draw from popular forms, and on “the storytelling arts that make reading a pleasure” (49). Their utilisation of the familiar and simple can still take on deep significance. Attebery asserts that “Postmodernism justifies the practice of fantasists, who have been willing to play with the inconsequential until it explodes into myth” (50). Certain fantasists, he argues, “bear out the theories of Postmodernists in which we recognise the parts of ourselves that defy other means of analysis” (50). Attebery, like Swinfen, approaches genre fantasy as worthy of literary analysis, without the cringe against the generic, the popular or the ‘low’. His analysis opens

fantasy to broader approaches, legitimating the form and the study of it as both a cultural and literary subject.

Attebery, however, recognises that fantasy conventions can also involve complications. He argues that fantasy fiction's employment of traditional narrative structures, for example, those identified by Joseph Campbell and Vladimir Propp, can entail an uninterrogated sanction of accompanying traditional social structures (Attebery 87). This is particularly significant to an examination of representations of gender and class within genre fantasy. It invites consideration as to whether the conventions of fantasy literature – which in many ways combine to create a desired effect of enchantment and 'pastness' – intrinsically lead to an essential conservatism in both form *and* ideology.

This question significantly informs my discussion of both *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and *The Fionavar Tapestry*. I will argue that Nix's texts utilise traditional structures in a manner that challenges hierarchical order, but that this challenge is more successful in the area of gender dynamics than it is in the areas of class and ethnicity. I will further assert that Kay's more extensive use of mythic imagery, stories and paradigms ultimately reinforces traditional hierarchies where masculine and Western structures and thought are privileged.

The ubiquity, and concomitant power, of traditional motifs may owe much to the way in which, as Attebery notes, popular works such as fantasy fiction borrow freely from and follow up "implications from earlier texts" (89). An

intertextual relationship between texts such as medieval literatures, mythologies, fairy-tales and even contemporary fantasy novels, can lead to certain patterns in class, gender and ethnic archetypes taking on the appearance of being natural. Though genre fantasy is not intrinsically inflexible, Attebery's observations still give insight into how the influence of historical paradigms can continue to embed longstanding hegemonic power structures in new texts.

The line that genre fantasy navigates is between adherence to and challenges against convention. It is within this space between conformity and departure that new conventions can be negotiated. These, in turn, may 'alter the species' (Todorov 6) of genre fantasy, however slight this alteration may be. The possibility of movement, then, becomes significant to a consideration of ideology within fantasy fiction, and is central to the question of whether fantasy's attachment to the medieval period and to traditional forms of narrative lead to a fundamental conservatism within the genre.

Hume, Swinfen and Attebery's work participates in a shift from confining and predominantly structuralist approaches to the consideration of genre fantasy. In her 2008 *Rhetorics of Fantasy* Farah Mendlesohn pertinently notes that current theoretical work on fantasy is less constrained by definitional frameworks. She observes:

It is now rare to find scholars who choose among Katherine Hume, W.R. Erwin, Rosemary Jackson or Tzvetan Todorov: it is much more likely they will pick and choose among these and other 'definers' of the field according to the area of fantasy fiction, or the ideological filter, in which they are interested. (Mendlesohn xiii)

Moving past arguments about the definition and worth of fantasy, Mendlesohn's *Rhetorics of Fantasy* and Mendlesohn and James' *A Short History of Fantasy*, 2009, represent something of a shift away from either negatively characterising or defending the genre, toward simply considering the literature in its own right. *A Short History of Fantasy* provides a critical chronology of fantasy literature, discussing key texts and authors and placing them within the context of the genre's development. Less broad in scope, it follows John Clute and John Grant's 1996 comprehensive reference volume *The Encyclopedia of Fantasy*, which contains over 4000 entries on fantasy in theory, literature, film and art.

Mendlesohn's *Rhetorics of Fantasy* goes further than a critical survey, offering new frameworks through which fantasy literature might profitably be considered. She argues her taxonomy "should be understood as a tool, not as an end in itself", recognising in the "modern context that taxonomical practices are increasingly polysemic and multiplex" (xv). Her category of 'portal quest fantasy' is one in which the fantastic world is entered through a portal, where the magic is in the world that exists on the other side of the portal. This fantasy, Mendlesohn asserts, is "about entry, transition and negotiation" (xiv), as the protagonists move from a mundane life into direct contact with a magical, fantastic realm. It is within this category that both Garth Nix's *Old Kingdom Chronicles* and Guy Gavriel Kay's *Fionavar Tapestry* are best situated.

In her category of 'immersive fantasy', the fantasy is seen as normal for both protagonist and reader. This form of fantasy invites the reader "to share not merely a world, but a set of assumptions" (Mendlesohn xx). In 'intrusion

fantasy' the magical or fantastic intrudes upon reality (as it is generally accepted), and in her final category of 'liminal fantasy' the fantastic in the text creates an anxiety as it balances at "the edge of belief" (Mendlesohn xxiii). These sets are, in Attebery's terms, not fixed but 'fuzzy' and may overlap. Writing within a particular style, however, Mendlesohn asserts, surprisingly entails a set of ideological assumptions attached to the chosen form (273), as the conventions of certain categories exert political demands. Offering her approach as but one of many through which to consider fantasy fiction, Mendlesohn's analysis demonstrates how emerging approaches to the study of fantasy literature can respond to and discuss new questions. Swinfen, Attebery and Mendlesohn, however, are representative of an increasing number of scholars who view genre fantasy as a literature that is relevant and concerned with modern human experience.

This thesis generally aligns itself with the views of these more recent scholars in asserting that genre fantasy is deserving of serious critical attention. The works of earlier theorists, however, still offer valuable insights regarding the form, appeal and effect of the genre. In accordance with the critical trend noted by Mendlesohn, this thesis "will pick and choose among these and other 'definers' of the field" (Mendlesohn xiii). I will be informed, rather than being constrained, by theoretical perspectives. The pastiche nature of fantasy fiction means it is not comfortably confined or defined by any one particular perspective. It is a genre liberally drawing from, but not limited to, folklore, fairy-tale, history, myth, literary conventions and, significantly for this thesis, constructions of the Middle Ages.

Fantasy literature appropriates from many sources, often reconfiguring and transforming the old into something remarkably familiar, yet paradoxically different. In the same way, this thesis hopes to draw from, remix, and build upon the capital of past fantasy criticism throughout its consideration of the chosen fantasy texts. Like Swinfen, Attebery and Mendlesohn I do not claim my analysis to be definitive or the final word on these texts. What I do argue, however, is that this analysis will demonstrate that fantasy texts reflect and respond to contemporary issues of political, moral and social relevance.

A similar argument can be made for the contemporary relevance of medievalist representation. Various imaginings of the Middle Ages provide ironically indefinable, but somehow familiar foci for contemporary cultural identification and projection. Spanning approximately one thousand years, and a geographic area extending beyond Europe to the borders of Asia, what is understood as, or associated with, the medieval is remarkably malleable. Indeed, in “Yearning for the sweet beckoning sound” (2011), Helen Dell argues that:

The ‘middle’ of Middle Ages allows the medieval to act as a space between, a ‘dark age’ between the brilliance of the Classical Age and the Renaissance. This age in the middle is stripped of its historical content and reduced to a screen on which nostalgic fantasies of a timeless, Edenic presence and plenitude may be glimpsed, but only dimly. (Dell 175)

All imaginings, however, are not idyllic. Susan Aronstein, in *Hollywood Knights*, notes that differing constructions of the Middle Ages function as pasts against which modernity can identify itself by opposition or alignment. As a barbaric, violent and superstitious ‘other’ it can work as a contrast to a

perceived civilised ‘enlightenment’ – confirming society’s progress or, alternatively, in its romanticised construction, the past becomes “a site of a lost ideal and a past to which the modern must return in order to ensure its future” (Aronstein 11). This demonstrates but a small part of the malleability of imaginings of the Middle Ages that serve the purposes of contemporary identification.

In “Dreaming of the Middle Ages”, initially published in 1973, Umberto Eco argues that the “middle Ages have always been messed up in order to meet the vital requirements of different periods”. He famously lists “Ten Little Middle Ages” (68), each invented for purposes other than understanding the period as it actually existed. These include: the Middle Ages as a pretext for colourful storytelling; as a site of ironical revisitation; as a barbaric age; as the age of romanticism; as the age of national identities; the age of decadentism; and the age of tradition (68-71). In “What is happening to the Middle Ages?” (2007) Thomas Prendergast and Stephanie Trigg express the concern that, rather than opening a wider understanding and discussion on the cultural utility attached to medieval period, Eco’s list has had:

a stultifying effect on the study of the Middle Ages both because it has encouraged the fields of medievalism to engage in a kind of criticism that is largely taxonomic and because it has perpetuated the split between understandings of medieval and medievalism.
(Prendergast and Trigg 216)

Prendergast and Trigg draw attention to Eco’s favouring of the ‘Middle Ages of *philological reconstruction*’: “By separating and, frankly, privileging this Middle Ages”, Prendergast and Trigg argue that Eco undermined the legitimacy of other medievalisms (216). Eco’s hierarchy licensed academic critique of medievalisms not bound by the central aspiration of a fixed

historical accuracy— those drawing from “different variable and partial elements of medieval culture” (Prendergast and Trigg 216).

Although, in practice, the over-determining influence of Eco’s taxonomy has served to inhibit broader considerations of medievalism, his list at least hints at the cultural utility of varying constructions of the medieval period. Prendergast and Trigg comment on the versatility of the Middle Ages, arguing it:

can always return to us, whether in dreamy, embroidered and idealized form (the medieval as romance), or as the abjected dark other to modernity (the medieval as gothic) or indeed in other variations made increasingly possible through postmodernist combination and play. (Prendergast and Trigg 217)

They assert that the “practice of medievalism exists as a kind of reflex to the past, producing a dynamic and flexible relationship between the present and the past” (217). They thereby draw attention to the ineluctable complexity of contemporary connections with the Middle Ages. Prendergast and Trigg’s perspective is subtly but significantly different from conceptions of medievalism that focus purely upon oppositions between modernity and the medieval. It recognises popular identification, representation and pleasure in a contemporary interaction and investment in a revived Middle Ages, and even in a fantastic medievalism.

Michael Alexander, too, in *Medievalism: The Middle Ages in Modern England* (2007) recognises different impulses in medievalism, one being “the recovery by antiquarians and historians of materials for the study of the Middle Ages”, and another being “the imaginative adoption of medieval ideas and forms”

(xxii). He also pertinently observes that these are not mutually exclusive, arguing that “the curiosity of the antiquarian can itself be a romantic impulse” (xxii).

The flexibility of the Middle Ages is even present in considerations that focus on alterity, such as Catherine Brown’s discussion of the Otherness of the medieval period. In “In the Middle” (2000), Brown refers to the Middle Ages as a “definitional whipping boy for generations of citizens who have needed an ‘all-purpose alternative’ against which to define themselves” (547). The Middle Ages, she argues, function as a place holder between classicism and ‘enlightenment’ – marking a “parenthetical death of the interval between Classical life and its humanist ‘rebirth’” (547). It is a time steeped in Otherness, but Brown asserts that the central issue is less the alterity of the Middle Ages, than “what we as putative nonmedievals are going to do with the difference. What stories do we tell ourselves about it? What do they do to and for us?” (548). Drawing upon Edward Said’s seminal *Orientalism* Brown emphasises the way in which the Middle Ages can be seen as Other, as it is defined largely by modernity’s discourses concerning the period.

Concerns about how modernity might appropriately and ethically interact with the Middle Ages are not new. As mentioned in the introduction, a key debate within medieval studies played out around Jauss’ 1979 paper “The Alterity and Modernity of Medieval Literature”, published in *New Literary History*. Jauss sought to defend contemporary academic interest in medieval studies by focusing upon “the aesthetic pleasure, the surprising otherness, and the model character of medieval texts” (182). The first two of these emphases (pleasure and alterity) respond to the Other, as pleasure can be found in “the

astounding or surprising otherness of the world opened up by the text” (Jauss 182). Jauss argues the “enjoyment of medieval texts for a modern reader” can be found by one “who still senses the aesthetic charm of the past” (184). As enjoyment can be impeded by things the reader finds difficult or inaccessible such as conventions, impersonality of style, formalism, symbolism and didacticism, Jauss, observes that texts which possess more accessible ‘readability’ – adventures, romances and ballads – hold greater popularity (184).

Such a sense of pleasure and strangeness can even be found in pseudo-medieval texts. Although their Middle Ages are not truly historical, medievalist fantasies, unsurprisingly, appropriate from these more pleasing and accessible aspects of medieval texts, utilising characteristics such as romance, adventure and the marvellous. Indeed, when speaking of medieval literature, Jauss recognises the allure of fantasy, saying the “elementary need for a fantasy world of adventures and lovers’ rendezvous, of the mysterious and the wish-fulfilling, may explain the success of this ‘evergreen’ of the medieval imagination” (184).

Although it may seem almost too obvious to require comment, there is a significant distinction between the authentically medieval texts that Jauss refers to in his discussion, and genre fantasy. Medievalist fantasy imagines and inherits from the Middle Ages; it is not a product of it. Although often set in a medieval past, genre fantasy novels are clearly contemporary texts, revealing as much or more about the time of their production as they do about the times in which these stories are situated. Genre fantasy, though

evoking a medieval ambience, is necessarily written from a time outside the Middle Ages.

Still, alterity, or at least strangeness, can play a significant role in the appreciation of both medieval literature and genre fantasy. Jauss places difference at the forefront of his discussion as he argues that a more ethical and rigorous approach to understanding the Middle Ages can be negotiated by a recognition of the alterity of both medieval text and the medieval world model. He asserts that medieval texts should be considered through a lens that takes account of this literature's alterity and the different expectations of a medieval audience. An appreciation of genre fantasy, too, can be aided by the understanding that, more broadly, audience expectations of genre texts differ from the expectations readers have of realist literature. Furthermore, there is a certain resemblance between a contemporary genre reader's approach to stories, and that of a medieval audience.

Jauss contrasts the modernist, humanist view which represents written 'work' as individual and autonomous pieces of artistic creation (188) with the movement and intertextuality of medieval tales that, by nature, shifted due to their oral transmission and aural reception. A medieval listener, he argues, would "not presuppose a self-submersion in the unique world of a single work" but would rather hold "an expectation which can only be fulfilled by the step from text to text, for here the pleasure is provided by the perception of difference, of an ever-different variation on a basic pattern" (189). Jauss suggests that, for the medieval consumer of these tales, pleasure was gained from generic expectations being met by the storyteller, and this pleasure was then accentuated by deviations from the expected. He refers to

this as “the charm of an already ongoing game with known rules and still unknown surprises” (189).

A similar process can be observed in the consumption of fantasy fiction. Generic characteristics can act as points of identification and accessibility for authors and consumers of fantasy fiction alike, providing platforms for the surprise of deviation. Indeed, Jauss notes that the pleasure attached to expectation and deviation is “as natural to the modern reader of detective novels as it was to the medieval hearer of the *chansons de geste*” (189). This pattern of familiarity and difference in storytelling sits alongside many other features of medieval literature, such as adventure, romance, a pre-modern space and temporality, which genre fantasy has appropriated from medieval literature.

Consideration of the present’s relationship with the past, however, does raise questions about how one might ‘appropriately’ use and interact with a former time. Despite the points of kinship between fantasy and medieval literature, there remains a significant difference between the relationship with the past Jauss proposes, and that which is evoked by genre fantasy. Jauss argues that elements which are pleasurable and accessible within medieval literature might provide a “hermeneutic bridge” to further knowledge and appreciation of the “astounding or surprising otherness of the world opened up by the text” (182). While accessibility and aesthetic pleasure are used here in the quest of a progressive understanding of the Middle Ages as they existed, genre fantasy uses these things for an entirely different purpose.

For genre fantasy, identification and pleasure can become ends in themselves, with medieval alterity being subsumed by the familiarity of generic representation. Consequently, although fantasy strongly draws from the Middle Ages in its use of character and setting, literary motifs, and even from the intertextual and pastiche nature of medieval storytelling, the Middle Ages as an historical period, as an uncomfortably and confrontingly alien Other, is largely absent from the genre. Recognisable images and reader identification mean that the strange alterity of the Middle Ages can, paradoxically, be transmuted into a familiar motif in medievalist fantasy.

The ahistoricism of such an approach to the Middle Ages has provoked critical concern. Umberto Eco's speaks of the Middle Ages as, historically, being "ravaged by a persuasive medieval nostalgia" (66). Rather than seeing romance and fantasy as points of connection with the past, Eco is overtly censorious of the way these aspects of medieval literature are foregrounded in the popular imagination. A certain similarity of opinion can be discerned in Fredric Jameson's argument in *Postmodernism, or the Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism*, first published in 1991. He suggests that representations of the past in contemporary cultural products are largely antithetical to, or at least a grave distortion of, the ideal of historical reality. Censure is tacit as Jameson speaks of "dead styles", and "all the masks and voices stored up in the imaginary museum of a now global culture", ready for exploitation by contemporary producers of culture as they mine the past (18).

Jameson argues that current interest in things historical no longer represents an attempt to understand the past as it was. Historical representation, rather, has become "the random cannibalization of all the styles of the past" and "the play of random stylistic allusion" constructed to satisfy a consumer appetite

for “pseudo events and ‘spectacles’” (18). He argues that the past is “itself modified” and then, in “a faithful conformity to poststructuralist linguistic theory, the past as a ‘referent’ finds itself bracketed, and then effaced all together, leaving us with nothing but the texts” (18).

Jameson, therefore, draws attention to something of the dilemma associated with contemporary relations with the past. He asserts that “genuine historicity” is incompatible with “postmodernist nostalgia”, contending that many contemporary ‘historical’ texts, particularly film, do not attempt to represent history but instead attempt to convey “pastness” (19). This becomes a symptom of the “insensible colonization of the present by the nostalgia mode” (Jameson 20). Jameson expresses concern about contemporary society’s understanding of historical intertextual references within contemporary texts. The evocation of the past in contemporary film allows them to connote a ‘pastness’ while sidestepping actual historicity. This creates a “pseudohistorical depth in which the history of aesthetic styles displaces ‘real’ history” (Jameson 20). The construction of a sense of ‘pastness’ is clearly discernible in medievalist genre fantasy. Fantasy texts overtly rely on the impression of ‘pastness’ above conformity to pure historicism.

Eco and Jameson express a concern that ‘real’ history will be supplanted by nostalgic imaginings. This fear, however, entails certain presumptions. First is a tacit acknowledgement of the power of story-telling and representation. Second is the implication that varying understandings of or relationships with the past cannot easily co-exist. There is an implicit supposition that modern consumers are not equipped to differentiate between real history and

romantic imaginings; that one necessarily overwhelms the other. Further affixed to the evident disapproval of nostalgia is a moral hierarchy in which there are ethical and unethical ways of relating to the past. Honesty is aligned with historical rigour, and nostalgia with misrepresentation. However, unlike the nostalgia films Jameson discusses, genre fantasy does not claim to be an historically accurate representation of times past. Indeed, through its magical aspects, the genre openly flaunts that it is imaginary, not realist. This is even more pronounced in fantasy stories set in secondary worlds like those seen in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and *The Fionavar Tapestry*.

Concerns about ahistoricism are a staple within medieval and medievalism studies. In “Deconstruction and the Medieval Indefinite Article: The Undecidable Medievalism of Brian Helgeland’s *A Knight’s Tale*” (2008), Louise D’Arcens considers critical responses to the overt and unapologetic ahistorical representations of the medieval past in Helgeland’s film. D’Arcens observes that within the discipline of medievalism studies, despite an established “critique of the positivistic ideal of gaining access to an unmediated Middle Ages” (82), there remains an “anxiety about anachronism within medievalist texts” (80). Like a great deal of medievalist genre fantasy, *A Knight’s Tale* utilises the appeal of a popular medieval imagination while simultaneously advertising that it is not history but an impossible fiction (in the film’s case through blatantly anachronistic use of twentieth-century music and symbols). D’Arcens asserts that, on one hand medievalism studies “is too reflexive to reproduce medieval studies’ faith in presence and the ideal of unmediated access to the medieval past, yet on the other hand, this same reflexivity bars it from adopting an untroubled affirmation of historical anachronism” (82). This can be seen in scholarly criticism of *A Knight’s Tale*

which simultaneously demonstrates “a clear disavowal of ‘the real Middle Ages’” and “an implicit reliance upon the ‘real Middle Ages’ it disavows” (D’Arcens 86). Such tension, D’Arcens argues, “discloses a paradigmatic instability with which all medievalism scholars grapple. Whenever medievalism scholars attempt to discriminate as to when and on what terms anachronism is acceptable, this same instability arises” (88).

A similar tension can be perceived within genre fantasy. Critical judgement regularly entails a higher valuing of novels which have a greater fidelity to the historical Middle Ages. Texts that draw more directly or more accurately from medieval history or medieval texts are often perceived as possessing a greater literary and aesthetic value than novels which rely more strongly on medievalist imaginings. In his 2004 article “The Problem of Transformation: The Use of Medieval Sources in Fantasy Literature”, Michael Drout argues that distance from medieval materials accounts for the variance in the aesthetic and critical success of genre fantasy texts. Novels which lack direct engagement with medieval sources, Drout argues, do not have “the unity of onomastics, sociology, or metaphysics found in the work of the more successful authors” (16).

Drout notes that “the link between fantasy and medieval materials is a critical commonplace” (4), but rather than speak of fantasy’s ‘appropriations’ from literatures of the Middle Ages (a term which he argues has connotations of expropriation) he speaks of ‘transformation’. In ‘transformation’ there is a recognition of fantasy’s kinship with medieval influences and sources, but also a recognition of difference (Drout 4). While appreciating that fantasy fiction is not dependent upon exact recreations of the ‘real’ Middle Ages,

Drouot's argument reflects similar anxieties to those D'Arcens discerns in medievalism studies, as the Middle Ages still holds the place of a more appropriate or authentic referent. This can be seen in Drouot's assertion that medievalist fantasy which only indirectly engages with medieval sources does not have the cohesiveness, richness or aesthetic power of works that are more directly indebted to a familiarity with and appreciation of medieval sources (15-16). Drouot argues that novels that are more reliant on generic and medievalist-looking tropes, drawn from earlier fantasy literature, are less critically successful than those that have the scaffolding of medieval sources to make consistent and reinforce the conceits of fantasy's secondary worlds (16). The privileged place of the 'real' Middle Ages is evident in Drouot's contention that fantasy has the power to introduce and illuminate medieval materials to readers, bringing "new life to medieval texts that might otherwise be ignored" (17) .

Drouot's argument provides an example of the exchange between fantastic medievalism and medieval scholarship as it attempts to ward off anxieties over distortions of the Middle Ages through the "rhetorical manoeuvre of justifying medievalism via the medieval" (D'Arcens 84-85). Indeed, the scholarly philological and medieval credentials of seminal fantasy authors such as J.R.R. Tolkien and C.S. Lewis are regularly emphasised by proponents of fantasy literature.⁷ Additionally, commentary on the rigours of historical research is commonplace in reviews of contemporary genre fantasy. Even within a literature that, on one level, resides outside consensus reality, historical accuracy retains importance as a marker of value, ironically

⁷ See, for example Chance, Jane. *Tolkien the Medievalist*. Vol. 3. Routledge, 2003. Cantor, Norman F. and James B. McSwain. Norman F. Cantor's *Inventing the Middle Ages: Lives, Works and Ideas of the Great Medievalists of the 20th Century* 1992.

illustrating a need for fantasy itself to mediate fantastic pleasure with notions of duty and fidelity to an actual past.

Being located beyond the borders of consensus reality, however, genre fantasy texts are able to use and construct a powerful sense of 'pastness' while simultaneously signalling their fictional status through their reliance on the unreal. This serves to create a space outside a strict authentic/inauthentic historical binary, utilising the modality of the 'would' not the 'did'. It imagines alternative 'realities' in worlds that operate according to different rules. A bold ownership of unreality offers the reader the possibility of an altered relationship with the past, but one that is clearly not setting itself up in the place of historical reality. Fantasy's understanding of its own fictional status, when supported by an unabashed embracing of the unreal, can provide the genre with something of a release from the ethical dilemmas that accompany the imperative to honour the alterity of the past. It offers a certain licence under which the cultural power held by imaginings of the past can be drawn upon, whilst side-stepping an obligation to any aspiration for pure historicism.

The medievalism in genre fantasy need not be authentic or even stable to have power and resonance. As will be seen in the following chapters, medievalism's very instability can widen the range of its cultural utility, providing inspiration and support to varying constructions of value and identity. Despite a generic kinship and similarities in mood and motifs, different Middle Ages can be found in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and *The Fionavar Tapestry* and, along with these, varied implications and ideological nuances. Indeed, the inherent plasticity of both medievalism and fantasy

means the genre is remarkably multifaceted, offering diverse opportunities for thought-provoking and scholarly engagement.

Chapter 2

North and South

This chapter introduces Garth Nix's *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and considers the implications of Nix setting a medieval Anglo-Celtic past against a more modern English society. It will discuss cultural heritage and identification, with a focus on the significance of medieval motifs and the concept of 'Northernness' within genre fantasy. It will argue that there is an affective weight and value attached to imaginings of a northern, medieval past. Nix's texts utilise such affective power as they participate in discourses that challenge the hegemonic dominance of scientific rationalism and industrial progress, privileging instead the value of aesthetics, morality and nature.

Garth Nix's *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* comprises *Sabriel* (1995), *Lirael* (2001) and *Abhorsen* (2003). The trilogy is set in a secondary world in which the North and the South experience different material and immaterial existences. The Northern Old Kingdom is magical, medieval and mystical while Southern Ancelestierre operates according to a scientific reality and is progressive, industrialised, utilitarian and pragmatic. Ancelestierre resembles England at the beginning of the twentieth century. Whilst both of Nix's

historical worlds connote 'pastness', each is imbued with very different values. The Old Kingdom projects a positive affective appeal while newly industrial Ancelstierre is represented in a more ambivalent, often critical, fashion.

The Old Kingdom is ordered according to 'the Charter', a governing magical force. The Charter is imbued with notions of preordained place and destiny, and essential right and wrong. The Charter is at the heart of all that which is good, appropriate and powerful in the North. It is ordered, not chaotic, and it is intimately connected to eternity and creation. *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* position Charter magic against unfettered 'Free Magic', which is raw and extremely powerful, but can also be corrupt, unrestrained, dangerous and ultimately self-absorbed. The fundamental and profound nature of the Charter is also positioned against an image of soulless modernity, represented by Ancelstierre's industrialisation, rationalist ideologies and pragmatic practices.

Sabriel, the first book of the trilogy, is situated in a time when the Old Kingdom is falling into anarchy. The kingdom has suffered greatly since the assassination of the Queen two hundred years earlier, leaving the Old Kingdom far more vulnerable to threats from the (un)Dead. Sabriel's father is the 'Abhorsen', which is both a role and title. The Abhorsen are necromancers who work within the power of the Charter, not to raise or communicate with the dead, but to make sure the dead remain in Death. Sabriel's quest begins as her father is trapped in the Precincts of Death. She needs to return to the Old Kingdom from Ancelstierre where she was schooled and take up the mantle of Abhorsen in her father's place. With the

reluctant assistance of Mogget, an inexplicably powerful but morally ambivalent 'servant' of the Abhorsen who takes the incongruous form of a domestic cat, Sabriel must save not only the Old Kingdom but also Ancelstierre from what is, quite literally, a fate worse than death. She must find her father and defeat Kerrigor, an unequivocally evil member of the 'Greater Dead', and his legions of (un)Dead minions. To assure a return to order in the Old Kingdom, Sabriel must also rescue and restore the rightful heir to the throne. This is not an insubstantial task for a seventeen-year-old girl, particularly one raised away from her father in non-magical Ancelstierre.

The events within the remaining two books of the trilogy, *Lirael* and *Abhorsen*, take place after Sabriel's success and the restoration of the Old Kingdom's monarchy. The protagonists are Lirael, a daughter of the Clayr (the seers of the Old Kingdom) and Prince Sameth, known as Sam, who is the son of Sabriel and of Touchstone, the rescued heir to the throne. Both these young characters suffer under expectations which they feel inadequate to fulfil. Lirael, though one of the Clayr, appears not to have the gift of sight. This leads to feelings of inadequacy and to self-imposed withdrawal and isolation. Sam is seen as heir presumptive to the title and role of Abhorsen but he suffers from an overwhelming and debilitating fear of all things associated with such a calling. Ultimately, despite these obstacles, Lirael and Sam join forces to oppose an even greater threat to their world than that posed by Kerrigor in *Sabriel*. They have to face Orannis, "the Destroyer! The Unmaker! The Unraveller!" who desires the annihilation of all worlds (Nix *Abh* 128). This undertaking becomes a platform for their coming of age, and for a concomitant exploration of role, societal expectations, individuality and subjective identity.

These novels conform to the expectations of many young adult novels, fitting comfortably in the category of *Bildungsroman* tales. The young protagonists grow to maturity during the unfolding stories. They deal with ethical dilemmas, and have their moral, intellectual and physical characters both challenged and strengthened during the progress of the tales. As well as being tales of individual growth, as I will argue in later chapters, these novels intersect with wider contemporary concerns such as cultural identity, class, ethnicity and gender.

At first glance *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* seem detached from the geographical and social context in which the novels were produced. Garth Nix, an Australian author, situates his book in very non-Australian place. Clearly, not only the landscape but also the societies of both the northern Old Kingdom and southern Ancelstierre are significantly removed from that typically associated with Australia's physical and cultural environment. Ancelstierre recalls early twentieth-century England, while the Old Kingdom is firmly situated in an imagined medieval time. Physically, the Old Kingdom is even further removed from Australia, on the 'foreign' side of even Ancelstierre's border, metaphorically on a kind of Celtic fringe.

Nix's choice of 'Britishness' in setting is noteworthy, particularly when one considers the myriad of settings ostensibly open to a writer of fantasy fiction, a genre theoretically unconstrained by reality, place and time. Peter Hunt notes that:

the forms that fantasy takes – for all the endless ingenuity of the human imagination – are surprisingly limited. Fantasy seems to have, like the folk tales from which it sprang, a restrictive number of recurrent motifs and elements: there are young, questing heroes, wise controlling sages, irredeemably evil monsters, and (although mercifully fewer these days) damsels in distress. (Hunt 2)

To Hunt's list might be added a limited landscape. 'British' or northern landscapes remain central within the genre, although, utilising the crusader's image of the Saracen, eastern or 'oriental' settings are increasingly popular in medievalist fantasy fiction. In "Popular Genres and the Australian Literary Community: The Case of Fantasy Fiction" (PG), Kim Wilkins offers insight into this phenomenon. Noting the prevalence with which Australian fantasy authors use "European geography, history, and mythology", she argues that this is largely "because these tropes fall within the 'horizon of expectations' that the genre community brings to the texts" (272).

In many ways the plausibility of a story is aligned with expectation. A familiarity of temporal and geographical space creates a sense of credibility within the secondary world of a text. In an "Old Kingdom Podcast" (OKP) recorded for his official British website, Garthnix.co.uk, Nix touches on these expectations. He refers to the United Kingdom as "the home of fantasy" (OKP1 1:48), noting that *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* reside within this tradition. He reveals that in writing these novels he "was thinking of an alternative England in some degree" (OKP1 8:51). Indeed, the map at the beginning of each of the novels in the series is clearly reminiscent of a map of Britain.

Fig. 1.



Despite a wide readership in Australia and overseas, northern settings work to situate *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, and Australian fantasy fiction more generally, in a marginal place within 'Australian' fiction. Wilkins notes that within Australian literary discourse the "default setting for Australian literature is the Australian landscape" (PG 267). Furthermore, she argues, "Realism has always been seen as the mode that most defines, or *should* most define, Australian writing" (PG 273). Transgressing both these expectations, Australian fantasy fiction is tacitly excluded from the heart of what is considered 'Australian' literature.

This exclusion makes assumptions that align non-realist representation with cultural disengagement. It also demonstrates how Australia seeks to define itself through literary discourse. The official sanction of works portraying realist renditions of distinctively 'Australian' life, whether it be rural imagings or multicultural urbanism, exhibits, perhaps, a remnant of the Australian 'cultural cringe'. There is a manner in which this literary discourse seeks to disavow the continued influence of British history, both medieval and colonial, on Australian culture. An official disdain for expressions of medievalism within literature seeks to eliminate fantasy on the basis that it is incompatible or unrepresentative of a distinctive modern Australian character. In *Medievalism and the Gothic in Australian Culture*, however, Stephanie Trigg addresses the perception of such an incongruity, drawing attention to ways in which conceptions of the medieval continue to assert an influence in Australia:

'Medieval Australia' enjoys the status of a provocative oxymoron, since the 'Medieval' initially has a much more restricted and at first glance, historical sense. Here the 'common sense' reaction is to say that Australia has no medieval past, separated as it is, so decisively,

from the English or European Middle Ages. But as the emergent discipline of medievalism has taught us, the 'Medieval' is only partly an historical category. The afterlife of medieval culture runs long and deep [...] medieval culture is understood as a source of images, narratives, roles and ideals, available to be combined with images from other periods and contexts, detached from any attempt to represent the historical or the real, or from any anxiety about authenticity or continuity of place. (Trigg xvi)

It would, therefore, be naïve to conclude that medieval and British allusions within a novel mean it is detached from the Australian environment in which it is produced. Nix himself comments on the varied sources and influences for his novels, with inspiration coming not only from folklore, fable and the fantasy tradition, but also from "history [...] the natural world, current events – everything really [...] everything is a potential source of ideas" (Nix OKP2 4:21). Unsurprisingly then, one can discern aspects of Australian cultural influence within *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*. As will be discussed in Chapter 3, the manner by which Nix mediates aspects of class and privilege is aligned with Australian egalitarian discourses. The Southerling refugee problem, addressed in detail in Chapter 4, intersects with a key issue within the Australian political landscape at the time of Nix's writing. A broader reading of the novels, therefore, entails an acknowledgement that the contemporary ideological and cultural environments at the time and place of production exert pressure on a text.

More than this, I suggest that setting a story outside present-day reality, particularly in an imagined past, paradoxically has the capacity to render a text more significant to its readers. Like Northrop Frye, Nix recognises

something of the “heavier weight of conceptual meaning” that fantasy inherits from its structural affinities and associations with myth (Frye 188). Indeed, Nix draws on the mythic associations that underpin fantasy stories. In his podcast interview Nix comments that he hopes that, through familiarity, the tropes he uses resonate “with a whole bunch of myth and legend which is hard-wired into each of us – [which] we’ve experienced through legend and fairy-tales” (Nix OKP2 11:19). He asserts that literature that “harkens back” to old stories and beliefs can be “much more powerful” (Nix OKP2 11:35). This form of ‘power’ is rooted in a sense that the past possesses deep substance, and it is often entangled in an alignment of antiquity with authenticity. As ‘heritage’, stories about the past can contribute significantly to the construction of contemporary identity.

Indeed, literary lineage strongly informs cultural identity. This is noted by C.S. Lewis in *The Allegory of Love*, as he speaks of the influence that medieval stories continue to exert on modern society. He argues:

Humanity does not pass through phases as a train passes through stations: being alive, it has the privilege of always moving yet never leaving anything behind. Whatever we have been, in some sort we are still. (Lewis 1)

To continue Lewis’ analogy, heritage is not left behind by settlers emigrating from Britain to countries such as Australia and Canada. The influence of English literature and British ancestry still provides a cultural and affective link within former British settler cultures. Such attachments, however, are not simply abstract, nor are they necessarily passive or even innocuous. As Trigg notes, “one of the primary manifestations of medievalism in Australia is

its capacity to serve as a model for social organization and for idealised forms of community" (xxii).

Trigg's observation draws attention to the ideological force of British heritage in colonial and postcolonial Australia. In "Rebuilding the Middle Ages", Sarah Randles argues that the medievalism evident in Australian architecture allowed Australians to construct "a false past for themselves as they failed to acknowledge the real past of the continent they had colonised (69). Louise D'Arcens extends upon this in "Most Gentle Indeed, But Most Virile" (MG) (2009), commenting that "dehistoricized allusion to the medieval period has a specific valence in the context of White Colonial Australia" (104). She argues that it is "simultaneously a sign of desire for proximity and cultural ownership of the medieval past, and a sign of distance and cultural amnesia" (104). Looking back to a more distant past and evoking the Middle Ages enabled, and continues to enable, White Australian society to forget its "role in in the destruction of indigenous culture and their participation, whether direct or indirect, in a history of atrocity and dispossession" (103).

Although Nix's texts do allude to contemporary Australian concerns regarding place and ethnicity, the British setting and the expectations that accompany the 'sword and sorcery' genre simplify a silence in regard to indigenous cultures. This silence is, in many ways, a by-product of the fantasy genre. In "'Cutting off the Head of the King': Sovereignty, Feudalism and Fantasy" (CotH), Kim Wilkins observes that, despite the continued inclusion of Aboriginal Dreaming mythologies in the Australian educational system, Australian fantasy rarely uses Indigenous mythology (133). She

suggests this is, in a large part, due to the pressures of the genre, arguing that:

the medievalism in Australian fantasy fiction makes it almost impossible to represent indigenous stories comfortably because the genre's typical structures and conventions, especially those concerning politics and power, are not equipped to engage with indigeneity as it is conceptualised in contemporary culture. (Wilkins CoH 140)

The absence of any reference to the Australian Aboriginal culture in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, however, can be contrasted with *The Fionavar Tapestry* as Guy Gavriel Kay overtly inserts a North American Aboriginal culture into his series. While the medievalism used in a great deal of Australian fantasy fiction may work to elide the violence of colonialism and dispossession, the appropriation of Indigenous culture and mythologies brings with it its own set of difficult ethical considerations.

Many of these difficulties relate to ownership of stories and practices. In *Dhuuluu-Yala: To Talk Straight*, Anita Heiss talks of the complexities attached to non-indigenous appropriation of Australian Aboriginal culture. Through highlighting the oral nature of the intergenerational transmission of Aboriginal stories, knowledge and cultural practices, Heiss argues that “reducing them to material form is tantamount to the destruction of them” (83). Heiss also points to the work done by Terri Janke on intellectual property rights and the incompatibility between Western, legal notions of ownership and the cultural reality of Indigenous practice where there are communal interests in ‘ownership’ of stories. Under the Australian *Copyright Act 1968*, “once stories are published in books and other documents, the person responsible for translating the oral story into written form is

recognised as the owner of the copyright for the text" (Heiss 83). Moreover, the person who translates an oral story into a material form becomes the recognised author of the work (Janke & Quiggin 15). This sits starkly at odds with oral traditions wherein stories are seen to belong collectively to particular communities, kinship groups, or language groups. The appropriation of Aboriginal stories as a resource for the works of non-indigenous writers, therefore, can have the result in a legal transferal of ownership through the assigning of copyright to the non-indigenous recorder (Janke & Quiggin 15).

The ethics related to using general Indigenous motifs and reimagining the Native and native cultures in Western literature are similarly complex. Although this does not involve appropriations of specific stories, it risks the distortion and fetishisation of Indigenous peoples, products and culture. Such issues are discussed in detail in Chapter 7 in relation to *The Fionavar Tapestry's* representation of the North American Nature through his tribal Dalrei culture.

What is evident in the medievalism of both *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and *The Fionavar Tapestry*, however, is a "desire for proximity and cultural ownership of the medieval past" (D'Arcens MG 104). The attachment that former British settler cultures retain for the 'mother country' is not unique. Medieval scholar Paul Zumthor speaks of the significance that the Middle Ages hold in broader Western cultural identity.⁸ Dating the phenomenon from the nineteenth century, he argues that a substantial part of medievalism

⁸ Zumthor, Swiss-born, having studied in France, and taught in universities in both the Netherlands and in Montreal, was well situated to observe the breadth of the appeal of the medieval.

“reduced the historical character of the Middle Ages to the mythic category [...] of ‘our origins’” (369). Though Zumthor is clearly censorious of the ahistorical decentring of the medieval period, the cultural force of the mythic category of ‘our origins’ seems undeniable, providing a point of contemporary appropriation and identification.

Although much of fantasy strongly relies on aspects of recognition and identification, the genre also rests, paradoxically, on the affect created by strangeness and otherness. The medieval period may symbolise ‘our origins’, but it is also characterised by what Jauss identifies as a “surprising otherness” (182) and what J.R.R. Tolkien labels an “arresting strangeness” (50). This creates an unsettling but pleasurable tension, as fantasy is situated amid both the familiar and the strange. It resides on the borderlands between a form of historical ‘reality’ and medievalist idealism. As Northrop Frye notes, it also sits somewhere between realism and myth (139). *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* make such liminality a focal point within the text. The imagery of a line between reality and myth is exemplified within Nix’s texts by the potent image of the border, which is a magical Wall dividing the mysterious Old Kingdom from scientific Ancelstierre.

Nix’s idea of two separate realities has a pre-modern historical origin. It was suggested to him by a photograph of Hadrian’s Wall, showing a green lawn in front of the wall and snow on the northern hills behind it. Nix remarks that this led to the impression of “summer on one side and winter on the other” (OKP1 7:48). As a boundary between English and Celtic cultures, this image demonstrates something of the different historical constructions of Britain from which writers are able to draw. Moreover, it is also remarkably

illustrative of the conceptual border between reality and magic. It encapsulates something of the strangeness that genre fantasy relies upon. It demonstrates a blend of beauty, of comfort and familiarity, with the unknown, the forbidding and the alien. A mood of elusive Otherness remains vital to the appeal of fantasy literature, but for an 'Other' to exist there must be a central paradigm from which Otherness deviates. Indeed, as mentioned in Chapter 1, J.R.R. Tolkien perceptively notes that fantasy is not *primarily* concerned with the mysterious Other, but with a human interaction with strangeness. Fantasy, he argues, centres not upon 'elves', but upon the "adventures of men in the Perilous Realm or upon its shadowy marshes" (17).

The issue of Otherness has been well theorised in a range of critical fields, among them, Postcolonialism. A number of medievalist scholars have pointed to analogies between Orientalism and medievalism.⁹ In his seminal *Orientalism*, Edward Said stresses that Western representation of other cultures has "less to do with [other cultures] than it does with 'our' world" (12). In much the same way, depictions of alterity in fantasy literature have less to do with imagined worlds than with 'our' world. Said draws attention to how cultural power can be discursively exerted through things such as "orthodoxies, canons of taste, text, and values" (12). He also argues that moral authority is claimed through comparative discourses about "what 'we' do and what 'they' cannot do and understand as 'we' do" (12). Catherine Brown argues that "it doesn't take much editorial tweaking for *Orientalism* to speak of medieval studies. Just read 'Medievalist' for Said's 'Orientalist,'

⁹ See, for example. Pick, Lucy. 1999. "Edward Said, *Orientalism* and the Middle Ages." *Medieval Encounters* 5.3: 265–71. Ganim, John M. 2000. "Native Studies: Orientalism and Medievalism." *The Postcolonial Middle Ages*. Ed. Jeffrey Jerome Cohen. New York: St Martin's Press, 123–34. Brown, Catherine. "In the Middle" *Journal of Medieval and Early Modern Studies*, Duke University Press, 30:3 Fall 2000.

‘Middle Ages’ for his ‘Orient,’ and ‘the present’ for his ‘Europe’” (549). In the area of medievalism, however, this is not a straightforward dichotomy, as the Other also plays the dual role of being alien, as well as being ‘our’ cultural heritage.

Moreover, in contrast to Orientalism where advantage always resides with the West, in depictions of the Middle Ages superiority does not always rest with the modern. As Nix’s approval of the medieval North above the modern South demonstrates, there is significant plasticity in ideas of the medieval. Indeed, in medievalism, superiority more frequently resides in the medieval. Though Said’s treatise on Orientalism can provide a model that greatly contributes to an analysis of the Other in medievalism, and even in genre fantasy, there are significant points at which the general analogy between Orientalism and medievalism breaks down.

Nix sets up a division between two differing constructions of Western civilisation. In *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* the axis of division is not one that separates East from West but one that defines North in opposition to South. It does not privilege one ethnicity over another, but divides in terms of temporality, placing nostalgic, chivalric, agrarian and pre-industrial imaginings of Britain against industrial and scientific-rationalist ones. The North represents the old world and old ways; the South stands for a modern world and for ‘progress’. Nix’s binary divides a fantastic, romantic world from a pragmatic and utilitarian one.

The placement of the Old Kingdom in the North and Ancelstierre in the South is not without significance. As can be seen in the map in Fig.1, Nix's secondary world accords Kim Wilkins' observation that even fantasy novels "written in Australia by Australian writers, and [...] read by Australian readers", use a northern topography, setting stories "in medieval castles, on maps where north is marked by ice and snow" (PG 265). This is not a merely arbitrary choice; there are strong affirmative connotations attached to the North in genre fantasy. In this there is an implicit appeal to mythic and medieval Anglo-Saxon and Celtic associations.

Within genre fantasy the valuing of the North is particularly connected to the influence of The Inklings, the literary discussion group in Oxford with which prominent medieval fantasists including J.R.R. Tolkien and C.S. Lewis were associated. Positive connotations are clearly discernible in Lewis's idea of 'North'. Lewis uses the term 'Northernness' to describe an emotion that combines acute joy and loss. In *Surprised by Joy* (SBJ) he describes this elusive but inspired mood as he speaks of experiencing 'Northernness' upon first reading a translation of Tegnér's *Drapa*, a funeral song written by Swedish poet Esaias Tegnér (1782-1846):

instantly I was uplifted into huge regions of northern sky, I desired with almost sickening intensity something never to be described (except that it is cold, spacious, severe, pale, and remote) and then [...] found myself at the very same moment already falling out of that desire and wishing I were back in it. (Lewis SBJ 20)

Lewis suggests that words or music, particularly those evocative of Norse myth, have the power to stir intense emotions. He also reminisces about another instance when "Pure 'Northernness' engulfed me: a vision of huge clear spaces hanging above the Atlantic in the endless twilight of Northern

summer, remoteness, severity..." (SBJ 62). Something of the painfulness, loss and longing that is embedded in nostalgia is present in the feeling of Northernness, which Lewis goes on to represent as "almost like heartbreak, the memory of Joy itself" (SBJ 62). 'Home' is also present as he likens the experience to:

the knowledge that I had once had what I had now lacked for years, and that I was returning at last from exile and desert lands, to my own country; and the distance of the Twilight of the Gods and the distance of my own past joy, both unattainable, flowed together into a single, unendurable sense of desire and loss, which suddenly became one with the loss of the whole experience [...] (Lewis SBJ 62).

With the combination of exquisite grief, the desire for an *idea* of home and the impossibility of attaining or retaining a grasp on that which has passed, Northernness resides on the intense edge of nostalgia. This is not the comfortable 'rose-coloured' view of times past to which nostalgia is often simplistically reduced and then dismissed. This is a powerfully raw emotional reaction, unable to disentangle grief from ecstasy, or the feeling of being lost from that of belonging.

Tolkien too, attaches significant value to the idea of North. In "Gathered around the Northern Fires" in *Tolkien and the Invention of Myth*, 2004, Andrew Lazo argues there is widespread scholarly support for the claim that "a love of 'Northernness' played a vital role in Tolkien's creation of Middle-earth" (192). He points to Tolkien's devotion to Northern legends, Norse language and Norse Myth (194). It is widely acknowledged that Tolkien, feeling that the Norman Conquest overwhelmed the traditions and mythology of the Angles and Saxons, experienced a sense of lost heritage. Rhona

Beare observes Tolkien's affective attachment to England's Nordic past led him to seek a 'recovery' of sorts "by composing myths appropriate to England" (1). She discusses this devotion in her paper "A Mythology for England" (2007), asserting that a northern climate was integral to the construction of such a mythology. She argues that mythology originating from cold regions such as Scandinavia is far better suited to the cool, misty, chilliness of England than that which arose from the warmer climes of the Mediterranean (1 & 4). This shows how issues of national and cultural identity are entangled in mythological identification.

In *Perilous Realms* (2005), Tolkien scholar Marjorie Burns also recognises Northernness in the mix of Nordic¹⁰ and Celtic influences in Tolkien's mythology, and discerns a fusion of these "Two Norths" in his depiction of the Middle-earth (12). Burns acknowledges that such an emphasis on the North did not, of course, originate with Tolkien, pointing to eighteenth century collections and translations of Scandinavian, Anglo-Saxon and Celtic texts, and their growing popularity during the nineteenth century (15). Significantly, the change in valuing that accompanied eighteenth and nineteenth-century Romanticism impacted upon cultural identity. Burns observes that an idealisation of the North entailed a concomitant rejection of the South: "Warmer, more southerly countries (whose histories and literatures had previously done much to shape England's culture and thought) were now seen as un-English, decadent, feeble and lacking in vigour or will (15). The South then, is newly reconstructed as an 'Other' against which Northern 'British' identity can be defined.

¹⁰ Burns acknowledges Tolkien's dislike of the term 'Nordic' due to its French origins and its association with 'racialist theories', but notes its serviceability as a word for "the Scandinavians and Northern Europeans combined" (Burns 181).

Ideological implications are also discernible in Burn's observation that, in the cultural imagination of the nineteenth century, Northern Romanticism answered a "longing for racial purity". Despite England's mixed ancestry, it allowed the English to see themselves as "inherently Northerners" (Burns 16). Clare A. Simmons, in *Reversing the Conquest* (1990), speaks of the way in which nineteenth-century constructions of identity discursively asserted a continuous English tradition where, despite Norman control, the "strength of Anglo-Saxon character prevailed. Englishmen, history proclaimed, were not readily defeated in battle and stripped of their most sacred rights of citizenship" (Simmons 142). By the beginning of the twentieth century, Simmons argues, "the concept of Saxon superiority was an integral part of the British myth of origins (192). England had seen a cultural "bloodless reversal of the Conquest" (Simmons 191). This "demanded a wholehearted identification with the Saxon and acceptance of their superiority over the Normans" (Simmons 191). Ambiguities within, and contradictions between ethno/historical realities and Northern identification are clearly present, highlighting the disjunction between history as experienced and as idealised memory.

These very ambiguities, however, make room for diversity in modes of identification. Burns draws attention to different versions of Northernness that allow for differences in cultural and ideological emphases. Celtic Northernness is associated with the fairy world, "mysteries of the spirit" (Burns 14), with charm, sensitivity and imagination (174). Indeed, Burns argues that Tolkien's affective representation of the West in his writing on Middle Earth represents a form of Celtic Northernness, revealing a particular

attachment to pre-industrial Wales (20-21). She notes that Tolkien's representation of the West "borrowed heavily Celtic settings, figures, attitudes and motifs" (21). Contrastingly, Germanic/Scandinavian Northernness is more associated with heroism, courage, manhood, determination and stamina (173). Even amongst those whose identification lay more strongly with a Teutonic Northernness, Burns argues, choices were available in regard to the type of Nordicism to be preferred, between varying Anglo-Saxon and Danish versions (16).¹¹

It is worthwhile remembering, however, that Anglo-Saxon identity in Britain arises from a history of invasion following Roman withdrawal in the early fifth century. Furthermore, the Danish invasions, beginning in the late eighth century, create an association between the north and threat. This adds a complexity to the notion of Northernness, indulging in the romance of danger as well as that of joy, conjuring notions of strength, robustness and bravery. Again, Tolkien's depiction of Faërie as 'perilous realm' is evoked. In both *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and *The Fionavar Tapestry* the threat to the secondary worlds arises in the North; Orannis and Kerrigor are associated with the Old Kingdom, and Rakoth Maugrim dwells under the ominous and intimidating northern Mount Rangat. Both idealised and menacing images work together to construct the air of Northernness from which fantasy novels are able to draw.

Burns, Simmons and Beare's observations offer insight into both the power and adaptability of perceptions of cultural lineage, especially when they are

¹¹ Burns notes that, in the twentieth-century, war with Germany solidified a pre-existing nineteenth-century preference for Scandinavian over German Nordicism as more representative of England's 'northern ideal' (Burns 19).

imbued with idealisation and heightened by identification. They also shed light on how Northern identification might be appropriated and utilised in support of differing, and even conflicting, ideological positions. Although Norse mythology, most notoriously, was co-opted in the early twentieth-century by Nazism, Northernness could also be made to serve other ideologies.

William Morris, for example, appropriates Northern imagery and medievalism in support of socialism. In his travel writings on Iceland, travelling to the North becomes equated with travelling to the past. Morris represents the height of the Middle Ages as a time which was less limited by class, or even by gender, and a time that demonstrated a personal connection with the work of one's hands. In an 1887 lecture, *The Early Literature of the North – Iceland*, he uses the feudalistic society of Iceland as an exemplar of social equity. Morris asserts power relations were enacted according to an assumption of “the equal personal rights of all freedmen” (Morris online), and also argues that “the position of women was good in this society, the married couple being pretty much on an equality” (Morris online). His socialist perspective is evident as he asserts that during this period:

manual labour was far from being considered a disgrace: the mythical heroes have often nearly as much fame given them for their skill as weapon-smiths as for their fighting qualities; it was necessary of course for a northman to understand sailing a ship, and the sweeps on board their long-ships or fighting craft were not manned by slaves but by the fighting men themselves; all this is perhaps a matter of course, but in addition the greatest men lent a hand in ordinary field and house work, pretty much as they do in the Homeric poems: one chief is working in his hay-field at a crisis of his fortune; another is mending a gate, a third sowing his corn, his cloak and

sword laid by in a corner of the field: another is a great house builder,
another a ship builder. (Morris online)

Here Morris's medievalism utilises idealised notions of the past and unites them with his contemporary political perspective.

Tolkien's 'Nordic' medievalism and its concomitant disdain of industrialism is one that has much kinship with Morris', but it also diverges by being both more conservative and anti-secular. Tolkien's foundational theistic beliefs are highlighted as he represents a pre-modern past as closer to primary reality than modernity. Contrasting nature against technology, he asserts that fantasies "have many more permanent and fundamental things to talk about" than "insignificant and transient" things such as electric street lamps, motorcars and factories (62). Moreover, Tolkien links the quality of joy found in successful fantasy with the joy and fulfilment he finds in the Christian story (70-71). Again, medievalism is employed in support of a particular ideological perspective.

Another ideological association with medievalism is identified in Kim Liv Selling's doctoral thesis, *Nature, Reason and the Legacy of Romanticism: Constructing Genre Fantasy* (2005). She argues that the privileging of Nature within fantasy literature has an ecological resonance in the contemporary world, and offers an alternative to dominant Western utilitarian thought. Following its romantic forebears, fantasy's medievalism provides a foil to "the mechanistic, progressivist discourses of Enlightenment Reason" (Selling 28).

Far from being escapist and socially irrelevant, archetypal fantasy's medievalism challenges and critiques many of the hegemonic ideologies of modernity, particularly the dualism between Reason

and Nature which underpins the overvaluation of discourses of capitalism, science, rationality and materialism, and forms part of an ongoing Romantic worldview. (Selling 31)

Just as Morris imbues his medievalism with socialistic ideals, and Tolkien imbues his with his theistic beliefs, Selling asserts that many recent fantasies are ideologically influenced by environmentalism. The genre, she observes, has been “symbolically re-charged with an awareness of ecological issues” (46). Again, medievalism is taken up in the service of contemporary ethical perspectives.

The above-mentioned examples from Morris, Tolkien and Selling all demonstrate a kinship in their valuing of nature and a pre-modern past over an industrialised modernity, but they also exhibit varying ideological emphases, demonstrating the adaptability of medievalism. Medievalism and Northernness, in various shapes, can be called upon to support and provide authority for differing perspectives. This also demonstrates something of the strength medievalist constructions within the cultural imagination.

Although some forms of Nordicism may appear increasingly ideologically distant, the affective power of Northernness in fantasy fiction remains a legacy. Whether attached to notions of mysticism, or heroism or pastoral romanticism, the idea of North and the term ‘Northernness’ is constitutive of a certain literary atmosphere. It invites identification through association with Celtic and Anglo-Saxon cultural heritage. Moreover, fantasy’s debt to stories such as Nordic sagas and Celtic mythology means Northernness becomes attached to an aesthetic mood which makes an acceptance of witches,

ogres, dragons, elves, faëries and magic more credible. It is able to make plausible a mysterious, but at the same time uncannily familiar, perilous realm of eerie beauty and unrestrained possibility. And despite the strangeness of this realm it is strongly, but paradoxically, tied to ideas of heritage, identity and of home.

Consequently, when Nix sets up the geography of his secondary world, the placement of his characters is anything but arbitrary. He deliberately draws on a rich tradition of positive Northernness, meshing his sympathetic characters and values with this favourable context, and situating those characters and values he wishes to challenge in the contrastingly negatively-presented South. It is no coincidence that an author writing for a fantasy audience would draw on the connotations of the North presented by forebears of the genre, such as Morris, Lewis and Tolkien.

Moreover, the positive resonances of this Northernness are particularly strong in British or British-influenced cultures such as Australia. It is in this context that I consider Nix's creation of a world with a medieval, mystical, cold and dangerous North and a progressive, industrialised, warmer South. A military perimeter and a magical wall separate the southern nation of Ancelstierre from the northern regions of the Old Kingdom. The border itself provides a strong physical illustration of the divide between a progressive modernity and a medieval ideal, and these representations are by no means neutral. To approach the North is to approach the past. The imagery used for the perimeter on the southern, Ancelstierran side of the boundary shows the worst of industrialisation. It depicts a barren no-man's-land, a "wasteland of wire and trenches" (Nix *Sab* 27) instantly evocative of the Western front in

the First World War. It is an image that recalls the first-hand experiences of influential twentieth-century fantasists such as Tolkien and Lewis. In “Authoring the Century: J.R.R. Tolkien, The Great War and Modernism”, Aaron Isaac Jackson speaks of “the resonance of the historical moment of [a text’s] composition”, and argues that “the historical has an inveterate propensity to erupt into the fantastic” (58). It is not surprising then that there are layers within genre fantasy that intersect with the loss, futility and destruction of war. Such images have evocative links to both broader historical associations with war across the ages, and to specific associations with the Great War.

In contrast to the barren wasteland at the south, the Wall on the Old *Kingdom*’s side of the border exudes an archaic beauty, with its medieval architecture in an inexplicable state of preservation. Whereas the barbed wire and trenches of Ancelstierre connote ruin and death, the Wall is a structure that conveys a profound substance: “it was stone and old, and about forty foot high and crenellated” (Nix *Sab* 27). Still more noteworthy, the wall radiates magic and life: “for those with the Sight, the very stones crawled with magical Charter marks – marks in constant motion, twisting, turning, sliding, and rearranging themselves under a skin of stone” (*Sab* 27). Such imagery explicitly and implicitly adds to pre-existing notions of Northernness as it attaches different worth to the countries on each side of the border; the South is barren and soulless, and northern Old Kingdom is alive, substantial and beautiful. The description of the border is just one of many examples where a value-laden contrast between the northern and southern nations can be discerned. The imagery used by Nix brings to the foreground comparisons between the modern, metropolitan industrialism encapsulated

by Ancelstierre, and the North's promise of a 'green', pre-modern, heroic and expansive land.

Nix himself comments that Ancelstierre represents an alternative England of about 1918, but one in which England has not lived through the Great War (Nix OKP1 8:52). Moreover, Nix "envisioned that there'd been a much longer period of French occupation of this sort of England analogue" (OKP1 9:10). Ancelstierre's French flavour, particularly when coupled with the trilogy's censure of the South, clearly intersects with Tolkienesque ideas which depict Norman influence as corrupting of England's 'northern' Anglo-Saxon mythology. Tolkien's casting of the Norman Conquest as an "unmitigated catastrophe" (Flieger 282) for English language and culture clearly privileges an older Anglo-Celtic England above the newer Norman England. Nix's higher valuing of the Old Kingdom over a Gallicised Ancelstierre implicitly aligns *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* with this form of Northernness.

Certainly, Tolkien's negative perspective on French influence was neither new nor unique. Billie Melman observes its existence in both political and literary discourses of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries:

British patriotism, regardless of political affiliation, had been notoriously Francophobe. The French, the historic enemy, and well into the nineteenth century Britain's chief rival on the continent, had traditionally featured as that nation's 'other'. (Melman 583)

Imaging an alternative 'England' that is more substantially affected by a longer period of French domination is, therefore, not culturally neutral.

The name 'Ancelestierre' may also imply a subsidiary status for the southern nation, 'Ancelle' being an archaic French term for 'serving girl', originating in 'Ancilia', Latin for 'handmaiden'. Where "The Old Kingdom" has connotations of maturity and permanence, "Ancelestierre" is made infant, feminised, and placed in an ancillary position. Moreover, the name might also suggest that Ancelestierre is ancillary to France as occupier, giving an image of an England that did not fight against 'the Norman yoke' or achieve the perceived Anglo-Saxon cultural dominance that Clare Simmons identifies in *Reversing the Conquest*.

Comparisons which value an Anglo-Saxon/Anglo-Celtic North above a Anglo-Norman South are evident even from the first chapter of *Sabriel*. The text's depiction of Wyverley College, Sabriel's Ancelestierran school, immediately illustrates many of the binary oppositions between North and South which grant the North a higher value. "Established in 1652 for Young Ladies, of Quality" (Nix *Sab* 12), Wyverley boasts a long history but its roots are Early Modern, not medieval. Nix's opening description of the school evokes something of façade, as the gilt and "mock Gothic" lettering on the sign that sits above Wyverley's wrought-iron gates harks back to a time before the school's existence. The 'mock Gothic' suggests an affectation of greater age, while the gilt masquerades as something of greater substance than it is in actuality.

No matter how staid Wyverley's outward appearance, its close proximity to the Wall means it occupies a place of contradiction. The magical 'realities' of the North unavoidably permeate practices within the school, and sit uncomfortably beside Ancelestierran 'realities'. The courses offered at

Wyverley demonstrate something of the contradictions between an untamed North and a cultivated South, as subjects such as “fighting arts” and “etiquette” are amusingly juxtaposed with each other on the school’s curriculum (*Sab* 14). Ambiguities, however, become most apparent in Wyverley’s attitude to the practice and existence of magic. Magic violates the rationalist and scientific stance of the South, making it remarkable that Wyverley, a respectable School in Ancelstierre, goes so far as to offer magic within its subject choices.

The text states that it is only close to the Wall between the Old Kingdom and Ancelstierre that magic might be practised at all. In an image evocative of Irish-Celtic Otherness, the reader is told that further south magic is “considered to be quite beyond the pale” (*Sab* 14); it is somewhere beyond civilised control. Indeed, throughout most of Ancelstierre, magic’s very existence was doubted and “persons of repute did not mention it” (*Sab* 14). Wyverley College’s “good all round reputation”, however, is able to lend some sanction to the teaching of magic to those with special parental permission (*Sab* 14-15). Despite a residual distrust of magic, Ancelstierran pragmatism, in this case fostered by the promise of material gain, counter-balances ideological reservations. Wyverley’s Head Mistress, by her own wish, remains ignorant regarding the practise of magic, not wanting “to know more about it than the pleasant fact that some parents would pay considerable sums to have their daughters schooled in the basics of sorcery and enchantment” (*Sab* 15). This entails an implicit censuring of the materialism of modernity, where money is raised above principle, and reinforces the sense of shallowness attached to the South.

The Head Mistress' wilful ignorance can also be seen as a metonym for the South's deliberate denial of all that is mysterious in the northern kingdom. It reflects a determined shutting of the eyes regarding the extent of Otherness represented by the Old Kingdom. The Old Kingdom is an alterity in the conventional sense of being a foreign land, but it is also Other in affect and practice. The mysticism and magic associated with the Old Kingdom place it outside the frame within which Ancelstierre is willing to experience and understand the world.

Medievalism and magic also situate the Old Kingdom as Other within the frame of a contemporary reader's experience of reality. The fantasy genre, however, provides a forum in which alternative ideas and, perhaps more importantly, the values attached to them, cannot be summarily dismissed due to their lack of conformity to consensus reality. Fantasy neither claims nor aspires to be real in a conventional sense. Instead, the fantasy reader allows the internal consistency of a story to grant plausibility and rationality based upon the rules within the constructed world of the story. What is possible, what is right, and what is wrong, will differ according to the varying realities of the secondary worlds within fantasy novels.

Demonstrating the legacy of influential fantasists such as Morris and Tolkien, within the frame of Nix's secondary world the power of magic is depicted as vastly superior to that of technology. Moreover, there is no compromise or marriage between the differing 'truths' of the Old Kingdom and Ancelstierre. Like oil and water, the disparate realities cannot occupy the same space and time. This is evident when the Abhorsen mystically visits his daughter during her schooling in Ancelstierre. When he appears the electric light in her study

is immediately extinguished by the presence of Charter Magic (*Sab* 16). The supremacy of magic is more graphically symbolised in Nix's description of the marvellous arrival of the Dead servant to deliver Sabriel her father's Charter-spelled bells and his sword. As the Dead creature passes through the First Form Girls' dormitory in search of Sabriel, each electric light flares, in turn, and then goes out (*Sab* 19).

This pattern of Magic overwhelming technology is often repeated within the novels. Ancelstierran technology such as machine guns, telephonic systems and motor vehicles begin to fail as they near the northern border. Nix's *Old Kingdom Chronicles*, therefore, demonstrate an overt privileging of the past. Though, inversely, the magical possibilities of the Old Kingdom cannot be sustained far past its southern border, magic is not constrained by the might of technology, but by magic's own power in the form of the Wall. Whenever a residue of magic does break through or blow across the border with the wind, it dominates and exposes the conceits of the industrial advancement of the South.

The border is, by necessity, an odd mix of magic and technology, northern realities and southern ideas; a place of disjunctions and unreliabilities. It is not only a place which demonstrates a difference in power between science and magic, it becomes a place of contest between more 'spiritual' or aesthetic perspectives and industrialised pragmatism. Beauty and purpose is set alongside mere functionality. Southern machine-made paper, clothing and even armour quickly perish north of the Wall. For example, Sabriel's passport, in order to prevent its deterioration, is "a hand bound document printed by letterpress on handmade paper with an artist's sketch instead of a

photograph” (*Sab* 32). Within the Old Kingdom one must default to a reliance on items created through intricate, personal handiwork. Arcane magical rites also have aspects that align the performance of Charter Magic with craftsmanship and artistic practice. Charter Mages ‘draw’ or ‘sketch’ the Charter symbols with their fingers and minds, ‘weaving’ them together to create objects imbued with magic, purpose and beauty.

This distinction between modern mass production and traditional handiwork is on display at the border. Upon arrival at the crossing point on her return to the Old Kingdom, Sabriel notes that the “Perimeter was built for modern war, but manned by people expecting something rather more medieval” (*Sab* 30). Being confronted by previously unknown realities that challenge southern perspectives, the experienced Ancelstierran guards overlay their drab early twentieth-century “factory Khaki” uniforms with symbols of medievalism – chain mail and bucklers bearing bright medieval decoration. Alongside their conventional weapons, they sport “extremely old-fashioned sword-bayonets in well-worn scabbards” (*Sab* 27). This allows for a contrast of styles where traditional handiwork is granted greater value.

Such depictions are sympathetic with Tolkien’s romantic contention that some of fantasy’s attraction is a by-product of a time where humanity was more in tune with beauty and nature, when people “delighted with the work of their hands” (65). This time is set against a modernity where “many men feel disgust with man-made things” (Tolkien 65). A valuing of personal artisanship is also a descendant of nineteenth century Pre-Raphaelite medievalism associated with John Ruskin and particularly William Morris, who saw machine-made items as tawdry, cheap imitations. In *The Story of Art* (2007),

E. H. Gombrich argues these artists mourned an idealised pre-modernity where hand-made articles and ornaments had a “meaning and nobility of their own” (535). They disdained industrialisation, dreaming of a “thorough reform of the arts and crafts and the replacement of cheap mass-production by conscientious and meaningful handiwork” (535). In an 1888 review, *The Revival of Handicraft*, Morris did “not shrink from saying bluntly that production by machinery necessarily results in utilitarian ugliness in everything which the labour of man deals with, and that this is a serious evil and a degradation of human life” (Morris online). It is not difficult to see a legacy of Morris’ thought in Tolkien’s writing, and in the continued valuing of craftsmanship in contemporary genre fantasy.

Indeed, *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*’ negative critique of Ancelstierran industrial ‘progress’ extends beyond warning of the destructive potential of modern warfare, here evoked by images of “barbed wire, bullets, hand grenades and mortar bombs” (Nix Sab 26). As with Tolkien and Morris, suspicion extends to other less violent indications of modernity. Vehicles, factory clothing and technical communication systems are all depicted as dull, unreliable and as lacking in both elegance and craftsmanship.

Morris emphasises the connection between medieval artisans and their work, privileging the combination of artistic beauty and purpose in an object’s creation. In his lecture on “Art and Labour”, delivered by him on numerous occasions between 1884 and 1886, Morris claims that:

in the Middle Ages everything that man made was beautiful, just as everything that nature makes is always beautiful; and I must again impress upon you the fact that this was because they were made

mainly for use, instead of mainly to be bought and sold as is now the case. I have also said that the workman produced this beauty because he was in his work master of his material, tools, and time, in fact of his work. (Morris online)

A similar ideal is showcased in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* through the character of Prince Sameth, who ultimately realises his destiny in the role of 'Wall-maker'. The Old Kingdom's original Wall-makers built the Charter Stones (powerful, protective relics) and the magical Wall at the Kingdom's southern border, and forged magical weapons and armour.

Sam's joy in the work of his hands is clear as he finds substance and comfort in creative exertion, immersing himself in these tasks almost to the exclusion of all else. In his small attic workshop "there was Charter Magic everywhere. The faded afterimages of Charter marks shone in the air, crawled lazily across the walls and ceiling, and clustered by the chimney" (Nix *Lir* 316-317). His personal investment in the things he creates is evident in his dedication, and in the mental and physical effort he expends as he weaves magic into both small artefacts and creations of power and significance. This is graphically symbolised by the blending of his own blood into the making.

His creations, no matter how small, are imbued with beauty, a simple elegance and also with purpose. This is exemplified in the ingenious tiny jewelled and winged frog that Sam crafts to deal with mosquitoes: a "bright sparking object" that "moved effortlessly, bronze wings beating as fast as a hummingbird's, making a soft sound like tightly closed shutters moving slightly in the wind" (*Lir* 484-5). Beauty and purpose are evident in 'trivial toys' like the frog as much as they are in the golden, Charter-spelled hand,

“just as good as one of flesh and bone”, that Sam creates for Lirael after she loses her own (ATW 116), or in the Charter-spelled sword he magically forges to bind The Destroyer (*Abh* 409). While factory-made objects from the South merely deteriorate, crumble and fail in the northern kingdom, Charter-imbued artefacts from the Old Kingdom remain powerful and largely uncorrupted by time and elements. They become a link to the past and the divine, as the Charter marks, alive and endlessly flowing in these objects, have a pure and unadulterated connection with eternity, the universe and with creation, transcending space and time.

Again, such representation ascribes the medieval past a far greater worth and a significantly deeper substance than modernity. When Sam speaks of Ancelstierre he notes that it “always seems somehow less real” than the Old Kingdom, like a “really detailed dream, but sort of washed out, like a thin watercolour. Softer, somehow, even with their electric light and engines and everything” (*Lir* 480-1). A sense of loss and of longing for home is revealed in Sam’s comment that, when in Ancelstierre, he feels part of him is asleep because he is denied access to the Charter (*Lir* 481).

More than this, however, *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* represents progress not simply as faded or impermanent, but as essentially posturing, empty and wilfully blind. This is exemplified by the young, predominantly conscript, Ancelstierran soldiers, particularly when compared to the experienced Crossing Point Scouts who, although Ancelstierran, have learned to recognise and respect (or at least fear) the powers within the Old Kingdom. The young officious soldier who greets Sabriel is a personification of the posturing South. In him there is more a pretence of manhood than actuality.

He is a representative from the far south “where no magic crept over the wall and widened the cracks in what they thought of as reality” (*Sab* 27). He is described as “so cleaned, polished and full of himself [. . .] a natural bureaucrat currently disguised as a soldier” (*Sab* 31). In demanding Sabriel’s papers he shows himself as ignorant, but he is unaware of this state, either missing or refusing to acknowledge the magic Sabriel performs to make the papers appear in her hand (*Sab* 31). By contrast, the experienced Scouts, somewhat versed in the ways of the Charter, immediately sense Sabriel’s magic and quickly respond to its potential danger. Their awareness and immediate reaction differentiates them from the pretentious corporal who is “deaf to the hum of Charter Magic” (*Sab* 33). Ignorance such as that displayed by the corporal might even be seen as something officially endorsed. It is necessary to practise such blindness in order to sustain the ideological credibility of the ‘truth’ as constructed by the Ancelstierran government.

The South’s realist discourse is maintained through a carefully controlled narrative regarding its northern neighbour. The South constructs itself as scientific, progressive and rational while it labels the North as backward and superstitious. The South’s meticulously preserved ‘reality’ does not include any recognition of magical possibility, even within the Old Kingdom itself. Those within the bureaucracy, primarily situated in Ancelstierre’s capital, Corvere, “far away in the south [. . .] refused to admit that this perimeter was different from any other contested border” (*Sab* 30). This belief is actively protected. On top of the practical difficulties attendant on the technological disruption that occurs whenever the wind blows from the North, tourism to the Wall is vigorously discouraged. There are very few people authorised to

travel to the Old Kingdom, implying a fear of difference, or even a form of xenophobia. While the Northern characters such as Sabriel, Sam and Ellimere widen their experience and knowledge by travelling and studying in the South, Nicholas Sayre reveals that for Ancelstierre, “officially, there is no Old Kingdom” (*Abh* 171). Trespassing within the perimeter zone is strictly forbidden, and uncompromisingly policed. As the sign near the border proclaims:

PERIMETER COMMAND
NORTHERN ARMY GROUP
Unauthorised egress from the
Perimeter Zone is strictly forbidden.
Anyone attempting to cross
The Perimeter Zone will be shot
without warning.
Authorised travellers must report
to Perimeter Command HQ.
REMEMBER—NO WARNING
WILL BE MADE
(*Nix Sab* 29)

This regulation recognises something of the power attached to the control of discourse. The South’s policing of information from the North works to maintain the authority and influence of Ancelstierre’s political elite. The desire to repress the spread of any but their own narrative, one which portrays the South as progressive and the North as backward and superstitious, speaks to the power that resides in stories and in the beliefs which they foster. In *Mere Nostalgia* (2000), Kimberly K. Smith suggests that the application of negative labels (such as ‘nostalgic’, ‘retrograde’ and ‘sentimental’) to values and desires attached to the past can exert powerful discursive force. This renders nostalgic emotional responses suspect, even

to those who experience them (Smith 522). She argues that such labelling undermines the views of those who grant high value to the past and of those who express reservations regarding the consequences of unfettered industrial progress (506). The unreal frameworks within genre fantasy, however, operate according to alternative webs of internal consistency and rationality. They are not constrained by the rationale of the primary world and this provides a discursive space where the hegemony of scientific and industrial process can be questioned.

Fantasy constructs a logic and plausibility of its own within the texts' secondary world contexts. The value attached to the Old Kingdom, therefore, can offer a counter-discourse to the scientific and industrial stance represented by the South. In the tradition of medievalist fantasy writers like Tolkien, aspects such as heritage, the natural world, beauty, and something akin to the spiritual, are highly valued. The lexis and imagery used for the Old Kingdom demonstrate an expressive energy where physical description is tied to an affective response. This can be seen in Sabriel's response on arriving at the Wall. Elegantly utilising the affective appeal of medievalism, Nix employs words with a strong and positive emotional charge, such as 'excitement', 'wonder', 'mystery', 'freedom' and 'alive' (Nix *Sab* 29). The emphatic repetition of the word 'felt', 'felt', 'felt' (*Sab* 29) highlights the importance of emotional engagement with the material reality of the Old Kingdom. His word choice overtly privileges things such as intuition, aesthetics and the archaic above things new, practical and pragmatic.

Although the Old Kingdom is represented as possessing greater beauty, substance and worth, the nostalgic longing in this representation is not for a

rural idyll. The Old Kingdom is dangerous, not a utopia offering a life of calm, rustic perfection. Significantly, a damaged Old Kingdom remains preferable to a soulless South. It is privileged above Ancelstierre, despite the circumstance of Sabriel's father being trapped in Death, despite the current lawlessness and disorder caused by the murder of the Old Kingdom's royal family and despite the refusal of the Old Kingdom's Dead to stay dead. Sabriel's awe and anticipation on returning home are not without a contaminating apprehension, but this is grounded in her fear *for* her father and in a burden of responsibility, not in a dread of the Old Kingdom itself (*Sab* 29-30).

Moreover, the danger attached to the Old Kingdom overlays the image of the North with a robustness and sense of adventure. Once more this ties in with a particular medievalist sense of British/Northern identity. A clear example of this can be seen in John Ruskin's *On the Nature of Gothic Architecture* (1854), in which he argues that a Northern "Gothic Mind" has a "[s]trength of will, independence of character, resoluteness of purpose, impatience of undue control, and that general tendency to set the individual reason against authority, and the individual deed against destiny". He contrasts this robustness with "the languid submission, in the Southern, of thought to tradition, and purpose to fatality" (33). The nostalgic appeal of these novels, then, is not rooted in a desire for escape to an idealised world. It is entailed, rather, in the weight and substance that heroic and romantic representations of a medievalised past can evoke.

Even things both terrible and dreadful can have an attraction of their own. Nix's texts seem to confirm Tolkien's assertion that even the "maddest castle

that ever came out of a giant's bag in a wild Gaelic story is not only much less ugly than a robot-factory, it is also (to use a very modern phrase) 'in a very real sense' a great deal more real" (64). It is within this tradition of fantasy that Nix's texts continue to unsettle straightforward notions of the real and unreal in literary representation, and of the value attached to them. Worth is measured not by any economic standard or gauge of progress, but by a yardstick that esteems history and beauty. *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, consequently, also contains a challenge to discourses which align modernity and industrial progress with understanding, and the pre-modern past with ignorance. There is an implicit critique contained within Nix's inverted representation of the rational/romantic dichotomy, with the romantic and not the rational placed in the position of advantage.

The character of Nicholas Sayre in *Lirael* and *Abhorsen* serves as a case study for such a discursive challenge. Nicholas embodies the progressive discourses of Enlightenment Reason and personifies the South's unwillingness or inability to step outside this scientific ideological perspective. His failure, therefore, works as a critique of pure rationalism. A nephew of the Chief Minister of Ancelstierre and close friend of Prince Sameth of the Old Kingdom, Nick has the advantage of being exposed to both Ancelstierran and Old Kingdom realities. He, however, refuses to recognise magic even when he experiences it first-hand. Following a personal encounter with the Dead and with a powerful Free Magic necromancer at the border of the Old Kingdom, he writes to Sam:

I admit that my scientific interest has been piqued by those apparently animated corpses and your own exhibition of whatever it was. I'm sure you think of it as magic, but I expect it can be explained by the proper application of scientific method. (Nix *Lir* 120-11)

This highlights the hegemonic power of Ancelstierre's scientific and rationalist discourses.

Indeed, Nicholas attempts to give 'rational' explanations to the inexplicable. For example, he attributes the northerners' ability to see maps on what he perceives as blank paper to tricks like "quasi-mystical memorisation" (*Lir* 314). He complains that scholarly texts on the Old Kingdom are "old and highly superstitious", and believes that as a scientist he will be able to reveal things about the Old Kingdom that have until now been screened by a "conspiracy of silence" (*Lir* 314). He also summarily dismisses Sam and Lirael's perspectives as "superstition" (*Abh* 167) and "mumbo jumbo" (*Abh* 170) and answers Lirael's 'incomprehension' and recourse to magical explanations, not with evidence to the contrary, but "with a superior smile" and an eloquent rolling of the eyes (*Abh* 167-8). Within the secondary world of *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, however, Nicholas' unstinting reliance on rationality alone is revealed, ironically, as irrational. Not only does his scientific arrogance cause him to be derisive of those with greater insight, his blindness to other perspectives allows him to serve as an unwitting tool for the forces of destruction. Within the web of reality constructed by Nix, Nicholas's rejection of magic is clearly illogical. As Sam tells Nick after he expresses disbelief when they are under attack from the Dead, "they'll kill you whether you believe in them or not" (*Lir* 180).

Fantasy's critique of pure scientific pragmatism, along with fantasy's emphasis on nature and aesthetics, connects with real world ideological concerns. In the *Abolition of Man*, first published in 1943, C.S. Lewis asserts that meaningful education and understanding require exposure to the value

of artistic beauty and “real sensibility”. A student taught only from scientific or pragmatic perspectives, he argues, becomes limited by a scepticism about emotional responses to place and to nature, thinking them “contrary to reason and contemptible” (11). Such a student, he argues, is at risk of becoming a “mere trousered ape”, never able to “conceive the Atlantic as anything more than so many million tons of cold salt water” (11). For all his scientific learning, Nick evokes something of Lewis’ ‘trousered ape’.

Through depicting the South’s beliefs and approaches, Nix’s texts show that there is ideological power attached to progressive, scientific discursive frames, but the texts also expose their limitations. Fantasy frameworks can offer a discursive space for alternative perspectives to scientific rationalism. The privileging of a medievalised, magical North over an industrialised South in Nix’s *Old Kingdom Chronicles* has discursive power. The high valuing of nature, of artisanship and of a marriage between beauty and purpose promotes an alternative perspective to the hegemony of scientific pragmatism and pure materialism, one which argues against progress that is at the cost of the natural world, relics of the past or cultural continuity.

Chapter 3 will discuss how *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* can further draw on the authority attached to heritage, Northernness and medievalism to discursively engage in contemporary debates regarding national identity and class. Chapter 4 looks more closely at Australian inflections through a case study on the novel’s representation of a refugee crisis. Chapter 5 then moves on to examine how notions of destiny and tradition in Nix’s trilogy are utilised to challenge conservative and hierarchical assumptions in regard to gender and role.

Chapter 3

Blood, Identity and Class

Where the previous chapter situates *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* within the Northern, medievalist tradition of fantasy writing, this chapter returns more specifically to the novels' Australian intersections. As argued above, medievalist genre fantasy is able to discursively combine affective representations of the past with issues of contemporary significance. This chapter pays particular regard to issues of national identity and class. It considers the ways in which these texts mediate between imaginings of the medieval and the feudal hierarchical assumptions which these entail, and contemporary egalitarian ideals. It will look at the tensions created by the uniting of medieval motifs, imagery and expectations with modern sensibilities. Although this chapter has a primary focus on the Australian context of the texts' production, it also touches upon the wider context of Western ideologies and cultural identity.

As addressed briefly in the Chapter 2, Australia appears far removed from medieval Britain. Australia is the antipodes, separated from Europe by the distance of both time and space. Virtually untouched by European civilisation

until the late eighteenth century, Australia never had that which is commonly understood as a medieval past. As Louise D'Arcens observes in "The Past is a Foreign Country" (PFC), for "any historically minded reader the phrase the 'Australian Middle Ages' [...] is patently oxymoronic" (319). Australia has no ancient ruins of castles or gothic abbeys, no Celtic barrows where swords and jewels are entombed with long dead warriors, no history of chivalric knights or royal houses. Temperate to hot, flat, in a large part desert, it appears climatically and geographically the antitheses of the cold, mountainous Northernness that fed the imaginations of the progenitors of popular fantasy. Still, as Stephanie Trigg asserts in her introduction to *Medievalism and the Gothic in Australian Culture*:

The medieval can be detached from its historical and geographical points of interest: its stories can be retold; its images relived in different contexts; and it can come to stand for a particular literary sensibility. The Gothic, too, can evoke its own historical past in eighteenth- and nineteenth-century romanticism, as well as harking back to its origins as a version of critical or sympathetic medievalism. (Trigg xix)

Generic fantasy motifs used by Australian authors often participate in a sympathetic medievalism. They reach back through cultural lineage; through the Anglo-Celtic heritage of the settlers who emigrated as representatives of the expanding British Empire and of the convicts who were forcibly removed from their homeland. D'Arcens comments that:

Australian medievalism emerged as a legacy of British colonialism, and as such also reflects the extent to which this nation has, its physical remoteness and avowed modernity notwithstanding, maintained a sense of proximity to, and continuity with, the medieval European heritage of its settler culture. Its literature, architecture, parliamentary rituals, and performance culture all attest to colonial

Australia's desire to situate itself within deep European and English tradition. (D'Arcens PFC 320)

Australia's desire to situate itself thus, however, does not necessarily indicate a purely reactionary impulse, or even mean that the 'mother country' is privileged above the new. Neither does it discount a blending of visions of the past with visions of the present.

In *Inventing Australia* (1984) Richard White speaks of how settlement within Australia answered certain British longings for a pre-industrialised past. He observes that for nineteenth-century pioneers:

romantic visions were an imaginative response to the industrialisation of Britain. Behind all the admiration for Australia's fresh air, its greenness, its sense of space, its Arcadian innocence and its imagined social harmony, there lurked an unstated comparison with a cold, crowded, polluted, industrialised and socially divided England. The industrial revolution was still, for many, a traumatic shock. The visions of rural innocence in Australia appealed to a deep-seated emotional resentment against industrialisation. (White 34)

This provides a pertinent illustration of how a privileged construction of the past can be appropriated for contemporary purposes in the formation of modern identity. These constructions looked back to an historical England, but in doing so they attached a greater value to the new Australia. Such a nostalgia for pre-industrial Britain can, paradoxically, be seen to stir a desire for a future in a 'new world'. White points to the significance of romantic constructions within the cultural perspectives of those promoting Australia and emigration:

supporters of immigration saw Australia becoming the sort of society they imagined England to have been in the past, before it disappeared under the grime of the industrial revolution. The *Edinburgh Review* made it quite clear: “by colonization nations are able to retrieve the past”. (White 34)

Although the landscape, geography and climate might be vastly different to that of the North, several of the impulses of migration and settlement within Australia mimicked those aligned with a more overt and Northern nineteenth-century medievalism.

In many ways these impulses resembled William Morris’ infatuation with Iceland and Nordicism, as the desire they reflected was not simply a longing for a pre-industrialised Britain. Certain socialistic, utopian ideals were implied by the pre-industrial fantasy. White argues that this idealisation of Australia imagined a culture that “would allow the labouring classes to reclaim their patrimony recreating a more equal society, for men at least” (34). Whether reflective of reality or not, through such constructions Australians indulged in a form of medievalism, even from the early stages of Australia’s modern, Western formation. Many aspects of its medievalism, however, looked back in order to move forward, creating a paradoxical ambivalence. Indeed, D’Arcens comments upon Australians’ “sense of themselves as both deeply connected to, yet also set adrift from, a pre-modern past that they revere yet also seek to supersede” (PFC 327).

Counter-intuitively, the absence of an actual medieval past produces a greater flexibility regarding the place the Middle Ages can occupy in the Australian cultural imagination. D’Arcens notes that, for Australia, there is a

literality in the phrase 'the past is a foreign country'. The "conditions of absence and distance", D'Arcens argues:

whether wistfully acknowledged or wilfully embraced, have even from the earliest days of Australian settlement granted Australian medievalism a significant interpretive freedom, paving the way for a wide-ranging and fertile engagement with a world that can, in the most concrete sense, only ever be imaginary for Australians.
(D'Arcens PFC 319-20)

This cultural contextualisation makes the popularity of medievalist fantasy with Australian authors and readers less remarkable. Although ostensibly lacking the central distinguishing marks of 'Australian' literature, that is, the Australian landscape and realism (Wilkins PG 267 & 273), these texts remain artefacts of the culture, place and time of their production.

Indeed, the 'significant interpretative freedom' that D'Arcens recognises in Australia's imaginative engagement with the Middle Ages leads to many identifiable contradictions in representation. Australia can be seen, like the ice wastes of the North, as open, mysterious and impenetrable – a remarkably 'perilous realm'. Contrastingly, it can be formulated as a land of green and pleasant pastures in the idealised shape of 'Merry England'. The Middle Ages, too, can be simultaneously the origin and the Other of the modern; they can be represented as inflexibly hierarchical, or as a time of greater opportunities. Although such differing constructions may be irreconcilable, they continue to co-exist within the spectrum of the broader popular imagination.

Although clearly medievalist in setting, and though heavily informed by Anglo-Celtic fantasy traditions and imagery, certain aspects of *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* intersect strongly with cultural tensions, with national ideological aspirations, and with central imaginings of Australian cultural identity. Rather than being removed from contemporary reality, such fiction reflects something of Australia's continued engagement with medievalism, and demonstrates the influence that British heritage continues to exert upon the Australian psyche. Indeed, tensions found in Nix's novels, as they seek to negotiate the contradictions between medievalism's fixed structures and contemporary democratic ideals, reproduce social and political tensions evident in modern Australia. An example of this can be found in the simmering debate on Australian republicanism that was a key cultural question during the period of Nix's texts' production. Driven by the approach of the Centenary of Australian Federation, this debate culminated in the 1999 Australian Republican Referendum in which Australians rejected the proposed severing of its political ties to the British monarchy.

In a 2000 post-referendum analysis by the Hon Justice Michael Kirby, Justice of the High Court of Australia, Kirby argues that, although most Australians "feel republican in their hearts", there is also a "vague lingering affection for the monarch" and a continued "measure of respect for the idea of the Crown" (online). Ironically, within the republican debate monarchism became associated with the common 'everyman' while arguments for republicanism were popularly construed as an indulgence in intellectual elitism (Kirby online). As will be seen later in this chapter, Nix employs a similar strategy to negotiate the tensions created by the hierarchical castes in the Old Kingdom, aligning his privileged protagonists with the underdog.

Pertinently, Kirby argues that the wider Australian public, if confronted with the contradictions entailed in Australia's vote to retain ties with the British monarchy, would react with indifference or contempt and, perhaps, just a fleeting acknowledgement of "the paradoxes of their constitutional situation" (online). Acknowledging that such cultural and constitutional contradictions exist within Australia, it is perhaps even more paradoxical that fantasy novels which reflect these tensions are largely deemed to sit outside the parameters of 'Australian fiction'.

It would be simplistic, therefore, to see Nix's use of royalty and medievalist hierarchies as disengaged from Australia's political and cultural context, even though social elites are specifically situated outside expressed Australian egalitarian aspirations. Indeed, egalitarianism is not just seen as desirable, it is officially espoused as a particularly Australian trait. The Australian Government's Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade (DFAT) proclaims in its factsheet *About Australia: people culture and lifestyle* that Australia is a "tolerant, informal and broadly egalitarian society" (1/7). Furthermore, it goes on to boast of legal and gender equality, equality of opportunity, and also claims that "there are no formal or entrenched class distinctions in Australian society, as there are in some other countries" (2/7).

Nix, however, obfuscates the class hierarchies in his series by foregrounding other qualities approved within Australian society. Characteristics such as the overt humility of the protagonists, a lack of entitlement in manner, an informality in practice and in dress, and a certain disrespect for protocol and

for authority, all fit within imaginings of Australian character. These mediate the tensions between the elitism of royalty and an egalitarian imperative. The lack of formality in dress and behaviour, for example, is reflective of that which Donald Horne, in *The Lucky Country Revisited*, labels a “cult of informality” (16). In a 2009 paper on Australian fashion and cultural identity, Jennifer Craik asserts that archetypal “Australian dress is regarded as anything that is practical, informal, and casual” (410). She argues that this reflects “the widespread mythology of the outback, the bush, and egalitarianism that came to characterize ideas about Australia in the mid to late nineteenth century” (420).

This Australian cultural affinity with casual, practical clothing aligns with the Abhorsen and Royalty’s attitude to dress in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*. Differences between privileged and common people are elided somewhat by informality in dress and manners. Unlike a generic fairy-tale princess or queen, Sabriel is not a paragon of sartorial elegance. Rather than appear in finery she is seen initially in a school uniform; thereafter she is predominantly dressed in a martial style – a doeskin tunic, leather breeches reinforced with segmented plates, an armoured coat and hobnail boots finished by her sword belt and bell bandolier (Nix *Sab* 129-130). Circumstances leave no time for glamour in the race to defeat Kerrigor as he and his Dead minions threaten to overwhelm the kingdom. She is shown bruised and battered, surviving flights from and battles against the Dead and suffering the rigours of travel for days without access to baths or fresh clothing. Sabriel’s circumstances throughout most of *Sabriel* neither suggest prestige nor adhere to conventional expectations of feminine beauty and desirability.

Even after Touchstone and Sabriel take up the roles of King and Queen in *Lirael* and *Abhorsen*, they express discomfort with the formality and impracticality of court clothes. This is made clear in Touchstone's musings during their diplomatic mission to Ancelstierre:

Touchstone still found it odd to see Sabriel dressed in Ancelstierran clothes, particularly their court clothes, as she was wearing today. She should be in her blue and silver tabard, with the bells of the Abhorsen across her chest, her sword at her side. Not in a silver dress with a hussar's pelisse worn on one shoulder, and a strange little pillbox hat pinned to her deep-black hair. And the small automatic pistol in her silver mesh purse was no substitute for a sword.

Not that Touchstone felt at ease in his clothes either. An Ancelstierran shirt with its stiff collar and tie was too constricting, and his suit offered no protection at all. A sharp blade would slide through the double-breasted coat of superfine wool as easily as it would through butter, and as for a bullet . . . (Nix *Abh* 2-3)

Accompanying this practical, casual approach to clothing, images of the royal family at home in the Old Kingdom also suggest an informal, egalitarian attitude. The family is depicted as neither condescending nor self-important. They are not demanding of co-operation or submission from those around them – nor do they appear 'entitled' in speech or manner. Ellimere may be a princess known for her beauty, but her "normal attire was old hunting leathers with her hair carelessly tied back out of the way". Sam believes she looks out of place in the court dress she dons when acting as co-regent (*Lir* 217). Occasions that require ceremony grate against Sam's "desire for informality" (*Lir* 217). Indeed, undertones of sacrifice become attached to any royal obligations to practise formality and ceremony. When Sam resists form,

ritual and courtly dress, Ellimere reiterates these are what is expected of royalty by the people of the Old Kingdom: “The Kingdom must come first. [...]The people’s morale is very important, and each member of the family must play a part in maintaining it” (*Lir* 218).

Regardless of the imperative to play the royal role on special occasions, casualness is clearly preferred. A strong image of informality is seen at the pivotal family conference in the reservoir. Touchstone, just returned with Sabriel from a mission, has “managed to wash and change out of armour and riding gear”. He appears “wearing an Ancelstierran-style bathrobe, his curly hair still wet from a hasty bath” (*Lir* 284):

‘Are you going like that?’ asked Ellimere, as Touchstone strode over to the fireplace and into the left-hand side of the inglenook. He turned as she spoke, looked down on his robe and the twin swords belted across it, shrugged, and went on. (Nix *Lir* 287)

This informal attitude to dress, united with an expressed lack of desire for pomp and ceremony, works to temper the images of privilege that traditionally accompany representations of royalty.

The royal family’s informal interactions with others also ameliorate notions of prestige. A clear example of this can be found when Ryelle and Sanar of the Clayr greet Sabriel and Touchstone by bowing. Touchstone’s immediate response is to exclaim, “don’t get formal on me!” (*Lir* 49). This lack of pretension does not only extend to interaction with others of the Blood – royalty, the Clayr and Abhorsen. In order to keep their children grounded Touchstone and Sabriel establish routines requiring their children participate in everyday household tasks, known as ‘Perspective’.

Though Perspective involves things such as washing dishes, mopping floors or even mucking out stables, it functions more as a practice of humility than as a bridge between the privileged and the common. As Sam notes:

the servants could rarely forget that Sam and Ellimere would be Prince and Princess again tomorrow. Most of the servants dealt with the situation by pretending Sam and Ellimere weren't there, with a few notable exceptions like Mistress Finney, the falconer, who shouted at them like everyone else. So Perspective was usually a day of drudgery performed in strange silence and isolation. (Nix *Lir* 219)

Perspective, however, grants royalty the privilege of condescension in behaviour and, perversely, it tacitly displaces some of the weight of responsibility for any perceived divisions between castes onto the "ordinary people" (*Lir* 219). Royalty demonstrates a willingness to transgress social boundaries, but this is not reciprocated, and is even resisted, by those of lower stations.

There is a more comfortable integration between the royal family and those with military and administrative professions in the Old Kingdom. Ellimere plays tennis with her peers, happily works with Jall as co-regent when her father is away, practises diligently with the Guard, and demonstrates close friendship with many in the court. This is also expected of Sam, even as he recovers from his almost fatal encounter with the necromancer in Death:

'He [Touchstone] said you needed to be busy,' said Ellimere. [...] 'It's about time you did something useful around here. I've also scheduled you to sit with Jall at the Petty Court every morning between ten and one, and you'll have sword practice twice a day with

the Guard, of course, and you must come to dinner—no ordering meals to your grubby workshop.’ (Nix *Lir* 218-219)

This down-to-earth approach is also enacted by the Clayr. In their community all are required to perform duties which include being on a kitchen and serving roster. This involves serving not only other Clayr, but also guards and visiting merchants (*Lir* 15-16). Their duties extend to lowly tasks such as washing dishes and cleaning toilets (*Lir* 58). More mundane responsibilities are supplemented by the expectation of participation in exercises such as sword craft, archery and Charter Magic. This performance of service creates an impression that, despite their inherited gifts and rank, there is little desire to practise exclusivity or to disdain mundane tasks as beneath a person of Blood.

Negotiating the hierarchies that are entailed by medievalist models is a complex process. While Nix distances the royal family from images of luxury at the palace, there are clear traditional markers of privilege at the Abhorsen house. The Abhorsen’s residence is one that exudes stateliness, lavishness and substance. “Heavily laden with Charter Magic”, it has gothic features including a dominating “floor to ceiling stained-glass window” and furnishings of lustrous timber, silver and gold (*Sab* 104-5). Not only is the Abhorsen house heavily fortified by both its natural environment and by magic, but it is also protected and manned by magical ‘Charter sendings’ – servants created and maintained by Charter Magic for service to the Abhorsen. Fantasy therefore provides Nix with a clear means to negotiate class hierarchies, that is, the use of magical or fantasy creatures to perform servant roles.

The Charter sendings are clearly not human. Every square inch of the first one Sabriel meets is “defined by tiny, constantly moving Charter marks and Sabriel could see nothing between them but moving air” (*Sab* 89). Sabriel finds this image disconcerting as “the illusion of flesh was imperfect, fluid and unsettling. Its face wouldn’t stay fixed, migrating between scores of different possibilities. Some were women, some men [. . .]. Its body and clothing changed slightly, too, with every face” (*Sab* 89). The constant movement of Charter-marks in these magical constructions may hint at a myriad of options and possibilities for these sendings, but ultimately the continuous flux of character works to deny these creatures any kind of stable, individual identity or subjectivity. The story’s use of these sendings as servants enables the privileged position of the Abhorsen to be enforced without the subjection of humans, answering some of the ideological difficulties associated with hierarchical class structures. It creates a fantasy wherein the subjugation of one group to another is quietly neutralised.

Some sendings, however, particularly the more ancient ones, do exhibit minds of their own. Mogget labels at least one ‘recalcitrant’, noting they are “[p]rivileged family retainers who always think they know best”. He calls them “practically human, in the worst possible way” (*Sab* 103). Nix, however, has created sendings whose wills and most fervent desires revolve around meeting the needs of their masters and mistresses. When Sabriel is introduced as the new Abhorsen all the sendings drop to their knees, offering their Charter-marked hands in service and loyalty (*Sab* 106). Sam notes to Lirael that, in the Abhorsen’s house, “no one has to do anything, really, because there are so many sendings, all eager to help. I think they get bored when the place is empty” (*Lir* 552). Any suggestion of exploitation is

undermined through portraying the sendings as finding fulfilment in their bonded service.

It is worth noting, however, that Nix does not give the Charter servants voices. This may emphasise the un-worldliness of the sendings, but it does not do so without an implication that the voice of the subaltern is suppressed. Once more, however, any suggestion of powerlessness is undercut by the way in which sendings appear to exert influence within the house, personifying a connection to authority and the past. While the Abhorsen house is far more formal than the palace, both in appearance and operation, it is kept 'old' in its ways by the sendings, often contrary to the desires of the Abhorsen themselves. The sendings are unmistakably concerned with the maintenance of tradition. Through them a tangible attachment to the past exists. Even though Abhorsen die and pass through the ninth gate into Death, their created Charter sendings remain in the living world as a link to the past. This provides the sendings with a distinct gravitas. Sabriel notes, as she "gently pressed" all the hands offered in service, that many of the Charter spells within them "were old, far older than Sabriel could guess" (*Sab* 106). The sendings, despite being created servants, feel a certain ownership over the current Abhorsen. This allows them to demand an adherence to tradition and conventions.

The protagonists' behaviours and reactions to the sending's deference, however, are more aligned with modern Australian aspirations for informality. They get to show a reluctance toward being pampered, washed, dressed and served. The lavish attentions of the sendings are represented as a point of endurance rather than as a right or a privilege. The picture of privilege is

simultaneously built up and pulled down within the novels. Nix is able to utilise affective medieval markers of privilege at the same time as he questions them. He can build his protagonists up as extraordinary, as deserving of worship and adulation and, simultaneously, further amplify their worth in the eyes of contemporary readers through emphasising their disinclination to be pampered and venerated.

While the subjugated position of the Charter sendings is thus neutralised, *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* more overtly affirm individual human autonomy, which, according to John Stephens, is a central principle in Australian children's/young adult fiction. He argues that it is "desirable, if not essential" for the characters to aspire to an individual selfhood (ix). Reflecting broader Western liberal ideologies, Nix's novels are unequivocally critical of slavery and of the loss of agency that results from enslavement through Free Magic. Slavery is a key signifier of the enormous evil attached to the practice of Free Magic. Indeed, slavery within death is one of the great fears for citizens of the Old Kingdom; as Sabriel notes, "[t]ruly the Old Kingdom was a terrible place, when even death did not mean an end to slavery and despair" (*Sab* 121). It is clear that the Northern characters experience acute horror at the thought of such enslavement. Sabriel, Lirael and Sam, despite very real threats of danger and an imperative to keep on task, stop, time and time again, to perform the litany and ritual of cleansing, peace and sleep over the recently dead, using Charter marks of fire to ensure the freedom of spirits so souls cannot be enslaved (*Sab* 55, 208, *Abh* 84-85, 129-30). Occasions where circumstances make it impossible to administer final rites are acutely distressing (*Sab* 59) (*Lir* 544-545).

The texts also contain overt criticism of actual human slavery. Sabriel experiences dread and anger at the realisation that humans are being enslaved in service of the necromancers and their dead servants: “men and women—living, breathing people” (*Sab* 118). There is a greater revulsion still at the discovery that scavengers in the fallen city of Belisaere are practising child slavery, using “children—slaves—as decoys, or bait, for the Dead” (*Sab* 264). In this instance Sabriel’s abhorrence is so great that it almost derails her from her duty as Abhorsen. Her instinct is to face impossible odds in an attempt to save these children from such a fate. Mogget needs to redirect her to the larger picture, asking “What will it profit these children and all the others who may come, if you are slain? It is the Dead who are at the root of this evil, and Abhorsen’s business is with the dead” (*Sab* 264). It is noteworthy that it is the seemingly amoral Mogget, a creature who claims that he has no interest in the rights and wrongs of the Abhorsen’s cause, who here clearly identifies slavery as evil. This represents the practice of slavery as unequivocally malevolent.

Paradoxically, Mogget himself is in a form of enslavement, but this is cast variously as a safeguard for the Old Kingdom or as a punishment for Mogget’s wrongs. In the final instalment of the tale it is revealed that Mogget is Yrael, one of the original deities of this secondary world; he is the Eighth Bright Shiner, who stood back, declining to become involved when the other seven deities took their stand against Orannis, the Destroyer. His moral ambivalence, his refusal to choose right, led to his ‘binding’ by the seven Bright Shiners who gave themselves up for the protection of the Kingdom. This binding made him a servant of the Abhorsen against his will. Mogget,

however, casts it more bluntly, claiming: "I am but a slave bound to service" (*Sab* 110).

Unquestionably, the divine power and Free Magic within Mogget make him an extraordinarily dangerous being. His anger over his own servitude makes him more dangerous still, and his wrath is most acutely directed toward those he has been made to serve. In moments where Mogget is temporarily released from his binding, he is represented as white hot and uncontained; twisting and transforming, as "white fire lines [...] streaming out, converging roiling, coming together", "a blazing blue white creature", distorting and changing (*Sab* 152). He is enraged by the very thought of his "[m]illennia of servitude", chained, he claims, "by trickery, treachery... captive in a repulsive, fixed flesh shape" (*Sab* 155). Although Mogget's reluctant service repeatedly provides invaluable aid to the cause of the Charter, it is only when Sam releases him from slavery, allowing him the power of choice, that Mogget is able to truly join with the others to defeat Orannis. Implicitly, despite the potential danger attached to the release of Mogget, true victory cannot be achieved until the issue of his binding is resolved and Mogget is again given the agency to choose (*Abh* 418).

There remains an identifiable ambivalence in the manner in which freedom is treated in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*. Completely unrestrained freedom, freedom that is executed indiscriminately, without regard for others, is portrayed as evil. Moreover, while a lack of choice is sometimes cast as unequivocally abhorrent, particularly when associated with Free Magic, when it is associated with the Charter it is positively constructed and cast as destiny. The texts make a distinction between the demands of 'service' to the

Charter, and 'slavery' under free magic. This is semiotically reinforced by the novel's imagery. While the Charter sendings are complex and beautiful, the unconstrained Free Magic constructions are ugly, monstrous, "fell creatures" (*Lir* 460). Kerrigor's powerful Mordicant that pursues Sabriel through most of the first novel is the antithesis of the shining and alive Charter sendings. In very basic Manichean terms it is clear the Charter servants are creatures of the light while the returned, enslaved Dead are creatures of darkness. The Mordicant is base and unnatural, having been built with "bog-clay and human blood moulded and infused with Free Magic by a necromancer, and a Dead spirit placed inside it as a guiding force" (*Sab* 85). The references to bog clay and human blood make allusions to occult and superstitious sacrifice. Despite the Mordicant's power, it appears savage, crude and primitive in comparison to the ordered beauty and artistry seen in Charter creations. Also, unlike Charter sendings who are able to demonstrate an, albeit limited, form of assertive personality in the performance of their service, the Mordicant demonstrates no agency of its own.

Like the Charter sendings, the novels' protagonists also have an apparently inexorable bond with the Charter. Unlike the sendings, however, they experience uncertainty and contend with questions of personal agency. As noted earlier, the issue of navigating one's own path is a central concern in Australian young adult literature. This appears to be at odds with the hierarchical notions of destined place that are often entailed in the fantasy genre's appropriation of medieval tropes. Through most of *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* the protagonists struggle with the demands of destiny and expectation. Indeed, the tension between destiny and freewill is foregrounded in the oft-repeated epigram throughout the novels: "Does the

walker choose the path, or the path the walker?”. These words “redolent with the echoes of Charter Magic” are “the very last words, all alone on the last page of *The Book of the Dead*” (*Sab* 47). I argue this tension is negotiated through an appeal to another principle that John Stephens identifies as central within Australian young adult literature: the idea that autonomous selfhood should be “intersubjective, not solipsistic; altruistic, not self-serving” (Stephens ix). This modifies the imperative to strive for independent agency.

Throughout most of *Sabriel* Sabriel resists her calling, insisting that her father still lives. Although this is primarily because, as a loved father and her only surviving family member, she does not wish him dead, it also represents an attempt to hold on to life choices available to her if she is not Abhorsen. If she finds her father alive she has alternatives. She can still go south, go to university, live an ordinary life like her friends, and enjoy the social freedom that includes meeting young men (*Nix Sab* 16). There is clearly something within her that craves this kind of choice, but destiny and altruistic duty also exert a strong pressure. Her Destiny is foreshadowed not only by her heritage, but in her very first experience within the precincts of Death as a new-born child, recorded in the novel’s prologue. Even as a babe Sabriel’s life force burns Kerrigor, her Greater Dead nemesis, giving her father time to send Kerrigor, for a time, deeper into Death (*Sab* 6-7). Sabriel knows from childhood that she has an “affinity for death and the dead” (*Sab* 16). This, however, does not equate to desiring the role of Abhorsen: “Death and what came after death was no great mystery to Sabriel. She just wished it was” (*Sab* 14). Despite her doubts, however, her destiny seems fixed. As Mogget unequivocally asserts: “you are Abhorsen, and you must put the Dead to rest. Your path has been chosen”. He simply laughs at her declaration that

she “can walk a different path” (*Sab*110). It appears that moral duty to others trumps individual choice.

Similarly, when faced with the expectations of destiny, the reluctance felt by Touchstone, Lirael and Sam is entangled with a desire to choose. Touchstone, due to a misguided feeling of responsibility for the state of the Kingdom, would choose abasement over kingship. Lirael's desire to belong with her sister Clayr would see her choose the sight above her destiny of Remembrancer and Abhorsen-in-Waiting. Sam's experience is more complex. Despite a desire to fulfil the expectations of both the Kingdom and the Charter, and a strong “resolution to be a proper Abhorsen”, this emotionally torments him. His belief that he is destined to be Abhorsen did “not banish the fear that still lurked in his heart” (*Lir* 305).

The tension between choice, destiny and altruistic service is further negotiated by a paradoxical association between agency and submission to the Charter. Accepting destiny becomes an active choice for these characters, and they ultimately achieve fulfilment in compliance. Life within the constraints of the Charter answers their deeper longings. Sabriel's desires for a romantic partnership (*Sab* 16) are answered through her relationship with Touchstone (*Sab* 351). Touchstone has family restored in his union with Sabriel; moreover, as King he is given greater opportunity fulfil his desire, indeed his need, to perform service and sacrifice. He is able to enact a penance for his unintended part in fall of the kingdom. A strong symbol of this is seen in his mending of the Great Charter Stones that were broken when his mother and sisters were sacrificed by Kerrigor. Touchstone uses his own blood mixed with Charter magic to repair them, for weeks

labouring alone, repeatedly reopening wounds in his own flesh to access the blood necessary for the mending (*Lir* 289-290).

For Sam, resolution is found when his true destiny is ultimately revealed. It is discovered that he is not marked as Abhorsen, but as Wallmaker, a magical artisan role which perfectly fits with both his gifts and desires. These coincidences between choice and destiny resolve tension within the novels, with yielding to destiny answering the deepest needs of the protagonists. There is only fulfilment and release when their true destinies, in accordance with the Charter, are revealed and accepted. In Sam's case he is released from the anxieties attached to the pressure of expectation and his fear of Death; moreover, as Wallmaker there is no tension between aptitude, desire and expectation.

Similarly, Lirael is released from the shame she feels over not having received the sight. Her roles as Remembrancer and Abhorsen-in-Waiting come as second nature to her. She accepts them as right and natural, even while she believes acting her part will bring about her death. Understanding her destiny, Lirael is able to access feelings of self, power and belonging that were denied to her when she stood outside her ordained place. Where previously it "seemed to be her fate that she would have no close friends" (*Lir* 107), she now has people with whom she can feel at home. The Dog encapsulates this as she tells Lirael during the denouement of the story, "you have found your family, your heritage; and you have earned a high place in the world" (*Abh* 422).

While choices of submission to destiny and service to others become conflated with fulfilment, the choice to transgress the will of the Charter is aligned with devastation and ultimate failure. Rogue characters such as Kerrigor, who was previously a royal prince, and Chlorr of the Mask, a necromancer who was formerly Abhorsen-in-Waiting, show that it is possible for those of the blood to act outside one's destiny. These characters, however, do not realise success, neither do they achieve completion. They can be viewed as warnings to those who seek fulfilment outside the 'natural' order ordained by the Charter; implicitly, rejection of destiny leads only to failure and destruction.

Nix's novels also portray choice within the bounds of the charter. Moreover, the novels actively demonstrate a wariness of *unthinking* compliance to authority, even to traditions tied to the Charter. This is an oft-repeated motif throughout *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*. Like the desire for informality, the rejection of pretentious behaviour, a disdain for tyranny, and the imperatives for an independent selfhood and altruistic service discussed earlier in this chapter, the motif of a wariness regarding authority is strongly attached to entrenched understandings of 'Australian' character. These traits combined, reveal a discernible synchronicity between the popular conceptions of Australian character and characteristics displayed and valued within the novels.

Richard White argues that from the nineteenth century there was "substantial agreement on a particular group of characteristics" that were considered distinctly Australian in quality. Along with values such as "independence", "egalitarianism" and a "dislike of mental effort", White lists "a certain

disrespect for authority” as one of the traits considered to be quintessentially Australian (76-77). Rooted in historical constructions of Australian identity, these characteristics still hold cultural power. A 2000 study by Tim Phillips and Philip Smith on what contemporary Australians see as ‘Australian’ provides evidence of the sustained resonance of these traits (204). Qualities such as demonstrating an “easy-going personality”, appreciating “casual dress codes”, and the idea of giving others a “fair go”, were seen as desirable, as was a cynical “disrespect for authority and pointless rules” (Phillips and Smith 218). Although this self-flattering view of Australia is perhaps more reflective of a desire for a distinctive national type than a reflection of actual practice, it is still revelatory of Australia’s cultural aspirations.

An elastic response to rules, forms and protocols is clearly evident in a number of episodes in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, demonstrating again the alignment between national values and the values expressed within the novels. Although there are laws tied to the Charter, the novels associate strict adherence with petty officiousness and pedantry. They suggest that even the Charter itself approves the bending of its own laws in the service of broader ideals. Principles such as compassion and understanding are shown to override unthinking compliance to the letter of the law. Indeed, *Sabriel* opens with a clear demonstration of this, as the Abhorsen persuades a disapproving Charter Mage to baptise his new-born daughter Sabriel, who has not survived her birth. The Abhorsen – whose role under the Charter is to ensure that the Dead remain dead – then rescues Sabriel’s spirit from Death, returning her to her now “living flesh” (*Sab* 7). The Abhorsen’s actions are clearly outside the perceived conventions of Charter. Even the

seemingly amoral Mogget proclaims in a voice that “seemed to carry the weight of centuries”, that the Dead “must not” be brought back into Life (*Sab* 109-110). He reiterates that Abhorsen “must put the Dead to rest” claiming any other path represents a fall into evil (*Sab* 110). The rightness of Sabriel’s father’s actions, however, is confirmed by the ‘taking’ of Sabriel’s Charter mark during the rite executed by the reluctant Charter mage: “the wood and ash disappeared from the priest’s forehead and slowly formed on the child’s. The Charter had accepted the baptism” (*Sab* 4). Consequently, Sabriel’s baptism and her survival in life are incontestably shown to be within the will of the Charter. Implicitly, greater principles rest behind and above conventions and rules, overriding fastidious obedience to the letter of the law.

Not only does the prologue begin with an infringement of religious protocol, the first chapter starts with a breach of promise and another cameo of the contravention of rules. The episode that introduces Sabriel as a young woman shows her “breaking the promise she had made to both herself and her father” in order to go into Death to rescue an unquestionably dead (*Sab* 11) pet rabbit belonging to Jacinth, one of the younger students at Wyverley College. Sabriel’s compassion seems to authorise her action, as the breach is but slight: “it was only a rabbit and Jacinth did love it so much” (*Sab* 14). Here, principles such as kindness and empathy take precedence over a strict obedience to moral or religious convention.

The epilogue to *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* provides a bookend to the prologue and opening chapter of the series. It again depicts a spirit reclaimed

from Death in the exercise of compassion. Although Nicholas Sayre has died in the final stand against the Destroyer, the Dog sends him back to into life:

‘How can I go anywhere? I’m dead, aren’t—’

‘I’m sending you back,’ said the Dog gently, nudging Nick’s leg with her snout, so he turned to face towards Life. Then she barked, a single sharp sound that was both a welcome and a farewell.

‘Is this allowed?’ asked Nick as he felt the [river’s] current reluctantly release him, and he took the first step back.

‘No,’ said the Dog. ‘But then I am the Disreputable Dog.’

Nick took another step, and he smiled as he felt the warmth of Life, and the smile became a laugh, a laugh that welcomed everything, even the pain that waited in his body. (Nix *Abh* 425)

What is significant here is that the Dog has now been revealed as Kibeth, a former deity, one of the Bright Shiners who imbued the Charter with much of her essence during its creation. Throughout *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* the Dog exhibits a clear disdain for formality and a disregard for letter of the law, so, by implication, these characteristics necessarily infuse the Charter itself. Although the larrikin traits in the Dog’s character can be imagined to reflect a distinctively Australian quality, the sense that compassion should outweigh legalism projects broader ideals within Western thought.

A critique of strict legalism does not just bookend the trilogy; it pervades much of the narrative and is evident early in Lirael’s story. Although the Clayr have a clearly defined and structured society, the application of strict formality is depicted as something cold and undesirable. Kirrith, Lirael’s bitter Aunt, is unsympathetically portrayed as someone “all for rules and regulation, tradition and conformity” (*Lir* 13). By contrast, more senior and

respected Clayr are approved within the story because they place the feelings of others before the application of rules and laws. Those who act outside complete legalism include Filris, “the Infirmarian, and the oldest of the Clayr still living” (*Lir* 101), and also the twins, Sanar and Ryelle, who are described as “the flawless embodiment of the perfect Clayr” (*Lir* 44). Sanar and Ryelle demonstrate compassion to Lirael when she is discovered trespassing near the Starmount Gate on her fourteenth birthday, considering suicide in despair at not having yet received the sight. Rather than punish Lirael they reassure her that she is one of the Clayr, and assign her a post at the Great Library to turn her mind from her troubles (*Lir* 62). When Lirael later breaks into the Old Levels of the library and accidentally releases a Free Magic creature, Filris hides Lirael’s folly from the girl’s superiors, protecting her position as a junior librarian (*Lir* 102-106).

The twins’ disdain for unthinking compliance to “rules regulation, tradition and conformity” (*Lir* 13) is again demonstrated in their disdainful reaction to Erimael’s demand that Lirael be blindfolded before entering Clayr Observatory:

‘You may pass. But the other with you has not Awoken. By the ancient laws, she must not be allowed to See the secret ways.’

‘Don’t be silly, Erimael,’ said Sanar. ‘What ancient laws? It’s Lirael, Arielle’s daughter.’ [...]

‘The laws are clear,’ said Erimael, still in the same stern voice, though Lirael saw her gulp nervously. ‘I am the Axe—Guard. She must be blindfolded if you wish her to pass.’

Sanar snorted and turned to the other woman. (Nix *Lir* 352)

Ryelle and Sanar demonstrate that their understanding of service to the Charter is greater than the understanding of those constrained by legalism. Those who refuse to question the appropriateness and the personal cost of applying the letter of the law are portrayed as small minded. The twins, along with the novel's readers, are able to see Lirael's extreme distress and shame at this treatment. Against the twins' empathy, stringent adherence to the law appears both unkind and unthinking.

Significantly, episodes such as this function on more than one level; they censure strict legalism and approve compassion and empathy, but they also obscure privilege. In "The Australian Enigma" (2007), a study on what is unique in Australian leadership, Neal Ashkanasy identifies characteristics that he argues "represent a quintessential expression of egalitarianism" (316). These are "mateship", a preference for those who are "one of us", a suspicion of "tall poppies",¹² and an appreciation of leaders as "underdogs" (316). In the Old Kingdom Chronicles, mateship is seen in the relationships and loyalty between the protagonists. Given their informality, unpretentiousness and human fears, each protagonist can appear like 'one of us' and thereby avoid the 'tall poppy syndrome'. The novels also situate the protagonists as underdogs.

Rather than appear as one of a privileged caste, Lirael is clearly portrayed as disempowered and disadvantaged. The fact that she has not awoken in the sight isolates her and makes her feel inferior. She is also physically Other to most of the Clayr; she is white skinned, dark haired and dark eyed and

¹² The 'tall poppy syndrome', involves high achievers being disdained as arrogant, and being disliked for rising above the group.

where her 'sisters' are blonde, blue eyed, with skin that quickly tans (Nix *Lir* 14). Her crisis of identity is compounded by not knowing anything of her father and by feeling abandoned by her late mother, who, in a very unClayr like manner, left the glacier. When combined with her Aunt Kirrith's cold, official and distant treatment (*Lir* 13), this all undermines any image of privilege within the text.

Moreover, even as Lirael is made aware of her giftedness, discovering that her true destiny is to see the past rather than the future, any sense of advantage is undercut by an equal sense of difference and of loss. Although exceptional, Lirael's gift is construed as something that further isolates her:

But while she had always been alone among the Clayr for her blindness to the future, now she was alone in another way as well. In a perverse reversal of all her hopes and dreams, she had been granted the exact opposite of her heart's desire.

For with the Dark Mirror and her new-found knowledge, She could See into the past. (Nix *Lir* 371).

This provides a clear example of how privilege can be glossed over and even completely overwhelmed by accompanying representations of isolation or emotional hardship.

Similarly, each of the novels' protagonists simultaneously appears as both advantaged and disadvantaged. Sabriel's position as Abhorsen is mediated by her youth, her inexperience, and by the cultural gaps in understanding attributable to spending her years of schooling outside the Old Kingdom in Ancelstierre (*Sab* 188). Although the royal heir, Touchstone's disadvantage is seen in his bastard ancestry, his two-hundred years of enchanted captivity

as the figurehead of a hidden funerary ship, and in the murder of his family immediately prior to his entrapment, a tragedy for which he feels he was, albeit unwittingly, partially responsible (*Sab* 186). Prince Sameth's disadvantage resides in his debilitating fear of Death, particularly when weighed against the expectation that he will be the next Abhorsen. Disadvantage is also present in others' lack of understanding and even derision regarding his desire to seclude himself and indulge in his creative artisanship (*Lir* 221).

The contexts provided by the stories too, with overwhelming terrors threatening the land, work to situate the protagonists in a position where the inherent power attached to their births is ameliorated by inescapable destiny and notions of personal sacrifice for the sake of the Kingdom. Moreover, the protagonists do not covet power. Interestingly, this represents a striking difference from the contest for leadership played out in Kay's *The Fionavar Tapestry*, to be discussed in Chapter 6. In *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* authority is not desired, but forced upon them by the protagonist's destinies in the Charter. In both Nix and Kay's series, however, the 'rightness' of position and roles becomes unassailable; they are affirmed by the authority of antiquity, blood and magic. This situates the question of power outside the realm of human decision and in the province of the supernatural, the divine. For those with access to power in the Old Kingdom, authority is not a privilege, but a responsibility.

Furthermore, for those of the Blood, the Charter does not exist as an external and confirming authority. Within the conceit of the story, the Old Kingdom's royalty, Abhorsen and Clayr literally embody differing aspects of the Charter.

Nix employs the medievalist device of a riddle, a mnemonic in the form of a child's rhyme, to reveal that the land is not simply governed, but was created and is held together through the power of the Charter that lives on in those of the Blood.

Five Great Charters knit the land
Together linked, hand in hand
One for the people who wear the crown
Two in the folk that keep the Dead down
Three and five became stone and mortar
Four sees all in the frozen water. (Nix *Sab* 232)

The five Great Charters were 'Bright Shiners', deities who fully sacrificed themselves in order to create the Charter and save the world from the power of the Destroyer. Through their sacrifice the Bloodlines and the Old Kingdom's magical artefacts were imbued with their essence. Line three of this riddle speaks of the royal family; line four of the Abhorsen; line five of the Wall and Charter Stones; and line six speaks of the Clayr. As the Dog (herself a remnant of another of the Bright Shiners who gave much, but not all of her essence, to the Charter) explains to Lirael:

'The Great Charters are the keystones of the Charter. The Bloodlines, the Wall, and the Charter Stones all come from the original sacrifice of the Five, who poured their power into the men and women who were your ancestors. Some of those, in turn, passed that power to stone and mortar [...]' (Nix *Lir* 461).

Consequently, the privilege attached to being one of the Blood does not simply authorise a participation in the power structures of the Old Kingdom, it requires it. More significantly, it is implicitly attached to notions of continued sacrifice. Just as the Five Bright Shiners sacrificed their whole beings to the

creation of the Charter, members of the Bloodlines continue to give the sacrifice of service to the Old Kingdom. Gifts and destiny are not for the recipients alone. As the Dog points out to Lirael, “You must grow in your own powers—for yourself, for the Kingdom, and for the Charter” (*Lir* 555). It is in this that the concept of altruistic service is most clearly emphasised, turning privilege into duty. As Lirael is unequivocally informed by Sanar, “you have been given other gifts, gifts that I’m sure will be sorely needed by the Kingdom. And as all of us of the Blood are given gifts, we are also laden with responsibility to use them wisely and well. You have the potential for great power, Lirael, but I fear you will also face great tests” (*Lir* 348). Being one of the Blood, therefore, is presented as a double-edged sword.

Not only does the notion of sacrifice attenuate the privilege of blood within *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, through its altruistic appeal it ushers the privilege of authority and position back into a place that fits comfortably within the wider aspirations of Australian identity. Though sacrifice for a higher cause is reflective of principles clearly apparent in broader western systems of value, nobility and belief, Australians have claimed it, most commonly drawing upon Anzac mythology, as a particularly national trait. The Anzac myth, originating with the Australian and New Zealand Army Corps’ (ANZAC) ill-fated landing at Gallipoli in April 1915, initially inducted sacrifice as a central ideal within the Australian cultural psyche. In a discussion of the Australian response to recent national tragedies (2010), Sarah Gillman notes how the rhetoric of sacrifice, mateship and heroism continues to reinforce “hegemonic discourses of Australian identity through the identification and promotion of virtues such as bravery and sacrifice as intrinsic national characteristics” (246).

Furthermore, during the time Nix was writing *Lirael* and *Abhorsen*, the second and third books of his trilogy, Anzac mythology with its concomitant notions of sacrifice and bravery were experiencing a resurgence under the leadership of conservative Prime Minister, John Howard. In “Lest We Forget” (2010) Matt McDonald asserts that the “power and centrality of the Anzac myth to Australian national identity is difficult to overstate” (293), observing that:

While leader (from 1996 to 2007) Howard had consistently defined the “digger” [Australian soldier] as the ideal manifestation of the Australian type, the Anzac myth as the central narrative of Australian identity, and the experience of Gallipoli as the defining moment in the foundation of the Australian nation. (McDonald 288)

Speaking of the impact of Australia’s involvement in the First World War, Richard White notes that commendations given to “raw colonial troops”, such as those from Australia, Canada and New Zealand, were taken up in the cause of Australian nationalism (128). Pertinently, Australia’s desire to feel a connection with the past can also be seen in the construction of the diggers’ image. White tells of John Masefield, future United Kingdom poet laureate, drawing on notions of heroism found in historical literary sources such as Shakespeare and the medieval *Song of Roland*, to eulogise ‘untested’ colonial soldiers. Though Masefield addressed colonial troops as a whole, the “reaction in Australia was to accept these idealised heroic qualities as not only characteristic of the digger, but to see them as distinctive to Australians” (White 129).

In “The Pleating of History: Weaving the Threads of Nationhood” (2005), Martin Ball notes that the Anzac myth answered the needs of a young nation to enmesh itself in an historical storyline: “Gallipoli provided the requisite epic narrative to lend a mythic dimension to [Australia’s] story. It provided the folds needed to pleat history into the story of nationhood” (165). The desire to feel linked to the past is seen as central to Australian cultural imaginings, as Ball asserts:

This nation craved an ancestral past, not a modern future. What Australia lacked was some cultural and historical baggage to call its own. It was not embarrassed by a medieval history, but in desperate need of one. There is no need to escape from a synchronous relation with the past; rather, this is exactly the type of temporal imagining the nation was searching for, a way of claiming an ancestral heritage without having to inflate the meagre and dubious details of the country’s ‘short history’. (Ball 170)

The Old Kingdom Chronicles’ representation of heroism is closely aligned with Australian values and aspirations. There is a significant imperative for altruism among those with the privilege of blood in the Old Kingdom. There is also a strong history of sacrifice. As members of the royal family, Touchstone’s mother and sisters were literal sacrifices, Kerrigor slaughtering them and using their blood to break two of the Great Charter stones. Sabriel’s father, Terciel, is killed within the course of *Sabriel*, sacrificing himself in order to give Sabriel an opportunity to escape and to continue the fight for the sake of the Kingdom. His death follows that of four other Abhorsen who had “fallen in this century alone, trying to deal with the Dead, the broken stones and the—the original problem” (Nix *Sab* 182). Lirael similarly, believes that binding The Destroyer will only be achieved at the cost of her life. She goes ahead regardless, but is saved by the intervention of the Dog, at the cost of the Dog’s current earthly life and of her own hand.

Sacrifice, for those of the Blood, is not only present in the loss of material life; it has many manifestations. These include the sacrifice of family life, the sacrifice of choice, and the sacrifice of connection to the material things of the world. Just before his death, Abhorsen Terciel speaks of this to Sabriel:

'I have not been an ideal parent, I know,' Abhorsen said quietly. 'None of us ever are. When we become the Abhorsen, we lose much else. Responsibility to many people rides roughshod over personal responsibilities; difficulties and enemies crush out softness; our horizons narrow. You are my daughter, and I have always loved you. But now, I live again for only a short time—a hundred hundred heartbeats, no more— and I must win a battle against a terrible enemy. Our parts now—which perforce we must play—are not father and daughter, but one old Abhorsen, making way for the new. But behind this, there is always my love.' (Nix *Sab* 301-302)

Arielle, Lirael's mother, also dies in service of the Charter after sacrificing both family and choice for the sake of fulfilling her destiny. Before Lirael's birth Arielle foresees this sacrifice will be required and leaves a message with Mogget:

'You will stand by my daughter near the Wall. You will see her grown, as I will not. Tell Lirael that ... that my going will be ... will have been ... no choice of mine. I have linked her life and mine to the Abhorsen, and put the feet of both mother and daughter on a path that will limit our own choosing. Tell her also that I love her, and will always love her, and that leaving her will be the death of my heart.' (Nix *Abh* 215)

Similarly, Sabriel, even after the restoration of the monarchy and the defeat of Kerrigor, is regularly separated from family due to the responsibilities of

her role, leaving Touchstone fearful for her safety and Prince Sameth feeling he is only of secondary importance to his mother. This can be seen in the exchange between Touchstone and his son following Sameth's almost deadly encounter with the necromancer Hedge in Death:

'Your mother is more worried about you than anything else.'

'Then where is she?' asked Sam[...]

'Apparently, there is a Mordaut riding the ferryman at Oldmond,' explained Touchstone patiently, as he had explained so many of Sabriel's necessary absences over the course of Sam's childhood.

'[...] She'll meet us back at Belisaere.'

'If she doesn't have to go somewhere else,' said Sam, knowing he was being bitter and childish. But he could have died, and apparently that still wasn't enough for his mother to come and see him.

'Unless she has to go somewhere else,' agreed Touchstone, as calmly as ever. [...]

'Sorry,' Sam mumbled. 'I know she has to do it. Being the Abhorsen and everything.'

'Yes,' said Touchstone, and Sam got a slight hint of his father's own deep feelings about the many and frequent absences required by Sabriel's battles with the Dead. (Nix Lir 207-8)

The above examples all demonstrate physical, social and emotional sacrifice in service of the Charter.

Although not facing the imminent dangers of Abhorsen, the Clayr too, perform sacrifice, most clearly in the severing of their connection with the material world in order to fulfil their destinies as the Kingdom's seers. Indeed, "[i]t was not uncommon for some of the more ancient Clayr to perceive only [. . .] fragmented futures and not be able to interact with the present at all" (*Lir*

101). Although this is an aspect of their calling, it does not come without a sense of loss. Just before her own death, Filris, Lirael's great-great-grandmother shares her regrets with Lirael, including sorrow that, being "[t]oo much a Clayr, I suppose, too much in the future", she was never close to her granddaughters or great-granddaughters (106). Filris admits to Lirael that "[m]ost of all I regret I have not lived enough in the present these last fifteen years. I should have met you sooner" (*Lir* 105).

As the ostensibly national traits of heroism and sacrifice actually reflect broader western discourses of moral value, these motifs translate well to an international western readership. As Ball astutely observes, "although the Gallipoli nation purports to celebrate a distinctive character and identity, it betrays the paradox that nationhood has been achieved as per the old way, war and sacrifice – the nation is not so different after all" (171). These texts, therefore, intersect with not only the cultural imaginings of contemporary Australia, but with widespread, longstanding discourses of merit and significance.

The Old Kingdom Chronicles' use of the image of blood and of bloodlines also heavily intersects with and reflects Anglo-Australian identity and desire. Ball observes that the "importance of blood to the national imagining runs on two levels. There are the Blood lines of racial strength and purity; and there is the Blood of sacrifice and martyrdom" (Ball 163). Although the Blood of sacrifice and martyrdom is foregrounded within *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, the notion that the Bloodlines need to remain unadulterated if they are to retain strength and purity is also present within the texts. An explicit example of this is when Dog explains to Lirael that the Five Great Charters not only

poured their essence into bloodlines of Royalty, Abhorsen and Clayr, but the Bright Shiners also “passed that power into stone and mortar, when blood alone was judged to be too easily diluted and led astray” (*Lir* 461).

Indeed, fear that the purity of the Charter may be corrupted is recurrent throughout the trilogy. Greetings are often accompanied by the touching of Charter marks in order to test against corruption. Examples include Mogget testing Touchstone’s Charter mark with a lick, “finding him to be unsullied by Free Magic, or necromancy” (*Sab* 184), and Lirael and Sameth’s first encounter, when Lirael remains suspicious despite the Dog’s assurance that “[h]e’s a royal prince all right [...] I can smell his blood” (*Lir* 471):

Quickly, Lirael reached across with her left hand and touched the Charter mark on his forehead, her sword held ready to strike if the mark was false or corrupted. But her finger felt the familiar warmth of the true Charter, bright and strong. (Nix *Lir* 473)

Certainly, this undercurrent concerning purity of blood sits within the frame of magic not of race. Royalty, Abhorsen and Clayr literally hold the essence of the Charter in their blood, and there is a need for it to remain uncorrupted by unconstrained Free Magic. Still, the metaphoric resonance of a need to maintain the purity of blood, of the imperative that it remain unsullied and undiluted, is not unproblematic. While the Old Kingdom’s strong Northern, Anglo-Saxon, Anglo-Celtic associations contrast with the Anglo-Norman associations of Ancelstierre, they contrast even more strongly with the Otherness represented by the Southerling refugees. This contrast will be discussed in greater detail in Chapter 4.

The exclusivity of the privilege of Blood, however, is somewhat offset by the fact that baptism into the Charter is available to all, not only to Royalty, Abhorsen and Clayr. There is general access to the Charter, unrestricted by caste, ethnicity, or gender. The difference between “normal people’s” access to the Charter and those of the Blood, however, is striking. This is evident in Sam’s musings about the affinity between his blood and ancient Charter artefacts:

Sam wondered about the use of blood, the same blood that ran in his veins. It felt strange to him that his pounding heart was in its way akin to the Great Stone’s ahead. [...] Why was royal, Abhorsen and Clayr blood different from normal people’s – even that of other Charter Mages [...]? Why did their blood contain Charter Magic, magic that could not be duplicated by marks drawn from the generally accessible Charter? (Nix *Lir* 290)

Still, there are many ‘normal’ Charter mages scattered throughout villages, the Royal Guard, and even the Ancelstierran army. Sabriel’s school, too, being situated close to the Wall teaches the use of Charter magic to select pupils (*Sab* 15). A number of the Perimeter Guard have been baptised into the Charter. Colonel Horyse speaks of the Crossing Point Scouts as “a somewhat motley collection of Ancelstierrans who’ve managed to gain a Charter mark and some small knowledge of magic” (*Sab* 35). Nicholas Sayre is another Ancelstierran who comes to possess a Charter mark after the Dog grants him a baptism and a second chance at life (*Abh* 425). The different forms of access to the Charter mix both elitist and egalitarian images, once more confusing and obscuring notions of inequity based on blood and caste. This hints at the way the novels negotiate ethnic difference, maintaining the authority and privilege for an elite group who are linked to the divine through

their blood, whilst simultaneously approving a (lesser) form of democratic sharing of this privilege.

Situating the story in an imagined past does not constrain its relevance. Despite a medieval and fantastic setting, the narrative and ideological bent in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* have a strong Australian inflection, and, more broadly, intersect with contemporary Western ideals. Although ostensibly concerned with a distant secondary world, texts such as *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* can be seen as barometers of their own times. They reflect the discourses, tensions, and ideological contestations present in Australian society at the time of their production. The following chapter will take the Southerling refugee crisis as a case study to illustrate how medievalist fantasy is able to comment on current political events.

Chapter 4

Refugees, Humanitarianism and Naturalised Western Power

This chapter will focus on how ethnic difference is represented in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*. It will do so with particular reference to the Southerling refugee crisis depicted in *Lirael* and *Abhorsen*. I will consider how Otherness is represented within the conceit of the story. I will also examine how the portrayal of the refugee crisis within the novels closely intersects with issues at the forefront of Australian politics at the time the novels were written. This entails a discussion of the rise of populist, Anglo-centric nationalist politics during the 1990s and early 2000s, particularly that associated with the reactionary political figure of Pauline Hanson and the related, albeit moderated, expressions of Anglo-centric nationalism by the then Prime Minister, John Howard, and other members of his government.

In the Preface to *Creating Australia* (1997) Stuart Macintyre sums up the political climate during this period. He casts the early 1990s as a time in which Australia culturally “found ways of managing diversity without ethnic recidivism”, but notes a stark discursive shift in the latter half of the decade after the election of the Howard Government in 1996:

Then in 1996, this new apparent national settlement was thrown into doubt. In the space of a year the cuewords of public discourse changed—from Paul Keating's 'Big Picture'¹³ to Pauline Hanson's 'Asian Invasion', from Don Watson's¹⁴ anticipation of the 'first postmodern republic', with the principal values of difference and tolerance, to John Howard's assault on the 'black armband' view of history'. (Macintyre ix)

John Howard's message did not stop at advocating a more forgiving, apologist view of Anglo-centric and racist practices and policies in Australia's past. It looked to approve and reassert the purportedly challenged Anglo-Celtic dominance at the centre of Australia's post-settlement historical cultural identity. In *White Nation* (WN) Ghassan Hage observes that the desire to maintain Anglo-centric cultural, political and economic power is, then, ironically, reconstructed as egalitarianism:

In a peculiarly Australian way, the call for 'equality' was emptied of its socio-economic significance and became effectively a call for the reassertion of the old Anglo-Australian order and for assimilation. There was no hypocrisy here, for egalitarianism was precisely a yearning for the time when Anglo-Celtic males could credibly, despite their class differences, imagine themselves to be just 'mates' and where they could all feel that they had an equal right to the nation" (Hage WN 204)

The disjunction between a firm belief in the liberal principles of equity and the increase in exclusionary rhetoric and political practice is obscured by the conflation of egalitarianism with Western British ideological, political and cultural dominance. It becomes axiomatic that Anglo-Celtic Australia is egalitarian, and by extension, that the Other threatens this fundamental cultural aspiration.

¹³ Australian Prime Minister (1991- 1996) Paul Keating's 'Big picture' looked toward greater economic and cultural ties with the Asia region, republicanism, and reconciliation between the settler and Indigenous Australians.

¹⁴ Historian, DR. Don Watson, was speech writer for Paul Keating from 1992-1996.

Deborah Madsen associates the conservative shift in Australia's politics of ethnicity with notions of home and homelessness, exposing a particular postcolonial concern with issues of identity. This is exemplified in Pauline Hanson's maiden speech in parliament:¹⁵

When Pauline Hanson asked, on behalf of the white-settler community, "where can I go home to?" she indelibly linked discourses of ethnic difference with those of nation, belonging, and homeliness. This is underlined by her use of home as a metaphor for nation when, in her maiden parliamentary speech, she proposed that "if I can invite whom I want into my home, then I should have the right to have a say in who comes into my country". (Madsen 19)

This rhetoric is both echoed and answered in John Howard's Federal election campaign policy launch speech of 28 October 2001: "we have a proud record of welcoming people from 140 different nations. But we will decide who comes to this country and the circumstances in which they come" (Politics 2001: online).

Although both Hanson and Howard were decried as racist by advocates of multiculturalism and charged with indulging in populist politics, it is clear that such rhetoric resonated with many 'ordinary' Australians. Hage notes that many Australians responded with wholehearted support for both Howard and Hanson, feeling that which he describes as a "neurotic sense of disempowerment" associated with the push for multiculturalism (WN 205). The largely imagined nature of this sense of White impotence, however,

¹⁵ This speech included the assertion: "I believe we are in danger of being swamped by Asians. Between 1984 and 1995, 40 per cent of all migrants coming into this country were of Asian origin. They have their own culture and religion, form ghettos and do not assimilate. Of course, I will be called racist but, if I can invite whom I want into my home, then I should have the right to have a say in who comes into my country". (Hanson, *Hansard* 10/09/1996, 3859)

does not invalidate the cultural insecurity attached to challenges to national identity.

This neurotic sense of disempowerment should not, however, allow us to dismiss the *actual* loss and disempowerment from which it has resulted. As far as cultural politics is concerned, whatever forms of inclusion and 'democracy' White cosmo-multiculturalism grants to ethnic people, it takes away from the more insular White working- and middle-class people who are perceived as unable, by definition, to appreciate and value otherness, let alone govern it. Indeed, deprived of the capacity of appreciating other ethnic cultures, and even with Anglo culture decreed as uninteresting and provincial by the multicultural order, those possessors of Angloness are left without even a stall at the multicultural fair. (Hage WN 205)

In such a charged political environment, refugee advocate Beth Gibbings notes in "Remembering the SIEV X" (2010), that:

Popular support for Hanson's extreme views shifted the public debate to the right, and allowed the conservative government, under Prime Minister John Howard, to take an increasingly hostile stand towards both Aboriginal people and asylum seekers. One result was the introduction in 1999 of a severe restriction on the rights of those people who had been recognized as refugees. (Gibbings 18)

Similar to the anti-intellectualism evident in the republican debate, pro-immigration and refugee advocacy became tied to the perception of intellectual elitism and often portrayed as the province of politically correct 'do-gooders'. It could be framed as an "attack on the core British values of traditional White Australia [...] where the figure of the ordinary 'mainstream' Australian, the 'traditional Aussie battler', is perceived as a victim of a conspiracy to change the very nature of the country" (Hage WN 20). Indeed, sociologist Katharine Betts argues that questions about "asylum seekers, defence and national security, terrorism, and immigration - bear on the

integrity of the nation, both at the symbolic level and in reality” (52). Clearly present in these debates is a disquiet over perceived challenges to Australia's traditional national identity, and this brings cultural tensions to the fore.

The Old Kingdom Chronicles were written in a period when these issues were increasingly at the forefront in national politics. Interestingly, *Lirael's* introduction to the Southerling refugee crisis is the only instance in the three novels where the South is referred to as the “Commonwealth of Ancelstierre”. This uses the structure of the title, the “Commonwealth of Australia”, and in doing so seems to subtly invite comparison. In an examination of the discourses circulating at this time, “Dog Whistles and Death Penalties” (2004), political analysts Murray Goot and Tim Sowerbutts speak of a divide in how the issues surrounding asylum seekers and immigration were framed. While talk-back radio and tabloid news produced examples of overt xenophobia and racism,¹⁶ Governmental opposition to asylum seekers, rather than employing a lexis which drew attention to ethnic difference, utilised suggestions of criminal activity and notions of inequity. It condemned ‘queue jumpers’, ‘people smugglers’ and ‘illegal immigration’ while avoiding mention of race or religion (Goot and Sowerbutts 5). In a rhetorical move that appealed to humanitarian values, policies of deterrence could be cast as protection for refugees, both from exploitation by the people smugglers, and from endangering themselves through risking perilous passages on unsafe boats.¹⁷ Asylum seeker advocates, however, saw

¹⁶ See Sara Wills: *Un-stitching the Lips of a Migrant Nation*”, pgs 80-83

¹⁷ See, for example, former Minister for Immigration Phillip Ruddock's comment that, if not for the governments hard-line approach, people smuggling would not have been curbed, and “we would have had people still sailing, we would have people still drowning and people who are not entitled to priority refugee claims getting resettled in Australia.”, “Tampa and all that, one year on”, *Sydney Morning Herald*, 27Aug 2002.

opposition to 'boat people' as "generated almost entirely by hostility to people from the Middle East" (Goot and Sowerbutts 3). The hard-line attitude to refugees was interpreted as populist, 'dog-whistle' politics, with the government playing the 'race card' (Goot and Sowerbutts 3).

The Old Kingdom Chronicles' inclusion of similar discourses gives an Australian inflection to the refugee issues addressed within the fantasy storyline. The novels present an obvious humanitarian argument against the hysteria and harshness rooted in xenophobia and racism. They make a similarly strong statement against the political exploitation of a fear of Otherness. This critique is centred on the character of Corolini, an Ancelstierran politician who has had a recent and surprising ascension in Ancelstierre's political realm. Ellimere, having left school in Ancelstierre only a year previous says Corolini's rise happened "after my time", while Sam could say by the time he left Ancelstierre that Corolini was regularly in the newspapers (Nix *Lir* 306). The naming of Corolini's 'Our Country' party has immediate resonance for the Australian reader, being suggestive of Pauline Hanson's 'One Nation' party. One Nation's meteoric rise provides another point of resemblance, as does the branding of Corolini as "a populist rabble-rouser" (*Lir* 163) within sections of the Ancelstierran press. Another similarity between 'Our Country' and 'One Nation' is that both groups seek political clout as a minor party through aspiring to the balance of power in government. Further similarity is discernible in the way both parties were able to pull other major political players further to the right of politics in matters of national identity and immigration.

Corolini's ascension to power is traced throughout the novels as he moves from being a mere demagogue to becoming someone who is able to exert significant influence on policy. The 'Our Country' party may have gained a foothold through "populist rubbish, pandering to the fears of the countryfolk" (*Lir* 295), but its power soon becomes disproportionate; as Touchstone notes: "Corolini and his party now hold the balance of power in the Ancelstierre Moot, they've been able to get the Southerlings [refugees] moved farther and farther north" (*Lir* 295).

Corolini's xenophobic rhetoric is able to stir protesting mobs, such as the surging crowd that attacked Touchstone and Sabriel in Corvere, "shouting, "Foreigners out!" and "Our Country!" The shouts were accompanied by bricks and stones" (*Abh* 8). Although *Abhorsen* was first published in 2003, there is, perhaps, a certain prescience in the novel's critique of politics that appeal to baser instincts and covertly incite hatred. Discourses such as those propagated by One Nation contributed to a cultural tension and environment in which incidents like the 2005 Cronulla riots could occur.¹⁸

Other images that resonate with an Australian reader are the text's references to hundreds of refugees arriving on boats, "packed aboard like

¹⁸ The Cronulla race riots occurred 11 December 2005 after a gathering of 5000 predominantly Anglo-Celtic people who were invited, via text, to reclaim 'their' beach from 'Middle-Eastern gangs' on behalf of 'Australians'. The *Reporting Diversity Project* notes that "they began with reports of the aftermath of the bashing of two volunteer lifesavers at Cronulla, a southern beachside suburb of Sydney. This followed ongoing tensions between Cronulla locals and visitors to the beach. On December 11, these tensions flared into what have been widely described as race riots, with violent confrontations between predominantly Anglo-European "Aussies" and predominantly Muslim "Lebs". The Cronulla riots sparked a wave of claims and counter-claims about responsibility for the violence and, more broadly, about the nature of race relations in Australia. Cronulla locals displayed varying responses, with some claiming that it was "about time" and that the riots were about "respect and pride" by white Australians; while others expressed shame and fear. Some differentiated between those involved in the rioting and the Lebanese community more generally. This range of responses reflected a similar scope of reactions from the community more generally". (Cronulla Riots (The) – The Sequence of Events online)

sardines" (*Lir* 162). This is despite surveillance and active measures of the "Navy and the Flying Corps to keep such trouble on the other side of the Sunder Sea", with many boats "turned back on the sea or at the major ports" (*Lir* 162). This form of border protection has a resemblance to that instituted by the Howard government, which approved practices such as turning back boats in international waters, refusing permission for boats carrying refugees to land at ports in Australian territories, and setting up the 'Pacific Solution' which led to the detention and processing of refugees by poorer Pacific nations such as Nauru and also Papua New Guinea "in return for large payments from the Australian government" (Clyne 180).

Correlations with the Australian refugee situation are also present in the forced internment of Southerling refugees while the "Ancestral government tried to work out how to send them back to their own countries" (Nix *Lir* 162). This is evident in the observation that every time a "mass deportment had been attempted, it had ended in hunger strikes, riots, and every form of possible protest" (*Lir* 162). This recalls situations such as the hunger-strikes and roof protests at the remote Australian detention centre at Woomera, particularly following rejection of a repatriation deal by Afghani refugees that would see many of them forcibly returned to the volatile situation from which they had fled (Skeers online). It evokes desperate measures such as suicides, self-harm, and the protests in which some "detainees in Woomera, Port Hedland, and Curtin sew[ed] their lips together" (Evans 167), graphically illustrating both a refusal to eat and their lack of voice. Similarly, Nix's image of thousands of "men in blue hats and women in blue scarves, and many children dressed completely in blue[...] throwing planks onto the concertina wire, forcing their way through and cutting where

they had to" (Nix *Abh* 261) recalls attempted breakouts from detention centres such as Woomera's "major Easter action in 2002 where Australian activists assisted over 50 detainees to pull down fences and escape" (Evans 164).

Much of the imagery *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* uses in describing the refugees and the crisis, however, is broad and generic rather than specific. It, therefore, resonates also with wider international concerns and with representations of peoples displaced by war across different times and spaces. Some of Nix's description is immediately evocative of more recent pictures of refugees in detention in remote locations in Australia such as Port Hedland and Woomera; centres which Christine Evans describes as "a vast prison complex ringed by five layers of razor wire, guarded by water cannon and patrolled 24 hours a day" (164). In *Lirael* many refugees had been:

given temporary refuge in what the *Corvere Times* described as "the remote northern regions of the nation," which clearly meant close to the Wall.

This must be one of the refugee settlements that had sprung up in the last three years, Sameth realized, noting that the field was surrounded by a triple fence of concertina wire and that there were several policemen near the gate. (Nix *Lir* 161)

Others passages evoke images of those displaced in the Great Wars of the twentieth century:

Hundreds of families. Grandparents, parents, children, babies. They all had the same scared look on their faces, and nearly everyone, no matter how old or small, was weighed down with suitcases, bags, and small bundles. Some had strange possessions, small machines

and metal objects that Lirael did not know but Sam recognized as sewing machines, phonographs, and typewriters. (Nix *Abh* 311)

In a broader sense, the refugee sub-plot within *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* participates in world-wide debates regarding the response to those displaced by war and adversity. The humanitarian undercurrents are evident in the texts' representation of the refugee issue. There is overt sympathy for the refugees' plight and censure of the way they are rejected or pushed out of sight either through turning them away from Ancelstierre's shores or through internment in remote camps. There is an awareness of the horror of war from which the refugees must be fleeing in order to take such great risks with their lives so as to escape.

There is even more overt censure of populist, dog-whistle, politics that feeds on fear of the Other and appeals to base hatreds. The condemnation of Corolini as a "dangerous egoist", happy to exploit the refugee situation, willing "to do anything to gain power", is unequivocal (*Lir* 163). The texts work on different levels, firstly to evoke empathy for the refugees and to demand a humanitarian response, and secondly, to condemn populist discourses of fear and hatred, particularly those utilised for political gain.

Nix's use of a medievalist secondary world as the setting for his story does not mean the events and the ideologies within the tale are detached from contemporary concerns. The novels contribute to current discourses and in many ways reflect the zeitgeist of the time and place of their production. Moreover, books set within the past, even one that is imagined, are able to

appropriate some of the authority vested in constructions of the past; they can evoke the weight of Lewis's, Tolkien's, and Morris's medieval Northernness in service of their own ideological concerns. But still, there is a complex exchange between modernity and the medieval which makes it difficult to completely escape hierarchies and assumptions embedded in appeals to the past. It is hard to escape the Whiteness implicit in Northernness, in ideas of blood and purity, and even in the power dynamics discernible in these texts' censuring of racism and championing of humanitarian refugee policies.

An analysis of *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, therefore, becomes problematic when considered within the frame of Whiteness. There is a way in which, while rejecting and censoring ethnic hatred and fear, the texts participate in contributing to the hegemonic privilege of Anglo-Celtic power. In *White Nation* Ghassan Hage considers the divide between what he ironically labels 'evil white nationalists' and 'good white nationalists'. He observes that whether nationalist imaginings are expressed as aggression and exclusion, or expressed as tolerant multiculturalism, in both of these formations the cultural power still resides in the hands of Anglo-Celtic Australia. He suggests that both these positions share "the same imaginary position of power within a nation imagined as 'theirs'. In fact, they enact the same White nation fantasy" (WN 79). *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* reflect this presumption of authority. While the text condemns aggression and exclusion, it assumes a position of power in order to practice tolerance and acceptance. As Hage argues in an earlier paper, "Anglo-Celtics Today: Cosmo-Multiculturalism and the Phase of the Fading Phallus" (AT), Australia's

multicultural “discourse of tolerance still presupposes a dominant Anglo-Celtic centre” (AT 62).

Hage uses Pierre Bourdieu’s notions of cultural capital to introduce a discussion of an Australian ‘national aristocracy’, where the ‘aristocracy’ not only holds cultural capital, but they “*naturalise their hold on it*” (AT 46). To feel one has a place in a nation, Hage argues, there must be a sense of not only “*homely belonging*”, the ability to feel that one ‘fits in’, but also of “*governmental belonging*” which gives the possessor a “right to contribute (even if by only having a legitimate opinion with regards to internal and external politics of the nation) such as it remains ‘one’s home’” (AT 48-49). Becoming a member of the national aristocracy, therefore, entails achieving dominance through being able to see oneself as “the natural, disinterested protector and guardian of an equally natural national order” (Hage AT 50). Though clearly benevolent, the Old Kingdom’s royalty, Clayr and Abhorsen exude this sense of naturalised power.

There is a strong implication that those in the North understand what is best for the refugees, even above the refugees themselves. Because of the North’s understanding, their concern over the entry of Southerling refugees differs from that of Ancelstierre. The Old Kingdom’s response is situated in humanitarian concerns for the wellbeing and protection of the refugees, where Ancelstierre’s response is founded upon hysteria and xenophobia. This is seen in Sam’s immediate response when Nicholas informs him: “Uncle Edward says that Corolini chap wants to send the Southerlings into your neck of the woods [...] Across the Wall. No room for them here, he says, and lots of room in the Old Kingdom”. Sam’s reply is that Corolini

“doesn’t know what he’s talking about. They would all die in the Borderlands. It’s not safe” (*Lir* 163).

The argument that it would be dangerous to send the refugees to the Old Kingdom is not simply one that appeals to the refugees’ physical safety; it also suggests that refugees would find it difficult to process the culture shock of living in a land in which magic exists. This can be seen in the dying Southerling man’s horrified reaction to Lirael trying to heal him with Charter magic. A simple movement of her hand evokes the response: “No! The Evil!”, as he attempts to escape Sam’s supporting hold. This is despite the Charter magic being “golden light” and “clear and bright” (*Lir* 547). Given the disjunction between Southerling (dis)belief in magic and Old Kingdom realities, Sam observes: “It must have been terrible for them when they crossed the Wall” (*Lir* 546-547). Although expressed as an informed concern for the mental well-being of the Southerlings, there is an underlying apprehension that the Southerlings would be unable to adapt to life in the North; that, given the fundamental difference in the way they perceive the world, they would never have access to even a ‘homely belonging’ in the Old Kingdom.

Such an apprehension also presupposes a generic Otherness. Although the refugees’ plight is empathetically represented, within the novels the Southerlings are seen as a mass; rarely, if at all, as individuals. None is given a name and not one appears in more than a passing fashion. Separated from the continent that is home to the Old Kingdom and Ancelstierre by the aptly named ‘Sunder Sea’, the names of the far South states from which the refugees are fleeing – Iskeria, Kalarime, Iznenia, and

Korrovia – also have a broadly generic alien quality, suggesting something of Eastern Europe or the Middle East in their tone. The texts' description of the refugees also leads the reader to see the Southerlings as a group rather than individuals. The issue of different ethnicity is side-stepped by the lack of particular physical descriptors. Apart from one boy who is seen to be fair-haired (*Lir* 544), Southerlings are generally distinguished by their national dress: "Nearly all of them had blue headscarves or hats, identifying them as Southerling refugees" (*Lir* 161). Although the issue of religion is not foregrounded in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, the images of women in headscarves are instantly evocative of Islam. At the very least, an Otherness in belief is tacit in the very different metaphysical perspective of the Southerlings; as Sam explains to Lirael, "They don't believe in magic, even the superstitions the Ancelstierrans believe in, let alone our magic" (*Lir* 547).

As the Southerlings are most clearly marked as 'Other' by their national dress, the Greater Dead's exploitation and abuse of the Southerling refugees can be clearly signalled through utilising the motif of blue. It is immediately evident that many refugees have been killed to become Dead minions, as they "wore the remnants of blue scarves and blue hats" (*Lir* 421). Such imagery is oft repeated: "In the cool light he saw that many of the slain people wore blue hats or scarves. A scrap of blue material was caught in the claws of one of the Dead that Lirael had banished with her pipes" (*Lir* 543-544); "piles of corpses, bodies everywhere, bodies hanging on the wire and piled on the ground. They were all blue capped and blue scarved (*Abh* 271).

Although the blue hats and scarves perform the purpose of instantly distinguishing the refugees within the texts' narrative, this too works to

present the refugees as an homogenous whole rather than as individual people. This is despite the refugees coming from four different states, and despite mentions of warring rebel, traditionalist, anarchist, and imperialist factions in the far South (*Lir* 161-162). There are occasional glimpses given of individuals, such as the Southerling matriarch with whom Sam negotiates settlement (*Abh* 338-340) the dead fair-haired boy (*Lir* 544) and the dying man who provides proof of the deceit, the treachery, and the horror enacted against the Southerling refugees before he, perhaps conveniently, succumbs (*Lir* 547-548). Rather than three-dimensional characters, these individuals are almost cursory asides within the book, primarily serving a narrative purpose within the story.

Even so, the texts empathetically represent refugees and demonstrate an understanding sympathy for their plight. Pertinently, it is the Old Kingdom that ultimately offers refuge to the Southerlings. Just as the refugees' safety motivated negotiations to prevent the movement of Southerling refugees to the North, their safety becomes the central driver in the offer of land in the Old Kingdom. This, however, evidences a certain paternalism toward the refugees, with Sam taking up the mantle of 'Prince Sameth', assuming the natural, aristocratic position of "disinterested protector and guardian" (Hage AT 50) of both those seeking refuge and of his national values:

'Southerlings! Friends! Do not go beyond the western ridge! Only death awaits you there! Do not believe the papers you hold—they offer only lies! I am Prince Sameth of the Old Kingdom, and I promise to give land and farms to everyone who stays in the valley! If you stay in the valley, you will be given farms and land beyond the Wall!' (Nix *Abh* 316).

Moreover, Sameth demonstrates a naturalised authority apart from his position as prince. Sam shows himself to be cosmopolitan enough to appreciate and understand the Otherness of the Southerlings. He is Old Kingdom royalty, educated in the traditions of the north and in the power of the Charter; he is the product of both royalty and Abhorsen. Sam also has experience and understanding of Ancelstierre through the time he has spent in the South during his schooling. He has mixed with those with entrenched power in Ancelstierre, his best friend being nephew to the Chief Minister. Indeed, his privilege extends beyond his position as prince.

For all his casual humility, Sameth fits the profile of what Ghassen Hage calls the 'cosmopolite':

The cosmopolite is a *class* (and classy) figure *and* western (or a culturally *and physically* westernised person), capable of appreciating and consuming 'high quality' commodities and cultures, including 'ethnic' culture. (Hage AT 63)

It is Sameth's ability to understand and appreciate Otherness that enables him to act as both protector and benefactor of the Southerlings. He demonstrates "cultural competence", being able to appreciate "ethnic cultural diversity" (Hage AT 64). Sam shows himself different from the ignorant "countryfolk" who Corolini is able to incite by appealing to their fears and anxieties (*Lir* 295). It is his ability to recognise, appreciate, and work within the Southerlings' own cultural framework (albeit for his own ends as well as theirs) that precipitates Sam's successful negotiations to have the Southerlings retreat into safety in order to secure land:

[Sam] was struck by a sudden thought. The group was led by an ancient matriarch, white haired and much better dressed than everyone around her. She was also supported by several younger

men and women. It was the only group that was not obviously a family, without children and without baggage. The matriarch was the leader, Sam thought. He knew that much about the Southerlings. Someone who might be able to turn back the human tide. (Nix *Abh* 320-321)

Sam's willingness to accept this Otherness is further demonstrated by his quick preparedness to participate in Southerling rites in order to prove his authenticity, acceding to the matriarch's request that he promise on his blood. He demonstrates grace in allowing his blood to be drawn and mingled with that of the matriarch (*Abh* 340). This mingling of blood demonstrates a symbolic joining of the Southerlings and those of the Old Kingdom, but it simultaneously represents the matriarch's acquiescence to Sameth's authority within the North.

The North's acceptance of the refugees demonstrates a power dynamic that naturalises the authority of the Old Kingdom, and the Old Kingdom symbolically remains strongly attached to Anglo-Celtic identity. For all the chaos at this point in the novel, it is still Prince Sameth who has the power to practise a national understanding, generosity and tolerance. Certainly, Sam's actions come from a humanitarian position, and he is motivated by a genuine concern for the well-being of both the Old Kingdom and the Southerling refugees. In this dynamic, however, power is naturalised and imbedded in the Anglo-Celtic North. Tolerance can be seen as a "strategy aimed at reproducing and disguising relationships of power in society, or being reproduced through that disguise" as a mode in which "domination is presented as a form of egalitarianism" (Hage *WN* 87). These texts overtly censure populist politics that feed on cultural anxieties and fears, but they also implicitly present a naturalised Anglo-Celtic centre of power.

This examination demonstrates how difficult it is for texts and discourses alike to escape from entrenched and hierarchical paradigms of power. Even overt challenges to cruelty, racism and xenophobia can paradoxically or unintentionally reinforce and naturalise hegemonic Western power. While the medievalist royal structure of the North serves to make the power dynamics within these texts more obvious, it can also make them more natural. The motifs of sacrifice, of protection, and destiny work to further obscure issues of privilege and power with *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*. Chapter 5 will consider gender dynamics in the novels; another area where traditional paradigms of power continue to exert a strong, naturalised pressure.

Chapter 5

Heroines and Heroes

Chapter 2 discussed the affective cultural power available to imaginings of the past and Chapters 3 and 4 considered how this cultural power is utilised in constructions of national identity, class and ethnicity. This chapter will consider how *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* represent gender within the context of a medievalised past. It explores whether a nostalgic appeal to the past necessarily leads to conservatism and the confirmation of traditional, patriarchal paradigms of power. Through an examination of the coming-of-age stories of both male and female protagonists this chapter will discuss ways in which these texts might conform to, subvert or challenge expectation in regard to gender roles. It will discuss the effect of Sabriel and Lirael's central heroic roles within the novels, and of the supporting roles of Touchstone and Sameth. It will consider the manner in which *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* mediate between the comparative influence of longstanding gender paradigms within literature and the influence of contemporary ideologies that aspire to gender equity.

As discussed in Chapter 1, Brian Attebery argues that an employment of traditional storytelling forms, patterns, and markers can easily entail an acceptance of conservative class and gender structures. Attebery asserts that traditional storytelling paradigms, particularly within coming of age fantasies, typically employ separate archetypal approaches for male and female protagonists. To discuss the hero's journey he points to the works of folklorist Vladimir Propp and mythologist Joseph Campbell, positing that the traditional rite of passage for a male is that of *displacement*, *transformation* and *return* (Attebery 87). To discuss the traditional heroine's journey he appeals to anthropologist Bruce Lincoln's pattern of *enclosure*, *metamorphosis* and *emergence* (Attebery 90).

Traditional paradigms hold a discursive strength that makes them difficult to challenge. Within *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, however, the journeys of the heroes and heroines are not clearly delineated by gender. Nevertheless, the texts do not so much repudiate archetypal representations as complicate them; sometimes appearing to conform, sometimes shifting slightly, and sometimes seeming to reverse gender expectation. This provides an example of blending the comfort of familiarity and the surprise of difference within genre fantasy. Given both *Sabriel* and *Lirael* can be seen as coming of age tales, it is not surprising that these heroines' journeys, at least superficially, can be made to fit within Lincoln's model of enclosure, metamorphosis and emergence. For much of her childhood Sabriel is sheltered in a protected boarding school in northern Ancelstierre. This enclosure offers protection from the malevolent forces growing in power in the Old Kingdom. It is revealed, too, that Sabriel's confinement at Wyverley is, in part, directed by destiny. It responds to the Clayr's foreknowledge that,

for the sake of the Old Kingdom, she would require a detailed geographical and cultural understanding of Ancelstierre.

Sabriel's enclosure at school is also, paradoxically, intended to give her greater freedom. Her father explains to her that safety in the Old Kingdom could have only been assured by keeping her "practically a prisoner" in the Abhorsen house (Nix *Sab* 297). Her sequestration at Wyverley, therefore, provides her with a less secluded childhood than life in the Old Kingdom could have offered. Pertinently, too, Sabriel has access to a particular form of freedom associated with her necromantic calling. Although her body remains fixed in Ancelstierre, the Abhorsen training she receives allows her spirit to travel within the precincts of Death. Consequently, Sabriel's 'enclosure' can be seen as both a 'shutting out' and an 'opening up'. Her experience at Wyverley ultimately broadens her knowledge and life experience, and this proves crucial to the protection and prosperity of her homeland. While Sabriel's experience in many ways corresponds to Lincoln's first step of enclosure, this is not without ambiguity or complexity.

A simple alignment of Sabriel's journey with Lincoln's model is further complicated by the ways in which her story also fits with the masculine paradigm of a hero's journey. Displacement is initially seen as she leaves the Old Kingdom to reside in Ancelstierre. It is even more clearly identifiable when she subsequently leaves Wyverley to participate in a literal and physical quest within the Old Kingdom.

There is a similar complexity in the narrative of Lirael's heroic journey. As one of the sisterhood of the Clayr, Lirael's childhood is spent in enclosure. All the seers of the Old Kingdom live in the mountain at Starmount Glacier, separate to the general population of the villages and few remaining cities of the northern Kingdom. They not only live apart from society, but often, in a sense, also apart from time – confusing present past and future because of their visions. Their experience of outside the Clayr's community is primarily through revelations, seen in visions and in the mirror of their glacier. Some higher-ranking Clayr do, however, have regular communication with their 'cousins', the Abhorsen and royalty.

It is significant that the Clayr's seclusion is not externally imposed. It is not the consequence of patriarchal or societal oppression, nor is it a means of withdrawal or escape. It is, rather, due to the Clayr's essential relationship with their glacier. It is firmly attached to their visionary calling. Regardless of how isolating and removed the Clayr's life might be from conventional experience, this sequestered existence allows access, through vision, to a world unconstrained by special and temporal limitations. Consequently, once again, this enclosure can be seen as both a 'shutting in' and as an 'opening up'.

Lirael's seclusion is even greater than that of the typical Clayr, as she is isolated even from her own community. This separation is partly self-imposed, and partly due to real and discernible differences between Lirael and the rest of the Clayr. Her difference is not merely the contrast of her pale skin and dark hair with the Clayrs' fair hair and tanned complexions. Lirael's parentage is in question as her late mother eschewed tradition, leaving the

glacier “to travel who knew where, only to return seven months gone with child” (*Lir* 13). Lirael was effectively orphaned at the age of five when her mother left the glacier never to return. Lirael’s isolation, moreover, increases as she enters her teen years without receipt of the sight. She is, therefore, physically and socially misfitted, and perceives herself as singularly ungifted. The reader, however, is able to recognise Lirael’s physical characteristics as those peculiar to the Abhorsen, and can, therefore, draw inferences regarding Lirael’s paternity and the direction in which Lirael’s giftedness might truly lie.

As is the case with Sabriel, Lirael’s ‘enclosure’ is paradoxically also a means of freedom. Her assignment to work in the Clayr library (a further symbol of quiet seclusion) provides access to a reservoir of knowledge in the form of texts, both magical and non-magical. Even more than this, Lirael’s natural aptitude as a Charter Mage allows her to ‘awaken’ forbidden keys within her Charter spelled bracelet. This grants her admission to the labyrinth of library corridors and to rooms deep within the heart of the Clayr’s mountain, leading to Lirael experiencing many dangers, including cursed books and Free Magic creatures. As with Sabriel, that which equates to enclosure and that which equates to freedom become confused.

Lirael’s ‘enclosure’ in the library is also the means through which she meets her sole friend and confidante, the Disreputable Dog. Lirael’s exposure to the incorrigible Dog, who constantly encourages a certain restless exploration in her, means that Lirael’s isolation within her community does not equate to a sheltered or protected existence. As with Sabriel, aspects of Lirael’s story also conform to the male archetypal hero’s journey. There is ‘displacement’

as she physically must leave the mountain glacier in order to fulfil her heroic destiny, 'transformation' as she takes up the mantle of Abhorsen-in-Waiting, and her 'return' to her rightful place in the Kingdom.

Sabriel's and Lirael's personal stories, however, can still be pressed into the mould where enclosure gives way to metamorphosis and emergence. Development and maturity are evidenced as these young women come to an acceptance of their heroic destinies. The awakenings they experience are less a rejection of external constraints and repressive expectations, and more an acceptance of their essential beings and destined place.

The male protagonists of *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, pertinently, can also be seen to undergo a process of enclosure, metamorphosis and emergence similar to that of the heroines. Touchstone experiences enclosure in a literal manner, akin to that which is endured by Snow White and Sleeping Beauty, as he is magically entrapped in a ship's figurehead, his soul in stasis just within the borders of death. Prince Sameth's life too, is not particularly distinguished by masculine rites. It initially follows the same route travelled by his mother, Sabriel, and sister, Ellimere. Like them, he attends boarding school in Ancelstierre prior to facing the challenges which lead to his 'metamorphosis' and 'emergence'. Pertinently, he ultimately emerges not to the adventurous and active life that he has been long expected to embrace, but to a happily enclosed life in his tower room workshop living out his essential calling as a Wallmaker. The male pattern of a hero's journey can also be laid across his experiences, but Sam's displacement represents more a running away from responsibility than the more generically depicted quest for freedom and adventure. Like the females within the novels, Sam's

passage to adulthood is not clearly delineated along archetypal gender lines. The journeys of Nix's protagonists are not uncomplicated; all might be seen to simultaneously conform to and push against traditional gendered models of coming of age rites.

Jane Tolmie's 2006 essay, "Medievalism and the Fantasy Heroine" provides another model through which to consider the representation of women in genre fantasy. She observes that a great deal of fantasy fiction with female protagonists centre "on the individual woman rising above a system that keeps her down [. . .] reversing expectations" (147). The exceptional heroine stands out from her female counterparts through being actively "independent, strong, feisty and passionate", but in a context where feminine passivity is the rule (Tolmie 146). Although fantasy provides a clear space for strong female characters, the strength of the trope of exceptionality can ironically serve to naturalise feminine weakness and submissiveness. The assertive, self-sufficient woman, argues Tolmie, is shown to be anomalous and different from 'normal' women. Paradoxically, even while the active woman is lauded within a story, there is a simultaneous confirmation of traditional female archetypes, as 'natural' femininity becomes aligned with conformity and passivity.

The characters of Sabriel and Lirael conform to the pattern of strong, active heroines. Significantly, however, within the context of *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, unlike the fantasy novels discussed by Tolmie, it is not exceptional that women should take on these active heroic roles. Within the secondary reality of the Old Kingdom the fact that Sabriel and Lirael are female is neither remarkable nor unnatural. Although both women may be

seen as extraordinary in differing ways, this is not premised upon any breach of gender expectation. Neither heroine suffers any gender-specific prejudices, hardships or oppressions like those Tolmie identifies as conventionally faced by female fantasy protagonists. They do not “dress up as men to escape restraints on their freedom, run away from abusive fathers, escape unwanted marriages, avoid, avert, or survive rape” (148).

In the Old Kingdom the idea of female warriors, rulers and Abhorsen is quietly naturalised. This is not simply a matter of caste and destiny. Even amongst those not of the Blood, women with active roles and power are easily found within the text; indeed, female royal guards and Charter Mages appear common, and there is mention that at least the last regent was female. Instances of active female participation are woven into Nix’s text without fanfare or particular comment on gender. The simple use of a feminine pronoun, for example, marks the gender of the Abhorsen who designed the first Paperwing (a light aircraft): “The Abhorsen who made it once flew it to the sea and back in a single afternoon. But she was a great weather-witch and could work the winds” (Nix *Sab* 137). Wallmakers, too, were both male and female, as Touchstone refers to the forger of his and Sabriel’s ‘ensorcelled’ swords as “he—or she” (*Sab* 226).

Many other mentions of females serving in what might conservatively be seen as ‘male’ roles are scattered throughout the novels. The sacrificed Charter Mage in the village of Nestowe is a woman (*Sab* 207). Sabriel, Lirael, Princess Ellimere and all Clayr are among the many other female Charter Mages in the Kingdom. The Royal Guard accompanying King Touchstone is described as “twoscore tall men and women” (*Lir* 320). With

the escalating threat to the Kingdom, Ellimere is prepared to increase her martial role. She notes to Sam: "I shall be spending more time with the Guard myself. Getting ready" (*Lir* 318). One of Sameth's regular guards is Tonin: "She was the same age as Ellimere, and they had been friends since they had played together as children" (*Lir* 323). Moreover, males are not privileged above females in matters of inheritance. There is a clear expectation that Princess Ellimere will inherit the throne above her younger brother Sameth. Pertinently, this is not due to her position as firstborn, but is the result of her aptitude for organisation and governance, because she is "demonstrably the perfect royal heir" (*Lir* 278).

Within the supernatural realm too, both good and evil have representatives of both genders. Oriannis the Destroyer's key necromantic henchmen are Hedge, a man, and Chlorr of the Mask, a woman. Of the remnants of the 'eight bright shiners' specifically mentioned within the story, Mogget (Yrael) is male and The Dog (Kibeth) is female. Astarael, the remnant of whom they encounter deep beneath the well at the Abhorsen's house, is not only female but she is the most powerful and frightening of these former deities (*Abh* 52-53).

The ever-changing Charter sendings present another interesting portrayal of gender within the northern kingdom. Each individual sending is made up of constantly moving Charter marks, meaning the sendings exist in a ceaseless state of change. The first sending Sabriel meets displays this constant state of flux in identity and gender. Sabriel notes the sending's "face wouldn't stay fixed, migrating between scores of possibilities. Some were men, some were

women, but they all bore tough, competent visages" (*Sab* 89). Within these magical creations gender is present, but it is by no means fixed or essential.

The clear understanding that Sabriel and Lirael are acting according to their destined roles further naturalises the Old Kingdom's images of assertive and active women. Within the novels, their behaviour is affirmed by the Charter. This has the effect of placing their conduct beyond reproach. Rather than being unnatural, their actions become unquestionably appropriate. Similarly, as will be discussed later in this chapter, the Charter confirms Sameth's withdrawal from a more athletic, physical sphere of activity, allowing him, as a male, to retreat to a realm of quieter creativity without censure.

Such portrayals are not merely curious diversions from archetypal gender characterisations. They have a discursive power that is further enhanced by the affective imagery and cultural weight attached to imaginings of heritage and the Middle Ages. In making female heroism unexceptional within a medieval setting, Nix's novels claim a retrospective authority for active female agency. Within the context of the novels, acceptance of gender equity becomes aligned with antiquity and confirmed through the essence of authenticity, magic and substance that is strongly associated with Northernness.

In comparison with the North, Ancelstierre reveals itself to be less enlightened and less inclusive than the medieval Old Kingdom. The gender divisions discernible in the modern nation of Ancelstierre show a limited range of roles and behaviour deemed appropriate for women. Indeed,

references to those with power in the South speak of men. The Sayres, Dawforth and Corolini, all influential politicians specifically mentioned within the text, are all men (*Abh* 5). The South's military too, appears completely male. Colonel Horyse's border guards are referred to as his "men" (*Sab* 51). Indeed, when Lirael and Sam have an urgent need to cross the border Sam disguises them with a magical 'glamour' as "an officer and sergeant from the Crossing Point Scouts" (*Abh* 211). Lirael's male disguise includes a bandaged head wound which prohibits her from speaking so her voice will not give away that she is a woman and expose them.

Nix's tale, "Nicholas Sayre and the Creature in The Case", also portrays Ancelstierre as a society where females have little access to power. The first of the short stories in his book *Across the Wall* (*AW*), this tale is a sequel of sorts to *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*. It offers "various bits and pieces of information about Ancelstierre" and gives a "glimpse of the people, customs, government, technology and landscape of Ancelstierre" (Nix *AW* 4). Early in the story the reader is introduced to Nicholas' uncle, "The Most Honorable Edward, Sayre, Chief Minister of Ancelstierre" (*AW* 6). There are mentions of Lewis, Ancelstierre's Hereditary Arbiter (*AW* 7), Nicholas' father, a politician (*AW* 12), and Dorrance, the head of Department Thirteen, known as D13, Ancelstierre's international intelligence agency (*AW* 10). This sets the tone for the rest of this tale in which not one of the Ancelstierran persons of influence mentioned in the text is female. The scientists, the agents, and government representatives, such as Sergeant Hodgeman (*AW* 14), Professor Lackridge (*AW* 18), Constable Ripton (*AW* 34) and D13's foot-soldiers are all male. The Ancelstierran women who appear in this story are either servants (*AW* 64) or mere beautiful decoration, such as the one used

to gain access to Nicholas's room – “[p]robably a not very successful actor or singer, the usual adornments of typical country house parties” (AW 43). These women stand in marked contrast to Lirael who arrives from the North at the end of this story to subdue the Free Magic creature of the tale's title (now escaped from her case), and to assist Nicholas' escape to the Old Kingdom.

As a Northerner schooled in Ancelstierre, Sabriel is situated between two views of womanhood. Her choices regarding to which of these she should conform become integral to Sabriel's emergence, her quest, and her coming into maturity. Wyverley, Sabriel's school, proclaims it caters for “Young Ladies of Quality” (*Sab* 12). There are distinct expectations concerning the attributes and manners which mark young ladies as ‘superior’. Proper conduct is ingrained in the girls' education, so much so that the words of her Etiquette teacher, Miss Prionte, often appear as Sabriel's first line of defence or offence when faced with challenging circumstances. Confronted by the officious young soldier at the border crossing, Sabriel employs a quiet tone and confident stare “in the manner which Miss Prionte had taught her girls to instruct lesser domestic servants in Etiquette IV” (*Sab* 31). She answers the soldier's continued questioning with a “frosty smile (also part of Miss Prionte's curriculum)” (*Sab* 32). Her quick resort to such manners demonstrates how learned behaviour can become instinctive, and appear right and natural.

Unsurprisingly then, Southern social conventions of feminine behaviour exert a pressure upon Sabriel. They inform her conflicted state of mind as she vacillates over whether to embrace her destiny as heir to the position of

Abhorsen, or whether to pursue a 'normal' life in Ancelstierre. Prior to discovering that her father is trapped in Death, Sabriel, like a typical seventeen-year-old girl finishing her schooling, is grappling with choices regarding her future. Should she go on to university? This would mean staying in Ancelstierre, remaining closer to friends, enjoying girlish and frivolous social dealings and meeting young men, but it would also mean her magic would wane (*Sab* 16). Should she, alternatively, return to the Old Kingdom? This would mean accepting the role of necromancer and being tied to protecting the North by keeping the Dead dead.

Just short of completing her final year at school, these are the considerations on Sabriel's mind as she waits in her study in expectation of a magical visitation from her father. She is faced with a choice between a role that fits within the Ancelstierran conventions of 'proper' womanhood, and a calling that would be considered anything but 'lady-like' by Miss Priorite. The semiotics of this portion of the text are particularly apt. The formal study in which Sabriel waits is indicative of security and privilege. It is recognition of the maturity and the responsibility she has as one of Wyverley's seniors and prefects. Sabriel is shown drinking from a china teacup, an image which evokes notions of refinement and domesticity. The teacup, however, is precariously balanced on the arm of the chair, hinting at the instability of this cultured normality (*Sab* 17). The unease Sabriel begins to feel at her father's continued absence also forebodes a shattering of this precarious peace (*Sab* 17).

The huge gulf between the two roads that are open to Sabriel is exposed by the contrast between the homely scene in the study and the danger that

awaits her. A Dead creature threatens the First Form girls' dormitory, breaking all illusion of security. Startled by the cry for help from Olwyn, one of the younger students, Sabriel manages to catch the teacup she has upset, symbolically still holding to the refined model of behaviour (*Sab* 17). On beginning to comprehend the situation, however, Sabriel reacts in what might be read as a decisive metaphorical rejection of the expectations attached to being a 'young lady of quality':

Sabriel threw the teacup aside and pushed past Olwyn. She was already half way down the corridor before she heard the porcelain smash behind her, and Olwyn's horrified gasp at such cavalier treatment of good china. She ignored it and broke into a run[...]. (Nix *Sab* 18).

Paradoxically, this passage implies both choice and fate. Sabriel is not compelled by these circumstances to run to danger. As a student she could have appealed for the help of teachers. Sabriel, however, assumes the role of protector as though it belongs to her alone. Her instinctive reaction suggests her destined role as Abhorsen is natural, essential and intuitive. Her response stands in contrast to the Ancelstierran model of refined, passive femininity represented by the formal study and the china tea cup. Sabriel's choice of the active over the passive adds to the texts' many affirmations of Northern ways above the ways of the South. In a reciprocal way, the value that is attached to Northernness provides affirmation of active female participation and agency.

The relationship between Sabriel and Touchstone provides another pertinent example of how *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* unsettle traditional gender

paradigms. Sabriel's awakening of Touchstone, and her releasing him from the figurehead of the ship in which he is trapped, begins this process. Most obviously this represents an ostensible gender reversal of the rescues within classic fairy tales such as *Sleeping Beauty* and *Snow White*, upsetting the generic trope of a man acting as the catalyst for female transformation. Sabriel takes the active role and Touchstone the passive. There are, however, subtle differences in the dynamics attached to these fairy-tale rescues and Sabriel's liberation of Touchstone.

Conforming to the pattern in many fairy tales, Touchstone is discovered in a mysterious, unnatural, and eerie environment. He is imprisoned within the figurehead of a royal funerary ship, hidden far from the ocean, in a "strange harbour". This 'harbour' is a deep sinkhole, protected both from sight and trespass by a "gleaming web-thin net" which, despite its fragile appearance, is of "considerable strength" (*Sab* 164-65). The uncanny, magical setting creates an aura of arcane substance, of awe; a boding that something of consequence is present or at least imminent. The generic familiarity of such imagery evokes the 'perilous realms' of Faerie. It carries with it the weight of countless stories that have come before. This grounds this episode in fantasy and fairy tale, but the inversion of gender roles creates an unexpected difference.

Rather than having the prince gazing upon the enchanted princess, offered for the visual pleasure of the rescuer and reader, here we have Sabriel gazing upon the displayed prince. Instead of falling in love at first sight, however, Sabriel is unsettled. She is quite discomfited by the figurehead, "a naked young man, carved in perfect detail", leaving her blushing due to its

life-like exactness (*Sab* 166). The description of Sabriel's initial examination indicates a sense of shame attached to her gaze, particularly when noting even a "circumcised penis, which Sabriel looked at in an embarrassed way before looking back at his face" (*Sab* 167). Despite this self-consciousness, Sabriel's gaze and thoughts demonstrate an awkward sexual objectification of Touchstone's body. His "muscles were lean and well formed"... his "hands well shaped and elegant"...his face "not exactly handsome, but not displeasing" (*Sab* 166-67).

Sabriel's perusal of Touchstone superficially appears as an inversion of the gender dynamics of 'the gaze', most notably theorised in Laura Mulvey's 1975 "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema". Mulvey discussed the 'male gaze' within the context of the Hollywood action genre, but the gaze has since received attention within more diverse areas of study. Clifford Manlove provides a useful summary of this as he observes that:

"Gaze theory" has also made its way into literary and cultural studies, queer theory, postcolonial studies, Holocaust studies, black/whiteness studies, and critical race theory. In most cases, the gaze is used to help explain the hierarchical power relations between two or more groups or, alternatively, between a group and an "object." (Manlove 84)

Indeed, the dynamics attached to looking are also exemplified in fairy tales like Sleeping Beauty and Snow White where passive women are displayed to the active male gaze. A great deal of scholarship has focussed upon exceptions to the inflexible structure of Mulvey's theory which argues the strength of patriarchy places all power with the man as voyeur and situates the woman as the object of man's controlling gaze. Cultural studies theorist

Richard Dyer, however, argues for gaze theory's continued relevance, saying it is important to:

explore the complex interplay of power in looking and at being looked at, above all in terms of who controls these relations, who has the right to look unchallenged, uninterrupted and unembarrassed, who controls the conditions under which they are looked at. (Dyer, 227)

Although Touchstone can be seen “displayed” in such a way that his appearance seems “coded for strong erotic impact” (Mulvey 19), Sabriel certainly does not feel the right to “look unembarrassed”. Neither, it seems, does she have the right to look “unchallenged and uninterrupted” (Dyer 227). Mogget slyly mocks her gaze at the sleeping Touchstone after his rescue – “I can get a blanket if you want to keep staring at him” (Nix *Sab* 176). Whilst Touchstone appears physically objectified, Sabriel's gaze is not free from a sense of shameful awkwardness. When Sabriel's interest, however, shifts to a ‘professional’ one (if one can call necromancy a ‘profession’), there is no sense of shame attached to a more thorough and examining gaze. When Sabriel gives attention to her magical intuition and the feeling that the figurehead is more than an intricate carving, she is able to look without embarrassment, “carefully examining him from every angle. The man's body was an intellectual problem now” (*Sab* 167).

Paradoxically, Sabriel experiences shame in looking at what she initially thinks is a work of art, but loses inhibition when she begins to understand the figure as a person. She recognises Touchstone's humanity in his expression containing shock, fear, betrayal and even a little madness – too real “to be the result of a woodcarver's skills” (*Sab* 167). This suggests that shame in looking attaches to the act of objectification rather than to the gaze itself. A

recognition of humanity allows Sabriel to see Touchstone as something apart from an object. This provides a subtle critique of superficial judgement and objectification based upon appearance rather than individual character.

Significantly too, and divergent from fairy-tale patterns, Sabriel's liberation of Touchstone is not spurred by notions of love or any desire to win the prize of a beautiful lover. It is prompted by the sense of an "injustice to be righted" and a perceived duty to "remedy unnatural necromancy and Free Magic sorcery" (*Sab* 169). Touchstone's rescue also requires much more than a kiss or the dislodgment of a poisoned apple; Sabriel needs to retrieve his soul from the borders of Death and, even for an Abhorsen, entering Death always entails danger. Touchstone's deliverance involves necromantic expertise, physical strength and determination. Sabriel is required to heave Touchstone's crystallised spirit through the strong currents of Death's river. She performs this task whilst escaping the threat of a lurking Dead thing that bears the medievalised form of a monster looking "like a cross between a hog and a segmented worm" (*Sab* 172). The act of deliverance combines both action and personal risk. The heroine, through skill and physical exertion, is the sole agent of Touchstone's restoration to Life. The hero's role, conversely, is an atypically passive one, even to the point where he collapses into the heroine's arms (*Sab* 175).

While Touchstone's rescue seems to represent a reversal of gender dynamics, the text demonstrates that which Dyer refers to as a more 'complex interplay of power' (Dwyer 227). Although Sabriel is the owner of the gaze and, within the active/passive binary, she plays the active role, an inversion of Mulvey's paradigm falls short as Sabriel's behaviour is not

motivated by a desire for control. The rescue, however, does answer certain of her fears, allowing her to reassure herself through positive action: “for the first time since she crossed the Wall, Sabriel felt there was a clear-cut problem for her to solve” (Nix *Sab* 169). Sabriel’s own refusal to see Touchstone merely as a sexual object alters the dynamics attached to the gaze within this story, representing an ambiguity in portrayals of gender and power.

This ambiguity is further reinforced at this point by a change in narrative perspective. Although *Sabriel* is narrated through a third person omniscient voice, Nix has thus far remained close to Sabriel’s perspective. Focalisation through the character of Sabriel works to privilege her perceptions, making her the agent through which the audience understands and interprets the action within the novel. Significantly, the passage immediately following Touchstone’s rescue is the only place in *Sabriel* where the narration steps away from her point of view and the perspective becomes that of Touchstone. This in itself has a power-shifting effect, as the reader is made aware that Touchstone has access to arcane knowledge – a great deal of which is withheld from both Sabriel and the reader.

Simple things such as his ability to name the sinkhole as ‘Holehallow’ demonstrate that Touchstone is admitted to secrets of the Old Kingdom. This is confirmed in his conversation with Mogget. It is clear that Touchstone understands who the cat is, despite Mogget being embodied in a different form and having a different name from when they last met. Touchstone’s tearful devastation when Mogget informs him that the Queen and her daughters are dead intimates a personal connection with the Royal family.

There are also hints of something dark attached to Touchstone's past. Even the name 'Touchstone', derisively given by Mogget, holds ambiguity. It has an, albeit anachronistic, intertextual resonance with Shakespeare's wise fool in *As You Like It*, and it also connotes a measure of value.

Information about Touchstone comes to the reader in a disconnected and incomplete fashion. It is contained in snatches of conversation between Touchstone and Mogget. It is seen in instances such as Touchstone's response to Mogget's suggestion he arm himself with weapons from the royal funerary ships – "but I'm not fit to wield royal—" (*Sab* 182), and in Touchstone's plea that Mogget keep information back from Sabriel: "Please don't tell her—" (*Sab* 183). The incomplete sentences mimic the incomplete revelation of knowledge. Readers are shown that both their and Sabriel's understanding is incomplete at this point of the novel. This is also a reminder of the gaps in Sabriel's knowledge of the Old Kingdom. It functions as a cue to Sabriel's own fears and vulnerabilities. As Touchstone and Mogget obviously share knowledge that is kept from Sabriel, the dynamics of power between Sabriel and Touchstone are confused. Although Sabriel is active, the rescuer, and the one who holds the gaze, she is denied full power. Touchstone's half-finished exchanges with Mogget, though self-deprecating, still effectively situate both the readers and Sabriel at a disadvantage. Sabriel is simply left with an uneasy suspicion that she is on the outside, that she is being told a "half-truth at best" (*Sab* 186).

Conversely, Touchstone's persona is passive and even ostensibly deferential but, despite being the object of both Sabriel and the reader's gaze, he does not cede control to the watchers; not to the watchers within the novel nor the

readers without. Touchstone's deliberate avoidance of Sabriel's eye – his affected humility with his “head bowed, carefully not meeting her gaze” (*Sab* 185) – and his seemingly deferential (but deliberately obtuse) responses to her questioning, ironically work against Sabriel's power rather than confirming it. These dynamics complicate any reading of *Sabriel* that might suggest that the casting of an active female protagonist presents a clean reversal of the hero/heroine roles. Indeed, Touchstone's adoption of a subservient manner, rather than empowering Sabriel, frustrates her attempts to gain an understanding of, or establish a connection with, the young man. His “servile manner [. . .] seemed to be an affectation” and Sabriel thought his behaviour reminiscent of a “bad actor playing the butler” (*Sab* 190). In her irritation she finds herself fighting to bite back scathing remarks “about the arrogance of pretended humility” (*Sab* 195). Touchstone's submission actually hinders rather than aids Sabriel's aspirations, creating a tension within the dynamics, not a reversal of gender hierarchies.

Amusingly, the power struggle between Sabriel and Touchstone is expressed almost as a contest in unworthiness. Touchstone's offer of service to the Abhorsen is refused by Sabriel who informs him of her own perceived inadequacies and the gaps in her knowledge of the Old Kingdom (*Sab* 188). Regardless of her repeated disavowals of both the authority and role of Abhorsen, the high rank attached to Sabriel's lineage and calling inescapably carries with it implicit power. Just as her role as Abhorsen grants Sabriel the intellectual distance to look on Touchstone without shame, it also works as a shield to any controlling male gaze. It is not she, or even her gender, that is seen by Touchstone, but her position. As he awakes from his enchanted sleep Touchstone sees a “woman, looking down at him, a young woman,

armed and armoured, her face. . . battered. No, not a woman. The Abhorsen [...]” (*Sab* 178). The uniform of her office – her emblazoned surcoat, her sword-belt, and her necromancer’s bell-bandolier – overwhelm her gendered identity.

Paradoxically, although not sexual in nature, Touchstone’s seeing Sabriel solely as Abhorsen is in itself a form of objectification. It takes a long period of acquaintance for him to recognise Sabriel as either an individual or as a woman; the realisation that she is both, leaves him surprised:

Almost for the first time he really looked at her. He saw the weariness there, and the incipient lines of care, and the way her mouth looked a little sad around the edges. Her nose was still swollen, and there were yellowing bruises on her cheekbones. She was also beautiful, and Touchstone realised that he had thought of her only in terms of her office, as Abhorsen. Not as a woman at all... (Nix *Sab* 279)

Although she is not sexually objectified, until Touchstone looks at Sabriel as a person and not as Abhorsen, she is denied individual subjectivity.

The above physical description of Sabriel is markedly different in style and detail from the description of Touchstone as the object of Sabriel’s gaze. The text’s images of Touchstone emphasise physical desirability, not only when he is on display as the figurehead but also after he has been awakened. There is a stress on his physical adeptness and strength as he is seen (albeit to the side) “performing a series of fencing exercises with his twin swords, and some stretches and minor acrobatics” (*Sab* 194). There is comment on him not being able to get the trousers provided past his “heavily muscled thighs” (*Sab* 183). Sabriel notices he looks “older and somewhat more

intimidating” when armed and in the heroic dress of a red leather jerkin, and “a kilt of red-striped gold, disappearing into turned-down thigh boots of russet doeskin” (*Sab* 184). Sabriel, by contrast, is never shown in an overtly sexualised manner. She is first introduced in a proper school uniform – regulation navy blazer, long skirt, stockings and sensible shoes (*Sab* 11) and spends most of the rest of the novel in her semi-martial Abhorsen garb.

Again, the physical display of Touchstone does not mean a reversal of dominant gender paradigms. Established structures of power mean the dynamics of a man displayed differ from that of a woman displayed. Indeed, Mulvey argues that the “principles of the ruling ideology and the psychical structures that back it up [mean] the male figure cannot bear the burden of sexual objectification” (Mulvey 20). She asserts that the male protagonist’s “glamorous characteristics are [. . .] not those of the erotic object of the gaze” but rather of “the more perfect, more complete, more powerful ideal ego” (Mulvey 20). Certainly, there seems a suggestion of this ideal type in the images of Touchstone in his heroic garb, although this is unsettled as Sabriel performs the more active role in most of their interactions. The protagonists in *Sabriel*, therefore, do not comfortably fit into dominant and straightforward gender patterns and, as such, create a tension that is sustained throughout the novel. Touchstone’s refusal to be open with Sabriel about his past, his access to knowledge that is denied her, and his greater physical strength complicate any attempt to read this situation as a direct inversion of traditional power dynamics.

Sabriel’s own attitude toward Touchstone is also complex. She deliberately shifts away from viewing him as a sexual object when he is displayed as the

figurehead. If any desire tacitly underlies his rescue it is not lust, but a yearning for companionship. Despite his physique, heroic dress and deference, her initial reaction to the awakened Touchstone is disappointment. Looking forward to company “other than the sardonic Mogget” (*Sab* 184), Sabriel has “sinking expectations” when she first speaks with him as he “didn’t sound overly bright”. His response to her queries are slow, hesitant and dull, “without inflection” (*Sab* 185-6). Sabriel becomes more hopeful though, when a rare unguarded look from Touchstone, reveals “a clear intelligent gaze” (*Sab* 186). This demonstrates that Sabriel seeks intelligence and substance above physical appeal. Her desire is for a more equal companionship, hinting that she wishes neither to dominate nor be dominated.

The desire for equality above dominance is reinforced in Sabriel’s negative reaction to Touchstone’s offer of service as sworn swordsman. His manufactured deference and his subservient addresses of ‘Milady’ and ‘Abhorsen’ only exasperate her. Touchstone pledges Sabriel his sword and service, but she rejects it with the frustrated explanation:

I have very little idea about what is going on. I have huge gaps in my knowledge of the Old Kingdom, including everything from geography to history to Charter Magic [. . .] I am not out to save the Kingdom, just to find my father, the real Abhorsen, so I don’t want to take your oath or service or anything like that [. . .]. And please remember, that my name is Sabriel. Not Milady. Not Abhorsen. (*Nix Sab* 188).

Although her refutation of authority is tied to the hope that her father might not truly be dead, as discussed in Chapter 3 it is also entangled in the desire to retain choice. Ironically then, Sabriel’s refusal of power can be seen as an assertion of self; as a demonstration of individual autonomy. It is an attempt

to remain in control of her own life rather than ceding to the dictates of destiny and fate. Also discussed in Chapter 3, Touchstone's rejection of authority can be read as an expression of personal agency as he chooses his own penance for his perceived wrongs (*Sab* 199). The notion of authority is undercut by the comic undercurrent present in this competition of self-deprecation, with both Sabriel and Touchstone each stubbornly arguing they are undeserving of power. Sabriel casts herself as unworthy of his oath, and Touchstone reacts by declaring to Mogget that he cannot be insulted by such a rejection, asserting "my oath isn't worth much" (*Sab* 189).

Touchstone's self-abasement, however, does not situate Sabriel and Touchstone's relationship completely outside long-standing literary gender paradigms. The image of him offering himself as a sworn swordsman draws deeply from the medieval models in which a Lady is venerated, despite her being outside the knight's reach. Within the courtly paradigm the knight practices humility and courtesy, swearing servitude to a highborn Lady, and refines and proves himself through abjectly acting out an undying obedience and commitment to her every fancy. Touchstone's deference, however, enacts a lowering of himself rather than an elevation of Sabriel.

Although the imagery evoked by Touchstone's offer of service draws upon courtly models, the dynamics are different. While fantasy fiction draws heavily from the past and medievalist representations, it is not bound by historical accuracy or authenticity. Indeed, Attebery observes that a freedom comes with this uncoupling from historical and cultural realities. He notes that fantasy "can begin with inherited story structures and direct them toward unexpected ends, turning Cinderellas into Princesses Charming and waking

sleeping strengths in *Sleeping Beauty*” (103). The relationship between Sabriel and Touchstone is mediated through imaginings of medieval service and devotion, but ultimately the text combines these images with more contemporary beliefs about equity, romantic love and commitment.

While this situates Sabriel and Touchstone’s relationship closer to those within romance fiction, a genre which is a legacy of courtly love literature, it still contravenes the active/passive gender dynamics of the romance genre. This is not only evident in Touchstone’s rescue and in Sabriel holding the primary heroic role as Abhorsen; Sabriel is also the character who makes the first physical overtures. She is direct and unrestrained when it appears Touchstone will succumb to the sound of one of the necromantic bells. As the sound of Astarael calls their essential spirits to death, inviting them “to plunge joyfully into the strongest current, to be carried to the very end” (*Sab* 313), Sabriel holds Touchstone with an appeal to sensuality and the materiality of the body. She “kissed him savagely, biting his lip, the salty blood filling both their mouths. His eyes cleared, and she felt him concentrate again, concentrate on Life, on living” (*Sab* 313). Representation within *Sabriel* can, therefore, be seen as a pastiche of old images and new representations, with the new further strengthened through its bonding with the old.

Although, as Attebery argues, traditional motifs, settings and narrative structures can entail an uninterrogated acquiescence to conservative gender paradigms (87) this is by no means inevitable. Fantasy’s protagonists need not bear the cultural burdens of historical or contemporary gender inequities. The economy of fantasy’s exchange with the past can be seen as one that is

curiously skewed to the advantage of the present. The past becomes a reservoir of cultural appeal, heritage, authenticity and authority, which can, ironically, be anachronistically appropriated to shore up and support contemporary ideologies, including aspirations for gender equity. The relationship between Touchstone and Sabriel demonstrates how a fantasy text can simultaneously utilise and step away from generic fairy tale romance and courtly love models, marrying traditional imagery to contemporary ideals. Although the trope of a Lady and her sworn protector is used within *Sabriel*, Sabriel and Touchstone's relationship enacts a departure from conservative gender paradigms and their inherent imbalances in power.

The movement away from traditional hierarchical models is nicely encapsulated in Sabriel's desire for an equal companion, bluntly expressed to Touchstone: "Don't call me milady and stop acting like a halfwit! Just be yourself. Behave normally. I don't need a valet, I need a useful . . . friend!" (*Sab* 199). Where both popular fairy-tale and courtly-love narratives emphasise physical desirability or prowess, *Sabriel* shifts value to attributes such as intelligence and companionability. Within older chivalric models the male's valour, long suffering, or nobility demonstrate his worthiness to win the most beautiful woman. In *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, however, beauty is underplayed, taking a secondary place to considerations of compatibility, mutual understanding and support.

As discussed above, Touchstone's physical prowess and attractiveness provide no compensation for Sabriel when she initially suspects he might be dull-witted (*Sab* 186). Similarly for Touchstone, character comes above beauty in his appreciation of Sabriel. He does not even notice her physical

attractiveness until he is able to look past her position as Abhorsen and recognise her vulnerabilities and humanity (*Sab* 279). Moreover, a corollary of their contest over who is least deserving of deference is that their relationship arises from an understanding and acceptance of the other's weaknesses as well as strengths. This facilitates a partnership where the talents and knowledge of each, if shared, make up for the lack in the other. Touchstone's understanding of the Old Kingdom – its ways, its history and its geography – compensate for Sabriel's superficial knowledge in these areas, while Sabriel's knowledge of Ancelstierre, necromancy and the current situation in the Old Kingdom, fills out the gaps in Touchstone's awareness. Touchstone brings a physical strength to aid Sabriel in her quest, and Sabriel is able to recall Touchstone to a calmer reality when he is unnaturally empowered, overtaken by battle-madness and uncontained fury (*Lir* 207), similar to the battle frenzy of mythical hero Cuchulainn in the Ulster Cycle, or the berserker rage seen in old Norse sagas. This emphasises balance and complementary attributes.

Although Sabriel is unaware of Touchstone's royal status until much later in the novel, there is also equity in that as Abhorsen and Prince, Sabriel and Touchstone are both descendants of the "Five Great Charters" (*Sab* 232). In aptitude too, they are both very strong Charter Mages, able to wield the Charter with power. Again this is revealed to the reader in a manner that demonstrates mutual support rather than a competition for dominance. Sabriel learns of Touchstone's capacity only when she is in need, as she struggles to perform a Charter ritual to send a soul beyond the Ninth Gate of Death. Faltering due to the influence of corrupted magic:

she felt assistance come, strength flowing through her, reinforcing the marks, steadying her hands, clearing her voice.[...]

The extra strength came through Touchstone's hand, his open palm lightly resting on her shoulder. As she straightened up the touch was lost. When Sabriel turned around, Touchstone was just drawing his right-hand sword, eyes fixed on the houses—as if he'd had nothing to do with helping her.

"Thank you," said Sabriel. Touchstone was a strong Charter Mage, perhaps as strong as she was. This surprised her, though she couldn't think why. (Nix *Sab* 208-209)

This incident early in their relationship exemplifies the protagonists' mutually beneficial and co-operative relationship.

The image of Touchstone lending invaluable support to Sabriel becomes recurrent throughout *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*. Not only does he lend her the strength of his Charter magic; his support is often lifesaving. Examples of his value to Sabriel are abundant. They include his quick thinking arrow ward when they are unexpectedly fired upon by the villagers of Nestowe (*Sab* 213), and his similarly quick action in pinning an escaping Dead Mordaut to the floor with his Charter-spelled sword, giving Sabriel time to return it to Death with her necromantic bells (*Sab* 223- 224). Touchstone is there to assist in the casting of diamonds of protection to guard her body while her spirit risks travel into Death to find her father (*Sab* 227-228). He also physically carries her from the imminent threat of capture by scavenger slave traders (*Sab* 319-320). While much of this has the appearance of a knight protecting his Lady in the traditional manner, the dynamic is subtly but significantly different as Sabriel fights alongside him, actively contributing to their safety, and being essential to the success of their mission.

Pertinently, Nix's representation of co-operative support is not restricted to the active, public realm, but extends to the domestic. Indeed, Touchstone takes on the greater share of childcare as Sabriel is often and necessarily absent to deal with threats from the Dead (*Lir* 207). Instances that demonstrate Touchstone's importance and worth frustrate ideas of dominance and submission within a relationship. Significantly, Sabriel and Touchstone's relationship fits within the dominant ideological aspirations that John Stephens identifies as pervasive in Australian young adult literature; he observes that a recurrent theme is that: "Human sexuality operates most satisfactorily within relationships grounded on sexual equality" (Stephens ix). Although Sabriel performs the central heroic role, the happy ending is made possible due to the way in which Sabriel and Touchstone work together and complement each other's strengths and weaknesses.

The dynamic of balance within this romantic relationship is echoed in the nonsexual relationship between the protagonists of *Lirael* and *Abhorsen*. Lirael performs the central role of the heroic warrior while Sam aids her quest with less active but similarly important and complementary skills. As Abhorsen-in-Waiting, Lirael is clearly more naturally adept in dealing with the Dead than Sam. He is a strong Charter Mage and competent with a sword but, unlike Touchstone, Sam is neither a soldier, nor a natural fighter. This creates an even more atypical dynamic between these two protagonists. Superficially, this pairing appears closer to an inversion of archetypal male and female role.

The contrast between Lirael and Sameth is striking, and most evident in the way in which they respond to Death and the Dead. Sam feels a sickening fear at the expectation he will one day become Abhorsen and wishes it were otherwise. The tension between desires and expectation is evident as he says of *The Book of the Dead*, “I can’t get away from it, but I can’t look at it either” (*Lir* 486). Lirael, on the other hand, “is unable to disguise her eagerness” to study *The Book of the Dead*, saying, “I can’t explain, but I feel that I must read it” (*Lir* 488). Similarly, Sam is repulsed by the bandolier of the Abhorsen’s necromantic bells given him by his mother: “He was aware of how cold it was, how it pressed against his chest and made breathing sudden urge to put on the bandolier and walk in to Death” (*Lir* 487). When Sam admits to Lirael that he is afraid of Death, she cannot understand it: “He was the Abhorsen’s son, the Abhorsen-in-Waiting. It simply was not possible that he could be afraid of Death. That would be like a Clayr who was afraid of the sight. It was beyond imagining” (*Lir* 485). A reading of their partnership as an inversion of gender roles, however, is complicated by Sam’s superior capacity as a Charter Mage and artisan and, ultimately, as discussed in the previous chapter, by notions of destiny.

Active/passive roles within the story are also complicated by actions that Sam takes in spite of his fear, making it clear that fear does not equate to cowardliness or selfishness. Regardless of his overwhelming dread, he faces the necromancer Hedge and his army of Dead when the bus carrying his school cricket team is attacked close to the Wall. He enters Death for the sake of his friends, without sword, bells or even time to cast a diamond of protection (*Lir* 179). The Dog points out this difference between fear and

cowardliness when Sam gives voice to his dread: “you don’t smell like a coward—so you can’t be one” (*Lir* 572). Sam’s natural position may not be that of a warrior, but ultimately this does not undermine his courage or contribution within the story.

In a genre that, largely due to its chivalric inheritance, emphasises physical prowess and martial adeptness, Sameth is allowed an alternative expression of masculinity and strength. Although his passion for creativity is initially seen as emasculating within the story, it is his capacity as an artisan which restores him to a position of respect and significance and proves to be central to the salvation of the Kingdom. In an interesting negotiation between historical archetypes and contemporary identity, Sam’s behaviour and role strongly echo a contemporary ‘geek’ or ‘nerd’ stereotype. These terms, being subject to quickly shifting social construction, are often used interchangeably, though ‘geek’, perhaps, carries with it a greater association with computer culture (Kendall NN 264). The geek/nerd identity entails notions of intellectual curiosity and obsessive interest— often in areas of science or computing but also in more eccentric or imaginative areas including fantasy, science fiction and gaming. This identity is also regularly associated with social awkwardness. In “Nerd Nation”, published in 1999, a time contemporaneous with the writing of *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, Lori Kendall writes that “the previously liminal masculine identity of the nerd” has been increasingly “rehabilitated and partially incorporated into hegemonic masculinity” (260). She notes that, alongside derided behaviours, geek identity also possesses “aspects of hypermasculinity (intellect, rejection of sartorial display, lack of ‘feminine’ social and relational skills)” (NN 164). It is also associated with material advantage as “[g]eek implies wealth” (Kendall

NN 164). Indeed, R.W. Connell notes in *Masculinities*, that the rise of computers has facilitated a redefinition of masculinity. Connell describes the area of Information Technology “as an arena of competition and power – masculine, technical”, and no longer working class (56).

Nix’s characterisation of Sam reflects something of the zeitgeist surrounding the increasingly visible geek identity. It also provides a further illustration of how popular fiction is able to participate in the cultural contests of its time. Raewyn Campbell (2012) comments that:

The signifier ‘nerd’ has undergone a dramatic shift in the last twenty years. Once laden with negativity and accruing societal derision and ridicule, the nerd label is now frequently worn as a badge of pride, even bestowing upon the wearer increased cultural status (Campbell 1).

She argues that the stories circulating within popular culture realms can gain mass and traction, and ultimately “effect a noticeable change in a discursive regime” (Campbell 2). The representation of Sam can be seen as but a part of the mass of stories exerting pressure on the definition of masculinity.

It is not difficult to see where Sam’s characteristics intersect with those associated with the geek. Whilst in Belisaere he indulges in antisocial behaviour, eschewing company, retiring “to his workshop, trying to forget his troubles in the construction of a particularly intricate and interesting magical mechanical” creation (Nix *Lir* 275). Sam’s obsessive interest in creativity and in the minutiae of Charter spells is initially belittled. Ellimere characterises his shutting himself away and “tinkering in that smelly workshop of yours”, as eccentric and useless (*Lir* 217). Almost punitively, Ellimere increases the

time Sam is to spend on other activities, social, civil and military, particularly humiliating him by assigning him to dance the part of the Bird of Dawning at the Midsummer festival:

‘Sameth! You are going to dance the Bird, like it or not,’ declared Ellimere. ‘It’s about time you did something useful around here. I’ve also scheduled you to sit with Jall at the Petty Court every morning between ten and one, and you’ll have sword practice twice a day with the Guard, of course, and you must come to dinner—no ordering meals to your grubby workshop. And for Perspective, I’ve assigned you to work with the scullions every second Wednesday.’ (Nix *Lir* 218-219)

She unequivocally declares that Sam would be of “a lot more use” training as Abhorsen than “mucking about making toys” (*Lir* 221). This, however, represents a misjudgement of the worth of Sam’s interests, knowledge and abilities.

The value Nix grants to Sam’s skills in Charter creation means a contemporary reader need not measure Sam’s character only against romantic medieval benchmarks of masculinity, such as valour and physical prowess. There is a greater complexity in Nix’s representations of manhood. Intellect and imaginative creative ability are also shown to possess great worth. There is a certain irony in Sam’s character seeming somewhat emasculated when in the warrior mode, but powerful when he is allowed to realise his potential as a ‘tinkerer’. Sam’s coming into his destined place can be seen as reflective of movements in modern society. Through a recourse to medieval tropes of magic and artisanship, in the character of Sam there is the figure of the geek, transported back to a medieval timeframe and granted power, importance and influence. This reflects changing notions of

masculinity, and demonstrates once more how constructions of the past can be used to confirm or support contemporary, even shifting, notions of gender role and place.

Given the recognised overlap between fantasy readership and many who align themselves with the geek/nerd identity, such a portrayal can also have a particular resonance and appeal to this portion of fantasy readership. Nix can be seen as 'hailing' his young adult male readership through Sam's character. Coined by Louis Althusser in "Ideology and the Ideological State Apparatus" (1968), 'hailing' and 'interpellation' represent a call to, and an acceptance or recognition of, an ideological subject position (301). In "Culture, Ideology and Interpellation" (1987), John Fisk explains that:

Hailing is the process by which language identifies and constructs a social position for the addressee. Interpellation is the larger process whereby language constructs social relations for both parties as an act of communication and thus locates them on the broader map of social relations in general. (Fiske 308)

Hailing for reader identification through a character such as Sam indicates the growing strength of 'geek' as a collective subject identity, and also shows this identity's increasingly visible place on the 'map of social relations'.

Nix's treatment of masculinity is similar to that of his treatment of femininity within *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*. It is not bound by traditional roles and behaviours, but it weaves images of the past into redefined notions of masculine identity. Although Sameth plays the passive role to Lirael's more active heroism, as with Sabriel and Touchstone, this pairing demonstrates the use of complementary talents and traits in order to achieve a final goal.

In the binding of Orannis it is Sam who makes the sword and Lirael who wields it. Their roles are inter-dependent, not hierarchical. There is a neat symbolism of this in the dénouement of the story, as Lirael loses her hand wielding the sword as Abhorsen, and Sam is able to make her a new Charter-spelled one drawing on his skills as Wallmaker.

Although casting females in the central heroic roles, and males in more auxiliary or passive roles, steps outside the dominant gender paradigms within traditional heroic texts, the stories in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* do not represent straightforward inversions of male and female hierarchies. They unsettle notions of traditionally appropriate male and female behaviour while simultaneously drawing from images and motifs of the past to add weight to the challenge. They provide a constructive case study of the complexities of gender representation in contemporary medievalist fantasy fiction. Nix strongly appropriates from, and appeals to, longstanding romantic literary models— from traditional rites of passage tales, courtly love imagery, fairy-tale motifs and imaginings of the past. His gender representations, however, conform to contemporary ideological aspirations for gender equity. Nix's portrayals demonstrate possibilities for more nuanced, elastic and dynamic gendered characterisation, indicating that appeals to the past are not inevitably conservative in function. This shows that fantastic renderings of a medievalised past can contribute to the shaping and confirmation of understandings of the present in regard to gender identity and place.

Chapter 6

East and West.

Continuing on from the discussion of Garth Nix's Old Kingdom Trilogy, the following chapters will focus upon Canadian writer Guy Gavriel Kay's high fantasy trilogy, *The Fionavar Tapestry*. Interestingly, Kay has a near association with Tolkien's fantasy world, having worked with Christopher Tolkien to compile and edit *The Silmarillion* from a mass of stories and 'histories' of Middle-earth written by J.R.R. Tolkien over his lifetime (Tolkien, Christopher 9). My discussion will consider how the images, ideals and social structures of the past are used, presented and valued within Kay's texts. Again, the focus will be upon how these impact on representations of ethnicity and national identity, class and gender.

I will argue that different constructions of the past within the novels are measured according to different standards of worth. Though Kay appropriates widely from various cultural imaginings, different mythologies, and diverse constructions of the past, the novels work to naturalise the superiority of the West, of masculinity, and of Western liberal ideologies. This chapter will examine the connection between modern Canada and medieval Fionavar and the centrality of the High Kingdom of Brennín. It will

introduce the different cultures within Fionavar before moving to a more detailed discussion of how Brennín is situated against Cathal, Fionavar's 'Eastern' culture.

As in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, there is a discernible national inflection within *The Fionavar Tapestry*. Where Australian-ness is covertly present within Nix's texts, there is an overt Canadian presence in Kay's. Indeed, the story's central focus is on Canadian characters' adventures in the "Perilous Realm" of Faërie. Five students from the University of Toronto are magically transported to Fionavar, the "first" of all worlds – the world of which all others, including our own, are simply shadows. Four of these students, Kevin Laine, Paul Schafer, Kimberly Ford, and Jennifer Lowell, magically 'cross' to Brennín, the medieval High Kingdom of Fionavar. The fifth, Dave Martyniuk, is accidentally taken to The Plain, north of Brennín, an untamed land peopled by nomadic hunters, the Dalrei. These are recognisably modelled upon images of the North American 'Indian', adding a further distinctive Canadian marker. The five become key participants in the alliance of 'the Light', joining the fight against Rakoth Maugrim, the unraveller, a fallen god and the personification of all evil, intent upon the destruction of all worlds.

As in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, there is a barrier between the modern and the medieval, but in this instance the barrier is a magical rather than a physical border between two very separate worlds. Again, as is the case in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, the older world is privileged and given supremacy over the modern world. This is clearly signalled in Fionavar's representation as the primary creation, the first of all worlds. Fionavar is initially introduced to the Canadians by Loren Silvercloak, a Mage from

Fionavar's High Kingdom of Brennin. Loren aptly fits the generic conventions of a sage wizard in the likeness of Merlin in the Arthurian tales or Gandalf in Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings*. This immediately provides him with a generic trustworthiness that elicits belief as he explains the primacy of Fionavar to the five travellers before assisting in their 'crossing' to his world: "There are many worlds [. . .] caught in the loops and whorls of time. [. . .] Only in Fionavar, the prime creation, which all the others only imperfectly reflect, is the lore gathered and preserved that tells how to bridge the worlds" (Kay ST 30).

The ideal represented by Fionavar draws upon the power of fantasy's archetypes and motifs, and also appropriates from the Platonic idea of Forms, which postulates the things of our world are mere reflections, shadows of a transcendent, more perfect, reality. This is by no means a new concept within the genre of fantasy. The influence of Plato's Forms is clearly observable in many works of the Inklings, although given a strong Christian inflection. The idea of a more perfect, transcendent reality can be found in C.S. Lewis' concept of the 'shadowlands', evident in his Christian analogy *The Great Divorce*, and in his children's series *The Chronicles of Narnia*. The protagonist in *The Great Divorce* (TGD) takes a bus trip to heaven from purgatory, "the grey town" (18). Heaven is so real and substantial that the visitors appear as ghosts within that setting, unable to affect or interact with the overwhelming material reality of this place:

It was the light, the grass, the trees that were different; made of some different substance, so that much solidier than things in our own country that men were ghosts in comparison. Moved by a sudden thought I bent down to try and pluck a daisy which was growing at my

feet. The stalk wouldn't break, I tried to twist it but it wouldn't twist.
(Lewis *TGD* 27)

More overt still, the concluding chapter of *The Last Battle* (*TLB*), the final book of the Narnia series, is titled "Farewell to Shadowlands". It shows the protagonists leaving behind an imperfect Narnia to experience the *real*, perfect, heavenly Narnia:

'Of course, Daughter of Eve' said the Faun. The further up and further in you go the bigger everything gets. The inside is larger than the outside'.

Lucy looked hard at the garden and saw it was not really a garden at all, but a whole world, with its own rivers and woods and seas and mountains. But they were not strange, she knew them all.

'I see,' she said. 'This is still Narnia, and more real and more beautiful than the Narnia down below'. (Lewis *TLB* 170)

The idea of a transcendent reality is also evident in Tolkien's *On Fairy Stories* as it argues that the "particular quality of joy in successful fantasy can be described as a sudden glimpse of the underlying truth or reality" (70). Continuing with the sensory analogy, Tolkien later notes that this joy "has the very taste of primary truth" (71). In "Saving the Myths: The Re-creation of Mythology in Plato and Tolkien", Gergely Nagy asserts that "Plato's forms and Tolkien's past are functionally in the same place" (88), both seeking, and even retrospectively constructing or appealing to, an original truth.

Fionavar's position as the prime creation, therefore, draws from fantasy convention and, more broadly, from wider Western philosophical tradition. Both fantasy and philosophical influences work together to shore up the

importance of the past as an ideal. The significant and authoritative place that the past holds in *The Fionavar Tapestry* is immediately evident as Loren Silvercloak appeals to “ancient wisdom” to justify his quest to fetch five strangers to his own medieval world. As Fionavar’s ills and triumphs have repercussions in all worlds, it is only right that Fionavar is given precedence above our world.

Even in modern day Toronto the authority and appeal of the past is evident. Loren Silvercloak does not seek his five travellers randomly. He finds them in the rarefied halls of academia at the University of Toronto, an institution strongly associated with scholarship on the Middle Ages through its Centre for Medieval Studies, founded in 1964. Moreover, the picture that the texts conjure of the University of Toronto draws on images of the past; Kay utilises symbols of heritage and history and imbues them with a sense of permanence and authority. This, in turn, subtly invests even the characters from this world with an aura of ‘pastness’.

History, with its own kind of pagan/magical inflection, is emphasised as Loren meets ‘the five’ at an international Celtic conference— in the “august precincts of the domed auditorium” of the Convocation Hall, complete with its glittering chandeliers and arched windows (*ST* 19-20). Even in the modern world Loren represents authority as he performs the role of a “reclusive genius” (*ST* 19), Lorenzo Marcus, the keynote speaker at the conference. The five leave the hall with Loren Silvercloak and the dwarf Matt Sören, Loren’s ‘source’ from whom he draws strength to fuel his magical powers. They walk across “the wide central green of the campus, then along the dark winding path known as the Philosophers’ Walk that twisted, with gentle

slopes on either side, behind the law school, the Faculty of Music, and the massive edifice of the Royal Ontario Museum” (ST 25-26). The semiotics of this description strongly appeal to the past. There are the obvious romantic, medieval literary tropes— the magician, the attendant dwarf, and the green, pleasant landscape. The imagery also links the scholarly culture of Toronto University to the past. It suggests the protagonists are formed by culture— by philosophy, law, music and by history itself. As in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, from the very beginning of *The Fionavar Tapestry* the past is situated in a place of privilege. Prestige and value are marked by an association with the past. The professional aspirations of the five, too, are attached to history, status and authority. Kevin and Dave are studying Law, Kimberly is a medical intern, and Paul is a young academic in the university’s history department. Jennifer is later revealed to be Guinevere from Arthurian mythology and, consequently, is even more deeply grounded in the past than her compatriots. Moreover, the five each realise an even greater personal potential when they are transported to the ‘past’, in the spatialised form of the world of Fionavar.

As previously noted, Fionavar is cast as the ultimate reality, more substantial and more real than the ‘shadowlands’ that include the readers’ own world. Kay’s hierarchy of worlds both participates in and confounds the frame established by Tolkien in “On Fairy Stories”. It participates in allowing fantasy to reflect a transcendent reality, but it confuses this frame through the employment of a different terminology. Tolkien demarcates between worlds of fantasy and reality by referring to the material world, the world in which the readers and the authors dwell, as the ‘Primary World’; and the imaginary constructs of fantasy authors, as ‘sub-creations’ and ‘Secondary Worlds’

(Tolkien 49-51). Kay's texts invert Tolkien's notions of primacy by presenting the sub-creation, Fionavar, as the 'first' world and marking it as the 'prime creation'. Given Kay's association with Tolkien through his work on *The Silmarillion*, this might indicate an attempt to step outside the constraints of Tolkien's influence. Kay's lexis gestures toward Tolkien's framework, displaying his awareness of the influence of Tolkien's writings on the fantasy genre, but it also shows digression. Indeed, in an introduction to a special edition of Kay's novel *Tigana*, James Gunn quotes Kay as saying that "to be successful in fantasy, you have to take the measure of Tolkien - work with his strengths and away from his weaknesses" (Gunn online). Kay's lexical choices, however, generate certain difficulties in regard to the vocabulary generally available to differentiate between the worlds inside and outside of a fantasy novel. Confusingly, within Kay's *Fionavar Tapestry* the 'Secondary World' is the '*first*' of all worlds' and the 'Primary World' becomes *second* to the fantastic 'sub-creation'. In an attempt to circumvent misunderstanding, the following chapters will avoid using the terms 'Primary World' or 'Secondary World' as set out in Tolkien's framework. Instead, when referring to the world recognisable to readers as their own, this thesis will refer to 'our world' or 'the readers' world'.

As the 'Prime Creation', Fionavar is set above the readers' modern world, and above all other possible imagined worlds. Within this already privileged world of Fionavar, the High Kingdom of Brennín is situated at the top of an internal hierarchy. It is presented as the centre of power, culture and influence. Brennín is clearly medieval but, as will later be discussed in greater detail, it is aligned with the privileged, sophisticated, enlightened West. Moreover, a particularly Canadian inflection can be found in Kay's

High Kingdom. Where Nix's imagined Middle Ages demonstrated Australian cultural aspirations such as informality, egalitarianism and mateship, Kay's central Middle Ages is an exemplar of masculine civility. In *White Civility* Canadian scholar Danial Coleman argues that at the centre "of English Canadian whiteness is a specific form of civility modelled upon the gentlemanly code of Britishness" (10). Colman asserts "this is a form of Britishness that is a uniquely settler-colonial project (211). It is equated with an educated enlightenment, progressiveness, and the "ethical moral concept of peaceful order" (Coleman 11), and is significant to "Canada's project to establish itself as a liberal, modern, and civil nation" (Coleman 13).

The High Kingdom's progressive enlightenment becomes particularly evident when Brennin is juxtaposed against the other cultures in Fionavar. These cultures variously evoke the Saracen, the North American 'Indian', and a more rudimentary Anglo/Celtic society. The centrality of Brennin in this fictional world is reflective of Kay's Canadian and Western perspective. Indeed, Kay himself acknowledges his own historical and cultural roots and their influence on his works. In a 1995 interview with *Solaris* magazine, Kay says:

When I say "we", I mean Western men and women, because that's the culture that I feel most at home in, it's the culture that most of us are, to some degree, shaped by. So, in that sense [my novels] have been incorporating that dimension, but it's not in any huge sense central to my thinking or my own work. (Trudel online)

This is indicative not only of the centrality of a Western cultural perspective in Kay's work, but also of the ease with which this perspective seems to 'naturally', and in an unmarked way, assume the centre. Rather than ameliorate the naturalised authority of Western thought and tradition in Kay's

work, the qualification that his Western bent is 'not in any huge sense' central to his thinking or writing demonstrates something of the uninterrogated power of Western influence. For Western readers who are participants in Kay's "we", this centrality easily appears natural, fitting within a hierarchy long established as right and plausible in Western literary representations. In *Fautlines: Cultural Materialism and the Politics of Dissident Reading*, Alan Sinfield discusses the role that narratives play in shaping notions of plausibility. He argues that:

The strength of ideology derives from the way it gets to be common sense; it "goes without saying." [. . .] As the world shapes itself around and through us, certain interpretations of experience strike us as plausible: They fit with what we have experienced already, and are confirmed by others around us. (Sinfield 32)

Within the canon of Western literature at large there is an essentialising of Western centrality. Despite a purported detached 'other-wordliness' in fantasy, a Western heart is also discernible in key conventions of the fantasy genre and in fantasy's medievalism. Stories which place Western notions of civility and behaviour at the centre feed into each other, increasing credibility as each reiteration confirms the others as correct; the more something is restated, the more 'natural' it becomes.

As has been well theorised within the field of postcolonial criticism, the influence of paradigms that naturalise notions of Western superiority are clearly evident in realist literature. In his seminal *Orientalism* Edward Said argues that literature plays a key role in constructing the Other: "Groups of texts, types of text, even textual genres, acquire mass, density and referential power amongst themselves and thereafter in culture at large" (20).

Moreover, Said identifies the power in this constructed authority, asserting that:

There is nothing mysterious or natural about authority. It is formed, irradiated, disseminated; it is instrumental; it is pervasive; it has status, it establishes canons of taste and value; it is virtually indistinguishable from certain ideas it dignifies as true, and from traditions, perceptions, and judgements it forms, transmits, and reproduces. Above all, authority can, indeed must, be analyzed.
(Said 19-20)

I wish to emphasise that both realist and non-realist texts alike can participate in essentialising Western authority and superiority. Even fiction genres such as fantasy borrow their structures of plausibility from culturally powerful ideologies that privilege Western perspectives. Fantasy also draws plausibility from its appeal to history, myth, tradition, and from longstanding literary depictions and conventions. It seems natural, therefore, when *The Fionavar Tapestry* situates discernibly Western behaviours, characters and ideologies at the centre.

Chapter 1 discussed the manner in which modernity can use the Middle Ages as an Other against which modernity can identify itself either through alignment (venerating the past) or through opposition (representing the past as a primitive, unenlightened other). *The Fionavar Tapestry* uses these differing constructions of the past; there is a Middle Ages with which modernity can identify, and varying Middle Ages that function as a superseded obverse. While the High Kingdom of Brenninn embodies the possibility of an ideal past and present, within Fionavar there are cultures that have inflections of medieval barbarism, violence and superstition. The 'Other' cultures of Fionavar become the East to Brenninn's West, the primitive

and uncivilised to Brennín's culture and enlightenment, and the feminine to Brennín's masculinity. Although these other cultures are Brennín's allies in the war against darkness, undercurrents of an inferior alterity can be discerned in portrayals of the peoples of Cathal and Eridu, in representations of the Dalrei of the plains, and of the Dwarves in their mountain kingdom. It can also be found in the depictions of those who worship the Goddess rather than the God.

Kay's varying constructions of the past are indicative of the malleability of the Middle Ages. They demonstrate how the medieval can change complexion, depending upon that which it is set alongside. Catherine Brown points to the flexible utility of the medieval as an Other alongside which modernity is set. She considers the manner in which 'non-medievals' "write, think, make movies, novels, poems, or advertisements" about the Middle Ages, arguing that if there were no Middle Ages:

people might have had to invent them just so that we could safely be non-medieval, and have someplace exotic to fly to when modern life got too, well, modern. Or so that we could have a convenient Other against which to define ourselves. (Brown 549)

There is both versatility and complexity in Kay's construction of his Middle Ages which is particularly evident in his creation of Fionavar's distinct civilisations, practices and beliefs. There is an implicit comparison between the present and the past, but simultaneously there are overt comparisons between different imaginings of the past. Brennín, its people, its politics, and its belief systems retain the centre, while representations of other cultures work to confirm Brennín's superiority.

Fionavar's cultural hierarchies are significant because popular constructions, even those that are both medievalist and imaginary, impact upon and reflect real world national discourses and beliefs. Indeed, the inclusion of many cultures in Fionavar itself mirrors something of Canada's contemporary pride in itself as a modern, pluralistic society. Coleman argues that:

for many Canadians, multiculturalism represents Canada's progressiveness, not only in comparison to the monocultural nationalisms of other countries but also in comparison to earlier eras of monocultural nationalism in Canada. Indeed, multiculturalism in recent public opinion polls has been selected as the most fundamental and proudly revered feature of Canadian 'identity'.
(Coleman 7)

Even so, the symbolic placement of a Western Brennin as the centre of power, knowledge and authority in Fionavar unsettles the progressive and egalitarian overtones attached to multiculturalism. It echoes and reinforces the naturalised authority of the West in our world and of Britishness in English speaking Canada. Coleman speaks of the problematic quality of trying to organise "a diverse population around the standardizing ideals of whiteness, masculinity and Britishness" (10). He also observes that "categories of privilege attempt to secure their privilege by rendering their preferential status as natural and therefore as immutable and irresistible" (10).

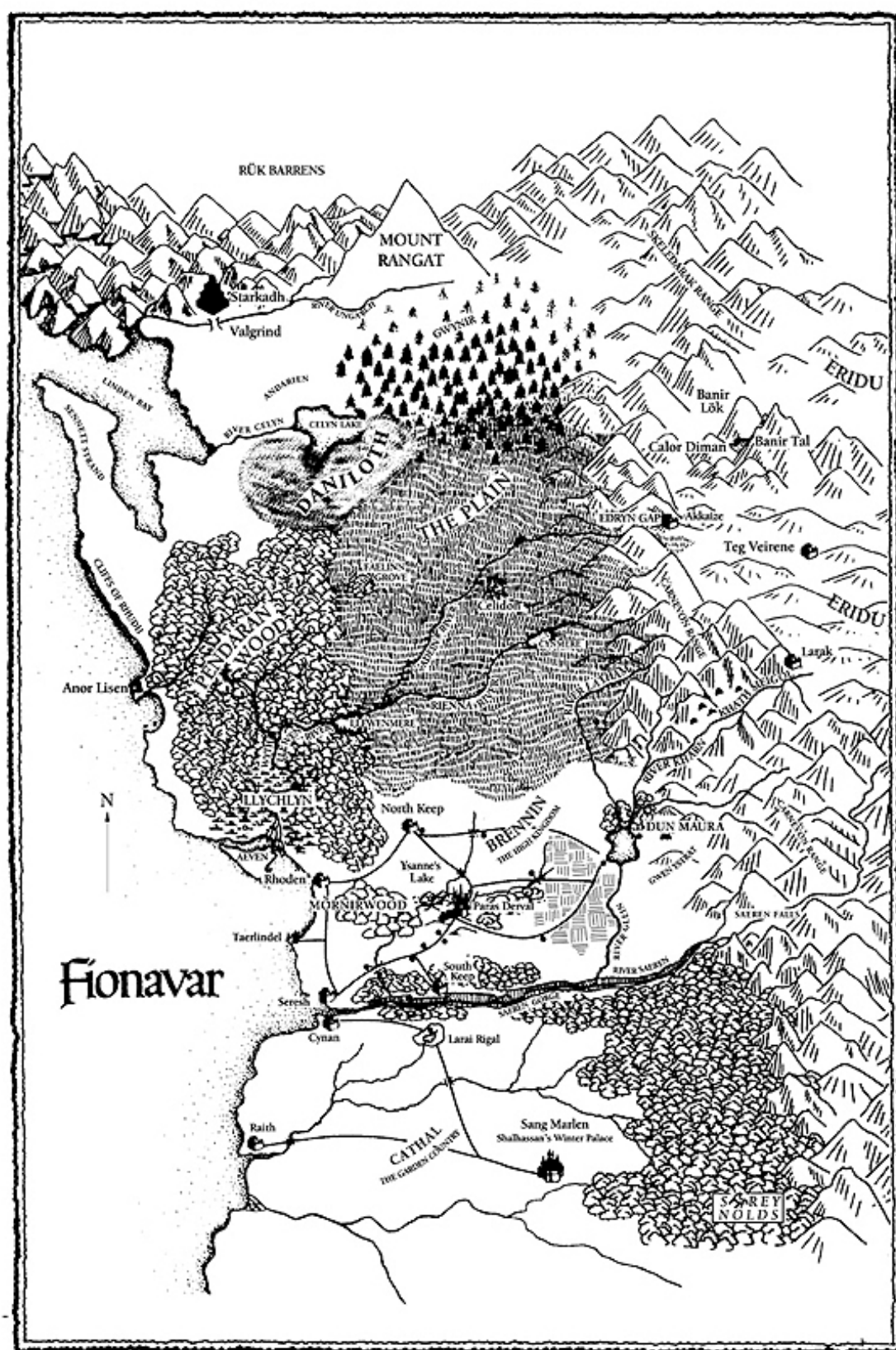
Canada's standardising ideals of 'whiteness, masculinity and Britishness' are also reinforced by its cultural association with Northernness. Unlike the antipodean Australia that relies on a spirit of Northernness, Canada has

access to the geographical North. Coleman argues that 'the Northern myth' was central to the figuration of Canada as:

a testing and improving ground for effete European manhood. According to this myth the rigours of a stern unaccommodating climate demanded strength of the body, character and mind while it winnowed away laziness, overindulgence and false niceties. [...] For early ideologues of the emerging Canadian nation the country's northern location meant it would remain the domain of upwardly mobile White people, and its Nordic environment would so strengthen and sharpen them that they would be improved over their ancestral British stock. (Coleman 24)

The semiotic and cultural significance attached to topographical settings in fantasy novels was discussed in Chapter 2, and the map Fionavar fits well within high fantasy's generic expectations (see Fig. 2.) Like the topography of the Old Kingdom, Fionavar's geography has the almost requisite woods, lakes and wastes, and situates the great, foreboding mountainous regions in the North. Unlike the case with Australia, this is not at odds with Canada's physical Northernness.

Fig. 2.



The High Kingdom placement in the middle of the map speaks to its centrality and importance, and the map shows Brennín in greater detail than the other nations, making it appear more substantial and complete. It shows the castle in Paras Derval, Ysanne's Lake, the North and South Keeps, its harbours, its cultivated fields, woods, the Goddess's caves in Dun Maura, towns and regions. By contrast other lands are represented more one-dimensionally. Cathal appears as sparse and desert-like, the Plain as a uniform mass of vegetation, and the Dwarf Kingdom as a small mountainous region. Eridu is similarly nondescript; moreover, it appears on the margins of the diagram, its geographical position at the edge of the map symbolic of its marginal place within the story.

The central position of the High Kingdom is made more natural by conventional, idealised images of a medieval realm. The palace in the capital, Paras Derval, has "battlements and towers, a garden, a central courtyard, an open square before the walls and on the very highest rampart a banner somehow blowing in a non-existent breeze" (Kay *ST* 31). Unlike the castle in the Old Kingdom's Belisaere, the architecture, décor and atmosphere of the palace inspire feelings of awe in the modern travellers as they take in its "pillars, windows, ever-present tapestries, the jewelled floor [and] the gem encrusted clothing of the lords and ladies" (*ST* 74). The lavishness of the castle and court is seen in the grand stained glass depictions of great warriors and victories, in the "raised dais of marble and obsidian", and in the "great throne carved of heavy oak" (*ST* 74). These are symbols of wealth, power and history. In contrast to *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, privilege and position are held up rather than played down.

Medieval markers of antiquity and authority are, ironically, reinforced by the above-mentioned connection between Brennín and enlightenment. Again, this does not sit at odds with Canadian experience. Coleman argues that “Britishness was believed to represent a unique achievement of liberty and authority while yet retaining a respect for traditional monarchical (and therefore divinely appointed) order” (20). The High Kingdom’s primacy is further strengthened and naturalised by its intimate connection to the reader’s modern world. This is primarily seen in Brennín’s association with the travellers from Canada. Kevin closely allies himself with Prince Diarmuid, becoming a member of his band, and Paul acts as the High King’s surrogate on the Summer Tree. Kimberly becomes Brennín’s seer and brings King Arthur from our world to Fionavar. Jennifer/Guinevere is reunited with Arthur at the palace of Paras Derval. Significantly, narration within the novels is largely focalised through the Canadian characters, providing a subjective, modern, Westernised perspective. Consequently, their allegiances work to invite reader identification with characters from Brennín.

While the medieval and magical aspects of the High Kingdom add an edge of alien mysteriousness to Brennín, the contemporary protagonists work as a conduit between this past and our present, and the Arthurian aspects draw on a sense of shared history and mythology. Familiarity with culturally significant Western mythologies can provide an interpretive key, allowing portents and symbols within a fantasy story to resonate with readers. For example, the link between the physical state of king and the suffering of the land, present in Arthurian and Celtic myths of Fisher or Maimed Kings, can cause the reader to connect the drought that afflicts Brennín with a moral

failing of the declining old King Ailell. Such symbols have the power to work, as Northrop Frye puts it, on some “murky ‘subconscious’” level (188). This is particularly the case when the images in the stories have been subject to persistent reiteration in Western literature.

Brennin's alignment with our West is only one way in which its authority is naturalised. Its central position is further confirmed when it is set alongside the other significant cultures present in the world of Fionavar. While on the surface Kay's inclusion of a range of non-Western cultures appears a liberal affirmation of cultural diversity, this open-handed perspective is not unequivocal. In “Eating the Other”, bell hooks speaks of how dominant White culture's relationships with the Other often simply serve Western desires for possession and experience. She argues that “[w]ithin commodity culture, ethnicity becomes spice, seasoning that can liven up a dull dish that is mainstream white culture” (179). While the centre of Fionavar remains Western, the Other cultures contribute interest and exoticism.

Despite positive representations of non-European cultures within these texts, there is a noticeable ambivalence as the novels ultimately draw on and reinforce literary ethnic stereotypes and assumptions. In *The Fionavar Tapestry*, Western, Eastern and native North American-like cultures work together toward the common goal of defeating a Dark and evil threat to their world. They fight with dignity, bravery and a self-sacrificial fervour. Brennin, however, not only retains its centrality during the war, but increases in authority and stature above these other cultures. Brennin's centrality provides a pertinent example of the “flexible *positional* superiority” that Edward Said discerns as constantly at work in Orientalism. This “puts the

Westerner in a whole series of possible relationships with the Orient without ever losing him the upper hand" (Said 7). By way of example, if the Other is savage, the West is civilised, but if the East is gentle the West is the strong. If the East is naïve the West is knowing, but if the East is eager to learn, the West becomes the teacher. Ironically, the greater the value attached to these Other cultures, the greater the value that adheres to Brennín as Fionavar's High Kingdom.

An understanding of how Brennín's Western authority is created, sustained and naturalised within the text entails a closer examination of Fionavar's secondary cultures. The following section provides a brief summary of Fionavar's cultures before moving on to a more in-depth reading of Kay's rendering of the peoples of Cathal, the Dalrei and the Dwarf Kingdom. The most powerful of these cultures is the southern kingdom of Cathal, located beyond the River Saeren, immediately evoking the Saracen in its name. Indeed, Saracen markers are easily located in Cathal's Eastern sounding names, titles and motifs. There is exoticism in its sultry weather, aromatic perfumes and images of exalted personages reclining in elaborate rooms, beneath the waving fans of slaves. Exoticism is further reinforced in modes of clothing, speech and form; in phrases such as "The sun rises in your daughter's eyes" (Kay *ST* 121). Cathal is cast as beautiful, but with an edge of cruel brutality. It is simultaneously represented as both under- and over-civilised. Forms of cultural interaction are depicted as overwrought. Formal ways of greeting, acting, and prescriptions on how to demonstrate respect, at once can appear highly cultivated, but also over-embellished, artificial and obsequious. Cathal is the only nation which, albeit unsuccessfully, presents a

challenge to Brennín's position of ultimate authority in the alliance of the Light.

In contrast to these Eastern markers, the texts' depictions of the northern tribes, the Dalrei, nomadic horsemen of the plain, evoke the American 'Indian' in a generic form. The explicit Native American overtones are not without an inflection of the noble savage. Furthermore, the texts indulge in the fetishistic representation of a more 'primitive' Other. This is largely evident in the mystical connection between the Dalrei and their land. Images of Shamans, hunts, totem animals, celebratory feasts and wild dances are accompanied by characterisations which are simultaneously evocative of an endearing naiveté and, paradoxically, of deep, natural wisdom. Unlike Cathal, the Dalrei do not seek power within the war nor covet positions of political or military prestige. They feel it an honour to ride at the side of the heroes of Brennín, and under Brennín's leadership.

The text's treatment of the land of Eridu is only peripheral. As the land is ravaged by a killing rain and plague, little information is given concerning its people. The only surviving Eridun are its outcasts, living in the mountains. Physically, there is an echo of Pacific Islander culture, with Eridun faces decorated with green tattoos. There is, however, also mention of the father of a young outcast, Faebur, donning a white robe to formally denounce Faebur in the Lion's Square in the city of Larak. The ritual of him calling upon four heralds to witness his son's exile seems to point to a rigidly structured society (Kay *DR* 12). The 'primitive' tattoos seem almost at odds with the picture of white robes and town squares. The people of Eridu are also referred to as the "People of the Lion". This in itself evokes Middle Eastern

imagery such as that which labels Christ 'the Lion of Judah', or Muhammad's son-in-law 'the Lion of Allah'. The strength of patriarchy can be seen in Faebur's banishment for refusing to marry in accordance with his father's direction. Though marginal within the story, the text's inclusion of the Eridu adds to the complex form of exotic and historic multicultural colour. Moreover, the genocide of the (albeit largely faceless) people of Eridu serves the purpose of proving both the immense evil and incredible threat of Rakoth Maugrim and his Dark forces.

Not all the secondary cultures in Fionavar are non-Western. The Dwarves, a Tolkienesque staple in genre fantasy, are Anglo-Celtic in representation. On the whole, the mountain regions of Banir Lök and Banir Tal and their people are portrayed as more earthy, perhaps even more 'ordinary', in their ways. The physical imagery, the border status, the mountains and the mines, evoke both Tolkien's Nordic dwarves, as well as those from Celtic mythology. Their society's down-to-earth and comparatively unsophisticated customs are suggestive of an earlier, less refined and less hierarchical medieval society. Things valued are more tactile than abstract. Although, within Fionavar, dwarves are traditionally allied with the light, Kay utilises an ambiguity derived from Nordic sagas where dwarves are "depicted as being among the powers of evil who lurk beneath the roots of the world-tree Yggdrasil" (Ashley 304). Though as a whole the Dwarves fit with Tolkien's rendering of them as an (albeit flawed) essentially good people, Kay highlights motifs of scheming and cunning – characteristics that have long been attached to depictions of Dwarves (Ashley 304)

The two remaining cultures represented within the alliance of the light sit in a different category to those mentioned above. The lios alfar (Norse for 'light elves') and the giant Paraiko are mythological types. Both embody the other-worldly, and as such, do not seem to completely belong to the earthly Fionavar. The Paraiko represent something from outside, a pre-history shrouded further in mystery due to their voluntary withdrawal from the younger cultures of Fionavar. The Paraiko's association with the creation of the Cauldron of Khath Meigol aligns them with Celtic giants and heroes who possessed magic cauldrons such as Bendigeid Vran¹⁹ and Culhwch from the Welsh tales of the *Mabinogion*.²⁰ The Cauldron also provides a particular link to early Arthurian legend through tales such as *Culhwch and Olwen*²¹ and *Preiddeu Annwn*,²² and through the Cauldron's links with the Holy Grail.²³ The lios alfar, too, are mysterious, seeming closer to the divine in beauty, history, and solemnity. Their very naming defines them as light. They are clearly Nordic in both appearance and in their mythical association, and this again emphasises Anglo-Saxon centrality. Consequently, the lios alfar might be seen as serving the metaphorical function of standing for Anglo-Western heritage and the Paraiko for Celtic lineage. The other-worldliness of both Paraiko and lios alfar sets them apart, making them less grounded or 'real' in relation to political power in Fionavar. Through support and alliance, however, they grant approval to and affirm Brennín's centrality.

¹⁹ Also known as 'Bran the Blessed', Bendigeid Vran possessed a cauldron that could raise the dead which he gave as a wedding gift when his sister Branwen married Matholwch, King of Ireland, see "Bendigeid Vran" (Guest 33-48)

²⁰ A "Collection of [medieval] Welsh-language tales offering a glimpse into the largely lost Mythology of Britain" (Sampson 600).

²¹ A tale where Culhwch seeks Arthur's help to complete tasks to win the hand of Olwen, the daughter of a Giant (Jones 95-136).

²² *Preiddeu Annwn* or *The Spoils of Annwn* is an early Celtic poem in which Arthur and his men sail to the Irish otherworld to steal a magic cauldron (Ashley 427). This story is adapted in "the Wandering Fire" (Kay part IV).

²³ See "Fisher King" (Ashley 353) and "Grail" (Ashley 427-8) also "Bendigeid Vran" (Dixon-Kennedy 50)

The following section will discuss the texts depiction of Cathal, arguing that *The Fionavar Tapestry* employs a literary Orientalism. Cathal's portrayal sits comfortably within generic and Orientalist representations of the East, disseminated through a great deal of Western media and literature. In "Representing Middle Eastern Women", Irvin Cemil Schick speaks of the ingrained nature of Orientalist understandings and tropes:

[a] peculiar mixture of eroticism and exoticism, including such elements as homosexuality, slavery, violence, polygamy, concubinage, harem life, and public baths, came to constitute the building blocks of a certain discourse generally included under the rubric of orientalism. This discourse found expression in diverse media, from philology to theology, from literature to painting, and has, to this day, strongly colored western perceptions of the Middle East and its inhabitants. (Schick 351)

Many of these motifs are present in *The Fionavar Tapestry*. Cathal is second to Brennin in military and political significance. An alliance rather than hostilities between these two civilisations, however, sets Kay's depiction at odds with many texts that represent or re-enact the Crusades by antagonistically positioning East against West. Instead, it represents that which E.L Ridsen calls the "desire to connect with and approve the Arabic Other [that] ends short of any serious cultural integration and barely touches admissions of the possibility of equity" (187). Regardless of Cathal's key position in the army of the Light, its generic Eastern alien-ness prevents any unequivocal acceptance of Cathal's Otherness.

Situated south of the High Kingdom it has a warmer, more sultry climate. Its gardens of Larai Rigal are renowned for their beauty and, fittingly, descriptions of the land and the court are highly sensual. Cathal's court is

first seen sitting within a luxurious pavilion situated on the Circle Path which winds its way for miles within the walled gardens. It is here that Shalhassan – “Supreme Lord of Sang Marlen, of Larai Rigal, and of the nine provinces of the Garden Country” (Kay *WF* 108) – is shown reclining “surrounded by the scented finery of his court [...] under the waving fans of the servants” (*ST* 123-124). Indeed, the whole of the air of Larai Rigal is infused with the heavy scent of perfumes, “of calath and myrrh, of elphinel and alder” (*ST* 121). It is redolent with opulence and decadence. The court is described as “hedonistic and overbred” (*ST* 191). This is vividly illustrated as Shalhassan’s courtiers enjoy the spectacle of the “oiled bodies” of slaves fighting, “writhing naked on the floor in the presence chamber” (*ST* 191). The cruel face of decadence is graphically depicted in the capricious practice of power by Shalhassan, as in one breath he pardons the two slaves only to have one garrotted the next moment by one of his mutes for being a “little tardy in his obeisance” (*ST* 192). Such a scene fits well within the generic tropes of “[s]ensuality, promise, terror, sublimity, idyllic pleasure and intense energy” that Said identifies as longstanding within Western literature’s Orientalist representations (118).

As Alan Sinfield observes, the force of such widely reproduced imagery asserts significant ideological power, making the stories and characterisations endorsed “difficult to challenge, even to disbelieve” (33). So while Cathal is shown as beautiful and exotic, this is countered by the edge of callous brutality seen in depictions of slavery, in the use of mutes in the inner sanctums of the court, in the commonplace whipping of servants, and in a casual disregard for human life. Such representations of the Other

discreetly support Brennín's Western medievalist model over the novels' 'Eastern' Saracen stereotype.

There is a notable competition played out between Brennín and Cathal when Shalhassan and his force cross the River Saeren into the High Kingdom in order to join with Brennín as allies. This incident provides a clear example of how *The Fionavar Tapestry* naturalises Western authority. Unlike *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* where the protagonists all experience feelings of inadequacy and reluctance in regard to authority, leadership of the Alliance of the Light is strongly contested. Shalhassan clearly covets the role. Upon leaving Cathal his determination and expectation is that he should be the supreme commander of the combined armies. His mode of entry into Brennín is designed to physically illustrate the strength of his claim. It is planned with cunning and stealth so that his arrival might catch the young King Aileron unprepared. Shalhassan expects the soldiers of Brennín will:

Look shabby and badly prepared when [Cathal's] glittering force, twenty-five hundred strong, galloped up from the southwest. And not just the horsemen either. What would the Northmen say when they saw two hundred of the legendary war chariots of Cathal sweep up to the gates of Paras Derval? And in the first of them, pulled by four magnificent stallions from Faille, would be not a war leader or a mere captain of the eidolath, the honour guard, but Shalhassan himself. Supreme Lord of Sang Marlen, Of Lai Rigal, of the nine provinces of the Garden Country.

Let young Aileron deal with that if he could. (Kay *WF* 108)

Shalhassan's entry is a show with purpose. It is not a "trivial display" or "mere flamboyance", but intended as an unequivocal sign that Cathal is "no

subservient realm to Brennín" (*WF* 109). He reasons that the feuding principalities of the south (which have since been united to form Cathal) may have ridden under the command of Brennín in the first war against the Dark, but they are no longer divided factions. They are strong and united under a "real ruler, a man who had sat on the Ivory Throne for twenty-five years now, subtle, inscrutable, imperious, no stranger to battle" (*WF* 109). Shalhassan does not intend to defer to Aileron.

Shalhassan's assertion that "[b]attles are won en route" (*WF* 109) is shown to be both presumptuous and prescient, as all his speed and careful stealth in preparation come to nought. The battle for the leadership *is* "won en route", but not by Cathal. Rather than being able to sweep into Paras Derval unannounced, Shalhassan finds himself and his army met and honoured en route to the city by Prince Diarmuid and a contingent of Aileron's forces. The road is blocked by:

a score of soldiers mounted before them, clad neatly in brown and gold, weapons presented toward him with high ceremoniousness. A horn blew, sweet and clear, from behind their ranks, and the soldiers turned sharply to line the sides of the wide road, making way for six children, dressed alike in red, brilliant against the snow. Two of them approached past the Seresh honor guard and, unruffled by the movements of his horses, brought to Shalhassan of Cathal flowers of Brennín for welcome. (Kay *WF* 111-112)

With increasingly obvious signs of Brennín's anticipation of his arrival, Shalhassan finds himself presented with a tapestry, "a work of sheerest art in a gesture befitting royalty", depicting a scene from the first war at Bael Rangat, illustrating the event most "sung and celebrated in Cathal" (*WF* 112). The tapestry, though ostensibly an offering which honours Cathal, is also a

reminder of their previous place, fighting under Brennín's leadership in the last war. This presentation is followed by a welcome from Prince Diarmuid himself, resplendent in "a cloak of purest white, falling in thickly furred splendour from shoulder to white boots"; creating a tableau of "studied magnificence" (WF 112). Such an honour is further capped as a heart-stirring rendition of *renabael*, the battle summons of the lios alfar, played as a fanfare to introduce an important emissary of the rarely seen elves, Na-Brendel. Na-Brendel's presence, in his office as "Highest of the Kestrel Mark" (WF 113), tacitly provides official endorsement by the lios alfar of Brennín's centrality.

Shalhassan, therefore, is completely thwarted in his attempt to sweep in and impress. He is escorted at walking pace along a road flanked by smartly turned out foot soldiers, and archers and horsemen of Paras Derval. Upon entry to the city square he is greeted again, this time by the cheering populace and a delegation of Brennín's dignitaries, from the First Mage and the High Priestess, to Toronto's Paul, now Pwyll Twiceborn, Brennín's Lord of the Summer Tree. All this leads to the moment where Shalhassan finally meets King Aileron, who, Shalhassan notes, "had done this, all of this, on perhaps two hours' warning" (WF 114).

The semiotics of the following scene again privilege Brennín. Shalhassan's studied appearance, "from the pleated, scented beard to the fur cloak he wore, artfully slit to allow access to his curved, bejeweled sword" has been calculated to impress with its splendour (WF 109). This ostentation is juxtaposed to the appearance of the young king, whose austerity stands in

sharp contrast to both Diarmuid's studied magnificence and Shalhassan's lavish finery:

Under the unkempt dark hair, the eyes of the High King were fierce and appraising. His stern, bearded face—not so boyish as he'd thought it would be— was fully as impassive as Shalhassan's own, and as unsmiling. He was clad in shades of brown and dun, and carelessly: his boots stained, his trousers well-worn. He wore a simple shirt and over it a short warm vest, quite unadorned. And at his side was no blade of ceremony but a long-hilted fighting sword. Bareheaded he came forward, and the two Kings faced each other.
(Kay *WF* 114-115)

The Eastern flamboyance personified by Shalhassan seems as excessive and immoderately indulgent against the modest, efficient and no-nonsense Aileron. Faced with the realisation he had been unequivocally outmanoeuvred by the young “warrior King”, Shalhassan understood “that he was not going to lead this war after all”, though “Aileron had not spoken a word” (*WF* 115).

Shalhassan is reduced to “[a]bandoning on the instant every stratagem he'd envisaged for this day”. Instead, when he speaks it is to cede the coveted leadership to the young, untested king: “High King of Brennín, the army and chariots of Cathal are here, and yours. And so, too, is such counsel as you would seek of me” (*WF* 115). With nary a word the great Shalhassan is brought to a recognition of Brennín's superiority over Cathal, and to acknowledge Aileron's right to lead over his own. The ‘East’ is made to bow to the ‘West’, and more than this, is made to consider it an honour to do so.

The story of Brennín's victory is not simply left at the point of Shalhassan's submission. Behind the scenes of Cathal's entry into Paras Derval there is another competition being played out. In this contest Shalhassan is not even a contender; it is a contest between the austere King Aileron and Diarmuid, his younger, more flamboyant brother. Shalhassan, in order to save face through grand gestures, promises twice the number of men requested by the young King and states he will feed not only his own army, but "as many of the folk of Brennín as our winter granaries allow" (*WF* 116). When Shalhassan announces his daughter will arrange these things from Cathal, Diarmuid mockingly undermines the older man by offering a wager on the location of Princess Sharra, claiming that she is not in Larai Rigal, but hidden within the army. A public charade is played out as the visiting army is searched without revealing Sharra, and Diarmuid pretends to concede the wager to Shalhassan, knowing all along that Sharra is hidden within Cathal's honour guard (*WF* 117).

This may, on the surface, appear as little more than a humorous interlude in the novel, but the undercurrent again affirms Brennín's supremacy. Despite all Shalhassan's secrecy and planning, it is proven that Brennín's intelligence network was well appraised of all Cathal's movements and, in knowing the princess' whereabouts, aware of even more than Shalhassan himself. For Shalhassan, his only compensation is in the knowledge that Aileron had received advanced warning of his arrival:

Shalhassan, calculating furiously, salvaged one meagre crumb of nurture from the ashes of the afternoon: they had known all along, but if that was bad it was a comprehensible thing and better that it had been done this way than in two hours without warning. That was – would have been – simply too formidable. (Kay *WF* 121)

This one meagre crumb, however, is quickly snatched away as it becomes apparent from Aileron's "black expression, very close to a killing look" that Diarmuid had not shared his intelligence with his brother (*WF* 123).

Although Diarmuid's closeness with this information initially gives the appearance of a rift in the High Kingdom's leadership, Brennin's natural dominance is again reinforced. Diarmuid reasons that he and Aileron approach things differently, he with more spontaneity and Aileron with "charts and plans" (*WF* 122). All is made right between the brothers as Diarmuid justifies his silence by asking, "How else would you have ever known? How else would you have been able to put your planning to the test? I expected you to succeed, Brother. We had it both ways" (*WF* 122). Rather than demonstrating internal discord, Diarmuid's concealment means Brennin is proved superior both in planning and in stealth.

Such a scenario effectively works to completely exclude Shalhassan and Cathal from the competition for leadership within the war. Despite all of Shalhassan's cleverness, age and experience he is simply no match for these young men of Brennin. Ultimately the contest is not, as Shalhassan understood it, between him and Aileron, between East and West, but between the two brothers, West and West. He and Cathal become irrelevant, merely instruments against which Brennin's natural glory is reflected. Shalhassan is left with nothing to do but concede with admiration, even awe, to these young men of Brennin. "*Both ways*, Shalhassan was thinking bemusedly. They knew all along *and* they had prepared in two hours. What sort of men were these sons of Ailell?" (*WF* 122). Shalhassan of Cathal must admit the superiority of Brennin and the privilege of serving under Brennin's

leadership. Moreover, Shalhassan's recognition of this privilege is immediately confirmed by representatives of the dwarves and the elves. "Be grateful,' came a voice at his side. 'They are ours'. He turned and received a golden wink from a lios alfar and a grin from Brock, the Dwarf next to him. Before he knew what he was doing, Shalhassan smiled" (WF 122). Brennin's centrality is made to seem inherently right and natural. By extension, implicitly it is right and natural that other cultures should take second place.

The 'common-sense' rightness of Brennin's leadership is not solely confirmed by the story told within the pages of *The Fionavar Tapestry*. Such authority is shored up by countless literary and artistic reiterations of Western dominance, in medieval and modern Western literature, in Western Art, and even within Western histories and philosophies.²⁴ The sheer mass of conventional Orientalist representation works to naturalise a hierarchy of West over East. Fionavar's internal hierarchy seems plausible, 'right', fitting within not only generic expectations of fantasy, but within grand narratives that pit the East against the West.

Kay's renderings of Cathal and Brennin supports the "flexible positional superiority" that Edward Said identifies in Orientalist text, as regardless of the manner in which Cathal is represented in relation to Brennin, Brennin retains the upper hand. Significantly, Cathal is by no means portrayed in purely a negative fashion. Under Shalhassan's leadership it is shown to be a great, powerful and astute nation. Even positive representations, however, can have negative connotations when placed within the frame of Orientalist

²⁴ See Said, pgs 22-23 for a broad sample of writers touched upon in *Orientalism*. Said sees this list as "still far from a complete history or general account of Orientalism" (Said 24).

discourse. The text is equivocal even in descriptions of Cathal and Shalhassan's strength, wrapping it in phrases such as "shaped by intrigue", or "subtle, inscrutable, imperious" (WF 109). Moreover, Cathal's greatness becomes co-opted to prove Brennín's worth. Brennín is not shown to be great via a comparison to a weak, foolish or underprepared rival. It is great in comparison with greatness. At the same time, the positive aspects of Cathal's portrayal work to obscure racist, or at least ethnically clichéd, undercurrents within the novels. Indeed, on the surface, the inclusion of an Eastern nation as an ally on the side of good can appear a generous image of the 'Other', but the underlying Orientalism in Cathal's representation ultimately works to reinforce ideas of Brennín's, and metonymically the West's, superiority.

The above competition between Diarmuid and Ailérón has echoes of an earlier incident in *The Summer Tree* when there appears to be a rift between the brothers over who will succeed to the throne after the old king's death. There is a tense stand-off during which Ailérón lays claim to both the Crown and the right to lead the war, declaring the absolute seriousness of his claim: "I will kill for it, or die for it before I leave this hall" (ST 362). The matter, however, is resolved by Diarmuid's flippant graciousness in ceding the Crown to his brother, claiming his decision is based solely upon his need for a pint of ale after a bad day: "It has only just occurred to me that as High King I couldn't very easily drop into the Boar at night, which is what I propose to do as soon as we've crowned my brother" (ST 376). Just as in the later incident with Shalhassan, the competition between the brothers becomes a win/win situation for Brennín, as both are shown to advantage, and both are able to reflect different aspects of Western leadership and identity. Ailérón's

severity and uncompromising seriousness of purpose is tempered by Diarmuid's offhand and paradoxical mix of flamboyance and humility, while Diarmuid's 'common' associations and disdain for form are similarly tempered by Aileron's sober dignity.

Aileron's presumption of leadership and assurance of his own centrality is not challenged by either Diarmuid or Shalhassan. It is, however, directly contested by the traveller, Paul Schafer. Just returned from his testing on the Summer Tree, Paul accuses Aileron of being an "arrogant bastard" for his single-minded focus on all he perceives as his due:

"How presumptuous can you get?" [. . .] "Your War. Your crown. Your destiny. Your war. *Your* war?" [. . .] "What about the lios alfar? [...]" "What about Cathal"? Isn't it their war too?" [. . .] "and Eridu? And The Dwarves? Isn't this Matt Sören's War? And the Dalrei?" (Kay *ST* 374)

Paul here gives voice to a disquiet over the uninterrogated assumption of Western centrality and authority within Fionavar. Indeed, the text almost anticipates the possibility of criticism, but at the same time it provides the opportunity to answer such a charge with an appeal to the unassailable authority of destiny. Aileron's reply to Paul's charge is simply, "I was born to fight this war" (*ST* 375). The altercation between Paul and Aileron, therefore, ultimately works to confirm and strengthen the rightness of Aileron's position as leader, making it beyond challenge.

More than this, Aileron's assertion that this is his destined role is confirmed by Kimberly, another of the travellers. This is significant because Kimberly is now the seer of Brennín; she is a seer in her own right, and has also been

gifted with the soul of Brennín's previous seer, Ysanne. Consequently, Kimberly speaks with a double authority as she announces: "everyone, I have to tell you I've seen this. So did Ysanne. [...] what he says is true" (ST 375). Kimberly comprehends the necessity of Aileron's leadership, as her "blood sang to her that this was right" (ST 233). Medievalist and supernatural understandings of fate and predestination make Aileron's role indisputable. Like Paul who is left with nothing to say to Kimberly but "If you tell me, I will believe it" (ST 375), the reader is left with no room to question Brennín's headship within the alliance or Aileron's position as leader.

Sinfield asserts in his discussion of the politics of plausibility that: "by appealing to the readers' sense of how the world *is*, the text affirms the validity of the model it evokes" (Sinfield 50). *The Fionavar Tapestry* utilises the strength of multiple, even contradictory, discourses to justify Brennín's higher status. Brennín's comparative enlightenment and association with the masculine Britishness at the heart of modern Canada make it appear progressive and civilized. At the same time, paradoxically, Brennín's position and eminence are confirmed by recourse to the weight of tradition and destiny. Brennín's authority is also supported by entrenched representations of the exotic Eastern Other. These both bind the East to an inferior character and promote a western 'we' as natural and central. Kay unites the affective power of the medieval, the strength of the modern, and a 'sense of how the world is' to privilege his High Kingdom and, by association, today's West. Chapter 7 moves on to consider Brennín's standing in comparison with the cultures of the Dalrei and the Dwarves.

Chapter 7

Dwarfmen and Indians.

As discussed in the previous chapter, as Kay's imagery draws on medieval and historical depictions of the Saracen, Cathal sits comfortably within both medievalist and genre fantasy paradigms. This chapter focuses on two other major cultures in Fionavar; the Dwarves, a Western race who are a staple of fantasy literature, and the Dalrei who, in their resemblance to the North American Indian, sit outside generic expectation. I consider various contemporary implications of the power dynamics between the High Kingdom and these cultures. I also continue my discussion on the flexibility and utility of medievalist representation.

While the presence of Dwarves is unexceptional in a fantasy novel, Kay's inclusion of the Dalrei is significant. Just as medievalist aspects work to signal an attachment to heritage and the 'old country' in fantasy from European settler cultures, Kay's insertion of Indian tropes signals an attachment to the nation of Canada. They represent a desire to include Native Americans in the web of his fantasy tale, and give recognition to the significance that indigenous cultural narratives hold in the construction of a

distinctive national character. Although the texts strive for a positive representation of the Indian, I will argue they struggle to escape from the power of Orientalism and from the ethnic marginalisation that is ingrained in Western literature concerning the Other.

Before moving on I wish to make a note about vocabulary. In his book *The Imagined Indian* (1992) Daniel Francis comments upon the terminological difficulty brought about by generic representations of Canada's Indigenous peoples. Literary depictions which owe less to actuality than to an archetypal 'imagined Indian' blur the distinguishing cultural signifiers of various and distinct Indigenous groupings. Rather than recognising difference, such portrayals blend individual groupings into a homogenous whole. Postcolonial critic Abdul J. JanMohamed addresses the implications of generic literary renderings of the Other, asserting that:

colonialist discourse 'commodifies' the native subject into a stereotyped object and uses him as a 'resource' for colonialist fiction. The European writer commodifies the native by negating his individuality, his subjectivity, so that he is now perceived as a generic being. (JanMohamed 64)

Largely the invention of Western colonisers, these archetypal images effectively advance the coloniser's own cultural, political and economic purposes. Francis identifies the need to differentiate between the imagined image of the Native, and Indigenous Canadians themselves. Consequently, he uses the term Native and Native peoples when "referring to the actual people" and "the word Indian when referring to the image of Native people held by non-Natives" (Francis 9). In the following discussion I will use Francis' terminology, employing 'Indian' to speak of the 'imagined Indian' evoked by Kay's Dalrei. I do so consciously, anticipating that this usage

might highlight the Western perspective in the texts and draw attention to the constructed character of this image of the Indian.

Obviously, *The Fionavar Tapestry's* classification as fantasy separates it from histories and biographies and realist colonial fiction. It makes no claims to anthropological and ethnographic authenticity and cannot be considered against an actual grouping of people or historical reality in any straightforward way. This notwithstanding, the representation of the Dalrei clearly owes a great deal to North American Indigenous cultures and, by allusion, still participates in postcolonial discourses of the Native. They add to the mass of literatures, popular or otherwise, that together work to construct and maintain a generic image of the 'Indian'. I argue that even as fantasy these texts are implicated in discursive power struggles surrounding the West and the Other, particularly in regard to issues such as self-governance and land ownership.

The past, again, adds weight to representation. Kay employs medievalism to facilitate the integration of an Indian culture into his fantasy world. As was discussed in Chapter 2, the strength of generic convention still exerts significant power on expectation and what readers perceive as appropriate in the fantasy genre. I noted Kim Wilkins' argument that, due to the way Indigeneity is conceptualised in Australian contemporary culture, it does not easily fit with the conventions of genre fantasy (Wilkins COtH 140). Although a Native American tribal culture sits outside generic expectation, Kay mixes Indian tropes with Norse motifs thereby mitigating the contrast between medieval and native pasts. Medievalism also works to offset or blunt the New

Age aspects that easily adhere to fantastic representations of Indigenous North American peoples.

The reconciling association between the Indian and the Norseman is evident in the naming of the key characters from the plains tribes. Rather than use names that immediately evoke the Canadian Indian, such as “Crowfoot”,²⁵ “Wandering Spirit”,²⁶ or “Pontiac”,²⁷ Kay uses Ivor, Leith, Levon, and Tabor; names more readily evocative of the Vikings. This does not necessarily indicate a stepping away from Canadian associations; rather, I suggest that it draws from stories of medieval Viking contact with the Skraelings or the Thule, the ancestors of modern Canadian First Nations peoples. This is most obvious in the naming of Ivor and Leith, the patriarch and matriarch of the central Dalrei tribe. ‘Ivor’, almost a homonym for ‘Ivar’, recalls Ivar Bárdarson, the Church steward who, in the mid-fourteenth century recorded that Greenland’s western Norse settlement was overwhelmed by Skraeling incursions (Ingstad and Ingstad 178). ‘Leith’, in its close resemblance to ‘Leif’ evokes a further Viking connection. According to the Vinland Sagas, in the eleventh century Leif Erikson (son of Erik the Red) established Norse colonies in what is now Canada’s Newfoundland and Labrador. By uniting images of the medieval Viking and Indigenous Canadians, Kay moves the Dalrei more toward the generic expectations of high fantasy, appealing again to Northernness. The naming of the tribe’s shaman ‘Gereint’ works similarly. This name is found in “Gereint, Son of Erbin” from *The Mabinogion*, a collection of medieval Welsh mythological tales (Jones 229). As the tribe’s

²⁵ Crowfoot (c. 1830 – 25 April 1890) or Isapo-Muxika was a chief of the Siksika First Nation in present day Alberta, Canada.

²⁶ Wandering Spirit (b.1845 - d.1885) or Kapapamahchakwew, was a Cree war chief of a band of Plains Cree.

²⁷ Pontiac (c. 1720 – April 20, 1769), or Obwandiyag was a Chief of the Odawa First Nation in present day Ontario, Canada

spiritual leader, Gereint is associated with a Celtic Northernness which, as mentioned in Chapter 2, is aligned with “mysteries of the spirit” (Burns 14), while the Dalrei as a whole are linked with Scandinavian Northernness, aligned with heroism, courage, and manhood (Burns 173). Although this ‘Europeanising’ of the Dalrei draws them more toward generic expectation, it somewhat dilutes their non-Western cultural distinctiveness, making the appropriation and mixing of Indigenous, Celtic and Viking tropes problematic.

This merging of cultural signifiers accords with JanMohamed’s assertion that cultural uniqueness and distinctiveness are lost within Western literature’s depiction of the Native subject. What he claims for realist fiction can also apply to fantasy. The dichotomy between the fantastic and the real is not as clear cut as it may superficially appear. All literature is representation, no literature is real. Indeed, JanMohamed speaks of the strong pull of the imaginary in realist colonial fiction, arguing that while “masquerading under the guise of realist fiction, the colonialist text is in fact antagonistic to some of the prevailing tendencies of realism” (JanMohamed 68).

The pull of the imaginary is evident in how colonial fiction often forecloses on the possibility of historical change and cultural development. JanMohamed points out that Western privilege is maintained by preserving the status quo. Colonial depictions of the Other, he asserts, have no “teleology other than the infinitely postponed process of “civilizing” (JanMohamed 69). The text traps the Native in a depiction that is always positioned as primitive in comparison to the image of Western civilisation. This positioning is clearly evident in Kay’s representation of the Dalrei. Indeed, *The Fionavar Tapestry* fixes the Dalrei culture within an indefinable past. This is akin to the way in

which the colonial writers that Francis discusses situated the Indigenous Canadian in “a timeless Indian past where nothing much really changed” (Francis 41).

Pertinently, genre fantasy is well placed to obfuscate ethical questions surrounding the appropriation of the Native as a resource for Western literature. Licence for ahistorical representation can be claimed through the defence that the text is situated in the imaginary. Kay himself refers to this licence in a 2002 interview with Guy Haley of SFX Magazine. He speaks of looking at history through “the prism of fantasy”. He claims a certain freedom in representation, saying “I’m not writing the actual events” (Haley, online). Despite Kay’s use of generic Indian motifs and signifiers, the filter of fantasy (over real historical time and geographical place) is used to assert a distance from the histories and peoples he is utilising as a resource. Kay tells Haley that through the employment of multiple mythic and historical symbols and stories he is endeavouring to create “an ambience, a generally mythic flavour”:

The Dalrei of the plains are taken from shamanistic traditions of North American Indians and the Russian steppes, of nomadic tribes. A great many mythical traditions worked their way into *Fionavar* quite deliberately and the underlying purpose was this inchoate floating about of mythic ambience, rather than an expectation that readers would know any specific reference. (Haley online)

It is unsurprising then, that the Dalrei characters and culture in *The Fionavar Tapestry* appear both archetypal and fetishised. Images of the occult and the ‘noble savage’ are clearly discernible. Spiritual motifs such as totem animals, vision quests, a bond with nature, shamanistic insight, and intuitive capacity

are emphasised. These are combined with representations of innate bravery and physical prowess which unite images of both the Indian and the Viking.

The reader is first introduced to the Dalrei when Dave Martyniuk, one of The Five Canadians, is separated from the others during the group's magical crossing to Fionavar. Instead of arriving in Brennín with his peers, he arrives in Faelinn Grove, a wood on The Plain. Significantly, Dave is on the social periphery of The Five. He is not a participant in the close friendship shared by the other four. Dave's connection is through Kevin and Paul with whom he plays on the university basketball team. Dave's separation occurs when he deliberately pulls away from the main group during the crossing, making his social outsider status a physical reality.

On arriving alone in the wood Dave is seen by Torc, a Dalrei warrior who initially mistakes the traveller for a trespassing creature of the Dark. Only Dave's timely and instinctive exclamation of "Holy Mother!" saves him from summary execution as Torc recognises that "creatures of evil did not invoke the Goddess" (*ST* 265). The pragmatic ruthlessness demonstrated by Torc is further confirmed by his subsequent question to Dave: "Why [...] shouldn't I just kill you?" (*ST* 266). This introduction immediately represents the Dalrei as fierce and warlike, evoking a trope attached strongly to the North American Indian. Drawing on generic representations of the natural 'Indian brave', the physical description of Torc complements the warlike image presented. The reader is made aware of his "very quick reflexes", the knife in his hand and his movement, executed with "honed speed and silence" (*ST* 266). Dave's initial impression is that "Torc spoke of killing with disquieting frequency" (*ST* 267). He is described as looking "like a wolf, with his lean body, his long,

straight, black hair, and the dark, unrevealing eyes. He never wore a shirt or moccasins; only his eltor skin leggings, dyed black to be unseen at night” (ST 260).

Torc’s presence in the grove, however, is at odds with this ruthless warrior image. He has been charged with keeping watch over some ‘babies’ in the wood. The ‘babies’ are, in actuality, two young teens of the tribe, sent to the Faelinn Grove to fast and to wait in quest of a vision of their totem animals. Talk of the growing incidence of creatures of the dark has led Chief Ivor to send Torc out to watch over the young men, unseen. The appearance of an essential and practical fearsomeness is thus combined with a picture of sensitive protectiveness, encapsulating characteristics that increasingly emerge as fundamental to the nature of the Dalrei.

Torc’s own existence reflects this marriage between harshness and sensitivity. He is simultaneously described as both an *outcast* and as a *child* of his tribe. Torc, like Dave, occupies a marginal position. This is due to his father’s exile and mother’s suicide after, “by the sheerest bad luck”, his father killed a pregnant doe during a traditional hunt of eltor from the herds that roam the plain:

An accident, the hunters agreed at the gathering: the buck he’d slashed had fallen freakishly into the path of the doe beside it. The doe had stumbled over him and broken her neck. When the hunters came up, they had seen that she was bearing. (Kay ST 261)

This back story draws on a popular belief that, for North American Indians, the killing of a pregnant bison was taboo. Despite the accidental nature of the doe’s death, Chief Ivor has no choice but to exile Torc’s father. It is explained

that: “No Chieftain could rise above the laws and hold his people” (ST 261). This incident provides an illustration of how fiction can inextricably bind the Native to the past. Stories often conflate authenticity with a lack of change. The inescapability of tradition fits with JanMohamed’s aforementioned contention that Western depictions of the Other shut down the possibility of Native development (JanMohamed 69). As the value of the Native is attached to notions of authenticity, cultural development and change, paradoxically, dilute the perception of worth.

While the uncompromising severity of upholding tradition is justified by the demands of authenticity, any residual suggestion of primitive savagery is further assuaged as the chief watches over and worries for young Tabor, the outcast. Ivor is represented as a clearly emotional man who “always cried too easily” (Kay ST 333). This too, uses a stereotype of the Native, evoking a picture of the weeping Indian widely used in North American environmental campaigns in the 1970s and 1980s. This paradoxical mix of severity and sensitivity, ruthlessness and childlikeness, is depicted as natural, as inherent in the character of the Dalrei. Although there is a certain cold-blooded practicality in their cultural practice, it is portrayed as something quite distinct from the detached brutality associated with Shalhassan and the people of Cathal. The uncomplex nature of the Dalrei sits in sharp contrast to Cathal’s sophisticated shrewdness.

Chief Ivor has his own natural children, but believes that Torc is “his son as well” (ST 261). He sees the whole tribe as his children. Indeed, Part Three of *The Summer Tree* is titled “The Children of Ivor” (ST 255). The metaphor of the Dalrei as children is far from being ideologically neutral. The image of

Indigenous Canadians as children is not without precedent. Francis notes that early twentieth-century historian Rev. R.G. MacBeth labels the Indigenous South Western Canadians “Children of the plains” (Francis 64), thereby justifying White paternalism. Regardless of the Dalrei’s competence, their fierceness, and their physical prowess, Kay’s depiction of them as children infantilises the culture as a whole.

Just as this world’s travellers who arrived in Paras Derval serve as a conduit between the readers and the characters from Brennin, Dave serves as a mediator between readers and the Dalrei. His perspectives and beliefs operate as points of identification and also appeal to ideals of a common humanity. JanMohamed observes, however, that even identification with the Other in literature can work to privilege European perspectives and ideology. He argues that:

[when faced with] an incomprehensible and multifaceted alterity, the European theoretically has the option of responding to the Other in terms of identity or difference. If he assumes that he and the Other are essentially identical, then he would tend to ignore the significant divergences and to judge the Other according to his own cultural values. If, on the other hand, he assumes that the Other is irremediably different, then he would have little incentive to adopt the viewpoint of that alterity: he would again tend to turn to the security of his own cultural perspective. (JanMohamed 65-66)

In both these instances Otherness takes second place to a Western perspective, demonstrating again the difficulty attached to challenging entrenched paradigms of Western power.

This dilemma creates a distinct ambivalence within Kay's texts. There is a tension between the lure of alterity and the desire for identification. *The Fionavar Tapestry* sometimes indulges in the exotic image of impenetrable difference, while at other points it seeks to draw attention to similarities. The instability this creates, rather than being mitigated by the character of Dave as a mediator for the Western reader, is actually reinforced, largely due to the fringe position Dave himself occupies among the Canadian travellers. From the moment Dave is introduced in the novel he is shown to be socially uncomfortable, feeling generally ill-at-ease within a crowd and particularly awkward next to the easy-going, accomplished and urbane Kevin Laine (Kay *ST* 20-21). Dave's place on the social periphery provides an obvious point of fellow-feeling, with Torc particularly, and with the Dalrei more generally. A taciturn man, Dave lacks the refinement and social competence seen most clearly in the person of Kevin and, less intensely, in the rest of the Canadian travellers. Although Dave strives hard in his study of the law, high academic achievement does not come to him as naturally as it does to other characters such as Kevin or his own scholarly brother, a speaker at the Celtic conference. Dave is keenly aware of his social ineptitude. He rues his lack of diplomatic skills, particularly upon his arrival in Faelinn Grove, wishing that instead of him it had been the eloquent, likeable Kevin facing Torc's initial aggressiveness (*ST* 266). Dave's marginalised position is, therefore, key in his identification with the Torc and the tribe.

Moreover, physically, Dave displays many of the attributes highly regarded by the warriors of the Dalrei. He is described as a tall, athletic and agile man who "bristled with a certain aggressiveness" (*ST* 274). It is at physical rather than academic pursuits that Dave is naturally adept, and it is this innate

athleticism that cements the firmest of bonds between him and Torc. When Torc's life is threatened by an urgach, a terrifying creature of the Dark, Dave's instinctive reaction saves the young tribesman:

Only an athlete could have done it. With purest reflex, Dave launched himself at the apparition that had emerged from the trees beside Torc. He hit the hairy, ape-like creature with the hardest cross-body block he could throw, and the sword swinging to decapitate Torc was deflected away. (Kay *ST* 268)

In return Torc kills the still raging creature, saving Dave. The bond and understanding that results from this shared physical experience are on an instinctive rather than an intellectual level:

The two men gazed at each other across the dead body of the monstrous creature.

'Well,' said Torc finally, still breathing hard, 'now I know why I didn't kill you.'

What Dave felt then was so rare and unexpected, it took him a moment to recognize it. (Kay *ST* 269)

The fellow-feeling between the two is on such an instinctual level that it is expressed and comprehended without specific explication. This suggests a unified humanity, confirmed by an elemental understanding between the contemporary Western law student and the savage Indian brave. It is destabilised, however, by Dave's pre-existing marginality, and his inability to fully belong in modern-day Canada. Although his character can be seen as a mediator between the modern reader and the Other, Dave's identification is founded more upon his being like 'them' than on 'them' being like 'us'.

Interestingly, Dave's affinity with the Dalrei also fits in well with desires expressed by New Age philosophies. In "Plastic Shamans and Astroturf Sun Dances" Lisa Aldred comments on the appeal of New Age ideals for those who experience a sense of loneliness and dislocation in their own society; they can look to Indian culture to fashion a sense of identity and imagined community (340). She asserts that the "Noble Savage provides a fantasy for Euro-Americans wishing to escape dilemmas of their own culture. Imitation of Native Americans and other appropriations of their identity have often accompanied this romanticization" (341). Misfitted in his own time and community, Dave's welcome into the Dalrei tribe gives concreteness to the fantasy of belonging.

Despite his bonding with Torc, the alterity of the Dalrei is once more foregrounded as Dave is introduced to the tribe as a whole. But due to the use of common Indian motifs, this alterity is, paradoxically, also comfortably familiar. In her thesis on boundaries in fantastic literature, Jennifer L. Miller comments on the utility of the familiar Indian tropes that Kay utilises:

In many ways, Kay uses these racial images as shorthand to create a group of people. By associating the Dalrei with Native American tribes, Kay is easily able to convey a group of people that is spiritual and in touch with nature, yet that is also slightly primitive when compared to the races of people that live in urban locations. (Miller 25)

Natural and spiritual associations are emphasised as Ivor welcomes back the two young riders that Torc had watched over, as they returned from the dreamworld of their vision quests, their eyes "yet wide with wonder not yet fully returned from the other world, from the visions that fasting and night and Gereint's secret drink had given them" (*ST* 270). Although dream quests are

exotic and alien to a contemporary Western reader's belief and practice, the familiar alterity of Indian motifs make such a depiction seem immediately credible and apt for the Indian tribal culture that Kay creates. Through the combination of generic representation and the fetishisation of alien spirituality, alterity is situated comfortably within a contemporary reader's understanding and expectations of the Other. The Dalrei's mystical ties to both nature and instinct need not be constructed and made plausible within the story itself. The Dalrei's association with the North American Indian means a connection to nature and spirituality becomes a pre-established given.

This form of spirituality is further accentuated and even personified in the character of the tribe's shaman Gereint, ceremonially blinded in order to come to his power and receive his mystical sight. The association between blindness and spiritual insight is another motif seen in New Age spirituality. For example, Mary Summer Rain and Lynne Andrews, commercially successful authors and (self-labelled) New Age shamans whose works are contemporaneous with Kay's *The Fionavar Tapestry*, claim authority from having been mentored by blind spiritual leaders— "No-eyes" in the case of Summer Rain, and Ruby Plenty Chiefs, who Andrews identifies as a Canadian Cree medicine woman (Aldred 332).

The brutality of the act of blinding the shaman in Kay's text is justified both by the frame of Native tradition and by New Age notions of primitive wisdom. The spiritual and cultural import of Gereint's blinding is shown to the reader from Ivor's perspective, illustrating the deep cultural significance of an intuitive rather than intellectual understanding:

The sight comes when the light goes, the Dalrei said. It was not the law but it had the same force, it seemed to Ivor at times. They found their totems in the dark, and all of their shamans came to their power in blindness with that ceremony on midsummer night, the bright torches and the stars suddenly going black. (Kay ST 272)

This demonstrates an acute difference in the way knowledge is represented across Fionavar's various cultures. Although the magic of the shaman brings knowledge, this insight does not come from intellectual enlightenment. The shaman gives up human sight and human perception for spiritual sight. The shaman's power contrasts significantly with the power of the mages from Brennín, whose magic comes from rigorous study; from a cerebral comprehension of Skýlore. In *Whiteness and Social Change* (2013), Colin Salter pertinently observes that "[r]elationally positioned to the subjectivities of other knowledge systems, white ways of knowing are constructed as epistemologically (and ontologically) superior. This is at the core of Enlightenment rationality" (33-34). The novels' utilisation of the Indian motifs of affinity with nature and spirituality, therefore, imports with it racial hierarchies that can be seen to privilege the West.

The intersection between the reader's world and Fionavar is also particularly significant. Miller talks of the importance of the "interplay between the fantasy world of Fionavar and the world as we know it". She argues that it affects "the treatment of race in the novel as the characters from our world come to Fionavar with the knowledge of Native American images and customs and are able to make connections between the Dalrei and certain Native American tribes" (30-31). I would argue that it is not only the characters within the novels who are able to make these connections, as these cultural affinities are also clear to readers. The idea of the 'Indian' is not simply

transported into the novel by the Canadian characters; the novels' image of the 'Indian' is also metaphorically transported to the reader's world. As the similarities between the Dalrei and the Indian are so clear, by allusion the novels' depictions contribute to the mass of real world discourses regarding the North American Native.

The fantasy world offers a space in which real-world issues can be discussed at a remove from reality. Miller argues that Kay:

uses the fantastic interaction between our world and the world of Fionavar to address real-world racial fantasies and inequities. The fantastic interplay in the border space between Fionavar and our world provides Kay with the space to challenge the images created by these fantasies and rewrite the resulting narratives of inequity. (Miller 33)

Miller asserts that Kay's granting of legal ownership of the Plain to the Dalrei and his writing the Dalrei as a living presence function as a challenge to racial inequities and to dying-race discourses (33-34). A challenge can also be identified in the strongly positive representation of the Dalrei as a people, and in their culture's healthy relationship with Brennin. I suggest, however, that Kay's depiction is ultimately subsumed by the very "real-world racial fantasies" that the texts seek to challenge.

JanMohamed addresses the intractability of entrenched racialised discourses as he distinguishes between two broad categories of colonial writing about the Other. The first he calls "the imaginary" where "texts are structured by objectification and aggression" (65). He asserts that in representations of the Native that fit within the imaginary category, "issues such as intention,

causality, extenuating circumstances, and so forth, are completely ignored; in the "imaginary" colonialist realm, to say "native" is automatically to say "evil" (65). He argues that:

The writer of such texts tends to fetishize a nondialectical, fixed opposition between the self and the native. Threatened by a metaphysical alterity that he has created, he quickly retreats to the homogeneity of his own group. Consequently, his psyche and text tend to be much closer to and are often entirely occluded by the ideology of his group. (JanMohamed 65)

Fantasy fiction often indulges in this kind of othering of created races. An archetype of this can be seen in Tolkien's unequivocally evil orcs and Uruk-hai. This type of othering is also present in *The Fionavar Tapestry*, seen in beings such as the urgach, orc-like creatures, and in the *svart alfar*, the dark elves. These beings are completely alien and irredeemably evil creatures of Darkness. The other broad category identified by JanMohamed is the "symbolic":

Writers of "symbolic" texts, on the other hand, are more aware of the inevitable necessity of using the native as a mediator of European desires. Grounded more firmly and securely in the egalitarian imperatives of Western societies, these authors tend to be more open to a modifying dialectic of self and Other. They are willing to examine the specific individual and cultural differences between Europeans and natives and to reflect on the efficacy of European values, assumptions, and habits in contrast to those of the Indigenous cultures. (JanMohamed 66)

Kay's depiction of the Dalrei clearly resides within this second category. Not only is Kay willing to examine and accept individual cultural difference, his texts extol the value of difference. The difficulty identified by JanMohamed, however, relates to the manner in which Western writers, in the attempt to find syncretic solutions to the oppositions between the colonised and

coloniser, resort to “imaginary” identification. Although these novels “are conceived in the “symbolic” realm of intersubjectivity, heterogeneity, and particularity”, they are “seduced by the specularity of ‘imaginary’ Otherness” (JanMohamed 66).

The desire to see the self reflected by the Other exerts a strong appeal and is further complicated by the pressure of longstanding paradigms of race, position and value. The issue of Dalrei’s land ownership provides a pertinent case in point. Miller sees Kay’s representation as a challenge to our world’s racial inequities:

By making the Dalrei recognized, celebrated owners of their land and the eltor in his fantasy novel, Kay uses the fantastic to rewrite the theft of the Native American land in our world and establishes them as a central, vital, *living* presence in Fionavar. (Miller 34)

I argue, however, that the very granting of the land to the Dalrei within the context of *The Fionavar Tapestry*, though ostensibly presenting a challenge to inequities in postcolonial practice, ultimately works to confirm white Western authority and liberality. Dave becomes the instrument through which the reader is informed of the circumstances that led to a legitimisation of the Native tribes’ ownership of the land. With Ivor’s youngest son, Tabor, as his guide, he is given a cultural lesson concerning the Dalrei and is told that that, historically, the Dalrei did not live in the camps but lived in transportable homes made “of eltor skin and poles so they were easy to carry” (Kay *ST* 277). According to Tabor, the Dalrei’s escape from the demands of a nomadic lifestyle, and the privilege of living in permanent dwellings, is largely due to the generosity of Brennin. Tabor explains that one thousand years previous the Dalrei were granted the Plain by Conary, High King of Brennin.

This was a reward after Conary was saved during the battle of Bael Rangat by the timely intervention of a Dalrei chieftain, Revor, and his riders (ST 277).

Tabor's exposition provides a remarkable example of the subtle political undercurrents that can be present in genre fantasy. The story he tells establishes that despite the Dalrei's traditional occupation of the Plain, the land was not recognised as theirs by the High Kingdom. This tacitly reproduces imperial notions that a nomadic lifestyle does not equate to ownership. John K. Noyes's essay in *The Imperialist Imagination* (1998) argues that colonial discourses around the nomad suggest a purely accidental relationship between the Native subject and the land: "Their relation to the territory can be described in terms of land utilization but not of ownership" (96). Conary of Brennín is able to gift the Plain to the Dalrei. This action unquestioningly presupposes Brennín's authority over the land. It also implies Western benevolence as Conary is positioned as having both the right and the generosity to reward Revor and the Dalrei with the land on which the riders traditionally lived and hunted. Moreover, the permanent housing that was erected after Conary's reward became a symbol of territorial ownership for the Dalrei:

Revor called a great gathering of all the Dalrei at Ceidon, the mid-Plain, and said that if this was now our land we should have some mark of ourselves upon it. So the camps were built in those days that we might have true homes to come to as we followed the eltor about the plain. (Kay ST 277)

The transferable dwellings of poles and animal skin clearly did not count as "true homes"; implicitly, this signified the Plain was not 'truly' theirs. Only permanent dwellings demonstrated 'true' ownership. The recognisable Native American cultural markers in *The Fionavar Tapestry* intersect with

contemporary political discourses on issues such as Canadian Native title. The right of the West to determine ownership according to a European standard of 'settlement' is taken for granted. It is not at all questioned in Kay's texts, certainly not by the power brokers of Brennin and not, it seems, by the Dalrei themselves. Indeed, the Dalrei express nothing but gratitude to Conary for legitimising their ownership of the Plain.

Kay's depiction fits comfortably within colonial paradigms of belief – paradigms which justified colonial power and the usurping and governing of Native lands with rationales such as *Terra Nullius*, and notions of protecting, civilising, and educating Native peoples. Questions of land ownership remain an issue of significance in former settler cultures such as Australia and Canada. Moreover, Native title was an issue of increasing political importance in Canadian law and politics at the time of *The Fionavar Tapestry*'s production. The landmark case of *Calder v. Attorney-General of British Columbia* (1973) was just over a decade before the publication of *The Fionavar Tapestry*. This decision asserted that rather than being based on nineteenth-century treaties, Native title rested on the "pre-existing occupation and social organization" of Indigenous Canadians (Reid 346). This opinion influenced the *Constitution Act, 1982*, which recognised Indigenous treaty rights (Reid 346). Moreover, 1984, the year *The Summer Tree* was first published, was the year of the decision in *Guerin v. The Queen* (Supreme Court of Canada) that confirmed that Indigenous title was based upon pre-contact occupation of a territory. Supreme Court Justice Dickson, although recognising the presumptive Indigenous rights of occupancy and possession, argued that European rights of discovery diminished Native rights and that ultimate title belongs to the Crown (Reid 347). The Crown, therefore, was

obliged to work in the best interests of the Natives, “so as to prevent the Indians from being exploited” (*Guerin v. The Queen* 336). 1984 also saw the beginnings of the *Delgamuukw v. British Columbia* proceedings; the complex and contested nature of the issue of Native land ownership is clearly demonstrated in the decision for this case not being reached until 1997.

It is, therefore, noteworthy that Kay overtly makes the ownership of The Plain an issue in *The Fionavar Tapestry*. As Miller observes, Kay rewrites “the theft of the Native American land in our world” (340). The novels present the Dalrei’s ownership of The Plain as something deserved, legitimate and just. This shows how novels reside within JanMohamed’s ‘symbolic’ frame, being “grounded more firmly and securely in the egalitarian imperatives of Western societies” (66). But the privileging of the West is equally evident as the intercultural politics of Canada are reflected in the intercultural politics of Fionavar. Just as in Canada, where Western legal processes are invested with the authority to determine Canada’s land ownership, it is Conary, High King of Brennin, who has the ultimate power of decision over The Plain. There is a similar paternalistic tone as Conary’s decision determines the ‘best interests’ of the Dalrei. There is an unavoidable, somewhat ironic, residue of benevolence and of a naturalised Western authority present even within a Western recognition and acceptance of Native title.

Significantly, matters of intercultural conflicts and relationships are made simpler in *The Fionavar Tapestry* than they are in the real world of Canada. As The Plain is geographically separate from the High Kingdom of Brennin, colonial realities such as conflicting land interests are absent from the novels, as are moral questions concerning genocide and displacement. The

novels, therefore, are able to elide significant issues which present Western colonisation in a negative light. They can simultaneously approve assumptions of Western authority and benevolence to the Other.

The physically separate states of The Plain and The High Kingdom also avoid current postcolonial tensions. Canadian political philosopher Will Kymlicka speaks of the complexity that occurs when one nation state has “two forms of community [that] may not coincide: The political community may contain two or more groups of people who have different cultures, speaking different languages, developing different cultural traditions” (135). The creation of a distinctive separate space for the Dalrei’s sovereign state rewrites the physical and cultural politics of Canada, avoiding tensions that can arise due to cultural plurality and attendant competing ideological and political demands. Certainly, the use of familiar racial imagery within an imagined world can comment upon real-world inequities, but the distantiation of fantasy, the rewriting in a created world, can also act as a blind and a justification in complex moral issues.

The Dalrei’s role as a loyal ally to Brennin in the war also intersects with real-world, historical racial discourses. Much of the text’s positive valuing of the Dalrei resides in an appreciation of their prowess and adeptness as fighting men. Francis argues that Canadian Natives’ usefulness in war became a central mediating factor in how they were viewed by wider Canadian settler culture. He points to an ambivalence in the characterisation of Indians as formidable combatants, observing that Western images of the Native ranged from the “frightful and bloodthirsty” to idealised manhood. The Indian could provide a standard of “virtue and manliness against which Europeans

measured themselves, and often found themselves wanting” (Francis 8). Moreover, Francis notes that as “long as Natives remained valuable allies in the wars the colonial powers waged against each other, the image of the Indian remained reasonably positive” (8). Kay’s texts clearly evoke the nostalgic picture of a noble and unspoiled people, of brave and heroic, but subordinate, fellow soldiers in war.

As was the case with Cathal, Kay reinforces Brennin’s right to ultimate authority through an appeal to antiquity. The texts rely on traditional ethnic hierarchies, on looking back to the allegiances and leadership in the past war to legitimate contemporary structures of power within Fionavar. As the new war unfolds with the renewed threat from Rakoth Maugrim, the stories of the past hold great sway in the determination of what should be the case in this war. Unlike Cathal, however, the Dalrei need no reminder of their subordinate place. Ivor’s oldest son, Levon, makes a proclamation at the first council of war that demonstrates the Dalrei’s acquiescence to both the authority of history and the High Kingdom:

Never in our long history have the Riders failed the High Kingdom in time of need. I can say to you all that the sons of Revor will follow the sons of Conary and Colan into the Riik Barrens and beyond against Maugrim. Aileron, High King, I pledge my life to you, and my sword; do with them what you will. The Dalrei shall not fail you. (Kay *ST* 392)

This rendering of the Dalrei is a significantly romanticised, nostalgic depiction. It recalls the period of colonial conflicts in North American history where both coloniser and the Native were allied in war, united against

common foes, such as in the war of 1812.²⁸ Furthermore, the texts approve and confirm this imagined Indian past, representing it as authentic, natural and beneficial. Within *The Fionavar Tapestry* there is an honouring, not a questioning, of the laws and customs that bind the Dalrei to the way things have been enacted through the ages. Therefore, they appreciate the rightness and the honour of fighting under Brennín's leadership and are presented in a significantly more positive light than Cathal for their understanding of their auxiliary role. Much of the Dalrei's value is confirmed in their humble recognition of place alongside Brennín and in their appreciation of the distinction that comes with fighting under Brennín's command. It is an obligation which, far from being resented, is a matter for gratitude.

Rather than being depicted as held back by an adherence to hierarchies, customs and celebrations of the past, the Dalrei's value is enhanced by their loyalty to these things. Paradoxically, this works in sharp contrast to the texts' depiction of Cathal, where Cathal's hierarchies, customs, and celebrations contribute to the image of a culture approaching decadence and decline. As will be discussed in detail in Chapter 8, it also sits at odds with the rendering of the cult of the Goddess which is represented as reactionary. Contrastingly, the text firmly anchors the Dalrei's value and authenticity in the past. Their place is preserved in time, and their worth becomes contingent on a lack of cultural evolution, upon an unchanged adherence to practices and traditions rooted in antiquity.

²⁸ The War of 1812 was between the British Empire and The United States of America. A key theatre of the war was the Canadian-American frontier. In response to American incursions on Native lands, a confederation of Native tribes fought as valued allies of Britain and British Canada.

This image of an unchanging Dalrei is confused, however, by the dénouement of the story. One strand in the 'happy ending' is that the chief's son Tabor is elevated to the position of apprentice mage. Tabor's removal from the Plain to Brennín is placed among the marriages, the feasting, and the bountiful harvests that demonstrate a return to completeness in Fionavar. While this might initially be seen as allowing the Dalrei to move outside the boundaries prescribed by traditional hierarchies, the implications of this promotion remain problematic. Rather than a development and evolution in the Dalrei's own practice, in order to advance Tabor needs to leave The Plain and the tribe behind and be initiated into Western systems of knowledge, practice and power. Approval and pleasure at Tabor's good fortune is shown by the travellers; by Paul who is now a son of the God, and by Kimberly, Brennín's Seer. On learning of Tabor's apprenticeship "Paul grinned and heard Kim laugh with delight". It was a matter of genuine relief, giving an "access to joy" (*DR* 410). Again, notions of destiny are used to confirm Tabor's new role as "Paul had an intuitive sense of the rightness, even the necessity of Tabor's new path" (*DR* 410).

Although Gereint, the elder Shaman of the Dalrei, is rendered as an unequivocally worthy figure, as a man of both humour and intelligence with access to impressive occult powers, Tabor is not marked to follow him in the traditional mystical ways of the shaman. Instead, this bright young man is honoured by access to the enlightenment that comes with a learning of Brennín's skylore. Certainly, this is a far less brutal process than the blinding that accompanies the Dalrei initiation into shamanism. Tabor's position as apprentice mage, however, is also tacitly placed above that of a Dalrei shaman. This becomes evident as Tabor explains to Kimberly that his "father

gave his consent after Gereint asked me to come back and teach him some new things next year" (*DR* 410). Once more, the Dalrei are infantilised by a comparison with Brennín. A child, an apprentice mage such as Tabor, after only a year of training, will explicitly have risen above the elder Shaman, making Tabor the teacher and the old man the child. Implicitly, growing up and enlightenment entails a leaving of The Plain to become a man of Brennín, accepting and adopting the High Kingdom's superior ways.

Having examined Western privilege in my discussions of the Dalrei and Cathal, I return to the fact that not all minority cultures in Fionavar are non-Western. The depiction of Fionavar's Dwarves uses many Nordic and Celtic markers but even in the relationship between the Dwarves' realm and the High Kingdom, Brennín's privilege is clear. Instead of being rooted in ethnicity, in this instance the High Kingdom's advantage is supported by discourses surrounding class. Rather than representing a high, chivalric medieval past, the picture the Dwarves evoke is of a different, older, cruder, form of medieval pastness. The imagery is suggestive of a manual, working class society. As the mountainous region is reminiscent of the Celtic fringe, particularly Wales, it at once conjures both an older Britain and a working class Britain.

Within *The Fionavar Tapestry* some constructions of a medieval past are upheld, valued and granted authority while other renderings of the Middle Ages remain suspicious. As noted in Chapter 1, many scholars including Aronstein, Eco and Brown, argue that the imaginary Middle Ages are particularly plastic, and that varying medieval representations serve different purposes for contemporary society. Modern identity can be informed by

alignment with, or against, different imaginings of medieval times. In his much cited “The Return of the Middle Ages” Eco suggests ten contrasting constructions of the medieval, of which I would like to highlight two. These are the “Middle Ages as a *barbaric* age”, and the “Middle Ages of *Romanticism*” (68). *The Fionavar Tapestry* can be seen to utilise both these constructions. Brennin, given its associations with nobility, chivalry and enlightenment, fits the image of a romanticised and utopian Middle Age. By contrast, the Dwarves fit with constructions of the Middle Ages as a more retrograde, barbaric and superstitious Other.

The medievalism of the Dwarf culture seems to predate the French-influenced chivalric model represented by the High Kingdom. The Dwarfmoot, for example, evokes the early Anglo-Saxon folkmoot which admitted all the free-men of a tribe to a moot’s deliberation. However, given the decision-making process among the Dwarves is limited to a select fifteen-or-twenty senior males (Kay *DR* 221), the Dwarfmoot more closely resembles *Witenagemot*, composed of higher status advisors to the Anglo-Saxon Kings. Cultural historian Billie Melman speaks of the significance of Anglo-Saxon traditions in the invention of a democratic British heritage. She argues that “because of its remoteness, the pre-Norman era could be reconstructed as an inclusive fiction”, and points to how a Saxon character has been co-opted and favourably attached to English freedoms, a limited monarchy and to representative government (578).

In Kay’s texts, however, the Dwarves’ narrow democracy is presented in a surprisingly ambivalent, even negative manner. Standing awkwardly alongside notions of destiny and divine right, it is portrayed as disrespect for

ordained kingly authority. This negative casting not only sits at odds with positive British constructions of their Anglo-Saxon heritage, but also with the strong liberal humanist undercurrents discernible in *The Fionavar Tapestry*. Independence and freedom of choice are strong themes within the novels, with key characters such as Paul, Diarmuid, and Kimberly ultimately proving their worth and winning approval for choosing to step outside the expectations of destined role and position. Indeed, Kay notes in his interview with Thomson that “[f]ree will is a fundamental theme in all of my writing. It’s deeply important to me to believe in it” (Thompson online).

The apparent internal inconsistency in ideological perspective is obfuscated, I suggest, by the malleability of medievalism, and by presenting the working classes as lacking in insight and discernment. The suspicion of the moot system arises because charismatic Dwarf brothers, Kaen and Blöd, use democratic power to lead the Dwarves away from the Light. Implicitly, Dwarves are not sophisticated enough to deal with the manipulation of political cunning, and would therefore be better off submitting to the direction of their ordained and wise king.

Although the Dwarfish community has fallen into wrong because of persuasive, corrupt leadership, as a people they remain in a morally ambiguous position. There are Dwarf characters that are respected and admired throughout the story; particularly Matt Sören, the King of the Dwarves in self-exile, and Brock who remains faithful to Matt and to the Light. Significantly, however, Matt and Brock are closely aligned with Brennin. They demonstrate their wisdom, in part, by leaving Banir Tal in the mountains, and allying themselves with those in power in the High Kingdom.

Indeed, in the explanatory catalogue of characters at the beginning of the novels, both Matt and Brock are listed under the italicised sub-heading “*From Brennín*”.

Although he is King of the Dwarves, Matt turns his back on kingship and deliberately takes on a subservient role in Brennín. He leaves the mountains and ties himself to the great mage Loren Slivercloak, becoming the source for Loren’s mystical abilities: following him, serving him, and submitting to being drained of his own power to give Loren the magical strength to practice as a mage. Implicitly, it is better to be a servant to Brennín than king of the Dwarves. Leaving his land without moral leadership, for Matt the cost of his abdication entails complex guilt and grief. His heart suffers the constant pull of tide of Calor Diman, the Dwarves’ sacred Crystal Lake. Matt, however, is still able to articulate to Loren, the privilege of being the mage’s source:

‘I regret nothing: not a breath, not a moment, not the shadow of a moment. [...] There is no weaving the Loom could have held to my name that I can imagine to be richer than the one I have known.’(Kay
DR 213)

The relationship between Matt and Loren provides a remarkable metaphor for the role other cultures play in relation to Brennín (and by extension, to the modern, sophisticated Western world). The strengths of Cathal, of the Dalrei and of the best of the Dwarves ultimately and primarily serve to enhance Brennín’s own standing and authority.

Interestingly, Matt Sören, himself utilises the past in inconsistent ways, both to condemn and to justify. He casts Blöd and Kaen’s desire for old spells and powers as backward looking and degraded, whilst simultaneously validating

his own claim for kingship, power and authority by appealing to ancient traditions and ancient powers. Indeed, Matt was first crowned after, in conformity to tradition, he formed a crystal to be offered to the powers of Calor Diman, the mountain's sacred lake. Matt himself explains:

'he who would rule under the twin mountains must first lie at full moon night beside the lake. If he lives to see the dawn and is not mad, he is crowned under Banir Lok. It is a dark ordeal, though, and many of our greatest warriors and artisans have been broken shards when the sun rose on their vigil [...].'

'I saw the full moon rise above that lake,' he said. 'I saw many things besides. I . . . did not go mad. In the end I offered and was bound to the waters. They crowned me King two days after.' (Kay ST 394)

Although traditions and stories of the past possess great worth and authority in the world of Fionavar, there are also points within the novels where they become associated with the obsolete and the base. Kaen is condemned for "combing the oldest books" after being ordered to stop by a young Matt Sören, who desires to move the Dwarves away from the "spells and powers of the old ways" to seek the light he was shown at the lake (ST 395). There is a clear ambivalence here, as Blöd and Kaen's nostalgic desire for old spells and powers is named as a thing of darkness, implicitly evil, while Matt's authority to condemn such activities is confirmed by his enduring an ancient trial, described as a "dark ordeal" (ST 394).

Such disparate uses of antiquity create an unresolved tension within the text. The manner in which the desire for knowledge is represented in *The Fionavar Tapestry* provides another example of inconsistent standards of judgement. Although learning and the acquisition of knowledge is represented as an admirable thing for the travellers from modern Canada

and for the kings, princes, seers and mages of Brennín, it is portrayed as a dangerous thing in the hands of the more archaic, less refined, working-class Dwarfish peoples. As miners and craftsmen, the Dwarves are described as possessing “a knowledge of secret things in the earth and a lust to know more” (*ST* 395). The lexical choice of ‘lust’ to express this yearning for greater knowledge is pertinent. It is a word with more base connotations than synonyms such as ‘aspiration’, ‘longing’ or ‘desire’. It is this “lust to know more” that precipitates the Dwarves’ disgrace as Kaen and Blöd’s yearning to know more is corrupted. Their longing for power and secret knowledge moves past simple lust and desire, becoming a passion, and then a crusade as they become obsessed with finding and unlocking “the secrets of a dark thing: The Cauldron of Khath Meigol”, with its power to raise the dead (*ST* 395).

As noted Chapter 6, the Cauldron of Khath Meigol draws from Celtic mythology. Cauldrons, such as Dagda’s in Irish myth, and the cauldron in the Welsh tale of “Branwen Daughter of the Llyr”, were reputed to be able to restore the dead (Dixon-Kennedy 60, 119). The Cauldron of Khath Meigol is a mystical relic, created by the Paraiko, a cloistered and ancient race of pacifist giants. Despite the life giving power of the Cauldron, it is considered a thing of the Dark, and the making of the cauldron by Connla, the mightiest of the Paraiko’s ancestors, is cast as a transgression, as “a wrong beyond remedy” (Kay *DR* 72). The use of Arthurian and Celtic mythology in this subplot contributes to the novels’ mythic ambience and also adds nuances of meaning.

The dark connotations that Kay attaches to the Cauldron are primarily imported from earlier myths. In “Branwen Daughter of the Llyr”, the cauldron was used to raise dead Irish fighting men during a war between King Matholwch of Ireland and King Bendigeid Vran, the Welsh giant, over Matholwch’s mistreatment of his wife, Branwen, who was also Bendigeid Vran’s sister (Guest 44). A Welsh victory was achieved after the destruction of the cauldron, but only seven of the Welsh army survived, and only five pregnant Irish women. Bendigeid Vran himself was mortally wounded and Branwen died of a broken heart at the destruction wreaked on her behalf (Guest 33-48). Kay also draws from Arthurian derivatives of this earlier tale. This is clear in the undisguised appropriation of the quest narrated in the tenth-century poem, attributed to Taliesin, *The Spoils of Annwn*. The poem tells the story of Arthur’s voyage to the otherworld in quest of a magical cauldron. This is mirrored in *The Fionavar Tapestry* as a re-awakened Arthur leads a voyage to the mystical island of Cader Sedat in search of The Cauldron of Kath Meigol. Arthur’s ship is named *Prydwen*, just as it is in the Welsh poem. Like the tale of Branwen the medieval story has a tragic outcome, with only seven of Arthur’s party returning alive (Dixon-Kennedy 20). Kay directly refers to the disastrous consequences of the mythic quest to create a mood of trepidation and disquiet for both his characters and his readers:

[Paul] and Arthur looked at each other. ‘I have a question’ said Paul.
The Warrior lifted his head. ‘When you were there last, how many of
you survived?’

‘Seven,’ said Arthur softly. ‘Only seven.’ (Kay *WF* 271)

The transfer of negative overtones from Celtic and Arthurian mythology to *The Fionavar Tapestry* shows the strength of older tales. Because of their generic nature fantasy texts do not stand alone; a great deal of meaning is

drawn from expectation, from the knowledge and ambience of pre-existing tales. Just as *The Spoils of Annwn* inherits from earlier Welsh tales, *The Fionavar Tapestry*, too, appropriates meaning from preceding versions of the story. Kaen and Blöd's desire to discover and understand the Cauldron inherits a sense of dark foreboding from its predecessors.

While Kaen and Blöd's quest for esoteric knowledge is presented as evil, manual labour is shown to be a fitting pursuit for the peoples who dwell under the Twin Mountains; the Dwarves are approved and respected for working with their hands. In a paradoxical way, the works of their hands both lift the Dwarves to a more sophisticated plane, whilst simultaneously binding them to the material. Dwarfish artefacts are works of incredible beauty, wonderful to the point that Kimberly, on travelling within the caverns of Banir Tal, is overwhelmed by magnitude and splendour of the Dwarves' creations:

crystalline works of art, exquisite and strange. Most were abstract shapes that caught and reflected the light of the corridors, but some were not: she saw a spear, imbedded in a mountain of glass; a crystal eagle, with a wingspan fully five feet across; and, at a junction of many hallways, a dragon looked down from the highest pedestal of all. (Kay *DR* 216)

There is no question as to the profundity of the "art and mastery of the crystal sculptures" or "the casual power inherent in the vanishing doorways and the corridor lighting" under their mountain. The grandeur in scale invites awe, causing Kimberly to become "dumbfounded" (*DR* 217).

The ceiling of the chamber was so high, and the light all around so convincingly natural, that it seemed to Kim as if they might, indeed, be outside, in the clear cold air of the mountains.

Caught in that illusion, still gazing upward, she saw that there seemed to be birds of infinite variety wheeling and circling in the huge bright spaces high above the hall. Light flashed, many-colored, from their shapes, and she realized that these too were creations of the Dwarves, held aloft and in apparent freedom of flight by a craft or art beyond her comprehension. (Kay *DR* 217-218)

The intrinsic worth of the Dwarves then, becomes rooted in labour and tangible creation – in material works of aesthetic beauty; it is not sourced in abstract enlightenment. Their greatest worth is earthbound. Their artworks and the wondrous beauty of their creation are contained in the underground caverns. They can create a vision of the sky in a marvellous way, but this remains illusion; it is not the true sky, or the true light of the sun. It is intrinsically bound by the earth, both materially and metaphorically.

The Dwarves' highest achievements then, inescapably anchor the Dwarves to the earth, and implicitly, the Dwarves ultimate good is to find fulfilment in their works, not desiring more like Kaen and Blöd. Kimberly, in awe of the diamond eagles that appeared to circle overhead, asks "How could the people who were able to place them there, who *wanted* them there, be allies of the Dark?" (*DR* 218). Indeed, as Kaen and Blöd are among the "foremost" (*ST* 395) of the Dwarf artisans, part of their tragedy is that their 'proper' talents are neglected in order to follow an improper desire for esoteric knowledge. Indeed, stepping outside one's appropriate place is seen to be intrinsically perilous. Kimberly reflects that the Dwarves "could do marvelous things with stone under their mountains. They could also, under Kaen and Blöd, be servants of the Dark such as Maugrim had never had before" (*DR* 214). Her judgement evokes essentialist notions of place and role. To be

good, to approach full potential, one needs to know one's place and to accept the appropriate boundaries of position, class and ethnicity; tacitly, the Dwarves need to remain true to their manual roots.

The very system of confirmation of Dwarf kingship proves the importance of the works of one's hands within their culture. As mentioned above, the would-be King is required to fashion a crystal to offer to the powers of the lake. Implicitly, the created work holds something essential about the creator within it. This is most evident in the final contest between Kaen and Matt over who has a right to rule in the Kingdom, where both are required to offer works to the lake. Not only does this incident tie individual dwarves' worth to the products of their physical labour, it also suggests that, for them, there is a greater worth in rawness, in simplicity, than in attempts at brilliance, sophistication and refinement.

The challenge between Kaen and Matt at the lake is the outcome of a word-striving between them before the elders of the Dwarfmoort – a striving which, in the text's narration, reinforces a suspicion of Dwarfish sophistication and brilliance, and affirms the plain and the unpretentious. The corrupted Kaen speaks first in the word-striving. Kimberly, who is already familiar with the eloquence of Brenn's court, is almost overwhelmed by Kaen's articulate persuasiveness.

she learned how words could be claimed and mastered, brought to a scintillant, glorious apex—turned into diamonds, truly—and all in the service of evil, of the Dark.

Kaen spoke, and she heard his voice rise majestically with the passion of a denunciation; she heard it swoop downward like a bird

of prey to whisper an innuendo or offer a half-truth that sounded—even, for a moment, to her—like a revelation from the warp and weft of the Loom itself; she heard it soar with confident assertions of the future and then shape itself into a cutting blade to slash to ribbons the honor of the Dwarf who stood beside him. Who had dared to return and strive a second time with Kaen. (DT 225)

Matt Sören's genuine authority, however, is established in the very simplicity of his reply.

Blunt words, sharp, prosaic, unadorned. Cold and stern, they slashed into the Hall like a wind, blowing away the mists of Kaen's eloquent imagery. Hands on his hips, his legs spread wide, seemingly anchored in the stone. Matt did not even try to lure or seduce his listeners. He challenged them. And they listened. (Kay *DR* 228)

The persuasive danger of Kaen's sophisticated expression is clear, it is swaying people with illusory tricks; it is not 'real' but rather the 'mists' of 'eloquent imagery'. Matt's bluntness, alternatively, is shown as honest; it is solid and substantial, rooted in the earth itself. By contrast, however, eloquence appears right and appropriate in Brennín's court. There it does not signify trickery or danger. When exposed to Kaen's superior oratory skills Kimberly compares it to "Diarmuid dan Ailell in the Great Hall of Paras Derval" and the "power of his light, sardonic, riveting words". She recalls Na-Brendel of the lios alfar who was able to "take speech to the edge of music and beyond", and she "held close the sound of Arthur Pendragon speaking to command or to reassure—with him, somehow, the two became as one" (*DR* 224-225). Clearly, eloquent persuasiveness in the High Kingdom is something to be esteemed; it does not signify danger and pretention as it does when Kaen speaks to the Dwarfmoot.

The lesson that the Dwarves should remain grounded and humble is reinforced as Kaen and Matt present the ritual offering of their works to the ancient and sacred Crystal Lake of Calor Diman. Kaen's "resonate and beautiful voice" (*DR* 282) is matched by the sophisticated artistry of his crystal creation, a replica cauldron – "a glittering delicate, ineffable glorious thing of crystalline light" (*DR* 283). Matt's offering, by contrast, is "roughly worked, all planes and sharp angles, not polished. Where Kaen's cauldron glittered brilliantly in the starlight, Matt's crafted dragon seemed dull beside it. It had two great, gouged eyes, and its head was turned upward at an awkward, straining angle" (*DR* 284).

Within the text, the symbolism of these offerings goes to the very heart of the essential nature of the Dwarves. Kaen's sophistication represents an aberration of the nature of his people. His too perfect creation reflects "the soul of an artist carried too far. The search, the yearning for knowledge and creation taken to a point where madness began" (*DR* 283). His desire for knowledge is dangerous because it departs from the material. "It was all abstract, internalized, and so all consuming" (*DR* 283). The abstract is clearly not a fitting sphere of interest for the Dwarves. Implicitly, they should remain earthbound; for the Dwarves, conceptual genius is almost conflated with madness. Kaen "was a genius, and mad. He was self-absorbed to the point where that could no longer be separated from evil, and yet he held this beauty within himself, pitched to a level Kim had never thought to see or ever imagined could be seen" (*DR* 283).

Just as Kaen's polished genius becomes an implicit indicator of hubris and insane evil, Matt's material bluntness becomes a signifier of appropriate

humility and solidness of character; his is an understanding of the essential nature of the Dwarves. In the roughness of his carving “there was a power beyond words, rising from the soul and the heart, from an awareness not sourced in the conscious mind”; in its lack of sophistication Matt’s rough dragon approaches an “ancient, primitive power” (*DR* 284). Paradoxically, particularly given the disapproval previously shown to Kaen and Blöd’s quest for knowledge of “the spells and powers of the old ways” (*ST* 395), antiquity here gives authority. The difference seems to be that the brothers’ quest was for an esoteric understanding founded in the abstract, while Matt’s carving is solidly anchored in the material. It is “hearthstone, bedrock, root” (*DR* 285).

The judgement between Kaen’s abstract beauty and Matt’s earthy roughness is confirmed by the choice of the Dragon of the Lake, “the power of Calor Diman. It was the heart of the Dwarves, their soul and their secret” (*DR* 283). The summary execution of Kaen, who is completely and utterly consumed by Dragonfire, and the restoration of Matt Sören’s kingship, make unquestionable the rightness of Matt Sören. This incontestably exposes the folly of Kaen and Blöd’s quest for knowledge and power within Fionavar.

Significantly, the Dragon recognises Matt’s growth during his time of service to Brennín.

Then the Dragon spoke. ‘You should not have gone away,’ it said with an ancient sorrow. So deep a sadness after so wild a blaze of power. Matt lowered his head.

‘I accepted your gift that night,’ the Dragon said, in a voice like a mountain wind, cold and clear and lonely. ‘I accepted it, because of the courage that lay beneath the pride of what you offered me. I

made you King under Banir Lok. You should not have gone away.'

[...]

'Nevertheless,' said the Dragon of the Lake, and there was a new timbre in its voice, 'nevertheless, you have changed since you went from here, Matt Sören. You have lost an eye in wars not properly those of your people, but you have shown tonight, with this second gift, that with one eye only you still see more deeply into my waters than any of the Kings of the Dwarves have ever done before.' (Kay *DR 289*)

It is only through going away from Banir Lok, through becoming a servant of Brennín, through gaining wisdom during his time in the High Kingdom, that Matt is able to return and realise his true self and potential. This, too, is confirmed by the ancient and divine power of the Dragon: "Be welcome back, Matt Sören, and hear me as I name you now truest of all Kings ever to reign under Banir Lok and BanirTal" (*DR 289*).

Once more, just as is the case with Cathal and with the Dalrei, value is attached to knowing and accepting one's place. 'Knowing one's place' in *The Fionavar Tapestry*, however, has more than one meaning, and Kay is able to pick and choose from among them. In dealing with the various cultures in Fionavar Kay slips between one that ties a person to his or her cultural or ethnic roots, and one that indicates an awareness of the overall authority and superiority of the culture of the High Kingdom. Both these constructions are conflated in the character of Matt Sören. Matt's leaving and time as source to Loren Silvercloak indicates an acknowledgement of the supremacy of Brennín, and his return as a better, truer man shows a submission to his essential self and Dwarfish destiny. Ideas of place and role are not only embedded in portrayals of class and ethnicity. The following chapter will discuss how they can also be informed by constructions of gender.

Chapter 8

Archetypes and Myth.

Just as constructions of the Other and class continue to exert an influence within the genre of fantasy, so too can longstanding constructions of masculinity and femininity. As noted in Chapter 1, Brian Attebery draws attention to fiction's use of "traditional storytelling forms and motifs", warning that this might also entail an unquestioning acceptance of the past's social structures (87). Through my discussion on *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* I have argued that conservatism in regard to gender roles is by no means inevitable. Still, the generic nature of fantasy fiction can bring with it, both for author and reader, certain traditional expectations in regard to 'appropriate' gendered behaviour, propagating and confirming archetypes of femininity and masculinity.

The influence of medievalism on the high fantasy genre has done much to perpetuate the medieval tropes of women as either the Madonna or the whore. There is the inaccessible perfect Lady or the dangerous woman, entrapping men with her beauty, luring them from the pathway of chivalry and higher purpose. In *The Allegory of Love* C.S. Lewis comments on the inherent misogyny of both these constructions, saying "the truth is that

'cynicism' and 'idealism' about women are twin fruits of the same branch—are the positive and negative poles of a single thing" (145). Such recognition, however, did not prohibit Lewis from employing these archetypes in his own fantasy fiction, with characters such as Ramandu's daughter in *The Voyage of the Dawn Treader* filling the role of the ideal woman, and the White Witch in *The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe* and Lady of the Green Kirtle in *The Silver Chair* embodying the dangerous woman.

The equating of powerful women with danger is an exceedingly strong gesture in literature and mythology. It is seen in stories of succubi and sirens, in Circe & Calypso in the *Odyssey*, Guinevere, Niniane and Elaine, Morgause or Morgan le Faye in Arthurian myth, in Spencer's Acrasia, in Keats's *La Belle Dame sans Merci* and in the modern *femme fatale*. Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar, in the *Mad Woman in the Attic*, speak of the mythic masks male artists have fastened over women's human faces, identifying women with "eternal types" that men "have themselves invented to possess her more thoroughly" (17). This mythical masking of women is reinforced when generic representation and traditional tropes draw from textual forms with an historical lineage of engagement in misogyny.

The mythological antecedents that Kay employs are worthy of attention, particularly in his representation of Dana, Fionavar's Mother Goddess, and the God, 'Mörnir of the Thunder'. Rather than primarily casting the story in *The Fionavar Tapestry* as a Manichean battle between Light and Darkness, Paul Kincaid's entry on Kay in the *Encyclopedia of Fantasy* comments that the Canadian travellers "find themselves amid a conflict between a patriarchy and a matriarchy" (531). Indeed, this dichotomy underlies much of the series.

Fionavar's mythology blends ancient Greek and even earlier Semitic myth with later Celtic and Arthurian and Norse myth. As indicated in Chapters 6 and 7, Fionavar's differing cultures, pasts and traditions are not seen as possessing equal validity or worth. Similarly, more ancient mythologies, such as those evoked by Dana, the Mother, tend to be feminised and presented more equivocally than mythologies with medievalist and masculine associations such as the Norse myth called to mind by Mörnir of the Thunder. This disparate value exists despite both Dana and Mörnir being aligned with the light, and despite Dana more actively intervening for the Light's cause.

Kay's Dana is sourced in deities such as the Semitic goddess, Astarte, and the Greek deity Aphrodite. Sir James George Frazer, who Kay describes as a "formative influence" (Thompson online), asserts in *The Golden Bough* that these mother goddess figures are "the personification of all the reproductive energies of nature" (Frazer 139). They are incarnations of nature, sex, death and blood. Consequently, Dana and her priestesses are associated with raw, libidinal, corporeal practices and desires that pose a threat to the rationality which is aligned with the God and masculinity in Kay's tale. A boding of danger permeates representations of the Mother Goddess and her adherents from very early on in *The Summer Tree*. The priestesses are first mentioned in whispered conversation as Prince Diarmuid tells the mage, Silvercloak, "There was a Gathering[...] Seven nights past at the full of the moon. A secret one. They invoked the Goddess as Dana, and there was blood" (Kay ST 58). It is pertinent that this uneasy exchange is between powerful men.

In *Salome and Judas in the Cave of Sex*, Ewa Kuryluk, like Gilbert and Gubar, comments on the extent to which constructions of femininity are from a male perspective. She argues these constructions are “male fantasies which for millennia have likened women to matter—the earth, the moon—and men to sources of energy—the spirit, the sun” (191). These pervasive conceptions are evident in Kay’s texts. Dana is associated with both the moon and the earth, while Mörnir is associated with the sky and with enlightenment. Historically, Kuryluk asserts, “masculinity has been conceived as a force which animates and illuminates passive, dark femininity, while woman was generally described as lacking something—spirit, mind, intelligence, reason, a name, or a penis” (191).

Dana’s association with the earth is emphasised, as the province of Gwen Ystrat is not only home to the priestesses’ Temple in Morvran and Dun Maura but also to the most sacred caves of the Goddess. In her discussion on the iconography of caves, Kuryluk notes their association with the womb, asserting that because of this connection “closed spaces tend to be perceived as female and associated with both security and threat”. She argues that the “ambiguity of the cave arises from the fact it offers protection but imprisons as well. That it rapidly turns from a shelter to a trap” (20-21). The association of the cave with the material female body increases the ambivalence of its symbolism. As a symbol of the womb and birth, the cave is associated with life but, as it is devoid of the natural light that is “universally equated with life, with reflection and consciousness, and with growth and development”, it can also evoke ignorance and death (Kuryluk 21). The ambiguity deeply ingrained in the image of the cave as female is

present in Kay's portrayal of Dana, and this hinders a complete trust in the Goddess.

Alongside the symbol of the cave, Kay also employs an intense image of the moon to represent the Mother Goddess. Dana's moon, like the cave, is not insubstantial. It is depicted as material, embodied and elemental. It is incredibly powerful when Dana sets an impossible full moon in the sky on the night Paul dies on the Summer Tree, a night there should only have been the sliver of a new moon. Intended as a message of defiance to Rakoth Maugrim, Dana's moon is described as "red, like fire or blood" and as shaped by power (Kay *ST* 246). Although associated with power and beauty, there is a symbolic ambivalence attached to the moon. Clearly, a tacit secondary status is accorded to the feminine moon as it is set in contrast to the strength and light of the masculine sun. Where the sun is a "greater light to rule the day" the moon is the "lesser light to rule the night" (*Genesis* 1:16). Masculinity is associated with the sun's strength, with illumination, and with the clarity of day, while femininity is aligned with the weaker moon, night, darkness and secrecy. Negative connotations are further heightened by the symbolism attached to the shifting nature of the moon's waxing and waning. While the sun remains constant the moon is characterised by an essential capriciousness in temperament, waxing and waning, never remaining the same.

In *The Fionavar Tapestry*, suspicion of the priestesses reflects a suspicion of the Goddess. The texts' introduction to Jaelle, the High Priestess, confirms male apprehensions regarding Dana and Goddess worship. Jaelle appears as the archetype of the dangerous woman, being physically stunning but

sans merci. It is worth noting that Jaelle's first appearance is focalised through the insightful and empathetic Kimberly, who sees Jaelle as a dangerous intruder in a male domain. Significantly, Kay situates the negative judgement of this powerful and assertive woman in the mind of a woman. Kimberly perceives that: "She is all malice, Jaelle, all bright, bitter malice" (Kay *ST* 154). Her fiery beauty "was not a beauty that warmed one. It cut, like a weapon" (*ST* 76). Not only in the eyes of Brenninn's powerful men, but in the eyes of a modern Western woman, Jaelle's demands for respect and reverence in the name of the Goddess, her very dignity and bearing in her performance as Dana's representative, are simultaneously represented as intimidating and outrageous. Brenninn's aged King Ailell describes Jaelle to Paul as a trouble maker, stirring up tensions to exploit. He calls her "ambitious beyond belief" (*ST* 83). From the king's perspective, Jaelle's desire to "return to the old ways of the Goddess ruling through her High Priestess" is implicit treachery against the kingdom (*ST* 83). He also casts Jaelle's ambitions as reactionary, nostalgic impertinence. The manner in which the priestesses source their power in Dana and the earth is particularly delegitimised as it is labelled archaic. The king explains to Paul that Dana's priestesses could have legitimately claimed authority in the bygone days "when the wild magic could only be reached underground, and usually only with blood", when power was "drained from the very heart of the earth [...] the province of the Mother" (*ST* 84). In the High Kingdom, however, women's power has been supplanted by the implicitly more civilised and enlightened power of men. The feminine primitive has made way for the masculine medieval.

Fionavar's new magical power is in the hands of the mages who support and uphold the rule of Brennín's kings. The mages' authority was established by the learning of skylore, achieved through a combination of a human quest for enlightenment and divine revelation. Skylore is overtly associated with the God and is separate from the Goddess. The first mage, Amairgen, learned skylore "from the God, from Mörnir" who "taught to Amairgen the runes of the skylore that freed the mages ever after from the Mother" (ST 313). This imagery sets up a significant opposition between the ways of the Goddess and the ways of the God. Women's power might be strong and substantial, but it attracts fear, derision, and the resentment of men. Loren Silvercloak's thoughts as he passes by the sacred region of the Goddess exemplify the texts' suspicion of women's power; he shakes his head at the thought of blood magic as his "very soul rebelled against the darkness of this power" (ST 34).

Men's power, on the other hand, is tacitly depicted as liberated; it is of the sky, and not bound by the earth. It speaks not only of the favour of the God, but of man's ingenuity in his quest for enlightenment. This makes Brennín's medievalism remarkably modern. The triumph of Amairgen's valiant quest not only frees men from a dependence on the Mother; ironically, it also frees them from the God. Where women's magic is fundamentally tied to the earth and the Mother, and can never be separated from the material, the mages have been taught the runes. Through their knowledge of the runes they are able to source their power not in the God himself, but in the mage's source, another mortal being. As King Ailell explains to Paul, this gives men independence from the gods:

If a mage were to use his magic to start a fire in that hearth, it would require power to do it. Once all our magic belonged to the Goddess and that power was tapped straight from the earthroot; and being both drained and expended in Fionavar, the power would find its way back to the earth – it would never diminish. [...] But since Amairgen freed the mages from the Mother, the power will be drained from the source only, and he rebuilds it in himself over time. [...] That is the anchoring law of the skylore. (Kay ST 84)

Unlike the priestess' elemental power, which is materially inseparable from the Goddess, the knowledge given by Mörnir to the mages effectively removes the God from the picture; it relinquishes power to men. Ultimately, it is men who are able to act apart from the gods, men who have the fortitude to defy divine destiny and create their own story, and men who gain most honour within *The Fionavar Tapestry*.

This masculine freedom reveals a strongly liberal humanist undercurrent that creates ideological tensions within Kay's texts because contemporary notions of freedom are entangled with powerful images of destiny and obligation to the deities. Clearly is it easier to negotiate this tension within the paradigm of skylore, which empowers men to act on their own, than it is to fit the ideals of individual agency with the integral and material nature of the Goddess. Kay's alignment of skylore with enlightenment allows men's power to plausibly fit within contemporary humanist models.

In *The Disorder of Women* Carole Pateman strongly links liberal humanist discourse to patriarchal power. She argues that a "belief in the essential subversiveness of women is of extremely ancient origin and deeply embedded in our mythological and religious heritage" (17). Women's

association with nature, and men's with culture, is tied to a view that women "cannot transcend their bodily natures and sexual passions", making them "unable to develop political morality" (Pateman 4). Alternatively, men "possess the capacities required for citizenship, in particular they are able to use their reason to sublimate their passions, develop a sense of justice and so uphold the universal, civil law" (Pateman 4). Although modern democratic ideals admit women as part of civil society, historically their bodily difference was used to situate them in the private sphere, "separated from the public world of freedom and equality, rights, contract, interests and citizenship" (Pateman 4). Pateman argues that this continues to inform the manner of women's inclusion even in contemporary citizenship (4).

An example of this hierarchical discourse's persistence can be seen in Kay's differing representations of men and women. The historical setting becomes an excuse for tethering the priestesshood, and by extension womankind generally, firmly to a more retrograde image of the past. By contrast, however, a masculine Brennin, through associations with enlightenment, freedom and individuality, becomes a form of medievalised present. This once more demonstrates the valency in images of the distant past. The contrast between the arcane past of the Goddess and the enlightened medievalism of the God gives the imagery of feminine power an edge of perversity.

This perverse edge is present, for example, in the sensual elements of the midsummer celebrations of Maidaladen where, the grey-robed priestesses "must go into the streets [...] to any man who wants them" (Kay *WF* 222). Again, Kay sources this image in mythology and folklore. With its revelry,

Maidaladan invokes the Greek festival of Dionysus, and Bakhtin's carnival²⁹ with its festivity and sexual abandon; it conjures the pagan in its echoes of the temple prostitution associated with the worship of Astarte, Aphrodite and Artemis; it also suggests celebrations such as the Celtic festival of Beltane³⁰ which rejoiced in anticipation of summer as a time of fertility and growth.

A mix between the vulgar abandonment of carnival and the seriousness of religious duty is present within Kay's depiction of Maidaladan; titillation is counterbalanced by the appearance of reverent gravity. For the priestesses the prostituting of their bodies is not represented as vulgar or even erotic, but as a spiritual act of worship to the Goddess. Maidaladan touches the priestesses as "restlessness" rather than lust or desire (*WF* 221). For the men, however, the spiritual appears irrelevant. Worship of the Goddess is sidelined as the focus is on "supercharged eroticism" (*WF* 204); it is an occasion for "rough, boisterous humour" (*WF* 217), camaraderie, and for crude jokes about bedding "a priestess or three" (*WF* 204). Respect for the Goddess seems absent from the occasion as the men assert that free sex is the "only good part" of the Goddess' rites (*WF* 204).

The text goes further still in its ambivalent representation of the occasion, showing an overt, even official, disdain of what is due to the Goddess. Esteemed men within the story eschew the pull of Maidaladan, either practising abstinence or finding sexual satisfaction away from the

²⁹ Bakhtin's carnival is concerned with plebeian and folk culture rather than the divine. An association, however, can be made with Maidaladan's transgressive nature, its clear concern with "sex, and with death", and through "its images infused with an 'obvious sensuous character'" (Murfin and Ray 48).

³⁰ "A Celtic festival held on 1 May, which marked the beginning of the Celtic summer [...] Fires lit on the night preceding the festival were held to purify the land after the ravages of winter and to herald a time of regeneration and regrowth". (Dixon Kennedy 49)

priestesses. Jaelle, understanding the erotic draw of the occasion, expresses a satisfaction at the men's presence in the Temple during Maidaladen, as Brennin's kings consciously abjured all but obligatory deference to the Goddess. She takes pleasure in reminding Aileron that his presence breaks established royal practice: "Long years have passed since last a King of Brennin came to Gwen Ystrat for Midsummer's Eve" (WF 188). She is, however, immediately put in her place by Loren Silvercloak who announces that the men have other purposes in mind and are not concerned with rites of the Goddess. His declaration that "the rituals of Maidaladan are not to interfere" with their mission is straight away backed by Aileron, who asserts that as High King he holds ultimate authority over Gwen Ystrat, before charging Jaelle to obey the First Mage's commands (WF 188-189). As Loren Silvercloak is the focaliser for this incident, the reader is given a privileged, male and antagonistic perspective of Jaelle, Maidaladan and the precinct of the Goddess.

Loren Silvercloak, being "braced by his training to resist" the lure of the Goddess, uses his every strength in an attempt to "deny the power of Dana in Gwen Ystrat" during Maidaladan (WF 187). Prince Diarmuid, who has previously proved himself licentious in practice, declares he does "not like the passion of Maidaladan". Preferring his own passion he seeks out Princess Sharra, asking "Could we not pretend it was not Maidaladan? To see where our own inadequate desire carried us?" (WF 230). Tacitly, it is a sign of masculine strength to eschew the lure of the Goddess. Although Maidaladan is a strong expression of the feminine authority of the Goddess, it is unable to overwhelm masculine authority. The very material urges associated with the Goddess are made subject not to the God, but to the

discipline and self-command of the greater men within Kay's tale, elevating them above the pull of the material.

A privileging of masculinity can also be found in the character of Kevin who takes on the role of Liadon, the Adonis figure from the myth of Adonis and Aphrodite.³¹ As Liadon he sacrifices himself to the Goddess in order to end the unnatural winter afflicting Fionavar. The character of Kevin exemplifies masculine accomplishment. He is popular, physically attractive, athletic, good humoured, optimistic and socially adept. He is "known to be bright and accomplished, a star in law school and one in the making, everyone said, when he got to the courts. He had respect and friendship and he had been loved, more than once. His, a woman had told him years ago, was a face made for good fortune" (WF 206).

Significantly, Kevin does not even feel the erotic pull of Maidaladan. Despite his reputation and prowess as a lover, the "truth was that nothing of the desire that every other man in the company was feeling had even touched him. None of it. [...] whatever was happening wasn't bothering to include him" (WF 204). His decision to offer himself to the Goddess is not one rooted in ardent, uncontrolled passion, but one made in coolness, one made with the head. His choice to go to the Goddess comes from a piecing together of evidence, an almost pragmatic understanding of who he is and what needs to be done. It is the decision of a lawyer, not a bewitched lover. This demonstrates a transcendence of masculine rationalism over erotic desire.

³¹ In his interview for *The Camelot Project* Kay states that within *The Fionavar Tapestry* the Adonis story is "incarnated in Kevin" (Thompson online).

The novel, however, contains recurrent indications that Kevin is attuned to the Goddess, ambivalently imbuing Kevin's decision with a sense of destiny alongside rationality. A key example is the extent to which he loses himself in the act of lovemaking. The first intimation of this arises in Chapter 1 of *The Summer Tree* when Jennifer "found herself remembering what love-making used to do to him" (ST 25). The novel reveals the weight of Kevin's intense, driving and never sated sexual desire. Indeed, one of his lovers in Fionavar comments that he carries Dun Maura, the Goddess' sacred cave, within himself (WF 77). To this Kay adds the mythical imagery of Kevin being gored by a bull in a hunting incident on the eve of Maidaladan. This mirrors the Semitic myth of Tammiz and Ishtar, and also the Greek myth of Aphrodite in which the Adonis figure is annually wounded to death by a boar before rising again in the spring (Frazer IV, vol. I, 11 and 225). It is certainly not irrelevant that one of the armful of prizes Kevin had won during his legal studies was the Award for Evidence (Kay ST 25). It is through his evidentiary skills that he comprehends the combined significance of all these signs. "It was coming together. The boar. The moon. Midsummer. The winter they could not end. It had, in fact, come together. From within the quiet, Kevin finally understood" (WF 219). He recognises that while the unnatural winter lasts, Arthur and his companions are unable to voyage to Cader Sedat to face the traitorous mage, Metran, and destroy the Cauldron of Khath Meigol. He understands that as a sacrifice, as Liadon, he has the power to usher in spring. Consequently, though Kevin's sacrifice is cloaked in images of destiny, it is masculine rationality that is privileged.

Even as Kevin he presents himself to the guardian of the Goddess' caves of Dun Maura, he remains unmoved by the supernatural allure of Maidaladan.

Even more than the other key men of Brennín in the novel he has withstood its appeal. Despite the text's overtones of destiny, Kevin gives himself without compulsion. Although his sacrifice takes the form of an all-consuming, libidinal, material, orgasmic coupling with the Goddess, his offering is an act of his will; it is a decision made with reason, as he knowingly exchanges his life for the small possibility of victory in the war against the Dark. Traditional masculine attributes are upheld as the text makes it clear that Kevin's driving force is not desire, but a nobler, altruistic chivalry. He deliberately sacrifices his civilised, erudite and sophisticated self to satisfy the primitive and ancient embodied in the Goddess. In doing so he makes way for the medieval heroism represented by Arthur and the men of the *Prydwen* as, with the coming of spring, they can sail to the otherworld in a perilous quest for the Cauldron.

Significantly, as the Goddess ends the winter, it is Kevin who is praised and it is the act of a man that is exulted. Kay's text re-enacts the grieving of the women for Adonis where "the death of the god was annually mourned with bitter wailing" (Frazer part IV vol. 1 224). Here all the priestesses of Dana join with Jaelle in lament:

'Rahod hedai Liadon!' Jaelle cried again, feeling it rise within her, demanding utterance. The Mormae were all there now; she saw them begin to tear their own robes, to rend their faces in a wildness of grief and she heard them lift their voices to lament as she had done. (Kay WF 239-40)

Given Kay's statement that he intended the Adonis story to be "incarnated in Kevin" (Thompson online), it is interesting to note a key difference. Frazer

asserts that those who grieved for Adonis “sorrowed not without hope, for they sang that the lost one would come back again” (Frazer IV. Vol. 1. 225). Kay’s retelling significantly departs from the Adonis myth at this point, as no corresponding hope of resurrection can be found in the priestesses’ expression of grief for Kevin. Kimberly, both as Brennín’s seer and as Kevin’s intuitive friend, understands the finality of his sacrifice to bring about the end of the unnatural winter:

The snow was melting everywhere—in the morning it would be gone [. . .]. There had been a victory, a showing forth of Dana’s power to balk the designs of the Dark. The power had been paid for, though, bought with blood, and more. There were red flowers growing everywhere.³² They were Kevin’s, and he was gone. (Kay *WF* 262)

There is no corporeal resurrection for Kevin. Kay’s choice to deviate from the cycle of sacrifice and bodily resurrection reinforces the association of women’s power with danger, as a threat to even such an exemplar of masculine success as Kevin was.

Kay argues that appropriate payment is necessary for the balance of a story. He asserts that he hates fiction “where victory appears too easy. It’s another theme--the price of power, the price of victory. If we want something, we have to pay for it” (Thompson online). Still, within *The Fionavar Tapestry* there are significantly different consequences attached to offering oneself to the Goddess, as opposed to offering one’s self to the God. Where Kevin’s sacrifice to the Mother in the caves of Dun Maura is irrevocable and total, Paul’s sacrifice to Mörnir on the Summer Tree is empowering; Kevin’s sacrifice to the Goddess entails a losing of self, while sacrifice to the God is

³² This draws again draws on the Adonis myth, as the “scarlet anemone is said to have sprung from the blood of Adonis” Frazer, part 4. vol.I, 226).

rendered as a trial of self-examination, as a finding of self; Kevin is completely consumed by the Goddess, where Paul is not only given back his life by the God, but is granted a form of participation in divinity itself. “He felt the presence of Mörnir then, within himself, latent, tacit” (Kay *ST* 352-353).

Enlightenment is again coupled with the God. Rather than bringing about oblivion, Paul’s sacrifice gains him access to the twin ravens of Thought and Memory. This image is taken from Nordic mythology, in which Odin’s two ravens, Huginn (thought) and Muninn (memory), are released each day to fly over the world and return in the evening to tell Odin all they have seen. The method of Paul’s sacrifice on the Summer Tree further aligns him with Odin who hanged himself on Yggdrasil, the World Tree, in a quest for wisdom. Like Odin, Paul gains access to the power that comes with knowledge. “He was the Twiceborn, he had seen the ravens, heard them speak, heard Dana in the wood, and felt Mörnir within him. He was the Arrow of the God, the Spear. He was Lord of the Summer Tree” (*WF* 106). As discussed in Chapter 2, Britain’s increased cultural affinity with its Celtic and Anglo-Saxon heritage, and the concomitant interest in Nordic mythology, was accompanied by a decreased sympathy with Classical mythology (Burns 15). Medieval Norse myth, when juxtaposed with ancient Greek mythology, can appear modern and vibrant, and inversely, classical mythologies can appear darkly occult and primitive. Kay’s depictions of the God and the Goddess reflect and reinforce this dichotomy, re-emphasising the privilege of a masculine progressiveness.

Curiously, impressed by Paul’s strength and endurance on the Summer Tree, it is the Goddess who intercedes on his behalf as he strives to give

himself over in total submission, and impossible vulnerability, to the demand of the God to bare all on the Summer Tree. The raw nakedness of the soul required for such a sacrifice was so great that “brave Kings of the sword, wise ones, gallant princes, all would turn away from so much nakedness and die too soon” (Kay *ST* 239). By showing Paul that that human fallibility is excusable, Dana enables him to endure the test.

Even while depicting the Goddess’ grace to Paul, however, the text tacitly implicates her as a one who cannot quite be trusted, as one not beyond manipulation for her own purposes. Indeed, Dana herself owns that all her gifts are “double edged” (*ST* 253). When directly questioned by the God over her interference with his sacrifice, Dana blatantly uses her sexual allure to distract him. Dana’s voice is “woven of hearth smoke and caves” as she evades the God’s enquiry; it is “gossamer like the Dawn”, and like the “finest lace” (*ST* 252-3). The Goddess asks Mörnir to intercede to save Paul’s life and gains the God’s co-operation with the promise of sex:

‘I have interceded, Lord, will you not do so?’

‘For them?’

‘And to please me,’ said the moon.

‘Might we please each other?’

‘We might so.’

A roll of thunder then. Laughter.

‘I have interceded,’ Mörnir said. (Kay *ST* 253)

The God, though, and not the Goddess, receives the credit and Paul’s honour for the gift of his life. Paul even condescendingly informs Jaelle, “it was Mörnir who saved me. It was his to choose. The Summer Tree is the

God's, Jaelle" (ST 354). Although the Mother Goddess intervenes on behalf of forces of light in the war against darkness, the honour is constantly rerouted to men— to Paul, to Kevin, and to the God.

The privileging of masculinity that is evident in the broader mythological frame of the novel is also evident in the characterisation of individual women. In a 1999 interview with Charlene Brusso, for *Marion Zimmer Bradley's Fantasy Magazine* Kay notes: "One area I always wrestle with is finding plausible roles for women in historical periods. I dislike 'cheating' too much and hate the sort of fantasy that gives women a broadsword. Too a-historical for me" (Brusso online). The imperative of 'plausibility' makes it unsurprising that Kay's female characters conform to literary archetypes of women: Kimberly is a seer; Jaelle, as high priestess, is a powerful, therefore dangerous, woman; Sharra is the beautiful, feisty princess and lover; Vae is the mother; Jennifer is literally the personification of Arthurian Guinevere, caught between love and duty.

The Madonna/whore dichotomy is also clearly discernible within the texts. The good women become wives – adjuncts to men. The women who are not wives are the whores. Some are represented sympathetically like the promiscuous tavern girls at the Black Boar and the unmarried women of the Dalrei tribe. Some, like Lady Rheva and the women competing for the attention of key men in court, are represented less than sympathetically. The priestesses provide an interesting amalgamation of the two sides of the binary. They stand between the virgin and the whore as they generally eschew men as part of their calling but, as part of the rites of Maidaladan, indiscriminately offer sex to men once a year on Midsummer's Eve.

Despite the prevalence of free-sex within the novels, hetero-normative marriage provides the resolution to relationships. In keeping with convention, the central women in the tale become wives, ultimately situating them on the traditionally virtuous side of the binary. Indeed the happy resolution of the novels is sealed with the long-established trope of marriages and unions. “There had been a number of marriages all over Fionavar that summer after the war, and a great many proposals” (*DR* 400). Jennifer/Guinevere is reconciled to Arthur. Chief Ivor’s daughter, Liane, marries Torc (no longer an outcast) who has long loved her. Although just hinted at the end of *The Darkest Road*, Kimberly pairs with Dave; their marriage is confirmed in *Ysabel*, a later novel by Kay. Most significantly, as it is symbolic of the marriage between the God and the Goddess, Jaelle forsakes the priestesshood in order to be with Paul, just as Ysanne, Brennin’s former seer, had earlier abandoned the role of High Priestess in order to be with the Raederth, a First Mage of Brennin. ‘Promoting’ his women characters to the role of wife conforms to Kay’s desire to remain plausible; ‘true’ to the pseudo-medieval timeframe of *The Fionavar Tapestry*.

Kay, however, appears selective with the historical realities he adheres to in regard to women and historical authenticity. Kay chooses not to allow his women to wield broadswords because he feels this sits outside historical plausibility (Brusso online), but he appears not to suffer similar reservations about a-historicism when it comes to casting ‘medieval’ women, almost indiscriminately, as sexually promiscuous and as desiring the sexual attention of men. The historical reality of a Catholic Middle Ages which placed a high spiritual value upon virginity is ignored, as is the social and

commercial value attached to virginity in a patriarchal society. Moreover, the very real risk of pregnancy in a period prior to reliable birth control, seems not to impress Kay to the same extent as does the a-historicism of a martial woman.

The choices that Kay makes in regard to the constructions of 'historic' womanhood highlight a difference between historical authenticity and historical plausibility. The strength of archetypal characterisations of woman as temptress and whore trumps other practical and historical considerations, allowing his representations to meet certain conditions of plausibility. The women of the court are cast less as individuals than as a set; as a "gaggle of court ladies whose principle yearning in life seemed to be to elicit all they could from [Jennifer] about Kevin Laine and Paul Schafer, with special and explicit focus on their sexual predilections" (Kay *ST* 135). Their interest and sexual involvement with men is by no means covert. Indeed, Lady "Rheva made it clear, that she'd spent the night before with Kevin. It was evidently a triumph in a continuing game of one-upmanship, and Rheva was exploiting it for all it was worth" (*ST* 136). Jennifer's "effortless dislike" entails an implicit negative judgement of these women's promiscuity. Like the women of the court, Brennín's servant classes are presented as similarly desiring, but with less of the competitive 'cattiness' apparent at court. Upon visiting a tavern it takes little time at all for Kevin and Paul to bed two of the serving girls, as the rowdy atmosphere "greatly facilitated a rapid acquaintance" (*ST* 172). As will be discussed in greater detail in Chapter 9, in the exotic culture of Cathal sensuality and eroticism are presented as even more intense and intrinsic. An exotic sexuality is also evident in representations of the Dalrei, depicting the feminine Other as essentially desiring. By the end of the first night that

Dave spends with the tribe, a night of celebration after the hunt, “Three girls, no less, had made their way through Ivor’s doorway to the room where Dave slept. Or didn’t, after all, sleep” (*ST* 297). This suggests an almost indiscriminate sexual commodification of women.

Curiously, however, the text is almost silent on the possibility of pregnancy outside marriage. Indeed, Fionavar’s families seem to fit comfortably within traditional Western family structures. Although unmarried women in the Dalrei tribe can choose to have sexual relations with any man they wish, calling “the shots with anyone they like until they decide to marry” (*WF* 148), all families mentioned within the text appear as fixed nuclear groupings such as Ivor, Leith and their children and Torc and his parents. In Brennín, Darien is fostered within a family comprised of mother, father and children. In Cathal, too, Sharra and her now deceased brother, Marlen appear to be products of a traditional Western family structure. Regardless of the extent of extra-marital sexual activity described within the text, the text mentions no tensions or confusions in regard to paternity. Princes Diarmuid and Aileron have no bastard siblings. There is no suggestion that Diarmuid has left behind a trail of illegitimate children; the welcoming Tavern girls seem free of progeny; there are no children sitting alongside the unmarried women at court; the priestesses go about their duties, seemingly unencumbered by children. This does not fit with Kay’s stated aversion to a-historical representation; indeed, the silence on the logical consequences of widespread practice of casual sex seems conspicuous.

Kay seems, whether by conscious choice or oversight, unwilling to undermine the titillation of transgressive sexual practices and the sexual

commodification of the women within his novels' sexual fantasy. A general silence on historical complications, such as the value of chastity, the possibility of illegitimacy and unsupported children, and uncertainty in regard to inheritance and succession, allows most of the extramarital sex within the text to remain uncomplicatedly pleasurable and erotic. Kay does not disturb the story or indeed, the reader, with questions of moral or physical responsibility for either male or female participants.

The text only admits the possibility of moral and physical consequences when these are integral to the larger arc of story that Kay wishes to present, as in the case of the rape of Jennifer by the evil god Rakoth Maugrim. This rape results in the conception and birth of Darien, upon whom the fate of Fionavar will ultimately depend. This exception for the sake of the story sits outside the representation of consequence-free sex otherwise seen throughout the novels. The only other conception alluded to within the novel also involves a union between a mortal and a deity – Dave and Ceinwen, Goddess of the Hunt. Like the union between Kevin and the Goddess, these incidents hark back to ancient stories depicting relations between gods and mortals, such as Zeus and women including Io, Europa, and Callisto, or Eos and her many mortal lovers. Kay says in his Thompson interview that the rape of Jennifer also consciously references Guinevere's abduction by Meleagant or Melwas (Thompson online), versions which can be found in medieval texts including Chrétien de Troyes's *Lancelot or the Knight of the Cart*, *The Life of ST. Gildas* by Caradoc of Llancarfan, and "The Knight of the Cart" in Sir Thomas Malory's *Le Morte Darthur*. The mythic weight of classical and medieval stories can work to obfuscate Kay's selective application of the laws of conception; the realm of the gods can be treated

differently from the realm of mortals. As Jennifer, Dave and Kevin's stories work within paradigms established by earlier tales, they have access to a form of mythical plausibility.

Just as paradigms established in earlier stories can grant plausibility, so too can archetypal characterisation. As evident in Kay's opinion on the need to find historically plausible roles for women in medieval fantasy fiction (Brusso online), he validates his anchoring of women's roles to traditional stereotypes through an appeal to historical authenticity. Kay responds to praise for his textual representation of women in an interview for *Sci Fi Channel Europe* with the comment:

I used to be flattered when people said I did convincing female characters, but lately I confess it bemuses me. The implied idea underlying the comment is that it is startling that a man can do plausible women characters [...]. Creating characters is, in a large way, an act of imaginative empathy, and I'm resistant to the idea that there are absolute borders to that. (Auden online)

Plausibility in characterisation is, however, a different creature from multi-dimensional, empathetic characterisation. Kay's women seem to conform more firmly to nostalgic and patriarchal notions of the past where women play not just a different, but a secondary role to men. Their primary function is to confirm the value and position of men. Though ostensibly powerful, the central women in the story ultimately find their place through attachment and submission to men. Although Kay's texts actively include strong and dynamic women characters such as Kimberly, Jaelle, Leila and Jennifer, they are made subordinate to both the men in the tale and to the paradigms that mould what is acceptable for women.

Strong parallels exist between the romantic subplots ubiquitous in contemporary fantasy fiction, and the genre of romance fiction. As Janice Radway notes in her influential *Reading the Romance*, despite strong characterisations of women and proclamations of female superiority, romance is “an active agent in the maintenance of the ideological [patriarchal] status quo”:

Because the romance finally leaves unchallenged the male right to the public spheres of work, politics and power, because it refurbishes the institution of marriage by suggesting how it may be viewed continuously as a courtship, because it represents real female needs within the story and then depicts their satisfaction by traditional heterosexual relations, the romance avoids questioning the institutionalised bias of patriarchal control over women. (Radway 217)

Through an examination of the dynamics between Touchstone and Sabriel, I argued in Chapter 5 that it is possible for genre fantasy to step outside entrenched gender hierarchies, even in the representation of romantic relationships. The relationships in *The Fionavar Tapestry*, however, confirm rather than challenge traditional gendered hierarchies. Indeed, Kay’s romantic subplots fit well within the romantic dynamic described by Radway.

As a medical intern in Toronto, Kimberly is advantageously situated to embark on a career in a socially and economically powerful profession. In *Fionavar*, however, her role as seer is one more firmly associated with the feminine. As seer, Kimberly holds great knowledge of both the future and the past, but her actions are directed by her sight and by the power of a magical ring, the Baelrath, also known as the Warstone. Significantly, Kimberly’s first role as seer is to validate the rightness of a man’s authority, confirming

Aileron as the new King of Brennin and as leader in the war. Despite the strength attached to her gifts, power comes at the expense of her autonomy. The Baelrath compels her to act against her character and even her will. It is “wild, allowing no compunction or pity, knowing only the demands of war, the dictates of absolute need” (*DR* 68). For Kimberly this is “deeply unsettling, but when had there been anything reassuring or easy about the ring she bore? In every single thing she had ever done with the Baelrath, there was pain” (*DR* 56). Although her gifts of the sight and the ring give her authority, she feels corrupted and stripped of her nature by their demands.

When Kimberly ultimately exercises her own choice in refusing the Baelrath’s command to bind the Crystal Dragon of Calor Diman, the ring withdraws its power (*DR* 291). This suggests a mutual exclusivity between power and Kimberly’s moral disposition, and also between the exercise of authority and female autonomy. Her assertion of self leaves her “powerless, empty of all save pity and grief, which didn’t count for anything” (*DR* 376). Although Kimberly is ultimately approved for her moral choice, there remains a suggestion that there is a fundamental incompatibility between weighty power and characteristics that are culturally more associated with femininity, such as nurturing and sympathy. This implies that authority and femininity are ill-fitted. Although Kimberly’s character holds substantial power within the story, the restoration of rightness at the end of the trilogy entails an abdication of this power and conformity to domestic tradition. This is seen in her marriage to Dave and in the renunciation of larger aspirations in the medical and professional realm in favour of the commonplace of family practice.³³

³³ See Guy Gavriel Kay *Ysabel* Simon and Schuster, London, 2007

The incompatibility between femininity and power, implied in the story of Kimberly, is more strongly reinforced in the story of Jaelle. Like Kimberly, Jaelle is another undeniably strong woman character within *The Fionavar Tapestry*. As high Priestess to the Goddess, Jaelle holds a position of authority that explicitly refuses full submission to male incarnations of power in the form of Brennín's monarchy and mages. There is a disdain for men shown in both her beliefs and her behaviour. Although, with the ascendancy of skylore, the priestess' power has been marginalised and often reduced to mere symbolism, Jaelle demands precedence on behalf of the Goddess, not only in the formal situations of ceremony in Court, but also in matters of decision making. It is Jaelle who performs the duty of crowning the new High King and who is appointed co-governor of the realm alongside Brennín's Chancellor while King Aileron is absent due to the war. As representative of the Goddess she has access to supernatural powers. "Hers was the duty and the power, both, to shape the spun webs of Dana's will" (*DR* 23), and she draws upon this power to actively participate in the war against the Dark.

Jaelle's power, however, is tied to the image of her as bitter and hate-filled in her dealings with men. Despite her authority, her competence and her position, Jaelle's strength is represented not as a positive value, but as evidence of an emotional lack. Her hostility is not only directed toward the men of Brennín but also, perhaps even more strongly, toward women who support them. A prime example of this is her attitude to Ysanne, who had forsaken the privilege high priestesshood in the order to become the lover of Raederth, a First Mage of Brennín: "Jaelle spoke again, her voice bitter, cold.

'She sold herself for a body at night. May the hag die soon and lie lost forever'" (ST 146).

It is easy to read Jaelle's attitude as something of a caricature of the modern angry, 'extreme' feminist. Kay's almost didactic censuring of this attitude is clear in the challenging exchange between Jaelle and Jennifer at the temple. This occurs after Jennifer's bodyguard objects to his charge entering the sanctuary, a place where he as a male is not allowed to follow. Jaelle's ensuing criticism of men's control is not validated, but rather cast as dangerous and duplicitous manoeuvring. Moreover, paternalistic authority is reinforced:

'Ah!' said Jaelle, her eyebrows arched maliciously. 'It seems that the men here are already saying what you can or cannot do. Forgive me my invitation. I thought I was dealing with a free visitor.'

Jennifer was not oblivious to the manipulation, and she remembered Kevin's words that morning as well: 'There's some danger here,' he'd said soberly. 'Trust Diarmuid's men, and Matt, of course. Paul says be careful of the Priestess. Don't go anywhere on your own.' (Kay ST 143)

As a clever woman, Jaelle is cast as malicious and manipulative, while the males, Kevin, Diarmuid, Matt and Paul are presented as intrinsically trustworthy. Significantly, Kay uses a female character, Jennifer, as focaliser, as the moderate voice that labels Jaelle's position as both excessive and perverted: "'I'm not happy about male control in my world, either, but I've never in my life met anyone as screwed up on the subject as you are.'" (ST 148). Jennifer becomes the vessel through which a man's texts can question Jaelle's feminist rhetoric. By implication Jennifer situates men as essential to a fulfilled complete womanhood, as she goes on to question if Jaelle can

“even guess what [love] feels like” (*ST* 148). This tacitly equates an autonomous and independent womanhood with being emotionally stunted, twisted and bitter. While Jaelle is censured within the text, Jennifer is tacitly approved within the text’s narration for her feminine empathy, and also for her intuition to trust Paul, Kevin and Diarmuid’s men over Jaelle.

The conservative and paternalistic overtones within the text are justified by the extreme representation of Jaelle’s disdain for male power, and further disguised by Kay voicing his ‘moderate’ views through a female mouthpiece. Jennifer is a character who gives lip service to feminist views while ultimately submitting to patriarchal authority. This represents a tacit legitimisation of conservative models of gender relations. It calls upon a positive nostalgia for times past, a nostalgia that adheres to notions of a gendered, essential order in which men hold authority as loving protectors. In order to achieve fulfilment and gain her happy ending, Jaelle is made to submit to these nostalgic models, and to the power of heteronormative romantic love.

Jaelle’s driving passion for the goddess, coupled as it is with her disdain for masculine pretensions, is broken down. In a rare moment of narrative focalisation through Jaelle, she finds herself uneasy with her power. Her certainty is first shaken by Kevin’s sacrifice to the Goddess, and ultimately undone by feelings of love for Paul.

For all Jaelle’s knowledge, all her immersion in the nature of the Goddess, Kevin’s had been an act so overwhelming, so consummately gallant, it had irrevocably blurred the clarity with which once she’d viewed the world. He was a man, and yet he had done

this thing. It was, since Maidaladan, so much harder to summon the old anger and bitterness, the hate. (Kay *DR* 25)

Following the tempering of bitterness that begins with Kevin's sacrifice, Jaelle cannot help but be impressed by Paul and his power as Lord of the Summer Tree. She tells Paul "I fell in love with you on the beach at Taerlindel. When you stood in the waves, speaking to [the sea god] Liranan" (*DR* 414). At Taerlindel Paul appeals to Liranan as a brother, as a fellow son of Mörnir, the god of Thunder. This displays Paul's divine aspect above his mortal one. A recognition of Paul's power makes Jaelle hold less tightly to her own.

It is not insignificant then, that a full realisation of her love for Paul comes when Jaelle again sees him at the pinnacle of his power, facing Galadan, the Wolflord, lieutenant to Rakoth Maugrim, and at the end of the final battle.

Jaelle looked upon his face and saw power written there so deeply and so clearly that she was afraid. And it was as Lord of the Summer Tree the Twiceborn of Mörnir that he spoke. [...]

He walked past her, slowly, [...]. Jaelle followed after Pwyll, carrying her silver circlet in her hand. Above her head as she walked down to the plain she heard the quick, invisible wings of his ravens, Thought and Memory. She didn't know what he was about to do, but in that moment she knew another thing, a truth about the depths of her own heart [...] (Kay *DR* 384-5)

The silver circlet that designates Jaelle as high priestess has fallen from her head; her carrying it in her hand rather than wearing it as a coronet not only a foreshadowing of her power passing to Leila; it also symbolically suggests that she is no longer ruled by her position. Instead of having the symbol of the high priestess of the Goddess above her head, Jaelle now senses the

ravens above her which represent the essence of Paul's power. Tacit within this imagery is that power and high status as a woman are incompatible with a romantic partnership; in such a relationship masculine authority naturally supersedes the feminine. It is significant that this scene of capitulation is also focalised by Jaelle, conflating male authority and female desire. Contrastingly, the passage where the couple declare their love and consummate their relationship is focalised Paul: "he was sure [...]", "the world shifted within him and around him [...]", "He took one step, another [...]", "he lowered his mouth[...]", "He was clear at last [...]" (*DR* 414). This provides an example of the manner in which sexuality, as represented within the novel, is fantasised from a masculine perspective.

Kay argues that a significant part of the happy ending of *The Fionavar Tapestry* is the "fusing of the skylore and the earth goddess magic that takes place symbolically in Paul and Jaelle" (Thompson online). On the surface, this symbolic joining of the God and the Goddess through Paul and Jaelle seems to represent conciliation, balance, and unification— creating a sense of completeness, good will and romantic fulfilment. This reconciliation, however, is only achieved at the expense of Jaelle's power and at the cost of her position as high priestess of the Goddess. Jaelle expresses her willingness to give up everything Paul, "I will die to have you" (*DR* 415).

Within the story, fate conveniently intervenes to remove all obstacles to Paul and Jaelle's union. It is happily revealed that Jaelle is now High Priestess in name only, as she is being succeeded by the young priestess, Leila, whose

actions during the war meant she was “marked by the Goddess to the white of the High Priestess” (*DR* 416). This leaves Jaelle with no option but to relinquish her place and serendipitously frees her to find true fulfilment through romantic love, without any crisis of loyalty. Indeed, implicitly, this romantic ending is the will of the Goddess, as Jaelle notes that “Dana moves in ways no mortal can understand, nor even the others among the gods” (*DR* 416). Again, however, credit is rerouted to a man, to Kevin, as Paul “could see a pattern shaping here, only a glimmering of it, but it seemed to him that the warp and weft of this, followed back to their source, would reach Dun Maura and a sacrifice made on the eve of Maidaladan” (*DR* 416).

In another symbolic representation of apparent balance between the God and Goddess, Jaelle agrees to live with Paul in the seer Ysanne’s cottage “halfway between the Temple and the Tree” (*DR* 416). This serves to highlight the irony of Jaelle’s former hatred of Ysanne for abdicating as High Priestess for the love of a man. But, as Paul remains Pwyll Lord of the Summer Tree while Jaelle gives up her power, the overriding imagery of an equal union obscures the undercurrent of inequity and elides the continuing power of traditional and hierarchical gender paradigms.

Even Leila’s ascension to position of High Priestess is something akin to a consolation prize. Her acceptance of a life within the temple is one made in grief after Finn, her true love, is destined by fate to leave humanity behind. When Finn relinquishes his earthly life to lead the ghostly Wild Hunt of Owein and his shadowy kings,³⁴ Leila laments: “I’ve lost the only man I’ll ever love!”

³⁴ Common throughout European folklore, the Wild Hunt is a supernatural hunt in which spectral hunters can be seen riding by, and the thundering of their horse’s hoofs and baying of their hounds

(WF 183). Devotion to the priestesshood is a second choice, a substitute for the true fulfilment of romantic love. Leila readily admits this, saying: “At midwinter full of moon, half a year from now, they will ask me if I wish to be consecrated to these robes. I will accept. I will never love another man” (WF 184). Finn is ultimately and tragically killed in the final battle while trying to answer Leila’s summons of love, expediently leaving Leila completely free to fully devote herself to the role of High Priestess. In both High Priestesses, Jaelle and Leila, we see the power of archetypal representation, and also the power attached to the fairy-tale motif of romantic love where passionate, heteronormative, and ultimately patriarchal, love and relationships are privileged above other formulations.

The story’s resolution of the Arthurian tragedy of the triangulated love between Guinevere, Arthur and Lancelot, also redeems Guinevere/Jennifer. This involves a reworking of the medieval character of Guinevere, relying upon reader familiarity with medieval and medievalist texts, especially the story of Guinevere’s love for and adultery with Lancelot which precipitated the downfall of Camelot. Kay’s story breaks the cycle of infidelity, of “absolute love and absolute betrayal” (DR 82), that these three were cursed to play over and over in many different worlds in the conceit of Kay’s story, mirroring the repeated infidelity in many retellings from medieval sources from Chrétien’s *Lancelot* to the Vulgate Cycle to Malory’s *Le Morte Darthur*, to modern texts from Tennyson’s *Morte d’Arthur* to T. H. White’s *The Once and Future King*. The importance of these background stories to a reader’s understanding of the Arthurian threads of *The Fionavar Tapestry* is clear. Indeed, Kay comments that he had to “introduce a few small glosses to flesh

heard”(Dixon Kennedy 408). Kay’s Wild Hunt is comprised of spectral kings who engage in indiscriminate slaughter.

out the story of the love triangle for the reader who might not be familiar with it". He notes that he "wanted to use the resonances of the triangle, but I found that I had to pluck a few chords of the original resonance to jog memories in readers" (Thompson online).

While Guinevere and Lancelot repeatedly suffer the pain, guilt and consequences of their ill-fated, transgressive love, Arthur too, unremittingly pays for his sins against the innocents. In this story, from the post-Vulgate *Suite du Merlin*, and popularised by Malory in *Le Morte Darthur*, Arthur, in an attempt to kill his bastard son Mordred and forestall a prophesy concerning the downfall of the kingdom, collects all the children born on May day, setting them adrift of a ship which founders on rocks, with no survivors but Mordred. Thinking it less likely that a modern educated readership "would remember Arthur's role as child slayer", Kay's text "gave a fairly clear description of what happened at that point in the myth" (Thompson online). Without this intertextual understanding of Arthurian myth the reworking and resolution of these stories in *The Fionavar Tapestry* has a vastly reduced impact. In Kay's tale Guinevere's relationship with Arthur is restored and not broken, even when Arthur returns from his quest for the Caldron to Cader Sedat with an awakened Lancelot. Lancelot's protection of Guinevere is displaced onto her half-god son Darien, as Guinevere sends Lancelot away to guard her son while he chooses his own road (*DR* 134). This action is one that, almost surprisingly, places Guinevere's role as mother above that of lover.

Although her pregnancy and Darien's birth mean that Guinevere is no longer the barren woman from Arthurian myth, there is a pathetic irony in Kay making this the result of a demeaning, emotionally and physically tortuous,

almost soul-destroying, rape. In these circumstances, Jennifer's refusal to perform the role of mother is, at the very least, understandable. Instead, she fosters her child with the motherly Vae because, as Jennifer says, "I need a mother who knows how to love her child" (WF 32). The implication that Jennifer feels inadequate for motherhood is made more plausible by the historical weight of repeated representations of Guinevere as barren, "an empty vessel, the shore without the sea" according to T.H White in *The Once and Future King* (White 498). Greater ambivalence attaches to Kay's Guinevere as mother, through the fearful threat that Darien poses as the son of Rakoth Maugrim. There is an almost literal sense in which Darien could be a realisation of Tennyson's lines about Guinevere in *Idylls of the King*: "Well is it that no child is born of thee. / The children born of thee are sword and fire, / Red ruin, and the breaking up of laws" (421-423).

When Jennifer returns to Fionavar, her child has matured at a supernatural rate, but she does not seek him out or attempt to talk with her son. On receiving news of him from Paul, Jennifer "listened, remote and regal, virtually untouched" (Kay WF 258). Her disinterest is such that it almost moves Paul to anger. Moreover, when Darien comes to Jennifer, lonely, frightened and confused about the path he should take, Jennifer overtly rejects the role of mother. "There was ice in her voice, and steel. Hard and cold and carrying, her tone knifed through the wind" (DR 118), as she refuses to accept a gift he offers in an attempt to please her.

'What,' he heard Darien's mother say, 'are you doing here?'

The boy's head jerked as if she'd struck him. 'I—she [Kimberly] told me. The one with white hair. She said you were . . .' His words failed him. Whatever else he said was lost in the tearing wind.

'She said I was here,' his mother said coldly, very clearly. 'Very well. She was right, of course. What of it? What do you want, Darien? You are no longer a baby—you arranged for that yourself. Would you have me treat you like one?' (Kay *DR*119)

Believing Darien is a random thread, outside destiny, Jennifer, having personally suffered from numberless returns of the cycle of fate, refuses to bind him to herself, even with a mother's love.

Darien said, 'Finn told me . . . before . . . that my mother loved me and that she had made me special.'

And now, as if involuntarily, Jennifer's hands did move, up from her sides, to clutch her elbows tightly in front of her.

'Acushla machree,³⁵ she said—or so Brendel thought. She started to go on, then seemed to pull herself up short, as on a tight, harsh rein.

After a moment she added, in a different voice, 'He was wrong... about making you special. You know that now. Your power comes from Rakoth when your eyes go red. What you have of me is only freedom and the right to choose, to make your own choice between Light and Dark. Nothing more than that.' (Kay *DR* 121)

Although Jennifer's distance from Darien is shown to be at the cost of significant personal grief, her rejection of the role of mother effectively shifts the character from Toronto's Jennifer to the medieval, childless Guinevere. In remaining firm in her determination, and in maintaining the remote public face of regal coolness, despite the emotional pull exerted by Darien's desire for a mother's love, she is placing the needs of the land above personal needs, electing to perform the role of queen. In sending both Darien and Lancelot away, holding resolutely to her commitment to Arthur, her choice is

³⁵ From the Irish: a *chuisle* (*moi chroi*) 'O pulse (of my heart)!' <http://oxforddictionaries.com>

an inversion of her behaviour at Camelot where surrender to feelings of love was key in the downfall of the kingdom.

As Darien's ultimate choice of the Light over the Dark leads to victory within the war, Guinevere is proved right; his death, in turn, allows her to at least grieve as a mother.

Kim exclaimed [...] 'Oh, Jen. You were right after all. You were so terribly right.' She was crying, and Dave saw that Jennifer Lowell, who was Guinevere, was weeping now as well, though silently.

In mourning for her child, who had taken the Darkest Road and had come at last to the end of it, alone, and so far away. (Kay *DR* 370)

Through this Guinevere is redeemed from the curse of her barrenness, and the taint associated with her refusal to act the role of mother. Moreover, her resolute fidelity to Arthur and to the land breaks the cycle of fate, of adultery and ruin. Culturally sanctioned behaviour, seen in submitting to Arthur both emotionally and sexually, provides Guinevere with fulfilment and healing, even to the point that sex with her husband immediately undoes the psychological trauma of her rape, leaving her "open to desire" (*WF* 273). In a parallel thread in the story, Diarmuid undermines the dictates of fate as he takes Arthur's death on Fionavar's battlefield of Camlann,³⁶ leaving Arthur alive to fight in the final battle. This, in turn, allows Arthur to save the life of Tabor, a child, in a symbolic reversal of the killing of the innocents. Indeed, in the Thompson interview (online) Kay states that his release of the Arthurian characters from fate constitutes the eucatastrophe of the story, the "sudden joyous 'turn'" (Tolkien 68). The resolution of the Arthurian story is multifaceted, allowing not only Arthur but also Guinevere, Lancelot and even

³⁶ The 10th Century *Annales Cambriae* records the battle of Camlann as the place of Arthur's death.

Arthur's dog, Cavall, to sail home to the Weaver's Halls; a key component of their release, however, is Guinevere's refusal of the role of whore and her concession to her obligations as wife and queen.

The stories of Kimberly, Jaelle, Leila and Guinevere demonstrate how the depiction of strong, ostensibly liberated, women characters can be folded back into traditional gender paradigms through the employment of archetype and myth. Fulfilment and happiness is achieved in conformity to patriarchal paradigms and wifely submission. While the strength of older stories lends a great deal of significance, and adds nuances of meaning to *The Fionavar Tapestry*, literary, mythological and archetypal precedents can also lead to conservatism.

Chapter 9

Romance, Seduction and the Other

Where Chapters 6 and 7 focussed upon the implications of ethnic representation in *The Fionavar Tapestry* and Chapter 8 on dynamics attached to gender paradigms and archetypal representation, this chapter unites these two themes. Generic expectation and the pleasure of romance are able to play a significant role in disavowing power imbalances attached to gender and even ethnicity. The following discussion considers another of the text's central romantic subplots, that of Prince Diarmuid and Princess Sharra, which begins with the romantically and erotically charged seduction of Sharra. I argue that the romance of this story elides an inherent sexual exploitation and the underlying sexual objectification of Sharra within Kay's tale. This romance encapsulates many of the key issues considered in the previous pages of this thesis. It demonstrates the weight of mythical allusion and the authority that can adhere to images and stories of past, and it allows an examination of the gendered power imbalances. Moreover, in this romance there is a doubling of meaning, as the gender implications of Diarmuid, Prince of Brennin, courting, manipulating and conquering Sharra, Princess of Cathal, has metonymic resonance. As Diarmuid stands for the West and Sharra for the East, the West is again shown as dominant and masculine while the East is subjugated and feminised.

Older stories carry inferences, connotations and authority with them. As the story of Diarmuid and Sharra evokes older texts it draws on their influence. Literary and cultural echoes are able to contribute to the ineffable sense of 'rightness' in a story. Intertextual aspects possess a resonance that adds to the plausibility of newer stories as they draw from the influential stories and tropes that preceded them. Moreover, readers themselves can be seduced by the generic familiarity, and by the historical and nostalgic overlay, to feel comfortable about the dynamics and themes present within. It can reassure to the point that readers overlook problematic subtexts. The ambience and the literary resonance in *The Fionavar Tapestry*, aided by Kay's knowledge and use of mythic and medieval tropes and traditional narrative patterns, obscure the ethnic and gender imbalances present in the episode of Diarmuid's seduction of Sharra.

There is a clear legacy of earlier tales in this couple's relationship: Sharra's seduction parallels the medieval French poem *Le Roman de la Rose*, "The Romance of the Rose"; as a love that crosses East and West it has echoes of the medieval French chateaufable, *Aucassin and Nicolette*; and it also uses biblical imagery. Sharra's name is strongly evocative of "the rose of Sharon" the "beloved" from the erotic *Song of Solomon* of the Old Testament (2:1, 1:2 SoS). The garden tryst, the descriptive exoticism, the lushness of the vegetation, the sensuality and physicality of the garden's beauty and aromas, and the narrative of passionate desire, all evoke the lovers' meetings in the *Song of Solomon*.

The cultural distinction between Brennin and Cathal brings with it echoes of forbidden love that the French Aucassin holds for the Saracen Nicolette in the late-twelfth/early-thirteenth-century chantefable. Although Diarmuid's and Sharra's story has significant departures from this medieval text, there are also many similarities. Sharra is the Princess of Cathal and Nicolette is revealed to be the daughter of the King of Carthage. Both Aucassin and Diarmuid are reluctant heirs, Aucassin to his father, the Count of Beaucaire, and Diarmuid to King Ailell of Brennin. Although love never renders Diarmuid ineffectual in his martial duty (as it does Aucassin), there is suggestion that passion leads to civic irresponsibility (Kline online). Diarmuid's desire for Sharra is at the risk of the safety of Brennin. If discovered in the garden Diarmuid could be killed; it "might even start a war" (Kay *ST* 125). Diarmuid also reveals to Sharra the details of how he breached Cathal's security (*ST* 130). Other resemblances can be found in the heroines both refusing all other suitors, and in their dressing up as men to escape social confinement and achieve their aspirations. While Nicolette disguises herself as a minstrel to return to Beaucaire (Kline online), Sharra disguises herself as one of the Honour Guard in her father's army in order to return to Paras Derval (*WF* 118).

The seduction of Sharra contains even stronger parallels to much of Guillaume de Lorris' early-thirteenth-century poem *Le Roman de la Rose* and, perhaps more so, to Jean de Meun's later continuation of the work which allows the young man to pluck the rose. The episode mimics, in a more realist form, the allegorical poem set in the Garden of Pleasure. Prince Diarmuid crosses the river and breaches the exotic gardens of Larai Rigal to court and seduce Sharra through both romance and deception, ultimately

plucking “the fairest rose in Shalhassen’s garden” (ST 132). The setting and dynamics of the encounter evoke romance, with the walled garden protecting and sheltering the beautiful princess, and the Prince risking danger in order to gain access to her beauty and her person.

The conflicting emotions and justifications that take place in Sharra’s mind during the encounter recall the psychological tensions demonstrated by the varying personifications of the Lady within *Le Roman de la Rose*. These personifications include those favourable to love such as *Bel Accueil* (fair welcome), *Pitié* (pity), *Franchise* (openness) and *Courtoisie* (courtliness). They also include some that work against the lover such as *Dangier* (resistance), *Peur* (fear), and *Honte* (shame).³⁷ Before the tryst Sharra determines to treat Diarmuid with “the courtesy due to his rank and the secrecy the passion in him deserved of her” (ST 125), mirroring the fair-welcome, pity and courtesy shown to the young lover in the medieval poem. Just as in the *Le Roman de la Rose*, Diarmuid, as lover, takes advantage of courtly manners and expectations regarding welcome, pity and courtesy, to undermine the protection of the Lady’s aloofness. Diarmuid’s taking of a kiss, however, sets up her defenses. It alerts her to her precarious position, warning her of the possibilities of danger and shame, and awakening her resistance and pride. Characters like Rebuff, Fear and Shame are all present before False Seeming’s trickery allows success in the conquest of the rose. The influence of themes and patterns in older stories, seen as overt allegory in *Le Roman de la Rose*, is subtly realised in Kay’s scene in Cathal’s gardens at Larai Rigal.

³⁷ I have gleaned character name translations from C.S. Lewis’s *The Allegory of Love* and Frances Horgan’s introduction and translation of Guillaume De Lorris and Jean De Muen’s *The Romance of the Rose*.

In the entry about Guy Gavriel Kay in *The Encyclopedia of Fantasy*, Paul Kincaid speaks of the range of mythological and historical sources that Kay draws from in his writing, noting Kay's "willingness to seek widely for inspiration". He comments that *The Fionavar Tapestry* "draws from a host of sources, notably British and Norse myth" (531). Scholarship on these novels tends to focus upon myth,³⁸ somewhat overlooking how other literary and medieval sources might inform the series. Although Kay provides a selected bibliography of key sources for his later novels, he simply cites "a decade's worth of reading in myth and legend, Arthuriana, and Celtic, Norse, or shamanistic traditions" as his influence for *The Fionavar Tapestry* (Kay Bibliographies online). In his interview with Thompson for "The Camelot Project", however, the extent of Kay's interest and familiarity with medieval literature becomes apparent. He reveals his reading of many medieval works, including *Sir Orpheo*, *The Song of Roland*, *The Neibelungenlied*, *Gawain and the Green Knight*, *Pearl*, and the chronicle histories of Geoffrey of Monmouth, Gildas, and Giraldus Cambrensis (Thompson online).

Whether deliberate or unconscious references, appropriations from and allusions to earlier literatures such as medieval tales and biblical texts are able to inform and enhance a modern tale, creating a literary resonance recognisable to Western readers. In her study of Medievalism in Australian Literature, *Old Songs in the Timeless Land* (OS), Louise D'Arcens takes Peter Bailey's notion of "knowingness" from the realm of Victorian music hall, and applies it to a reader's understanding of medieval references in popular text (126). Bailey's "knowingness" describes a general rather than informed

³⁸ See compiled scholarship on *Bright Weavings: The Worlds of Guy Gavriel Kay – The Authorized Website*, <http://www.brightweavings.com/scholarship/index.htm>

engagement with widely accessible cultural information. Addressing the medievalism in the popular poetry of colonial Australia, D'Arcens argues that:

Those readers who were in possession of greater knowledge could engage with the medievalist allusions in these poems at a deeper level, and enjoy their own sense of distinction in doing so; but for the knowing, rather than erudite, public, the Middle Ages became, to use Bailey's incisive phrase, 'what everybody knows, but which some know better than others'. (D'Arcens OS 127)

Kay's medievalist appropriations and allusions invite similar levels of engagement. While the whole readership may not be aware of the range or nature of Kay's sources they are still able to participate in a "knowingness" about stories, myth and the Middle Ages. Northrop Frye makes a similar observation in regard to the reading of romance that harks back to older stories and myth, saying: "If we are reading the story as critics, with an eye to structural principles we may make the association [...]. If we are reading the story for fun, we need not bother: that is, some murky 'subconscious' factor in our response will take care of the association" (188). Reader engagement, whether based upon a more detailed knowledge or a 'knowingness', facilitates a sense of shared participation, of communal ownership over the underlying stories.

Before moving on to a more detailed discussion of the sexual dynamics between Diarmuid and Sharra, I wish to reiterate the doubling of meaning in this relationship in regard to the East and West. Following the death of her brother in a hunting accident the year previous, Sharra, as the only living child of Shalhassan, is his heir. As such she is not simply an individual; there is a manner in which she represents Cathal. This is made explicit in an

exchange between Sharra and Diarmuid where Sharra emphasises that she should not be treated as though she is just any woman; “She was a princess of Cathal” with a primary duty to her people. It is not insignificant that Diarmuid replies “Am I not heir to a throne, just as you are?” (Kay *ST* 130). The story of Diarmuid’s conquering and ravishment of Sharra then, works on two levels, an individual one, with all its gender implications, and one where Sharra stands as a metaphor for the East and Diarmuid for the West. This episode sits as a precursor, or as a pair, to the story of Shalhassan’s humbling and submission discussed in Chapter 6. Furthermore, this incident reinforces the novel’s feminisation of the East in comparison to the masculine West represented by Brennin. This dynamic, however, is hidden behind generic, popular romantic imagery.

Romantic language, too, particularly when combined with sensual and nostalgic settings, can assist in presenting as romance what I argue is a manipulative and coercive scene. Diarmuid’s seduction of Sharra contains familiar echoes of earlier romantic and erotic texts, and does not immediately appear non-consensual. His approach is not one of physical force, but rather one that relies on the language of love and desire. Steven Rendall (2008) pertinently comments that:

The distinction between seduction and rape parallels, and is in large measure based on, a distinction between language and physical force, between saying and doing. [...] To a considerable extent, seduction and rape have the same goal, not merely in the banal sense that they seek sexual intercourse, but also, and perhaps more fundamentally, in the sense that they seek to establish power over another individual. The coercive force of language, and particularly of argumentative language, is of course not identical with the

coerciveness of sheer physical force, but it is perhaps not so different from it as we would like to imagine. (Rendall 74)

Through historical, romantic tropes, a manipulative situation can be constructed so as to appear one of love rather than control, cloaking the parallels between the dynamics of seduction and of coercion.

Coercion is further elided when women are constructed as unconsciously willing. As discussed in Chapter 8, Kay generally portrays women as desiring. The implications of Sharra being cast as desiring and willing are amplified by the overtones that accompany Sharra's embodiment of both the East and femininity, and also by Diarmuid's embodiment of the West and masculinity. Although framed as romance, there is a manner in which the woman's body becomes the site on which cultural dominance is enacted.

The story's fantastic exoticism allows Kay to draw on literary and discursive constructions of the libidinous female. That which Andy Martin, in his article "Willing Women" (2006), identifies as a trope in colonial writings of the exotic Other, is also present in Kay's fantasy. Within *The Fionavar Tapestry* "women are already possessed by a latent [sexual] appetite that can be triggered by any passing stranger" (153). Martin argues that literary representation adds to discourses in which "manifest power and violence" become "translated into a miasma of latent sexual desire and pleasure" (158).

The historical examples Martin considers, a combination of both artistic and nonfiction texts concerning the exotic feminine Other, demonstrate how texts

can have a significant impact on belief and behaviour. The combined strength of journals, novels, artworks and even scholarly texts is able to create and reinforce discourses that construct exotic women as, in essence, willing. Indeed, Martin points to Freud's assertion that there is no such thing as an unconscious 'No.' "The unconscious always says 'Yes'. Only the self-denying duplicity of the conscious mind is capable of saying 'No.'" (158).

The discursive strength of such constructions allows sexual coercion to more plausibly be rewritten as a romantic encounter. In "Hymeneal Acts: Interrogating the Hegemony of Rape and Romance", Nina Puren observes that the economy of rape can be "indistinguishable from the economy of romance" (18). Puren points to how discursive transformation is achieved through a tacit implication that the female has agency. This is achieved when *resistance* is narrated as *desire*. The woman, because of her sexual attractiveness and through the assumption of her desire, is construed as "the precipitatory agent of the sexual event" (Puren 19).

Considering examples in Mills and Boon romance novels, Puren argues that a woman's 'no' holds an important place in maintaining the "temporal threshold of romance" (21). Resistance, she argues, is both a trope and condition of the romance genre, marking the woman as a respectable subject (21). The woman's capitulation to the hero's sexual advances after repeated 'no's, therefore, shows how

[the] romance economy produces woman as a liar – her necessary no, which preserves the romantic threshold, and is a mark of her own legitimacy, must always have as a signified, a desiring body. Otherwise, what happens to it is rape and not romance". (Puren 21).

Certainly this pattern is evident in both *Le Roman de la Rose* and in the seduction of Sharra in *The Fionavar Tapestry*.

The tension in virgin/whore dichotomy, evident in both medieval and medievalist texts, is intensified by the combination of youth and erotic exoticism in Sharra. Jeana Jorgensen, in an analysis of female agency in eroticised retellings of fairy tales (2008), comments on the problematic ambivalence that arises from contradictory demands within representations of womanhood. There is an inherent contradiction in the coupling of an expectation of innocence with the construction of a willing and desiring woman. Jorgensen argues that this “duality is a manifestation of the virgin/whore complex” (34). She asserts that it represents a commodification of innocence, where innocence “becomes a trope meant to evoke desire in the reader, because within the story, innocence signifies sexual eagerness that is ready to be exploited” (34). In *The Fionavar Tapestry* Sharra sits within this trope. She is just past that awkward “long limbed coltish” stage (Kay *ST* 120). At seventeen she is not only sexually innocent, but even “not yet accustomed to men calling her beautiful” (*ST* 120). She remains unmoved by “the men who had knelt before her father’s throne seeking her hand” (*ST* 121).

Significantly, the language Kay employs in his introduction to Sharra is infused with sexual overtones. There is the repeated motif of a smouldering, heated longing: “Within her, too, there flickered yet a secret flame of rebelliousness...”; “Even now the flame burned...”; “Memories that fired her...”; “burning like a lien in the gardens at night...” (*ST* 121). Although Sharra embodies innocence, the suggestiveness of both the lexis and

broader sensual imagery encodes this innocence as nascent sexual eagerness. Consequently, Diarmuid's sophisticated seduction can be understood as not simply awakening her longings but, rather, as his response to them, as his answer to her innate desires. With this literary and discursive sleight of hand agency is transferred from him as seducer to her as desirer.

The suggestion that Sharra is complicit in her own seduction is also confirmed by her actions. It is present in the revelation that she keeps secret the unsigned letters of love that begin to appear in her room. These letters express a longing that "sang to her" and "awoke within her breast [...] longings of her own" (*ST* 121). When Diarmuid's final letter arrives with a signature, it proves Sharra's "burning" suspicion that Diarmuid is her audacious admirer, giving "shape and certainty to what she had long guessed and held in her heart as a talisman" (*ST* 121-2). Diarmuid, therefore, is depicted as the object of Sharra's desire, prior to her even laying eyes upon him. Returning to the ethnic metaphor, it is significant that her desire is for a Western lover, not for one of her many suitors from Cathal.

Kay continues to use suggestive language in his description of Sharra. On the evening that Sharra receives this final letter the sexual imagery is evident in passages like; she "did not dream of childhood or of childhood games when at length sleep found her, twisting from side to side all night, her hair loose and spread across the pillow" (*ST* 123). The sexual implications are not difficult to recognise in the picture of her tangled in her bed, and in the lexis such as 'loose', and 'spread'. This goes further than configuring Sharra as desiring; she appears almost wanton as innocence is again conflated with

sexual readiness. Consequently, before Sharra and Diarmuid even meet, the strength of language and of archetypal representation of woman as both virgin and whore, construct Sharra as ready, as desiring. This creates a lens through which Diarmuid's coercive actions can be seen, not as predatory, but as answering Sharra's own, albeit yet unacknowledged, needs. It is as Martin notes in his paper on 'willing women': "no crime has been committed since he was only responding to an implicit invitation: all along he has done nothing but provide the supply to her demand" (151).

Moreover, the text suggests that, although Sharra is sexually innocent, she is by no means naïve. It depicts her as sophisticated in her dealings with men. This is clearly seen in her cool, controlling formality with one of her suitors, the young Vanassar of Gath, and in her cold dismissal of his leering father. She is cast as someone who is not only schooled in propriety and behaviour, but as someone possessed of natural intelligence. In Sharra, Kay is able to mix aspects of the ingénue on the cusp of womanhood, but still longing for the freedom of childhood, with the image of a sophisticated, knowing and ready woman. This idea is reinforced by Diarmuid's response on first meeting her.

'Fools,' said Diarmuid dan Ailell. 'They told me you were beautiful.
Said it in six different ways.'

'And?' She stiffened, anger ready as a lash.

'And, by Lisen's eyes, you are. But no one ever told me there was a
cleverness in you. I should have known. Shalhassan's heir would
have to have subtlety.' (Kay *ST* 127)

Ironically, Diarmuid's admission of Sharra's cleverness gives him an advantage. Recognition of her cleverness proves his own. It immediately

unsettles her expectations, and in turn, her sense of control: “She was completely unprepared. No one had ever said this. Off balance, she fleetingly remembered all her Venassars, so effortlessly handled” (ST 127). Diarmuid’s understanding of Sharra’s intelligence becomes part of his seduction whilst simultaneously absolving his behaviour. An acknowledgement of Sharra’s power paradoxically works toward her disempowerment; it elides the moral implications attached to Diarmuid’s seduction of an inexperienced seventeen-year-old. Diarmuid is able to argue that Sharra is not a girl: “not in the ways that matter” (ST 127).

The problematic character of Sharra’s seduction is further cloaked by the text’s subtle change in narrative register. In his writing of Diarmuid and Sharra’s encounter Kay adopts a more formal, faux archaic style, evocative of fable and romance. Rather than utilising more conventional phrasing such as ‘She had been a pretty child’, ‘She remained proud’, or ‘They spoke of desire’, Kay employs a syntax more evocative of the mythic – “A pretty child she had been...” (ST 120), “Proud she remained...”, and “Of desire they spoke...” (ST 121). *The Fionavar Tapestry* is already somewhat distanced from the reader by its placement in a medieval secondary world. The adoption of a more formal register for this particular episode appeals to the cultural legacy of older tales. It attaches an even greater sense of distance and further mythic gravitas to this section of Kay’s tale.

The weight of this archaic ambience is further enhanced by the sensuality of the physical setting of the tryst, adding more romantic distance from modern ‘reality’. Indeed, the reader is informed that the “gardens were another world” (ST 125). This sets up a further degree of distance. The garden is ‘another

world' inside the fantasy 'other world' of Fionavar. Here "the disturbing night scents of the flowers", the "starlight and the crescent illumination of the moon", the "soft chirping of insects and the splashing of the sculptured waterfalls" contribute to the sensual overload of the scene. So too, does the idea of a man waiting in the garden; one who had written to Sharra "of what lips and hands might do" (*ST* 125). Utilising motifs of exoticism, romance and of fairy tale, the remove of other-worldliness becomes a further mediating factor in Diarmuid's seduction. It invites the reader to approach this incident as a romance, cloaking the manipulation and the power imbalance that a closer consideration of the incident might expose.

Medievalism, romanticism and exoticism therefore work together to create something of a moderating remove between the reader and the action taking place within the story. In "Guilty Pleasures" (2008) Linda J. Lee argues that historical settings in genre romance allow readers to enjoy fantasies of forced sexual encounters from "a safe distance", able to distinguish the eroticised fantasy from real life brutalities (55). Still, despite the spatial and temporal remoteness associated with the story of Diarmuid and Sharra, there is little sense of emotional distance. Janice A. Radway argues that identification with the characters is fundamental to the attraction of romance fiction (113). Consequently, the notion of 'distance' is not straightforward.

Moreover, reader expectations for genre romance of the popular, highly formulaic variety that Radway and Lee discuss, will be of a different nature from those brought to reading a complex fantasy trilogy of almost 1200 pages. There is also significant difference in the gender constitution of both authors and readers of each genre. While readers and writers of genre

romance are predominantly female, there is, comparative to romance fiction, a much stronger male representation in the readership and authorship of the genre fantasy. These factors complicate the simple transference of concepts from the abovementioned studies on romance fiction across to romantic episodes in fantasy fiction. An awareness of the genre's male readership, for example, frustrates the interpretation of fantasies of sexual coercion as mere escapist pleasure or as collective feminine fantasies of "female empowerment" where "the heroine tames her arrogant, domineering, ruthless mate" (Lee 62).

Generic expectation, too, can play a role in justifying behaviours that tread upon or even overstep the line of coercion, manipulation or domination. It provides a route via which readers can dismiss, or reinterpret as romantic, events that might in a different literary context cause alarm or at least disquiet. There is an anticipation that the text will bring about a romantic or fairy-tale conclusion to the relationship, whether it be one of tragedy or one of happy resolution. The fairy-tale ending works to provide a retrospective justification for transgressive interaction between the romance's hero and heroine. In her discussion of mass produced romances, *Loving With A Vengeance* (2008), Tania Modleski argues that readers' knowledge of the generic formula allows them to "understand the hero's behaviour in terms of the novel's ending" (33). She asserts that this enables detachment and identification to work together.

Since the reader knows the formula she is superior in wisdom to the heroine and thus detached from her. The reader then achieves a very close emotional identification with the heroine partly because she is intellectually *distanced* from her and does not have to suffer the heroine's confusion. (Modleski 33)

Moreover, the tension created by the combination of romance and transgression, rather than unsettling, can work to increase reader enjoyment. Rick Altman, in *"Film/Genre"* (1999) asserts that pleasure arises from behaviour that exceeds or pushes against the boundaries of social acceptability. Within the generic economy, Altman states, "generic pleasure is always preferable to social correctness" (147). He also suggests that viewer pleasure increases in proportion to the extent of the transgression. This pleasure, however, is contingent upon a text's ability to ultimately right the wrongs and return to the comfort of cultural norms. Transgressions, he maintains:

undermine the very foundations of the culture limiting our free range – and that is precisely what pleases us. It is only through this escalating denial of cultural values that we reach the highest levels of generic pleasure.

Yet genre films almost never end at their greatest distance from cultural norms, the point where generic pleasure is at its height. On the contrary, genre-based films virtually always follow a long period of intensification with a rapid and definitive restoration of cultural values. (Altman 155)

A viewer's anticipation of recovery and reintegration into cultural expectation becomes integral to the enjoyment of transgressive behaviour. Paradoxically, transgression is used to confirm consensus morality, as the story is ultimately folded back into cultural conformity.

Although Altman is speaking of generic expectation within film, his observations on the power of genre can be transferred to the reading of fantasy fiction. In *The Fionavar Tapestry* romantic pleasure is on offer, but

there is also titillation at the transgressive elements of Diarmuid's conquest; in his audacious and artful taking of Sharra's virginity. Pleasure is acceptable as the genre fosters the expectation that there will be a "restoration of cultural values" (Altman 155). Indeed, this expectation is not misplaced in *The Fionavar Tapestry*, as ultimately the romance returns to cultural conformity through an understanding of their mutual love, underscored by a formal engagement. There remains, however, a tension between the expectations attached to generic romance and those that arise from the story's medievalist context and lineage. Within this historical context, the interracial aspect of Diarmuid and Sharra's romance adds to the sense of transgression, hinting at miscegenation. In the same way as the pairing between Paul and Jaelle is symbolic of reconciliation between the God and the Goddess, this union suggests a marriage of East and West. However, as will be discussed in greater detail later in this chapter, Diarmuid's death decisively shuts down the possibility of such a union. Thus the text once again conforms to conservative cultural expectations.

There is a clear escalation of the transgressive pleasure on offer throughout the encounter between Diarmuid and Sharra. At first there is just a hint that propriety is being tested. There are the smuggled, secret letters, initially containing suggestions of desire, but becoming increasingly "bold as time went by" (Kay *ST* 121). Still, this remains within the realms of words and dreams. Sharra's going out to meet Diarmuid, however, raises the level of transgression from one of words to one of action. Sharra's intention in engaging in a secret tryst, however, is not similarly transgressive. She wishes to demonstrate grace and treat him with becoming courtesy, but she makes it clear that she has no intention of allowing his sexual advances.

Although Sharra's behaviour in permitting the meeting breaches propriety, it does not fully strain the bounds of morality.

A further escalation of the risk and rupture of propriety comes with the meeting. Diarmuid's slightly mocking and unconventional behaviour intensifies the sense of danger in the scene. His challenges and his backhanded flattery unsettle Sharra, as this behaviour is outside her expectation. To this is added the physical aspect of the touch of his hand on her arm and the surreptitious movements where his fingers graze the edge of her breast. Although Sharra still feels she will be able to maintain control of the situation, there is a subtle shift in her plans, an easing of her aloof severity, as she considers graciously granting Diarmuid a goodbye kiss on the cheek (*ST* 128). Although only a slight concession, this suggests a capriciousness in Sharra's intentions, implying that she lacks an understanding of her own mind and wishes in relation to Diarmuid and, once more, intimating she is inherently willing.

When unsettled, Sharra finds safety in convention and distant politeness, giving Diarmuid the structured and familiar tour of the gardens she has given many suitors. Diarmuid's uncompromising disparagement of Sharra's formality, however, delegitimises her means of distancing herself from his sexual pursuit. Her agency and sense of control are destabilised as he labels her behaviour a pretence, and characterises her propriety as emptiness, accusing her of "speaking like someone scarcely a person", merely playing at being a "gracious Princess" (*ST* 129). Diarmuid undermines Sharra's options for culturally appropriate behaviour, intensifying the danger of her position. He portrays her formality as immaturity, in one breath – "I expect to see and

hear the woman” – and in the next he implies that she is acting at odds with her essential self, and should let go of the adult façade: “Who was the girl who climbed the trees in this garden. The Princess in her role bores me, hurts me. Demeans tonight” (*ST* 129).

Diarmuid, the embodiment of masculinity and the West, claims superior perception and assumes the power of definition. His characterisation places Sharra in an almost untenable situation. Her propriety is cast as pretence, as childishness and as cruelty. Diarmuid claims to understand the real Sharra better than she does herself. Male authority is naturalised as he alone declares the night theirs, and presumes the right to take her, his arms suddenly “around her waist in the shadows of the lyren, and his mouth descending [...]” (*ST* 129).

Sharra strongly attempts to reassert control but she is already situated in a place of disadvantage. Her rejection of his sexual advances, however, appears unequivocal – “‘No!’ She broke way violently, and almost fell”. When he steps toward her she repeats her refusal. “‘No!’ Her hands were up to ward him”. The demands of form and appearance are shown to still exert considerable influence on Sharra, as she holds to a semblance of dignity, despite an instinct to flee. She clearly expresses her position.

She shook her head. Some voice within was wildly telling her to run,
but instead she spoke, as carefully as she could.

‘You must not think, my lord Prince, to win the daughter of
Shalhassan, merely by coming here and –’ (Kay *ST* 130)

Her seemingly unambiguous refusal, however, is weakened by the narration that constructs her as liar, as acting against her own will. “Her heart was a mad, beating winged thing she had to control. Had to. She was Sharra” (*ST* 130). Her bodily reaction is privileged above her mind and her reason as the narration focuses on the physical: “breathing was difficult. She was conscious of her breasts, of the wind about her, the nearness of him, and the dark warmth at her centre” (*ST* 130).

Again, Sharra is portrayed as desiring. Diarmuid is, therefore, proved to hold superior knowledge. Because he is represented as understanding Sharra’s wants better than she does herself, his coercive behaviour can be construed as answering her needs. This works to justify the trickery he uses to ultimately claim her. Ironically, Diarmuid employs an impression of Sharra’s empowerment and agency to disempower her; he argues that Sharra holds the power over his life or death, and this becomes a weapon of manipulation in his hands. He makes it very clear that if Sharra calls for help or exposes him in an attempt to escape his sexual advances, that she will be responsible for his death. This brings a twofold increase to danger, creating a tension between sexual risk on Sharra’s side, and mortal risk on Diarmuid’s. Diarmuid emphasises with finesse the physical danger he faces. His letter requesting the tryst makes good use of the emotive power attached to risk. It simultaneously highlights his own courage and prowess, while flattering Sharra and ostensibly placing her in a position of control.

I must come. Death is a dark I seek not to find, but if I must walk
within its provinces to touch the flower of your body, then I must.
Promise only that should the soldiers of Cathal end my life it will be
your hands that close my eyes, and perhaps it is – too much to ask, I
know – your lips that touch my cold ones in farewell.

[...] You hold my life as a small thing between the fingers of your hands. (Kay *ST* 122)

When it appears the palace guard is nearby, Sharra believes that if she continues to argue with Diarmuid she will reveal his presence and their tryst. Diarmuid makes it abundantly clear that discovery under such circumstances would make her responsible for his death. His refusal to leave Sharra despite the risk, effectively attaches action to his words, appearing to prove both his sincerity and the extent of his love.

'If they find me they kill me,' said Diarmuid. 'If they can. Perhaps you will close my eyes, as I once asked.' The expression changed then, the voice roughened. 'But I will not leave you willingly, though all of Cathal come calling for my blood.'

And gods, gods, all the gods, his mouth on hers was so very sweet, the touch of his hands so blindingly sure. His fingers were at the fastenings of her bodice, and dear Goddess, her own hands were behind his head, pulling him down to her, her tongue sought his in a hunger so long denied. Her breasts, suddenly released strained toward his touch, and there was an ache in her, a burning, something wild being set free [...] (Kay *ST* 131)

Clearly, despite her stated rational choice, her cool propriety, her practised aloofness, her repeated 'No!', and her denunciation of Diarmuid's presumption, Sharra is proved a liar; she is shown not to understand her own needs. She becomes a titillating mixture of the naïve child, needing to be shown her true self by a man, and the awakened and sexualised woman, configured as unconsciously wonton.

This, as mentioned earlier, is not simply a matter of sexual politics. Although the intimate sphere affects to be outside cultural and ethnic politics, this is belied by these lovers' embodiment of East and West. This episode is not simply a metaphor for, to put it crudely, the West 'screwing' the East. It also works as a covert naturalisation of ethnic hierarchies. The story locates Sharra's 'true' nature in her body, in her sexual response which overwhelms her rational mind. Diarmuid, by contrast, although indulging his bodily desires, is engaged in a game of strategic manipulation and one-upmanship. His 'truth' is located in his sharp, clever mind. This incident, therefore, exemplifies the text's feminising of the East and a masculinising of the West. Sharra's eventual submission is inevitable, innate and, as revealed by her body's instinctive response to Diarmuid, inscribed in her 'true' self. The dichotomies in the tale are reinforced; Masculine over feminine; West over East. Woman and the East are again aligned with the body, with instinct and emotion, while man and the West are confirmed as rational and naturally dominant. The realm of sexual politics, therefore, participates in the ultimate essentialisation of the novels' ethnic hierarchies, further strengthening the novels' tacit justifications of Western dominance.

In the same way that sexual politics can participate in understandings of ethnicity, beliefs about ethnicity can reciprocally inform a reader's interpretation of sexual politics. Martin discusses the ease with which discursive constructions of Otherness naturalise portrayals of exotic women as libidinous and willing. He observes that "a presumption of desire and at least the promise of pleasure" becomes integral to eliding coercion: "Every verbal 'no' is therefore only a tease, a rhetorical ornament, a lure, concealing an implicit but overwhelming 'yes' (62).

The discursive strength of such constructions are such that reader alignment and admiration remain with Diarmuid; it may even evoke desire in female readership, despite the dénouement proving the garden encounter to be an exercise in bravado and homosocial point scoring. Moreover, this alignment survives the revelation that his life was not in any immediate danger, that the threat of being discovered by guards was no more than a ruse enacted by Diarmuid's own men outside the garden walls. Diarmuid rejoins his waiting men with a thumbs-up, a flamboyant leap and roll, his eyes flashing with an "intoxicated hilarity": "'Done!' he said, [...] 'I have plucked the fairest rose in Shalhassen's garden'" (ST 132).

Moreover, Sharra's distress, her anger and her humiliation upon learning of Diarmuid's deceit, is rendered as a somewhat overdramatic wilfulness. The punishment she metes out to Cathal's Captain of the Guards, blaming him for his failure in security, is not constructed as an indication of hurt and mortification. It is portrayed as little more than an undisciplined tantrum, "rash and precipitous" (ST 192). This unsympathetic characterisation of Sharra's reaction is transferred to her attempt to kill Diarmuid, enabling the reader to interpret this incident as prideful petulance above hurt and humiliation, even though her actions are likely to cost her life. Rather than signalling Sharra's suffering or highlighting the serious weight of Diarmuid's mendacious taking of her virginity, the novel uses Sharra's attempt on Diarmuid's life as an opportunity for understated humour. It becomes a tension breaker in the scene where Diarmuid and Aileron face each other over the question of accession to Brennin's throne. The scene reinstates the bond of brotherhood as Aileron literally throws the crown at Sharra, destabilising her as she

pitches her dagger in Diarmuid's direction. The episode then becomes more about Diarmuid than Sharra, as his response demonstrates his magnanimity, cleverness and elegant charm. Even with Sharra's dagger still in his arm he unperturbedly moves to justify Sharra's action and to guard her reputation and life.

'We will treat this lady,' Diarmuid was saying, 'with all the dignity due to her. If I am not mistaken she comes as a vanguard of an embassy from Shalhassan of Cathal. We are honoured that he sends his daughter and heir to consult with us.' [...]

'I stole a flower from Larai Rigal four nights ago in such a way that the Princess would know. It was an irresponsible thing, for those gardens, as we all know, are sacred to them. It seems that Sharra of Cathal valued the honor of her country above her own life - for which we in turn must honor her.' (Kay *ST* 370)

So instead of being Sharra's despoiler, Diarmuid takes on the role of her saviour and protector, both of her life and her reputation. Sharra is once more in the subordinate position as her strong assertion of agency, demonstrated in her attempt on his life, is undermined. Instead of being able to enact revenge, Sharra becomes obliged to Diarmuid for his grace in this situation. This image also fits the model of a knight protecting the reputation of his lady, nostalgically appealing to chivalric notions of romance. The generic strength of such imagery appears to override the role Diarmuid has played in the potential loss of Sharra's reputation, and his responsibility for the circumstances that precipitated the actions that place her life at risk.

Sharra and Diarmuid's final understanding, however, plays the crucial role in reshaping this story as romantic rather than abusive. It provides the "rapid

and definitive restoration of cultural values” that Altman sees as necessary for pleasure (155). The generic reversal that restores the safe order takes place at the Goddess’ temple on midsummer’s eve, during the erotically charged festival of Maidaladan. The most striking difference between this tryst and the encounter in the gardens of Larai Rigal is Diarmuid’s consideration of Sharra’s wishes.

Unsurprised by Diarmuid’s insouciant proposition implicit in the one word, “Later”, Sharra is, however, taken aback by the fact the proposition was an appeal, not a demand: “What didn’t fit, what had unnerved her so much, was that he had made it a question, a quiet request, and had looked for a reply from her” (*WF* 226). This repositions Diarmuid’s behaviour within a chivalrous, courteous model of behaviour toward women, though there remains a characteristic audacity in his stealing into her chambers disguised in the robes and hood of a priestess. This time, as he finds himself once more facing the blade of her drawn dagger, his flippant and sardonic manner is replaced by an appropriate reverence, demonstrated by his observation of the temple’s rites of propitiation.

Eschewing the transgressive forwardness that marked his previous manners, Diarmuid maintains a respectful distance from Sharra as he claims that, despite the passion of Maidalaidan, “I did not come to bed you” (*WF* 229). There is a raw vulnerability in his voice as he addresses her, showing respect for both her rank and the expectations of formal courtship:

‘Princess, these are evil times, for the war imposes its own constraints and this war may mean an ending to all that we have known. Notwithstanding this, if you will allow, I would court you as

formally as ever a Princess of Cathal has been courted, and I will say to your father tomorrow what I say to you tonight.' [...] 'Sharra,' he said, 'the sun rises in your eyes'.

So many men had proposed to her with these, the formal words of love. So many men, but none had ever made her weep. (Kay *WF* 229)

The deceptive manipulation used to overwhelm Sharra's refusal and take her virginity in the gardens is replaced by a respectful sincerity. He responds to her silence by making to leave, promising he will not speak to her father without her permission. His earlier coercion is overwritten with his present deference, and there is no question of force as Sharra herself becomes the one to propose he stay with her that night, asking "Whom else should I ever love?" (*WF* 230). This scene rewards the readers for their faith in the generic formula; their trust in Diarmuid as a worthy romantic hero is proved sound.

This romantic resolution increases the affective poignancy of the tragic death of Diarmuid. Fitting with Kay's belief that within fantasy fiction there needs to be payment to balance victory, Kay sacrifices the figure that "readers appear to find the most charismatic and sympathetic and glamorous" (Thompson online). Diarmuid's heroism and worth is enhanced as he takes Arthur Pendragon's place and death in single combat against Uathach, champion of the dark forces. Grief and loss is intensified as the love story between Diarmuid and Sharra is brought to the forefront with the narrative role of focaliser for the battle moving between Diarmuid and that of Sharra. Their story ends in a demonstration of eternal love, transcending even death, as a weeping Sharra implores Diarmuid to "Wait for me by the Weaver's side" (*DR* 325).

A different reading of this tragic and romantic denouement, however, can arise from an historical perspective of intercultural relationships, and the (in a medieval context, transgressive) suggestion of miscegenation. Although Sharra and Diarmuid's relationship holds out the promise of racial and cultural unification, it stops short of allowing its fulfilment. Instead it transforms this promise into an unrealised utopian ideal, not wholly rejected, but deferred to an abstract ethereal future in the after-world of the Weaver's Halls. This follows a pattern identifiable in other medievalist tales that flirt with idea of miscegenation,³⁹ an exemplar of which is Sir Walter Scott's *Ivanhoe*. As Scott does with Wilfred of Ivanhoe and Rebecca, Kay courts the idea of intercultural union, but ultimately circumvents its realisation. *The Fionavar Tapestry* is able to imagine the romance, but not the marriage.

While Sharra and Diarmuid's romance appeals to the idealism of ethnic unification, Diarmuid's death allows the story to evade the political and cultural complexities attached to its enactment.⁴⁰ Significantly, Diarmuid's death also marks a virtual absence of Sharra from the rest of the novel, with only a mention in the final chapter of how many proposals were made "after the old fashion" in tribute to "Diarmuid dan Ailell, who had revived the tradition by proposing in this way to Sharra of Cathal" (*DR* 400). It is as though, without the possibility of marriage, the novel's ending has no place for her. In *Ivanhoe* the abnegation of the romance between Rebecca and

³⁹ See, for example, Michael Ragussis' discussion of miscegenation in Scott's *Ivanhoe*, "Writing Nationalist History: England, the Conversion of the Jews, and *Ivanhoe*" (200-205) and Louise D'Arcens examination of the foreclosed relationship between a Half-Aboriginal girl and the Anglo-Saxon protagonist of *A Sydney-Side Saxon*, "Inverse Invasions: Medievalism and Colonialism in Rolf Boldrewood's *A Sydney-Side Saxon*" (173-179)

⁴⁰ Ragussis (above), for example, discusses how marriage for Rebecca would have entailed a renunciation of her religious and cultural identity. In the story of *Nicolette and Aucassin*, Nicolette is baptised into Christianity and eschews her Saracen origins.

Wilfred of Ivanhoe enables a safer, more culturally sanctioned union between Wilfred and Rowena. Similarly, as Diarmuid takes Arthur's predestined death, the sacrifice of Diarmuid and Sharra's relationship allows for fulfilment in the relationship between Guinevere and Arthur, enabling the restoration of their marriage as the story folds transgression back into cultural and moral conformity.

Even with its tragic ending, the story of Diarmuid and Sharra fulfils the promises implicit in tropes such the meeting of a prince and princess, youth and beauty, romantic and exotic settings, and formal, evocative narrative style. Romantic expectations are met in their discovery of mutual love, again confirming the constancy of the traditional fairy-tale romance. The assumptions and faith of the reader are not disappointed, and the special licence granted for Diarmuid's transgressive behaviour is validated by the dénouement of the tale.

Wrapped as it is in exotic and romantic imagery and situated in a temporal space that evokes 'pastness', the vignette of Sharra's seduction may at first seem little more than an amorous lark, a 'boys' own' adventure, with an erotic edge to it. Indeed, the familiarity of the tropes Kay employs makes this an almost comfortable love story. There is the daring prince on a quest, the beautiful princess secluded in the walled castle, the exotic garden, and even the touch of magic in the use of mage's arrows and rope to breach the seemingly impenetrable fortifications of Cathal. This is promoted to high romance with the resolution, the declaration of undying love, the engagement, and the tragic, untimely death that parts Sharra and Diarmuid.

These things, however, elide the questionable undertones of narcissism, misogyny, objectification, and Orientalism discernible within this incident.

Allusion to archaic literatures such as *Aucassin and Nicolette*, *Le Roman de la Rose*, and *Song of Solomon* within this medievalist tale further grant a certain historical validation, holding out a template, a precedent, to offer moral immunity to Kay's depiction of Sharra's seduction. Despite the tragic ending, just as in the stories of Paul and Jaelle, Kimberly and Dave, and Guinevere and Arthur, a 'right' ending is achieved through feminine recognition of and submission to masculine worth. Moreover, Kay's employment of strong, gifted, and ostensibly independent women is undermined by the undercurrent that privileges traditional gendered hierarchies. Even romantic, nostalgic constructions of the past, however, do not necessarily indicate a detachment from contemporary concerns and ideological debates. They can be utilised in an apologetic fashion to justify and reassert the current continuation of hegemonic masculine, Western control.

Conclusion

This thesis responds to popular and even scholarly conceptions that fantasy fiction is essentially escapist, often reactionary, and removed from modern concerns. Through a close reading of Garth Nix's *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and Guy Gavriel Kay's *The Fionavar Tapestry*, I have argued that, rather than being culturally disengaged, medievalist fantasy discursively intersects with contemporary ideological issues of cultural significance. My particular focus has been on the pressure that British and, more broadly, Western influence continues to exert on fantasy fiction from former British settler cultures. I explore how modern British/Western perspectives are enacted in the novels' representations of ethnicity, class and gender.

I have situated this discussion in the evolving areas of fantasy and medievalism studies. Historically, with the notable exception of Tolkien's "On Fairy Stories", fantasy studies were largely constrained by an academic privileging of realist fiction and by a focus on generic, structural elements above the aesthetic value and cultural implications of works of fantasy. The last two decades of the twentieth century saw a discernible movement toward a greater inclusion of fantasy in literary scholarship. This movement included defences of fantasy such as that by Ann Swinfen, new theoretical perspectives such as those offered by Brian Attebery, and comprehensive reference volumes such as *The Encyclopedia of Fantasy* edited by John

Clute and John Grant. The twenty-first century has seen a continued increase in both the volume and the respectability of fantasy literature within scholarship, although there remains a residual suspicion of its popularity, its generic nature and its ahistoricism. Similarly, medievalism studies also reveal anxieties associated with popular engagement and ahistoricism; postcolonial medievalisms perhaps even more so. These anxieties, however, combined with attachment to a British heritage, reflect cultural and national experiences in former British settler cultures such as Australia and Canada. They expose the tensions between the pull exerted by cultural heritage and contemporary aspirations for modern and distinct national identities.

However, the things that cause anxieties – that is ahistoricism, the unreal, and popular engagement – are the very things that provide medievalist fantasy fiction with its much of its power. Freed from the constraints of historical authenticity and natural possibility, medievalist and fantastic imaginings can be co-opted for many purposes and attached to diverse ideological perspectives. Although British medievalism might seem out of place in modern postcolonial societies, it reaches back through cultural lineage to access the affective weight of ‘pastness’ and heritage. Although Australia and Canada are physically separated from Britain their medievalisms, reflected in their literature, architecture, ritual and popular culture, imbue these nations with a certain ‘Britishness’. Indeed, a medievalist ‘Northernness’ retains resonance, even in the ‘Great South Land’ of Australia, appealing to a quality, rather than a geographical North. However, despite *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and *The Fionavar Tapestry*’s underlying legacy of Britishness, each series has particular nuances that distinguish its Australian or Canadian roots and reflect its modern origins and

concerns. Although grounded in a cultural attachment to heritage, medievalist fantasy's use of the past is neither essentially conservative nor inherently backward-looking (though even reactionary texts reveal something of contemporary debates and ideological contestations). Indeed, the flexibility of medievalism enables the past to be appropriated and attached to contemporary ideals.

The adaptable utility of the Middle Ages as a resource to buttress various ideological perspectives is apparent in Nix's and Kay's dissimilar representations of progress. Like fantasists such as Morris and Tolkien before him, Nix demonstrates a cynicism toward industrialisation. He uses the contrast between a medieval Old Kingdom and a modern Ancelstierre to highlight the substance and value of the past, questioning unfettered progress and a naïve faith in scientific rationalism. Kay, contrastingly, uses the contrast between the civilised Medievalism of Brennin and more primitive forms of pastness to privilege human ingenuity above belief systems bound by nature and the earth. These varied depictions may represent the individual ideological bents of the authors, but they might also be reflective of the times in which the texts were produced. Kay's *The Fionavar Tapestry* was produced in the early-to-mid-1980s, when concerns surrounding global warming were only just making their way into the mainstream media, whereas *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* was written in the late 1990s and early 2000s after the issue of human-caused climate change had damaged confidence in the benefits of scientific, industrial progress.

Many elements of the novels are inflected by the context of their production. Both *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and *The Fionavar Tapestry* aspire to

modern liberal ideals of equity in the manner in which they include and represent Other cultures in their texts, but these aspirations are only realised with limited success. The quintessential Britishness of Nix's setting, and particularly the medieval temporality of the Old Kingdom, allows him to sidestep colonial anxieties relating to the displacement and oppression of Aboriginal populations. Moreover, as Kim Wilkins argues, the medievalism in genre fantasy makes it an inapt means of engagement with Australian Indigenous issues (Wilkins *CotH* 140). Conversely, however, appropriations of Indigenous motifs *can* entail ethically fraught complexities of their own, as non-Indigenous writers utilise Native images and themes as resources for Western literature. Although Kay's use of the Dalrei demonstrates an attachment to Canadian identity and a recognition of the importance of the Native American culture in Canada's national narratives, he is unable to escape discourses that privilege the coloniser over the colonised. Moreover, the physical separateness of the realms of Brennín and the Plain also obfuscates the uncomfortable realities of colonial displacement, dispossession and oppression.

The Fionavar Tapestry's inclusion of the peoples of Cathal, of Eridu, the Dwarves, the Paraiko and the lios alfar, along with the peoples of Brennín and the Dalrei, reflects the significance of a progressive multiculturalism to Canada's self-image. Indeed, the fact that these cultures are all ultimately aligned with the Light shows a fundamentally positive and hopeful rendering of intercultural politics and relations. Western tropes of enlightened progress and medievalist notions of place and destiny, however, work to situate a Western Brennín above the Other worldly cultures of Fionavar. At the same time, Orientalist representations of Cathal, the noble savage imagery

attached to the Dalrei, and the rudimentary, manual roots of the Dwarves all reinforce the rightness of an enlightened and civilised Brennin's authority.

Nix's engagement with Otherness is primarily seen in his depiction of the Southerling refugee crisis. His rendering of this crisis reflects political issues at the fore of Australian politics during the period in which Nix was writing the series; that is Australia's own refugee crisis and the rise of populist, xenophobic politics. Despite clearly condemning populist politics that feed on cultural anxieties and fears, Nix's texts, like Kay's, do not escape conventional Western paradigms of power. The medieval trope of destiny – particularly when combined with representations of the protagonists' natural aristocracy, enlightened appreciation and acceptance of Otherness, and an edge of protective paternalism – works to uphold a Western Anglo-Celtic centrality. Both Kay's and Nix's series demonstrate the power of uninterrogated assumptions of Western superiority and the difficulty attached to attempts to transcend entrenched paradigms of Western power.

Although both *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and *The Fionavar Tapestry* have medieval monarchies and hierarchies, the manner in which class is represented demonstrates differing Australian and Canadian nuances. Nix's novels work hard to negotiate the tensions between medieval hierarchies and egalitarian national ideals. An Australian dislike of 'tall poppies' and formality, and a concomitant suspicion of authority, is mediated through elements such as the protagonists' humility and their reluctance to accept high office, by informality in clothing and manner, and through representing them as 'underdogs' within the story. The privilege of class is further occluded by uniting the notions of destiny and the performance of sacrificial

service. Indeed, sacrificial service, although reflective of enduring and longstanding Western ideals, has been appropriated in national discourse as a particularly Australian trait. The conflation of authority with sacrifice, therefore, admits the Old Kingdom's aristocracy into paradigms of Australian values.

Whereas in *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* destiny is used to *excuse* the distinction of high class, in *The Fionavar Tapestry* it is used to *uphold* it. In keeping with Canadian national aspirations, in Fionavar there is an aristocracy of the civil and deserving. The association of the High Kingdom of Brennín and its rulers – the kings and mages – with enlightened progressiveness justifies an ordered and civil governance for the common good. As an intelligent, resourceful, methodical and determined man, King Aileron suffers no insecurity or compunction in claiming the throne of Brennín. His authority is further naturalised by the way in which he embodies the Canadian ideal of White, masculine, civil Britishness. This also validates Aileron's headship over the Alliance of the Light. His civilised Westernness vindicates his authority over the exoticism and decadence of Cathal, the primitiveness of the Dalrei, and the unrefined roughness of the Dwarves.

There is also a difference in how gender roles are approached by Nix and Kay. Both series demonstrate deference to modern Western ideals of gender equity in that they not only have strong male protagonists, but also strong and central female protagonists. In *The Old Kingdom Chronicles*, however, Nix utilises medievalism to provide a retrospective authority for an active female agency, whereas Kay's representation of women in *The Fionavar Tapestry* is constrained by his medieval frame. Nix naturalises female

participation in a range of disciplines and activities traditionally tied to masculinity. Moreover, he does so without making this feel exceptional or anomalous within the realm of the Old Kingdom. The idea of a female Abhorsen, regent, soldier, mage or Wallmaker passes without particular comment. In modern Ancelstierre, however, traditional gender paradigms appear to be in place. Nix's alignment of gender equity with his privileged medieval, rather than his degraded modern, situates an authority for contemporary active female agency in the past. It provides it with a history and pedigree from a time and place depicted as more 'real' and substantial than today. Nix thus offers a broad and positive image of female participation in the public sphere.

Likewise, Nix's portrayal of his heroes also demonstrates a shift in paradigms of what constitutes masculine behaviour. Both Touchstone and Sam take on supporting roles to female protagonists, but without the sacrifice of their masculinity. Indeed, both men prove necessary to the safety of the kingdom and to victory in their battles against evil. Nix does not so much invert the active/passive dichotomy often attached to male and female roles, as complicate it. Indeed, the novels aspire to a balance in relationships between male and female protagonists, whether romantic or platonic. Prince Sameth's role as Wallmaker, reflecting as it does the image of the contemporary geek or nerd, also reflects and reinforces the broadening category of acceptable and valued attributes of masculinity.

Contrastingly, Kay's stated aversion to ahistoricism and his quest for 'plausible' roles for his heroines within his medieval timeframe sees his strong women limited by conservative expectation and archetypal

representation. Moreover, the romantic subplots within *The Fionavar Tapestry* also bind women to traditional paradigms that privilege the masculine over the feminine. Indeed, power and feminine fulfilment are implicitly shown to be incompatible, as the happiness and 'rightness' at the end of the story is dependent on women's wifely submission.

The marriages at the series' ending echo the privileging of Brennín through its association with an enlightened, progressive, Western masculinity. This is seen most clearly in the romances between Prince Diarmuid and Sharra, and Paul and Jaelle. Although Paul and Jaelle's union seems to reflect modern liberal aspirations in its representation of a marriage between the God and the Goddess, the fact that this is only achieved at the sacrifice of Jaelle's power undermines the symbolism of gender equity. Moreover, her marriage sees Jaelle removed as a frustration, as an irritant whose practice and persistence has previously inhibited complete domination by male authority in Brennín. The relationship between Diarmuid and Sharra mirrors the masculinity of Brennín and the West and the feminisation of Cathal and the East. Kay, however, obscures problematic and exploitative subtexts by presenting the story as romance. Like the marriage between Paul and Jaelle, the engagement between Diarmuid and Sharra demonstrates modern liberal thought as it holds out the promise of a union between East and West, but this is cut short by Diarmuid's untimely death.

Kay's representations of gender might ultimately fold back into conformity with entrenched paradigms of Western masculine power, but as Nix's representation of gender demonstrates, fantasy need not be constrained by its medievalism. Indeed, the malleability of medievalist representation is even

seen in Kay's ahistorical portrayal of indiscriminately sexually available women. Imaginings of the Middle Ages can be utilised to contest conservative power structures and patterns as well as to uphold them. Moreover, conservatism should not be equated with cultural detachment, as this often reflects tensions, fears and anxieties present within a dynamic contemporary culture. In this way medievalist fantasy fiction is no different from realist fiction as it engages discursively with contested issues of cultural significance. It can challenge, subvert or reinforce hegemonic power structures; it might even seek to challenge or uphold these things but fail to do so, or it might simply passively reflect certain elements of the contemporary zeitgeist.

My discussion of *The Old Kingdom Chronicles* and *The Fionavar Tapestry* has presented just some examples of the discursive flexibility and cultural power offered by fantastic medieval imaginings. I have argued that, although medievalist fantasy fiction might initially seem misfitted in postcolonial states that are both spatially and temporally removed from Britain and the Middle Ages, it is very much a product of the place and time of its production. To return to where I began my argument, the very popularity of fantasy fiction attests to the continued resonance of medievalist constructions in former British settler cultures. Indeed, I would argue that broad claims which seek to relegate an entire genre to the province of nostalgic, reactionary or culturally detached literature are naïve or perhaps even wilfully ignorant. Scholarship would be considerably impoverished if it allowed anxieties over ahistorical, non-realist, popular and medievalist representations to impede a wider consideration of the social, cultural and political implications within the diverse and flexible genre of fantasy fiction.

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